

Writing Task 2 — Sample Answers

120 questions × Band 6, Band 7 and Band 8 = 360 answers · for review before seeding

Source

IELTS Academic Writing Task 2 Question Bank (IELTS_Writing_Task2_Question_Bank.pdf)

How each band was written

- **Band 6** — All parts addressed but some ideas underdeveloped; relevant position that may be slightly unclear; paragraphing present; mechanical linking; 4–7 small learner errors. 255–295 words.
- **Band 7** — Clear position throughout; main ideas extended and supported; clear central topic in each paragraph; good range of vocabulary; 1–3 minor slips. 265–315 words.
- **Band 8** — All parts well developed with relevant, extended support; logical sequencing; wide, flexible vocabulary and structures; rare minor errors. 275–335 words.

Checks already done

- every question has all three bands; word counts inside the ranges above
- the three answers were written separately (not one essay with words swapped)
- British spelling; no headings or lists; no invented statistics, studies or real people

What to look for

- Does each answer feel like its band (not too strong for 6, not too weak for 8)?
- Band 6 / 7 errors are deliberate — they should be realistic learner errors.
- Task 1: are the key features and the overview right for the visual?
- Task 2: does each essay answer every part of the question?
- Mark ☐ Approved or ☐ Needs changes under each question and add notes.

Homework in primary schools

Topic: Education · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_opinion_01

Some people believe that homework should be abolished in primary schools because young children need time to play and rest after the school day. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

290 words

Clear, largely consistent position · relevant ideas but examples are general and underdeveloped · mechanical linking (Firstly, Also, Secondly) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays many parents and teachers are discussing about whether young children should get homework or not. Some people think that homework in primary schools must be stopped because children needs time to play and rest. I mostly agree with this idea, although I think a small amount of homework can still be useful.

Firstly, primary school children are very young and they already spend six or seven hours in the classroom every day. When they come home they are tired and they want to play with their friends or watch cartoons. If they have to do a lot of homework, they can feel stressed and they may start to hate school. Also, playing is important for children because they learn how to share, how to solve problems and how to be creative. For example, when children play football in the park they learn teamwork, which is not possible from a worksheet.

Secondly, homework can make problem in the family. Many parents work until late and they don't have time to help their children. As a result, the child cannot finish the task or the parent do it for him, so the homework is not useful. In my country, I have seen many parents who argue with their children every evening because of homework.

However, some homework can be good. For example, reading a short story with parents for ten minutes is enjoyable and it improve the child's reading skill. This kind of activity is not same as difficult exercises.

In conclusion, I agree that most homework should be abolished in primary schools because children need to play and rest after school. But short and easy tasks like reading can still be given, because they help children without making them tired.

Band 7

311 words

Clear position maintained throughout · main ideas extended and supported, with some generalisation · logical paragraphing · good range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary · mostly error-free sentences.

It is often argued that primary school pupils should no longer be given homework, since young children need free time to play and recover after a long school day. While I accept that heavy workloads can be harmful at this age, I largely disagree with abolishing homework altogether, because short, well-designed tasks bring benefits that cannot easily be replaced.

There is certainly some truth in the argument for abolition. Young children have limited concentration, and after six hours of lessons many of them are simply too tired to learn effectively. Unstructured play is not a waste of time either; it helps children develop social skills, imagination and physical health. When homework takes up most of the evening, it can create anxiety and turn learning into a source of conflict between parents and children, which is

clearly counterproductive.

However, the solution to excessive homework is to reduce it, not to remove it completely. A few minutes of daily reading or practising multiplication tables helps pupils to consolidate what they have learned in class, and a regular practice is particularly important for basic skills such as literacy and numeracy. Moreover, simple tasks teach children to organise their time and take responsibility for their own work, habits which will become essential at secondary school, where the workload increases sharply.

Homework can also strengthen the link between school and home. When parents see what their child is studying, they are better able to support them and to notice any difficulties at an early stage. A child who reads aloud to a parent each evening, for instance, is likely to gain confidence as well as fluency.

In conclusion, although young children certainly need time to play and rest, I do not believe homework should be abolished in primary schools. Instead, it should be limited to short, meaningful activities that support learning without taking over family life.

Band 8

308 words

Fully addresses the task with a nuanced, consistent position · well-developed, extended ideas · skilful paragraphing and cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary · wide range of structures with only a rare minor slip.

The question of whether primary school children should be set homework has become increasingly contentious, with critics arguing that young pupils need their evenings for play and rest. I agree with this view to a considerable extent: formal homework offers limited academic benefit at this age, and the time it consumes is better spent on activities that support children's broader development. Nevertheless, I would stop short of banning all learning outside school.

The strongest case for abolition rests on how young children actually learn. At primary level, understanding is built largely through exploration, conversation and play rather than through repetitive written exercises. A seven-year-old who spends an evening building something with friends or helping to cook a meal is practising language, problem-solving and cooperation in a way that a worksheet rarely replicates. Rest matters just as much: tired children struggle to concentrate, and a school day followed by an hour of compulsory tasks can leave little room for the sleep and relaxation they need.

Homework also tends to widen existing inequalities. Pupils whose parents have the time and confidence to help them tend to complete assignments to a high standard, whereas those from busier or less advantaged households may fall behind or become discouraged. In such cases, what is intended as extra practice ends up rewarding family circumstances rather than effort, and can turn evenings into a source of tension.

That said, there is a difference between set homework and encouraging a love of learning at home. Reading together for pleasure, for example, is widely regarded as valuable and places little strain on children. Schools could therefore replace compulsory assignments with optional, informal suggestions of this kind.

Overall, I largely support abolishing formal homework in primary schools, since young children gain more from play, rest and family life. Informal reading at home, however, should still be warmly encouraged.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

AI and take-home assignments

Topic: Artificial intelligence · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_02

As artificial intelligence becomes more capable, universities should stop assessing students through written assignments that are completed at home. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

294 words

Relevant position, partly agree, stated clearly · ideas relevant but support is general · linking is mechanical · vocabulary adequate with some word-form errors · several grammatical errors that do not impede communication.

Today artificial intelligence programs can write essays in a few seconds. Because of this, some people think universities should stop using written assignments that students do at home. I partly agree with this opinion, but I don't think home assignments should be stopped completely.

On the one hand, it is true that AI make cheating very easy. A student can ask a chatbot to write a full essay and then they just change some words and submit it. The teacher cannot always know if the student wrote it or not, so the marks will not show the real ability of students. This is unfair for the honest students who work hard. For this reason, universities should use more exams in the classroom, where students cannot use any technology.

On the other hand, written assignments at home have many benefit. Students have more time to research a topic, read books and think deeply. In an exam, students are under pressure and they only have one or two hours, so they cannot show all of their knowledges. Also, in the real job, people usually write reports with enough time and they can use computers, so home assignments are more similar to the real life.

In my opinion, the best solution is to change the type of assignment. For example, the university can ask students to explain their essay in a short meeting with the teacher, or to write about their own experience which AI does not know. In this way, the assignments will be still useful and cheating will be more difficult.

In conclusion, I partly agree that AI is a big problem for home assignments. However, I believe universities should not stop them totally, but they should change them so that they are more fair.

Band 7

310 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported with relevant suggestions · clear central topic in each paragraph · range of cohesive devices · less common collocations used appropriately · few minor slips.

With the rapid development of artificial intelligence, many students can now produce a well-written essay simply by typing a request into a chatbot. As a result, some argue that universities should stop assessing students through written assignments completed at home. I disagree with this view, as I believe such assignments remain valuable if they are redesigned rather than abandoned.

Admittedly, AI poses a serious challenge to traditional coursework. When a tool can generate a coherent essay in seconds, it becomes difficult for lecturers to know whether the submitted work reflects a student's own understanding. This undermines the fairness of grades and may

discourage those who complete their assignments honestly. Supervised exams would obviously reduce this risk, which explain why the idea of abolishing take-home work is attractive to some institutions.

Nevertheless, relying only on timed exams would come at a considerable cost. Extended assignments teach skills that a two-hour exam cannot measure, such as researching independently, evaluating sources and developing an argument over several weeks. These abilities are exactly what graduates need in most professional roles, where reports are rarely written under exam conditions. Removing coursework would therefore make university assessment less relevant to working life.

A more sensible approach is to adapt assignments to the new technology. Universities could require students to submit drafts and notes showing how their ideas developed, or ask them to discuss their work in a short oral examination. Tasks could also be linked to local data, fieldwork or class discussions, which a general AI tool would struggle to reproduce convincingly. Some courses might even permit AI use openly and assess how critically students used it.

In conclusion, while AI has made cheating easier, it does not justify abandoning home-based written assignments. Universities should instead redesign these tasks so they continue to develop and assess the independent thinking that higher education is meant to encourage.

Band 8

314 words

Fully developed response with a precise, consistent position · ideas logically sequenced and well supported · cohesion managed skilfully · wide, natural vocabulary · complex structures used flexibly and accurately.

Generative AI has made it possible for almost anyone to produce a fluent essay in seconds, and this has led some commentators to argue that universities should abandon take-home written assignments altogether. I agree with this position only to a limited extent. While unsupervised essays can no longer be trusted as the sole measure of a student's ability, eliminating them entirely would sacrifice some of the most important aims of higher education.

It is undeniable that the traditional take-home essay has become vulnerable. Detection software is unreliable, and a student who submits machine-generated text with a few careful edits may be almost impossible to identify. When grades can be obtained without genuine learning, qualifications lose credibility, and conscientious students are effectively penalised for their honesty. For modules where assessment is heavily weighted towards a single essay, the case for introducing supervised elements is therefore compelling.

However, extended written work serves purposes that invigilated exams cannot. Producing a substantial piece of writing requires students to locate and evaluate sources, sustain an argument and revise their thinking over time. These are precisely the capabilities employers and researchers value, and they cannot be demonstrated in a two-hour sitting where memory and speed are rewarded above reflection. Replacing coursework wholesale with exams would, in effect, narrow what universities teach to what can be tested under pressure.

The more productive response is to rethink how assignments are designed and verified. Requiring annotated drafts, research logs or a brief viva in which students defend their arguments makes outsourcing far less attractive. Tasks grounded in personal fieldwork, recent seminar discussions or original data are also much harder to delegate to a general-purpose model.

In short, AI has exposed genuine weaknesses in take-home assessment, but the appropriate remedy is reform rather than abolition. Universities that adapt their assignments thoughtfully can protect academic integrity without abandoning the independent thinking that written work develops.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Companies versus consumers

Topic: Environment · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_03

The responsibility for protecting the environment lies mainly with large companies rather than with individual consumers. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

281 words

Position clear and maintained · relevant main points but examples are general and lack depth · linking is adequate but repetitive · vocabulary adequate with some awkward phrasing · several agreement and article errors.

Protecting the environment is one of the biggest challenge in the world today. Some people say that big companies are mainly responsible for this, not the normal consumers. I agree with this statement to a large extent, but I also think individuals have some responsibility.

The main reason why I agree is that large companies cause most of the pollution. Factories produce a lot of smoke and waste, and many companies use huge amount of plastic for packaging their products. One company can make more pollution in one day than thousands of people in one year. Also, companies have a lot of money and technology, so they are able to change their production to more green methods, for example using solar energy or recycled materials. If the big companies change, the effect on the environment will be very big.

In addition, consumers often do not have a choice. When a person goes to supermarket, almost every product is wrapped in plastic, so even if he want to avoid plastic, it is very difficult. That is why the companies should take the first step and give people environmental friendly products with reasonable price.

However, individuals are also important. Companies make products because consumers buy them. If people buy less things and choose products from companies that care about nature, the companies will be forced to change. Also, people can save electricity at home and use bus instead of car.

In conclusion, I believe that the large companies has the main responsibility for protecting the environment because they create the most pollution and they have the power to change. However, consumers should also do their part by making better choices in daily life.

Band 7

307 words

Clear position throughout · ideas extended and supported, with some generalisation · clear topic sentences · good range of linking · some less common collocation · very few errors.

There is ongoing debate about who should carry the main burden of protecting the environment. Some people believe that large corporations bear the greatest responsibility, while ordinary consumers play only a minor role. I largely agree with this view, although I think consumers have an important part to play in pushing companies to change.

The most convincing reason for placing responsibility on large companies is the scale of their impact. Energy firms, manufacturers and major retailers are responsible for a large share of carbon emissions, waste and deforestation, often far more than any individual could produce in a lifetime. A single decision by a multinational to switch to renewable energy or reduce packaging can therefore have a greater effect than millions of individual efforts. Companies also possess the financial resources and technical expertise needed to develop cleaner

processes, which most households simply do not have.

Furthermore, consumers' choices are shaped and limited by what companies offer. It is difficult for someone to live sustainably if affordable products are all packaged in plastic or if public transport is poorly developed. In this sense, blaming individuals can distract attention from the structural changes that are really needed, and some businesses may even encourage this focus to avoid stricter regulation.

Nevertheless, consumers are not powerless. Businesses respond to demand, so when large numbers of people buy second-hand clothes or avoid products linked to environmental damage, companies have a strong incentive to adapt. Individual behaviour, such as reducing food waste or flying less, also add up when it is widespread and can help to create social pressure for government action.

In conclusion, I agree that large companies should take the main responsibility for protecting the environment because of their enormous impact and resources. However, consumers still have a meaningful role, mainly by using their purchasing power to hold those companies accountable.

Band 8

316 words

Sophisticated, fully developed position · well-supported ideas with relevant examples · logical sequencing and seamless cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary and collocation · varied complex structures with virtually no errors.

Whether environmental protection is chiefly the duty of large corporations or of individual consumers is a question that shapes how societies respond to climate change and pollution. In my view, the primary responsibility does lie with major companies, but framing the issue as a choice between the two risks overlooking how closely their behaviour is connected.

The case for holding corporations principally accountable is persuasive. Industrial production, energy generation and global supply chains account for a large share of emissions, and decisions taken in a handful of boardrooms determine how goods are made, transported and packaged for millions of people. When a major retailer eliminates single-use plastics or an airline invests in cleaner fuels, the environmental gain dwarfs anything a conscientious shopper could achieve alone. Companies also have the capital to fund research into cleaner technologies, and they are the ones that profit from environmentally harmful practices, which strengthens the moral argument for making them pay for the damage.

Moreover, emphasising personal responsibility can be misleading. Consumers can only choose from the options available to them, and sustainable alternatives are often more expensive or simply unavailable. A family living in a suburb without reliable public transport, for instance, has little choice but to drive. Urging such people to change their habits while leaving corporate practices largely untouched shifts the burden onto those with the least power to solve the problem.

This is not to say that individuals are irrelevant. Collective consumer behaviour sends signals that companies cannot ignore, and public pressure is often what persuades governments to regulate industry more strictly. The growth of demand for plant-based food and electric vehicles illustrates how shifting preferences can reshape entire markets.

Overall, I agree that large companies bear the greater responsibility, given their scale, resources and profits. Consumers, however, remain an important catalyst, since their choices and political pressure help to ensure that corporations actually meet that responsibility.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Free public transport

Topic: Transport · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_opinion_04

Public transport in cities should be completely free of charge in order to reduce traffic congestion. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

288 words

Clear position with relevant reasons · some ideas are general and not fully extended · linking is mechanical but effective · adequate vocabulary with some repetition · several grammar errors that do not reduce clarity.

Traffic congestion is a serious problem in most big cities around the world. Some people believe that if public transport is completely free, more people will use it and the traffic will decrease. I agree with this idea for the most part.

The first reason is that money is important for many people when they choose how to travel. If a person have to pay for the bus every day, it can be expensive, especially for students and workers with low salary. So they prefer to use motorbike or car. But if buses and trains are free, many of them will leave their cars at home. This will make the roads less crowded and also reduce the air pollution, which is a big problem in cities like mine.

Another reason is that free transport is fair for everyone. Poor people can travel to their job, to hospital or to school without worrying about the cost. This can help them to find better jobs and improve their life. In addition, the city will save time because there is no need to sell tickets and check them.

However, there are some problems with this idea. The government need a lot of money to run the buses and trains, so it may have to increase the taxes. Also, if the service is not good, people will still use their cars even it is free. For example, if the bus is always late or very crowded, people don't want to use it.

In conclusion, I agree that making public transport free can reduce traffic congestion, because it encourages people to stop using private cars. However, the government must also improve the quality of the service, otherwise the plan will not be successful.

Band 7

311 words

Clear, consistent position · main ideas developed with relevant support, though one example is generalised · well-organised paragraphs · appropriate range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary · mostly accurate grammar.

Many cities suffer from severe traffic congestion, and one proposed solution is to make public transport entirely free for passengers. Although this policy has some clear attractions, I largely disagree that it is the best way to tackle congestion, because cost is rarely the main factor that keeps drivers off buses and trains.

Supporters of free travel argue that removing fares would encourage people to switch from private cars. This may be true for some groups, such as students and low-income workers, for whom daily fares represent a significant expense. Free services would also make cities more inclusive, since everyone could reach jobs, schools and hospitals regardless of their income.

However, most car owners choose to drive because it is faster, more comfortable or more convenient, not because public transport is too expensive. If buses are overcrowded, unreliable

or do not reach the suburbs where people live, abolishing fares will change very little. In fact, some cities that have introduced free transport found that many new passengers were people who previously walked or cycled, which does nothing to reduce the number of cars on the road.

Furthermore, fares provide an important source of funding. Without this income, transport authorities would depend entirely from taxation, and in times of budget pressure they might be forced to cut routes or delay improvements. This could make the service less attractive and eventually encourage more people to drive.

A more effective approach would be to invest in frequent, reliable services and combine this with measures that make driving less appealing, such as congestion charges or limited parking in city centres. Reduced fares for certain groups could also be offered.

In conclusion, while free public transport would benefit some residents, I do not believe it would significantly reduce congestion on its own. Improving service quality and discouraging car use are likely to be far more effective.

Band 8

322 words

Well-developed, nuanced argument with a clear position · ideas logically sequenced and fully supported · skilful paragraphing and cohesion · precise, natural vocabulary · wide range of accurate complex structures.

Abolishing fares on buses, trams and trains is sometimes presented as a simple remedy for urban traffic congestion. While I accept that free public transport has genuine social merits, I disagree that it is, by itself, an effective way of reducing congestion, and I believe the money it would require could be spent more productively.

The appeal of fare-free travel is easy to understand. It removes a cost that weighs most heavily on low-income households, simplifies journeys for occasional users and sends a strong public signal that the city values collective transport over private cars. For young people and those on modest wages, eliminating fares might well be the deciding factor that makes the bus a realistic alternative.

The difficulty is that motorists are generally less sensitive to price than to time and convenience. A commuter who drives does so because the car offers a direct, predictable journey; if the equivalent trip by public transport involves two changes and a long wait, making it free will rarely alter that calculation. Experience in several cities suggests that fare-free schemes tend to attract people who would otherwise have walked or cycled, which increases demand on the network without taking many cars off the road.

There is also the question of funding. Ticket revenue typically covers a substantial part of operating costs, and replacing it would place a permanent burden on public budgets. When finances tighten, it is service frequency and maintenance that usually suffer first, precisely the qualities that persuade drivers to switch.

Congestion is therefore better addressed through a combination of measures: sustained investment in faster, more frequent services, dedicated bus lanes, and policies such as road pricing that reflect the true cost of driving. Targeted discounts can protect those on the lowest incomes without sacrificing essential revenue.

In conclusion, free public transport may be socially desirable, but as a strategy for reducing congestion it promises more than it is likely to deliver.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Protecting historic city centres

Topic: Cities · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_opinion_05

Governments should prevent the construction of new buildings in historic city centres, even if this limits economic growth and the supply of housing. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

285 words

Position clear though somewhat simplistic · relevant ideas with limited development · paragraphing appropriate · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary with some awkward collocations · several article and agreement errors.

Many cities have old centres with beautiful buildings and long history. Some people think the government should not allow any new buildings in these areas, even if it is bad for economy and housing. I agree with this opinion to a large extent.

Firstly, historic city centres are very important for a country's culture and identity. Old buildings like churches, markets and palaces show how people lived in the past and they are part of our heritage. If the government allow modern buildings there, the old character of the area will be destroyed and we can never get it back. For example, a tall glass tower next to an old castle looks very strange and it make the area less beautiful.

Secondly, historic centres attract a lot of tourists. Tourists come to see the old streets and traditional architecture, not modern offices. So protecting these areas can actually help the economy, because tourism creates many jobs in hotels, restaurants and shops. In this way, the economic loss from not building is not so big as people think.

On the other hand, I understand that cities need more houses because the population is growing. Young people cannot find apartments with cheap price in the centre. However, I think new houses can be built in other parts of city, such as suburbs, where there are more space and the land is cheaper. The government can also improve public transport so people can travel to the centre easily.

In conclusion, I believe the government should stop new construction in historic city centres because these areas are very valuable for culture and tourism. The need for housing and economic growth can be solved in other areas of the city.

Band 7

299 words

Clear, balanced position maintained · ideas extended and supported, with occasional over-generalisation · logical progression and clear paragraph topics · good cohesion · some less common vocabulary · frequent error-free sentences.

In many cities, there is tension between preserving historic centres and meeting the demand for economic development and new housing. Some argue that governments should ban all new construction in these areas, whatever the economic cost. I agree that historic centres deserve strong protection, but I believe a complete ban goes too far.

There are strong reasons to protect historic districts. Their architecture represents centuries of cultural history, and once an old building is demolished or overshadowed by a modern tower, the loss is permanent. These areas also give cities a distinctive identity, which is valued by residents and is a major attraction for the tourists. In many European and Asian cities, the old town is the main reason visitors come at all, so careless development could damage the local

economy rather than help it.

However, an absolute ban would create serious problems. City centres are usually where jobs, transport and services are concentrated, and preventing all new building there would push housing further from workplaces, increasing commuting times and rents. It might also turn historic districts into museum-like spaces, full of tourists but empty of ordinary residents and local businesses. A living city needs schools, shops and homes, not only monuments.

A more balanced solution is strict but flexible regulation. Governments can limit the height and design of new buildings so that they fit the character of the area, protect the most important landmarks completely, and encourage the conversion of old, empty buildings into housing. Many cities have successfully added modern homes on vacant plots without harming their historic appearance.

In conclusion, while historic city centres should be carefully protected, I disagree with preventing all new construction. Carefully controlled development can preserve heritage while still allowing cities to meet the needs of the people who live in them.

Band 8

323 words

Nuanced, fully sustained position · ideas well developed and logically sequenced · cohesion and paragraphing skilfully managed · wide, precise and natural vocabulary · complex structures handled flexibly with no noticeable errors.

Historic city centres are among the most visible expressions of a society's past, and the pressure to redevelop them is often intense. The proposal that governments should forbid all new construction in these districts, regardless of the economic and housing consequences, reflects a legitimate concern for heritage. However, I largely disagree with it, since a blanket prohibition would ultimately harm the very places it aims to preserve.

It is certainly true that insensitive development can do irreversible damage. A single oversized office block can dominate a skyline that has remained largely unchanged for centuries, and the demolition of a period building cannot be undone. Historic quarters also have considerable economic value in their own right, drawing visitors whose spending supports thousands of local businesses. For these reasons, protecting landmarks and the overall character of old districts should be a clear priority for planners.

Yet a complete ban confuses preservation with freezing a city in time. Historic centres have always evolved, with each generation adding buildings of its own era, and many admired streets are the result of such layering. More practically, prohibiting construction where land is most in demand drives up property prices, forces lower-income residents out and leaves the centre dominated by short-term lets and souvenir shops. The outcome is often a district that looks authentic but has lost the everyday life that once defined it.

A more sophisticated approach combines firm protection with carefully managed change. Listed buildings can be safeguarded absolutely, while strict design codes govern the height, materials and scale of anything new. Derelict sites and disused commercial buildings can be converted into homes, bringing residents back without compromising the streetscape. This allows cities to accommodate growth while keeping their historic identity intact.

In conclusion, historic centres deserve robust protection, but an outright ban on new building would sacrifice housing, vitality and affordability for the sake of a static appearance. Intelligent regulation, rather than prohibition, is the better course.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Learning ability over qualifications

Topic: Employment · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_06

In the future, a person's ability to learn new skills quickly will be more important than the qualifications they hold. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

278 words

Clear position with a relevant concession · main ideas relevant but supported by general examples · linking adequate though repetitive · vocabulary sufficient with some repetition · a number of agreement errors.

In the past, having a good degree or certificate was the most important thing for getting a job. Nowadays, some people say that in the future the ability to learn new skills quickly will be more important than qualifications. I agree with this statement.

The main reason is that technology is changing very fast. Many jobs that exist today will disappear, and new jobs will appear which we cannot imagine now. A person who studied a subject ten years ago may find that his knowledge is already old. For example, many office workers had to learn how to use new software and online tools during the last few years. The people who learned fast was able to keep their job, but others had difficulties. This shows that learning quickly is a very useful ability.

In addition, companies today want employees who can adapt. When a company starts a new project, it need workers who can understand new things without long training. A person with many certificates but who cannot learn is not so helpful for the company. Also, a lot of skills can now be learned online for free, so the qualification from university is not the only way to prove your knowledge.

However, I don't think qualifications will become useless. Some jobs, like doctors, engineers or lawyers, always need official degrees because they are very responsible jobs. Nobody want to be treated by a doctor without a qualification.

In conclusion, I agree that the ability to learn new skills quickly will be more important than qualifications in the future, because the world of work is changing very quickly. But for some professions, qualifications will still be necessary.

Band 7

300 words

Clear position throughout · both aspects extended and supported · logical organisation with a clear topic in each paragraph · range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary · very few errors.

It is often claimed that, in the future, the capacity to acquire new skills rapidly will matter more than formal qualifications. I partly agree with this view: adaptability is becoming increasingly valuable in a changing job market, but qualifications will continue to play an essential role, particularly in certain professions.

On the one hand, the pace of technological change means that specific knowledge becomes outdated more quickly than before. Software, industries and even entire job categories can transform within a few years, so employees who can learn new tools and methods efficiently are likely to remain employable. Many employers now place greater emphasis on problem-solving and flexibility during interviews, recognising that a degree obtained years earlier says little about how well a person will cope with tomorrow's challenges. The growth of

short online courses also allows workers to update their skills continuously without returning to university.

On the other hand, qualifications still serve important purposes. In fields such as medicine, law and engineering, formal training ensures that professionals meet agreed standards, and it would be dangerous to allow people to practise simply because they claim to learn quickly. Qualifications also provide employers with a reliable way to compare candidates, especially when hundreds of people apply for the same job. Moreover, completing a degree often demonstrate the very ability to learn that critics claim is more important.

In my view, the two are becoming complementary rather than competing. A qualification may open the door to a career, but the ability to keep learning will determine how far a person progresses once they are inside.

In conclusion, I agree that the ability to learn new skills quickly will grow in importance, but I do not think it will replace qualifications. Both will be necessary, with adaptability becoming the key to long-term success.

Band 8

307 words

Clear, well-qualified position · ideas fully extended with relevant, specific illustration · logical sequencing and effective cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary used naturally · varied structures with only rare minor imprecision.

As automation and digital technology reshape the labour market, many commentators predict that the ability to learn quickly will soon outweigh the value of formal qualifications. I agree with this prediction to a large extent, although I believe qualifications will remain important as a baseline, particularly in regulated professions.

The central argument concerns the shrinking shelf life of knowledge. A graduate entering the workforce today may find that much of what they studied is obsolete within a decade, as new tools, regulations and business models emerge. In such an environment, what distinguishes successful employees is not what they learnt at twenty-two but how effectively they can master unfamiliar tasks at forty. A marketing specialist who can quickly grasp a new analytics platform, for instance, is often more valuable to an employer than a colleague with a more prestigious degree who struggles to adapt.

Hiring practices already reflect this shift. A growing number of companies assess candidates through practical tasks and probation periods rather than relying solely on certificates, and some technology firms have dropped degree requirements for certain roles altogether. At the same time, the availability of online courses and workplace training means that skills can be acquired and demonstrated outside traditional education, weakening the monopoly that formal credentials once held.

Nevertheless, qualifications are unlikely to disappear. In professions where mistakes can endanger lives, such as surgery or civil engineering, society rightly insists on rigorous, standardised training that cannot be replaced by a talent for fast learning. Degrees also signal persistence and a foundation of knowledge on which further learning can be built.

On balance, I expect qualifications to become a starting point rather than a guarantee of career success. Adaptability and the capacity for continuous learning will increasingly determine who thrives, while formal credentials will remain indispensable only where public safety and professional standards demand them.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Advertising to young children

Topic: Advertising · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_opinion_07

All advertising aimed at children under the age of twelve should be banned. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

292 words

Clear, consistent position · relevant main ideas with basic support · some development is repetitive · mechanical but clear linking · adequate vocabulary · several subject-verb agreement errors that do not obscure meaning.

Nowadays children see advertisements everywhere, on television, on the internet and even in their games. Some people think that all advertising for children who are under twelve should be banned. I completely agree with this idea.

The first reason is that young children cannot understand the purpose of advertising. They believe what they see on the screen and they don't know that the company only want to sell products. For example, if a child see an advert for a new toy with happy children playing, he thinks that he will be very happy if he gets it. Adults can think critically but children are not able to do this, so it is not fair to target them.

The second reason is that advertising can be bad for children's health. Many adverts for children are about sweets, fast food and sugary drinks. These products are very attractive with bright colours and cartoon characters, and children ask their parents to buy them. If they eat this kind of food too much, they can become overweight and have health problems in the future.

In addition, adverts create pressure on the parents. Children always want the newest toys and they cry or become angry if parents say no. Many families don't have enough money to buy everything, so this cause arguments at home. Also children can feel sad when their friends have things that they don't have.

Some people say that companies need to advertise to sell their products. However, they can still advertise to parents, because parents are the one who pay for the products.

In conclusion, I strongly believe that advertising aimed at children under twelve should be banned, because children cannot understand it and it can harm their health and their family life.

Band 7

290 words

Strong, clear position throughout · ideas well extended with relevant illustration · counter-argument addressed · logical paragraphing · good range of cohesive devices and some less common vocabulary · few errors.

Children today are exposed to a constant stream of advertisements on television, websites and mobile games. As a result, there have been calls for a complete ban on advertising directed at children under twelve. I strongly agree with this proposal, since young children are especially vulnerable to persuasive marketing.

The main reason for my view is that young children lack the ability to recognise advertising for what it is. Before a certain age, many children cannot clearly distinguish between entertainment and a commercial message, and they tend to accept claims at face value. When

a cartoon character they love tells them that a particular cereal will make them stronger, they are likely to believe it. Targeting an audience that cannot critically evaluate information is, in my opinion, fundamentally unfair.

Secondly, much of the advertising aimed at children promotes products that are harmful or unnecessary. Sugary snacks, fast food and expensive toys dominate children's channels and apps, and their marketing often relies on bright colours, free gifts and celebrity endorsements. This contributes to unhealthy eating habits and encourages a materialistic attitude from an early age. It also puts a considerable pressure on parents, who may face tantrums or feel guilty when they cannot afford the latest products.

Opponents argue that a ban would harm businesses and restrict freedom of expression. However, companies would still be able to market their products to parents, who are ultimately the ones making purchasing decisions. Moreover, several countries already restrict advertising to children, which suggests that such regulation is both practical and effective.

In conclusion, I firmly believe that all advertising aimed at children under twelve should be banned. Protecting young children from manipulation and unhealthy influences is more important than the commercial interests of advertisers.

Band 8

314 words

Fully addresses the task with a strong, qualified position · ideas extended and well supported · counter-arguments integrated skilfully · cohesion managed naturally · wide, precise vocabulary · accurate, varied complex structures.

Advertisers spend vast sums targeting children, whose influence over family spending is considerable. The suggestion that all advertising aimed at under-twelves should be prohibited is therefore a significant one, and I agree with it to a large extent, while recognising that a ban would need to be carefully defined to be workable.

The most compelling argument concerns children's cognitive development. Younger children often struggle to recognise the persuasive intent behind an advertisement and are inclined to accept its claims uncritically. Marketing techniques that would barely register with an adult, such as a favourite cartoon character endorsing a snack or a toy shown in an exaggeratedly exciting setting, can be highly effective on a seven-year-old. Directing such messages at an audience that cannot defend itself against them is difficult to justify ethically.

The consequences extend beyond the individual child. Advertising to children is dominated by foods high in sugar and fat, and repeated exposure shapes preferences that may persist into adulthood, with obvious implications for public health. It also fuels what is often called "pester power", placing parents under pressure to buy products they cannot afford or would not otherwise choose, and encouraging children to measure their worth by what they own.

Critics of a ban raise two points: that it would unfairly restrict legitimate businesses, and that parents, not governments, should protect their children. Yet firms would remain free to advertise to adults, who make the actual purchasing decisions, and the sheer volume of online marketing, much of it embedded in games and videos, makes parental supervision alone unrealistic.

The main practical challenge lies in enforcement, particularly on digital platforms where age and intent are harder to define. Clear rules on content designed to appeal to children would be essential.

In conclusion, I strongly support banning advertising aimed at children under twelve. Their vulnerability to persuasion outweighs the commercial arguments against such a restriction.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Taxing unhealthy food

Topic: Health · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_08

Governments should tax unhealthy foods, such as sugary drinks and fast food, in the same way that they tax tobacco. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

285 words

Position generally clear but slightly repetitive in conclusion · relevant ideas, some underdeveloped · linking mechanical · adequate vocabulary · several errors in comparatives, prepositions and agreement that do not block meaning.

In recent years, the number of people who are overweight has increased in many countries. Some people think the government should put a tax on unhealthy food like sugary drinks and fast food, as they do with cigarettes. I agree with this idea to some extent.

On the one hand, a tax can make people buy less unhealthy food. When the price of something goes up, people usually buy less of it. For example, many people stopped smoking or smoked less when cigarettes became very expensive. The same thing can happen with fizzy drinks and burgers. Also, the government can use the money from this tax for hospitals and for health education in schools, which will help the whole society.

On the other hand, unhealthy food is not exactly the same like tobacco. Cigarettes are always harmful, but eating a pizza or a chocolate sometimes is not dangerous. The problem is only when people eat too much of it. So it is not fair to punish everybody who enjoy fast food occasionally. Moreover, this tax can be a problem for poor families, because cheap fast food is sometimes the only thing they can afford after a long working day, and fresh food is often more expensive.

In my opinion, the government should tax the most unhealthy products, such as sugary drinks, but not all fast food. At the same time, they should make healthy food more cheaper and teach people about good diet.

In conclusion, I partly agree that unhealthy food should be taxed like tobacco. A tax can reduce consumption and give money to health services, but it must be used together with other actions so that poor people are not affected too much.

Band 7

300 words

Clear, well-reasoned position · main ideas extended and supported · logical organisation with clear central topics · good range of linking · some less common vocabulary · generally accurate with an isolated word-choice slip.

Rising rates of obesity and diet-related illness have led some people to argue that governments should tax sugary drinks and fast food in the same way as tobacco. While I believe that taxes on certain unhealthy products can be useful, I disagree that such food should be treated exactly like tobacco.

There are clear arguments in favour of taxing unhealthy food. Price has a strong influence on consumer behaviour, and higher prices usually lead to reduced consumption, as has happened with cigarettes in many countries. A tax on sugary drinks, in particular, could discourage people from consuming large amounts of sugar without any real nutritional benefit. The revenue could also be used to fund public health campaigns or subsidise fruit and vegetables, which would make healthier choices more accessible.

However, food is fundamentally different from tobacco. There is no safe level of smoking, but most foods that are considered unhealthy are only harmful when eaten regularly and in large quantities. Taxing them heavily would therefore penalise the many people who consume them occasionally and responsibly. In addition, defining what counts as "unhealthy" is much more complicated than identifying a tobacco product; a burger made at a restaurant and one prepared at home may be quite similar, yet only one could realistically be taxed.

Such taxes may also have a disproportionate affect on low-income households, who spend a larger share of their income on food and often rely on cheap, processed meals. Unless the money raised is used to make healthy food more affordable, the policy could increase inequality without improving diets.

In conclusion, I support moderate, targeted taxes on products such as sugary drinks, but I do not agree that unhealthy food in general should be taxed as heavily as tobacco. Education and support for healthier choices are equally important.

Band 8

310 words

Sophisticated, clearly qualified position · ideas extended with precise supporting detail · logical sequencing and paragraphing · wide, accurate vocabulary · flexible use of complex structures with virtually no errors.

With obesity and related conditions placing growing strain on health systems, some argue that governments should tax sugary drinks and fast food as they tax tobacco. I agree that fiscal measures have a role to play, particularly for sugar-sweetened beverages, but I believe equating unhealthy food with tobacco is both conceptually flawed and potentially counterproductive.

The case for taxation rests on sound principles. Consumers respond to price, and the dramatic decline in smoking in many countries owes much to sustained increases in tobacco duty. Sugary drinks are an especially suitable target: they provide calories with virtually no nutritional value, they are easy to define, and there is evidence that levies on them encourage manufacturers to reduce sugar content. Revenue raised in this way can be reinvested in school meals, sports facilities or subsidies for fresh produce, amplifying the health benefit.

Nevertheless, food differs from tobacco in crucial respects. Cigarettes are harmful in any quantity, whereas burgers, chips or chocolate are problematic only as part of an unbalanced diet. A tax modelled on tobacco would therefore treat moderate consumption as though it were inherently dangerous, which many people would reasonably regard as excessive state intervention. Moreover, "fast food" is a notoriously vague category, and drawing a line between a takeaway meal and a restaurant dish would invite both confusion and avoidance.

There is also the issue of fairness. Food taxes are regressive, weighing most heavily on households with the least disposable income, and in areas where fresh food is expensive or hard to obtain, higher prices may simply reduce families' budgets rather than change what they eat. Any such tax must therefore be paired with measures that make healthy alternatives genuinely affordable.

In conclusion, targeted taxes on clearly defined products like sugary drinks are justified, but applying a tobacco-style regime to unhealthy food in general would be neither fair nor effective.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Who teaches good behaviour?

Topic: Children / Family · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_opinion_09

Parents, rather than teachers, should be mainly responsible for teaching children good behaviour and respect for others. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

275 words

Clear position with relevant support · ideas somewhat general and repetitive · paragraphing logical · linking mechanical · vocabulary adequate for the task · several preposition and agreement errors that do not impede understanding.

Good behaviour and respect for other people are very important qualities for children. Some people think that parents, not teachers, should be mainly responsible for teaching these things. I agree with this statement.

Firstly, children spend most of their time with their family, especially in the first years of life. Before they start school, they already learn how to speak, how to eat and how to behave with other people from their parents. If parents teach them to say "please" and "thank you" and to share with others, these habits will stay with them for all their life. Also, children usually copy what their parents do. If a father is polite with his neighbours, his son will probably learn to be polite too.

Secondly, teachers have many students in one class, sometimes more than thirty. They don't have enough time to pay attention for the behaviour of every child. Their main job is to teach subjects like maths, science and languages. If the teacher must spend a lot of time to correct bad behaviour, the other students cannot learn well.

However, teachers also have some role. At school, children learn how to work in groups, how to follow rules and how to respect people from different backgrounds. Teachers can support what the parents teach at home. But if the parents don't teach good manners, it is very difficult for teachers to change a child's behaviour.

In conclusion, I believe that parents should be mainly responsible for teaching children good behaviour and respect because children spend more time with them and learn by copying them. Teachers can help, but the main responsibility belong to the family.

Band 7

300 words

Clear partly-agree position maintained · both roles extended and supported · clear paragraph focus and logical progression · range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary · mostly accurate with one agreement slip.

It is often debated whether parents or teachers should take the main responsibility for teaching children to behave well and respect others. Some people believe this is primarily the role of parents. I partly agree with this view, as I think parents should lay the foundations, but schools have a vital and distinctive contribution to make.

Parents clearly have the greatest influence during a child's early years. Long before children start school, they learn how to treat others by observing the adults around them, and values such as honesty, kindness and patience are absorbed through daily routines at home. A child whose parents speak respectfully to each other and to strangers is far more likely to adopt the same attitude. Moreover, parents can give individual attention and correct behaviour consistently, which is difficult for a teacher responsible for a whole class.

However, schools provide experiences that the family cannot. In the classroom, children must cooperate with peers from different backgrounds, follow shared rules and resolve conflicts without their parents' help. These situations teach respect in a wider social context and prepare children for adult life in a diverse community. Teachers can also reinforce good behaviour through clear expectations and by being positive role models, which is particularly important for children whose home environment are less supportive.

For these reasons, I believe the responsibility should be shared. Parents are best placed to instil basic values, while teachers help children to apply them in a broader setting. When the two work together and send consistent messages, children are much more likely to develop good behaviour that lasts.

In conclusion, although parents should play the leading role in teaching manners and respect, I do not think teachers' contribution should be seen as secondary. Effective moral education depends on cooperation between home and school.

Band 8

312 words

Well-developed, qualified position throughout · ideas extended with precise illustration · logical sequencing and skilful cohesion · wide, natural vocabulary · wide range of structures with rare minor errors at most.

The question of who should teach children good behaviour and respect for others is often framed as a choice between home and school. I agree that parents should bear the primary responsibility, since the values children absorb in their earliest years are formed largely within the family. However, I would argue that teachers play an indispensable supporting role rather than a marginal one.

The strongest argument for parental responsibility lies in the timing and nature of early learning. Children's attitudes towards others begin to take shape long before they enter a classroom, and they are shaped less by explicit instruction than by imitation. A toddler who sees a parent listen patiently, apologise when wrong and treat service workers courteously internalises these patterns almost unconsciously. Parents also have a depth of knowledge about their own child and the continuity of contact over many years that no teacher, responsible for thirty pupils for a single year, can match.

There is also a question of accountability. If parents come to assume that manners and respect will be taught at school, they may neglect this aspect of upbringing, leaving teachers to address behavioural problems that divert time from learning. Recognising that the family is the first line of moral education places responsibility where it can be exercised most effectively.

That said, schools offer something that homes cannot: a structured community of peers. Learning to share resources, wait one's turn, work with classmates one did not choose and respect people from different cultures are lessons best learnt in a group setting. Teachers who model fairness and enforce consistent rules can reinforce good habits and, crucially, compensate for children who receive little guidance at home.

In conclusion, parents should be principally responsible for teaching good behaviour and respect, but this responsibility is most effectively fulfilled when schools reinforce and extend the values children first learn within the family.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Circumstances in sentencing

Topic: Crime · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_opinion_10

When deciding on a punishment, courts should consider only the crime that was committed, not the personal background or circumstances of the offender. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

290 words

Clear position with relevant examples · counter-view acknowledged · ideas somewhat simplistic and underdeveloped · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several verb agreement, comparative and word-form errors.

When a person commits a crime, the court must decide what punishment to give. Some people think the court should only look at the crime and not at the background of the person who did it. I disagree with this opinion because I think the situation of the offender is also important.

Firstly, not all crimes happen for the same reason. For example, if a poor mother steal food from a shop because her children are hungry, it is different from a rich man who steals for fun. Both of them committed the same crime, but I believe the mother should get a lighter punishment because she had a serious reason. If the court ignore this, the punishment will not be fair.

Secondly, looking at the background can help to reduce crime in the future. If the judge knows that a young offender grew up in a difficult family or has problem with drugs, the judge can send him to a programme to help him instead of prison. In prison, young people often meet other criminals and they become more worse. But with the right help, they can change their life and not commit crimes again.

However, I understand why some people want the courts to consider only the crime. They think that everyone should be treated equal and that some criminals may use their difficult past as an excuse. This is true, and the judges must be careful. The background should not be used to avoid punishment totally for serious crimes like murder.

In conclusion, I disagree that courts should consider only the crime. The personal background of the offender should also be considered, because it makes the punishment more fair and can help people to stop committing crimes.

Band 7

300 words

Clear position throughout · opposing view addressed · ideas extended with relevant examples · logical paragraphing · range of cohesive devices · good vocabulary with a minor comparative slip · frequent error-free sentences.

Some people argue that when courts decide on a sentence, they should focus solely on the crime itself and ignore the offender's personal background and circumstances. Although I understand the desire for consistency, I largely disagree with this view, as I believe justice requires courts to consider the individual as well as the offence.

Those who support this approach believe it guarantees equal treatment. If two people commit the same crime, they should receive the same punishment, regardless of their wealth, family history or social status. This principle is appealing because it prevents judges from showing favouritism and makes sentences more predictable. There is also a concern that offenders might exploit sympathetic stories about their past to avoid appropriate punishment.

However, identical acts can carry very different levels of blame. A teenager who commits a theft under pressure from an older gang member is not equally responsible as an adult who plans the same crime for profit. Similarly, factors such as mental illness, severe poverty or a history of abuse can affect a person's judgement, and ignoring them would produce sentences that feel harsh and unjust. A fair system should reflect not only what was done but why it was done.

Considering circumstances can also serve the wider purpose of reducing crime. If a court understands that an offender's behaviour is linked to addiction, it can impose a sentence that includes treatment, which is more likely to prevent reoffending than a short prison term. In this way, taking background into account benefits society as well as the individual.

In conclusion, while treating similar crimes consistently is important, I disagree that courts should ignore offenders' circumstances completely. Sentences should be based mainly on the seriousness of the crime, but adjusted where personal factors genuinely affect responsibility or the chance of rehabilitation.

Band 8

311 words

Sophisticated, clearly argued position · ideas fully extended and logically sequenced · opposing view evaluated skilfully · precise, wide-ranging vocabulary · complex structures used accurately and flexibly.

Whether sentencing should be based purely on the offence, or should also take account of the offender's background, touches on a fundamental tension in criminal justice between consistency and individual fairness. I disagree with the view that courts should consider only the crime, although I accept that the weight given to personal circumstances must be carefully limited.

The argument for focusing exclusively on the offence has genuine merit. Equality before the law implies that similar acts should attract similar penalties, and sentencing that varies according to personal history risks appearing arbitrary. There is also a legitimate worry that well-resourced defendants, able to present their lives sympathetically through expensive legal representation, may secure more lenient treatment than those without such advantages.

However, a system that looks only at the act itself would disregard the degree of culpability, which is central to any meaningful notion of justice. An offence committed by someone acting under coercion, suffering from a serious mental illness or driven by desperate need is not morally equivalent to the same act committed out of greed or cruelty. Most legal systems already recognise this through concepts such as mitigating and aggravating factors, and removing them would make sentences blunter rather than fairer.

Circumstances are also relevant to the forward-looking purposes of punishment. A sentence is not merely retribution; it is intended to protect the public and reduce the likelihood of reoffending. Understanding that a young offender's behaviour is rooted in addiction or an unstable home allows a court to choose interventions, such as supervised treatment, that address the underlying cause rather than simply imposing a custodial term.

The key, therefore, is proportion. The seriousness of the offence should set the broad range of any sentence, while personal circumstances inform where within that range it falls. On this basis, I believe courts are right to consider both, rather than the crime alone.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Opinion in news reporting

Topic: Media · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_11

News organisations should report only facts and should never include the personal opinions of their journalists. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

268 words

Clear position with a relevant qualification · main ideas relevant but general · linking adequate but mechanical · vocabulary adequate with some repetition · several agreement errors that do not affect understanding.

News is very important in our life because it tells us what is happening in the world. Some people think that news organisations must report only facts and journalists should not give their own opinion. I agree with this idea to a large extent.

The main reason is that people need correct information to make decisions. For example, before an election, people read the news to know about the candidates. If the journalist write his personal opinion, the readers can be influenced and they may vote for the person the journalist like, not the person they really prefer. This is dangerous for democracy. News should help people to think by themselves.

Another reason is that nowadays there are too much fake news and many people do not trust the media. When news is full of opinions, it is difficult for the readers to know what is true and what is only the idea of the writer. If news organisations report only facts, people will trust them more.

On the other hand, sometimes opinion can be useful. Some topics, like economy or politics, are very difficult to understand, and an expert journalist can explain what the facts means. However, I think this should be in a separate part, for example an opinion column, and it must be clear to the readers that it is not the news.

In conclusion, I mostly agree that news organisations should report only facts and not the opinions of their journalists, because people need true information and trust in the media. If opinions are included, they should be clearly separated from the news reports.

Band 7

309 words

Clear position throughout · ideas extended and supported, with some generalisation · logical organisation with clear topic sentences · good cohesion · some less common vocabulary · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

In an era of instant news and widespread misinformation, some people argue that news organisations should limit themselves strictly to reporting facts, without any personal opinion from journalists. While I agree that news reports should be as objective as possible, I disagree that opinion should never be included, as analysis plays an important role when it is clearly labelled.

There are good reasons to value factual reporting. Readers rely on the news to form their own views on political and social issues, and when a journalist's opinions are mixed into a report, the audience may be influenced without realising it. This is particularly concerning during elections or crises, when biased coverage can shape public opinion on a large scale. Strictly factual reporting also helps to rebuild trust in the media at a time when many people suspect that news outlets are pushing a particular agenda.

However, facts alone do not always tell the full story. A list of figures about inflation or a statement from a government minister may mean little to ordinary readers unless someone explains the context and possible consequences. Experienced journalists who have covered a subject for years is often well placed to offer this kind of insight. Removing all interpretation would leave audiences with information but little understanding.

The real problem, in my view, is not opinion itself but the failure to separate it clearly from news. Reputable newspapers usually distinguish between news articles and editorials or columns, allowing readers to know when they are reading an interpretation. Maintaining this distinction, and making it obvious on websites and social media, would address most of the concerns raised.

In conclusion, news reports should be based on facts, but I do not believe journalists' opinions should be banned entirely. Clearly labelled analysis and commentary help audiences to understand complex events and remain a valuable part of journalism.

Band 8

323 words

Nuanced, fully sustained position · ideas extended and logically developed · cohesion managed skilfully · wide, precise vocabulary · varied complex structures used accurately throughout.

Concerns about media bias and misinformation have prompted calls for news organisations to report nothing but verifiable facts, excluding the personal views of their journalists altogether. I agree that the core of news reporting should be factual and impartial, but I disagree that opinion should never appear, since informed commentary, when clearly identified, serves a valuable public function.

The argument for strict factual reporting is rooted in the democratic role of the press. Citizens depend on the news to understand events and hold those in power to account, and they are entitled to form their own conclusions. When commentary is woven into ostensibly neutral reports, readers may absorb a journalist's perspective without recognising it as such. This subtle blurring is arguably more damaging than openly partisan coverage, because it erodes the audience's ability to distinguish evidence from interpretation, and with it their trust in the media as a whole.

Yet it is naive to suppose that facts can be presented without any judgement. Deciding which stories to cover, which sources to quote and what context to include already involves editorial choices. Moreover, many issues, from climate policy to interest rates, are so complex that raw data offers little insight to non-specialists. A correspondent with years of experience can explain why an event matters and what its likely implications are, which enriches public understanding rather than distorting it.

The more sensible standard, therefore, is transparency rather than prohibition. News reports should strive for accuracy and balance, while analysis and opinion should be explicitly labelled and presented separately, as is the practice in most respected publications. The challenge in the digital age is to preserve this distinction when articles are shared on social media, often stripped of the labels that signal their purpose.

In conclusion, factual reporting should remain the foundation of journalism, but clearly marked opinion has a legitimate place. The priority should be to keep the two distinct, not to eliminate commentary entirely.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Identity checks on social media

Topic: Social media · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_12

Social media companies should be required to verify the real identity of every person who uses their platforms. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

268 words

Clear position with relevant reasons and drawbacks · ideas relevant but not fully developed · linking mechanical · adequate vocabulary · several comparative, agreement and word-form errors that do not block meaning.

Millions of people use social media every day, and many of them use fake names. Some people believe that social media companies should check the real identity of every user. I agree with this idea because it can make the internet more safer.

The first reason is that when people are anonymous, they often behave badly. They write rude comments, bully other users and spread false information, because they know nobody can find them. If companies verify the identity of every user, people will think more carefully before they post something. For example, a student who bully his classmate online would stop if he knows that his real name is shown.

The second reason is that verification can reduce crimes on the internet. There are many fake accounts which are used to cheat people or to steal their money. Also, some adults create false profiles to contact children. If every account is connected to a real person, the police can find the criminals more easy and the users will feel more protected.

However, there are some disadvantages. Some users worry about their privacy, because they have to give their ID card or passport to a company. If the company is hacked, this information can be stolen. Moreover, in some countries people use fake names to criticise the government safely, and verification can put them in danger.

In conclusion, I agree that social media companies should verify the real identity of users because it can reduce bullying and online crime. However, the companies must keep the personal information safe and they should not show the real names to everyone.

Band 7

314 words

Clear, consistent position · ideas extended and well supported · alternative solution offered · logical paragraphing and good cohesion · some less common vocabulary · frequent error-free sentences.

Online abuse, scams and fake accounts have become serious problems on social media, leading some people to argue that platforms should be required to verify the real identity of every user. Although I understand the reasons for this proposal, I largely disagree with it, since the risks to privacy and free expression outweigh the likely benefits.

Supporters of mandatory verification believe it would make users more accountable. When people know that their posts can be traced back to them, they may be less likely to harass others or spread deliberate misinformation. Verification could also make it harder for criminals to create multiple fake accounts for fraud, and it would help authorities to identify offenders more quickly.

However, the evidence that real names improve behaviour are limited. Many people already post offensive content under their own names, which suggests that anonymity is not the only

cause of online abuse. At the same time, requiring every user to upload identity documents would create huge databases of sensitive information, which could be targeted by hackers or misused by the companies themselves. A single data breach could expose the personal details of millions of people.

Anonymity also protects vulnerable groups. Whistle-blowers, victims of domestic abuse and people who live under authoritarian governments often rely on pseudonyms to speak freely without putting themselves in danger. For them, compulsory verification could mean choosing between silence and serious risk, which would be a significant loss for public debate.

A better approach would be for platforms to invest in faster moderation, to verify accounts only in specific cases, such as those used for advertising or selling products, and to cooperate with police when a crime is reported.

In conclusion, while identity checks might reduce some harmful behaviour, I do not believe they should be applied to every user. Targeted measures would protect people more effectively without sacrificing privacy and freedom of speech.

Band 8

323 words

Sophisticated position fully sustained · well-developed, logically sequenced ideas · counter-argument evaluated precisely · cohesion skilfully managed · wide, natural vocabulary · wide range of accurate structures.

As concerns grow about online harassment, fraud and coordinated disinformation, the idea of obliging social media companies to verify the real identity of every user has gained considerable support. I agree that anonymity is sometimes abused, but I disagree with universal verification, which I believe would create serious new harms while doing relatively little to address the existing ones.

The appeal of the proposal is understandable. Anonymous accounts can be created in seconds, allowing individuals to harass others, operate networks of fake profiles or impersonate legitimate businesses with little fear of consequence. Linking every account to a verified person would, in theory, restore a degree of accountability and make it easier for victims and law enforcement to pursue those responsible.

In practice, however, the relationship between anonymity and misconduct is weaker than often assumed. A great deal of abusive content is posted openly under users' real names, indicating that social norms and platform design shape behaviour at least as much as identifiability does. Meanwhile, compelling billions of users to submit passports or identity cards would concentrate highly sensitive data in the hands of private companies, whose record in safeguarding personal information is far from reassuring. The consequences of a breach on that scale could be severe.

Equally significant is the value of anonymity to those with legitimate reasons to conceal their identity. Journalists' sources, employees exposing wrongdoing and political dissidents in repressive states often depend on pseudonyms to speak at all. For such users, mandatory verification would not merely be inconvenient; it could expose them to retaliation, with a chilling effect on precisely the kind of speech that open societies should protect.

More proportionate measures are available: verification for accounts that advertise, sell goods or reach very large audiences, stronger moderation, and swift cooperation with courts when unlawful conduct is reported.

In conclusion, universal identity checks would be a blunt instrument whose costs to privacy and freedom of expression outweigh its limited benefits.

☐ Approved	☐ Needs changes	Notes:
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Funding traditional crafts

Topic: Culture · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_13

Governments should provide financial support for traditional arts and crafts, even when there is little public demand for them. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

273 words

Clear position with relevant main ideas · examples general and somewhat underdeveloped · counter-argument briefly addressed · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and word-form errors.

In many countries, traditional arts and crafts such as pottery, weaving and folk music are disappearing because not many people buy them anymore. Some people think the government should give money to support them, even if there are not much demand. I agree with this opinion.

Firstly, traditional arts are part of a country's culture and history. They show how our ancestors lived and what they believed. If nobody continues these crafts, the knowledge will be lost forever and the next generation will not know about their own tradition. For example, in my country there are some villages which are famous for making handmade carpets, but now only old people know how to make them. If the government help them, they can teach young people and keep the skill alive.

Secondly, traditional crafts can be good for tourism. Many tourists want to buy something special and local, not products made in factories. If the government supports the artists, they can make more products and sell them to tourists, and this will bring money to the country.

However, some people argue that the government has more important things to spend money on, like hospitals and schools. I agree that these things are more important, but the money for traditional arts is not very much compare to the whole budget. So I think it is possible to do both.

In conclusion, I believe that the government should provide financial support to traditional arts and crafts, even when people don't buy them much. They are an important part of our identity, and with some help they can also become a source of income in the future.

Band 7

302 words

Clear, qualified position maintained · ideas extended and supported · counter-argument integrated · logical paragraphing and cohesion · some less common vocabulary · generally accurate with an occasional agreement slip.

Traditional arts and crafts, such as hand-weaving, woodcarving and folk music, are declining in many parts of the world as mass-produced goods and modern entertainment become dominant. Some argue that governments should fund these activities even if public demand is low. I agree with this view to a large extent, although I believe such support should be designed to encourage self-sufficiency.

The most important reason for state support is that traditional crafts represent a form of cultural heritage that cannot be easily replaced. The techniques involved are often passed down orally from one generation to the next, and when the last skilled practitioners retire without apprentices, the knowledge disappears permanently. Unlike buildings, which can sometimes be restored, a lost craft is extremely difficult to revive. Low demand today does not

mean these skills have no value; it simply means the market fails to reflect their cultural importance.

Moreover, financial support can help traditional arts to find new audiences. With funding for training, exhibitions and online marketing, artisans can adapt their products for modern consumers or the tourist market, and some crafts have regained popularity in this way. Governments can also include traditional arts in school programmes, which increase awareness among young people.

On the other hand, public money is limited, and critics argue that it should be spent on essential services rather than on activities few people are interested in. This concern is reasonable, which is why funding should be targeted and relatively modest. Rather than paying artisans indefinitely, governments could offer grants that help them to become commercially viable over time.

In conclusion, I believe governments should support traditional arts and crafts even when demand is limited, because they are an irreplaceable part of cultural identity. However, this support should aim to help these traditions survive independently in the long term.

Band 8

315 words

Clear, well-qualified position throughout · ideas extended with apt analogy and illustration · logical sequencing · skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary · varied, accurate complex structures.

As global markets fill with inexpensive, mass-produced goods, many traditional arts and crafts are struggling to survive. Whether governments should fund them despite limited public demand is a question of how societies value their cultural inheritance. I agree that such support is justified, provided it is aimed at preservation and renewal rather than indefinite subsidy.

The strongest case for public funding is that traditional crafts embody knowledge that the market cannot adequately value. Techniques such as natural dyeing, instrument-making or regional embroidery have often been refined over centuries and are transmitted through years of apprenticeship rather than written manuals. Once the last generation of practitioners disappears, that knowledge is effectively irretrievable. Low demand at a given moment therefore says little about a craft's long-term worth, in the same way that a museum's value is not measured by its ticket sales.

Traditional arts also contribute to a community's identity and cohesion in ways that are difficult to quantify. Festivals, local markets and workshops centred on these crafts give places a distinctive character, foster pride among residents and can form the basis of cultural tourism. Targeted funding can help artisans reach new audiences, whether through collaborations with contemporary designers or through online platforms that connect them with buyers worldwide.

Admittedly, public budgets face competing demands, and it would be difficult to justify spending heavily on crafts while essential services are underfunded. There is also a risk that permanent subsidies preserve traditions in a lifeless, artificial form. These objections argue not against support altogether, but for designing it wisely: documenting endangered techniques, funding apprenticeships and helping practitioners develop sustainable businesses.

In conclusion, I believe governments should provide financial support for traditional arts and crafts even when demand is weak, since their cultural value far exceeds their current market value. The aim, however, should be to give these traditions a viable future rather than to keep them artificially alive.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Limiting tourist numbers

Topic: Tourism · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_opinion_14

Popular tourist destinations should limit the number of visitors allowed each year in order to protect local communities. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

277 words

Clear position throughout · relevant ideas with basic development · counter-argument briefly addressed · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several plural and agreement errors that do not block communication.

Tourism is a very big industry and many cities and islands are visited by millions of people every year. Some people think that famous tourist places should limit the number of tourists to protect the local people. I agree with this idea.

First of all, too many tourists cause a lot of problems for the local communities. The streets become very crowded, and local people cannot live their normal life. For example, in some famous old cities, residents cannot even walk to work or go shopping easily because there are tourists everywhere. Also, the prices of food and houses become very high, because many owners prefer to rent their apartments to tourists for more money. As a result, local families have to move away from the place where they grew up.

Secondly, a large number of tourist can damage the environment. They produce a lot of rubbish and use a lot of water and energy. Beautiful beaches and historical buildings can be destroyed if too many people visit them every day. If this happen, the place will not be attractive anymore, and in the future tourists will stop coming.

On the other hand, some people say that tourism bring money and jobs to the local people. This is true, but if the number is limited, the tourists can still come and spend money. The place can also increase the price of tickets so that it still earn enough money.

In conclusion, I agree that popular tourist destinations should limit the number of visitors every year. It will protect the local communities and the environment, and it will also help these places to stay beautiful for the future.

Band 7

305 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported with relevant examples · clear paragraph focus · good cohesion · some less common vocabulary · generally accurate with a minor linking slip.

In recent years, several popular destinations have struggled with overcrowding, and some people believe that annual limits on visitor numbers are needed to protect local communities. I agree with this view to a large extent, although I think such limits should be applied flexibly and combined with other measures.

The main argument for limiting visitors is the impact of mass tourism on residents' daily lives. In many historic cities and small islands, streets, public transport and beaches become so crowded during peak season that locals can no longer use them normally. In addition, the growth of short-term holiday rentals has pushed up housing costs, forcing many families and young people to leave the neighbourhoods where they have always lived. Without controls, some destinations risk becoming places that exist only for tourists.

Excessive tourism also damages the natural and cultural assets that attract visitors in the first place. Fragile environments, such as coral reefs and mountain trails, can suffer long-term harm from heavy use, while ancient sites deteriorate when thousands of people walk through them each day. Setting a maximum number of visitors can help preserve these places for future generations.

Nonetheless, tourism is a vital source of income for many communities, and a strict cap could lead to job losses in hotels, restaurants and shops. For this reason, limits should be carefully planned. Destinations could introduce daily quotas for the most vulnerable sites, charge higher fees during the busiest months, and encourage visitors to travel in the off-season or visit less well-known areas nearby. By this way, the economic benefit is spread more evenly.

In conclusion, I believe popular destinations are justified in limiting visitor numbers to protect local residents and the environment. However, these limits should be part of a wider strategy which balances the needs of communities with the economic advantages of tourism.

Band 8

306 words

Well-developed, nuanced position · ideas logically sequenced and fully supported · effective, precise cohesion · wide, natural vocabulary and collocation · complex structures used accurately and flexibly.

Few issues illustrate the tension between economic opportunity and quality of life as sharply as mass tourism. Some argue that the most popular destinations should cap the number of visitors each year to protect local communities. I agree with this principle, but I believe that rigid annual limits are often less effective than more targeted forms of visitor management.

There is little doubt that unchecked tourism can seriously undermine residents' wellbeing. In some historic cities, the conversion of apartments into holiday lets has driven up rents to the point where long-standing residents are priced out, while local shops give way to souvenir outlets. Overcrowded streets, congested public transport and constant noise can make everyday life exhausting. When a community begins to feel like a stage set for visitors, the very authenticity that attracted tourists is lost.

The environmental case is equally compelling. Coastal ecosystems, mountain paths and archaeological sites can absorb only so much footfall before suffering lasting damage. For such places, limiting access is not merely desirable but essential if they are to survive in any recognisable form.

However, a single annual quota is a rather crude tool. Tourist pressure is usually concentrated in particular seasons, days and districts, so a yearly cap may do little to relieve overcrowding at peak times while needlessly turning visitors away in quieter periods. It could also harm the many residents whose livelihoods depend on tourism. More refined measures, such as timed entry to key sites, daily limits on cruise-ship arrivals, restrictions on short-term rentals and higher fees in peak season, can address the specific sources of pressure while preserving the income that tourism brings.

In conclusion, popular destinations are right to control visitor numbers in order to protect their residents and environment. Yet this is best achieved through flexible, carefully targeted management rather than a blunt annual ceiling.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Practical or pure research?

Topic: Science · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_opinion_15

Scientific research should be funded according to its likely practical benefits rather than simply to increase human knowledge. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

270 words

Clear position with relevant example · ideas general and not fully extended · conclusion somewhat repetitive · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary with some awkward forms · several agreement and tense errors.

Governments and companies spend a lot of money on scientific research every year. Some people think this money should only go to research which has practical benefit, not research that only increase our knowledge. I disagree with this opinion.

Firstly, it is very difficult to know which research will be useful in the future. Many important inventions came from research that seemed to have no practical use at the beginning. For example, scientists studied electricity and light many years ago only because they were curious, but now we use this knowledge for computers, phones and medicine. If they only did research with clear benefit, we might not have this technology today.

Secondly, knowledge itself has value. Humans always want to understand the world, for example how the universe began or how the brain is working. This kind of research makes our life more rich and it inspires young people to study science. Also, pure research gives the base for practical research. Engineers and doctors use the discoveries of basic science to create new products and treatments.

However, I understand that the money for research is limited. When there are serious problems like diseases or climate change, it makes sense to give more money to research which can solve them quickly. People who pay taxes wants to see results from the money they give.

In conclusion, I disagree that scientific research should be funded only for practical benefits. Both kinds of research are important, and governments should give money to research that increase human knowledge as well, because in the future it can bring many benefits that we cannot imagine now.

Band 7

314 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas well extended with relevant historical illustration · logical progression · range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary · mostly accurate with one minor slip.

With limited public budgets, many people argue that scientific research should be funded according to its likely practical benefits rather than simply to expand human knowledge. While I accept that applied research deserves significant support, I disagree with making practical value the main criterion for funding decisions.

It is understandable why some prefer to focus on practical outcomes. Research is expensive, and governments must justify their spending to taxpayers who expect visible results, such as new medical treatments, cleaner energy or improved crops. When societies face urgent challenges like pandemics or climate change, directing money towards solving them seems both logical and responsible.

However, the history of science shows that the most transformative discoveries often come from research with no obvious application at the time. Scientists who investigated the structure of atoms or the behaviour of light were motivated largely by curiosity, yet their work eventually led to technologies ranging from medical imaging to the internet. Had funding been limited to projects with predictable benefits, many of these breakthroughs might never have happened. The problem is that practical value is extremely difficult to predict in advance.

Furthermore, basic research provides the foundation that applied science depends on. Engineers and medical researchers build on theories and data produced by scientists who were simply trying to understand how the natural world works. Reducing support for fundamental research would therefore weaken applied research in the long term, since there would be fewer new ideas to develop.

In my view, a balanced system is needed, in which a substantial part of funding goes to curiosity-driven research selected for its scientific quality, while specific programmes target pressing practical problems.

In conclusion, although practical benefits are important, I do not think they should determine all research funding. Supporting the expansion of knowledge for its own sake is essential, as it is frequently the source of the most valuable practical advances.

Band 8

318 words

Sophisticated argument with a clear position · ideas fully extended with precise, apt examples · logical sequencing and skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary · varied, accurate complex structures.

Decisions about which scientific research to fund have become increasingly contested, with some arguing that public money should be directed primarily towards projects likely to yield practical benefits. I disagree with this position. Although applied research clearly merits substantial investment, making practical utility the principal test for funding would, paradoxically, reduce the practical returns of science over time.

The case for prioritising applied research is not without force. Governments are accountable to taxpayers, and when resources are scarce it seems reasonable to favour work that promises better treatments, more efficient energy or safer infrastructure. In the face of pressing problems such as antibiotic resistance, research with clear objectives offers a tangible sense of progress.

The central difficulty, however, is that the usefulness of knowledge can rarely be foreseen. Many of the technologies that define modern life emerged from inquiries pursued for their own sake: studies of quantum behaviour made possible the semiconductors in every smartphone, while research into obscure bacteria provided the tools behind modern gene editing. No funding committee assessing these projects at the outset could have predicted such outcomes. A system that rewards only anticipated benefits would systematically overlook the unexpected discoveries that often prove most valuable.

Fundamental research also sustains the wider scientific ecosystem. It trains highly skilled researchers, generates the theoretical frameworks on which applied work depends and keeps a country at the frontier of knowledge. Moreover, there is intrinsic worth in understanding the origins of the universe or the workings of the mind, questions that reflect a basic human aspiration and inspire future generations of scientists.

The most sensible approach is therefore a portfolio: dedicated funding for mission-driven research on urgent problems, alongside secure support for curiosity-driven work judged on its

scientific merit.

In conclusion, while practical benefits matter, they should not be the dominant criterion for funding science, since the pursuit of knowledge itself remains the most reliable source of future innovation.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

A legal four-day week

Topic: Work-life balance · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_16

Employers should be legally required to allow staff to work a four-day week without any reduction in pay. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

278 words

Partly-agree position clear · relevant ideas on both sides, some underdeveloped · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several errors with verb patterns, comparatives and agreement that do not impede meaning.

In recent years, the idea of a four-day working week has become very popular. Some people think that the law should make all employers to give their workers a four-day week with the same salary. I partly agree with this idea.

On the one hand, a four-day week has many advantages for workers. People today are very stressed because they work long hours and they don't have enough time for their family and hobbies. With an extra day off, they can rest, do sport and spend time with their children. As a result, they will be more happy and healthy. Also, some companies which tried this system found that their employees worked more efficient and made less mistakes, so the productivity did not go down.

On the other hand, I don't think this should be a law for every employer. Some businesses cannot close one day in the week. For example, hospitals, restaurants and shops need workers every day. If they must give a four-day week without reducing pay, they have to hire more staff, and this is very expensive. Small companies especially may not have enough money and some of them can go bankrupt. Then the workers will lose their jobs, which is worse than working five days.

In my opinion, the government should encourage the companies to try the four-day week, for example by giving them some help or tax reduction, but it should not force them. Each company know its own situation better than the government.

In conclusion, I believe a four-day week can be good for employees, but it should not be required by law for all employers, because some businesses cannot afford it.

Band 7

291 words

Clear position maintained · ideas extended and supported, with some generalisation · logical organisation · good range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary and collocation · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

The four-day working week has attracted growing interest, and some people now argue that employers should be legally obliged to offer it without any cut in pay. Although I believe shorter working weeks can bring real benefits, I disagree that they should be imposed on all employers by law.

There is no doubt that a four-day week could improve employees' wellbeing. Many workers suffer from stress and exhaustion, and an extra day off would give them more time to rest, look after their families and pursue personal interests. Several companies that have experimented with the model report that staff became more focused and motivated, and that productivity stayed the same or even improved. A healthier and more satisfied workforce may also mean fewer sick days and lower staff turnover.

However, making this a legal requirement would ignore the huge differences between sectors. In offices where work can be reorganised, a four-day week may be relatively easy to introduce. But in hospitals, care homes, factories and shops, where services must be provided every day, reducing hours without cutting pay would mean hiring extra staff at considerable cost. Small businesses, which often operate on narrow profit margins, could struggle to survive, and some might respond by cutting jobs or raising prices.

A more practical solution would be for governments to encourage rather than force the change. They could support pilot schemes, share results with employers and perhaps give staff a legal right to request shorter hours, while leaving each organisation to decide what are workable.

In conclusion, a four-day week without loss of pay has clear advantages for employees, but a universal legal requirement would place an unfair burden on many businesses. Voluntary adoption, supported by government, is a more realistic way forward.

Band 8

317 words

Clear, nuanced position throughout · ideas fully developed with precise support · logical sequencing and skilful cohesion · wide, natural vocabulary · varied complex structures with rare minor errors at most.

Trials of the four-day week in various countries have produced encouraging results, prompting calls for employers to be legally required to offer it with no reduction in pay. While I am broadly sympathetic to the aims of this proposal, I disagree that it should be made compulsory, since a universal mandate would fail to account for the diversity of modern workplaces.

The potential benefits are considerable. Long working hours are associated with stress, burnout and poorer physical health, and an additional day of rest could allow employees to recover, care for relatives and engage more fully in family and community life. Many organisations that have adopted a shorter week report that staff concentrate more effectively, waste less time in unnecessary meetings and are less likely to leave, suggesting that output need not fall when hours do. For knowledge-based work in particular, time spent at a desk is a poor measure of productivity.

However, these results come largely from firms that chose to participate and were able to reorganise their work accordingly. The picture is very different in sectors where output is tied directly to hours, such as healthcare, retail, hospitality and manufacturing. A hospital cannot simply provide twenty per cent less care; to maintain services on full pay, it would need to recruit additional staff, often in areas already facing shortages. For small businesses with tight margins, the added cost could lead to redundancies or closure, ultimately harming the workers the policy is meant to help.

A more effective approach would be to promote the four-day week through incentives and evidence rather than compulsion. Governments could fund pilot programmes, publish their findings and give employees a statutory right to request flexible arrangements, which employers could refuse only on reasonable grounds.

In conclusion, a four-day week may well represent the future of work in many industries, but legislating it for every employer would be premature and potentially damaging.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Renting versus home ownership

Topic: Housing · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_17

Governments should focus on improving the quality and security of rented housing rather than helping young people to buy their own homes. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

282 words

Position mostly clear though slightly hedged in conclusion · relevant ideas, some general · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays it is very difficult for young people to buy a house because the prices are very high. Some people think the government should improve rented housing instead of helping young people to buy their own homes. I agree with this opinion to some extent.

Firstly, many young people cannot buy a house even with help from the government. They have low salaries at the start of their career and they cannot save enough money for a deposit. If the government give them a small amount of money, the house prices will probably go up and the problem will not be solved. So it is more useful to make rented houses better, because many young people will rent for a long time anyway.

Secondly, the quality of rented houses in many cities is quite bad. Some apartments are old, cold and have problems like damp walls. Also, landlords can increase the rent or ask the tenants to leave with a short notice. This make people feel stressed and they cannot plan their life. If the government make rules to protect tenants and improve the condition of houses, the life of millions of people will become better.

However, owning a home is still a dream for many people. A house gives people security for the future and they don't have to pay rent when they are old. So I think the government should not stop helping completely, for example they can help people who buy their first home with low price.

In conclusion, I mostly agree that the government should focus on the quality and security of rented houses, because this help more people. But some help for young buyers is also necessary.

Band 7

310 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported · clear central topic in each paragraph · range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary · mostly accurate with a minor pronoun slip.

As property prices have risen faster than incomes in many countries, home ownership has become increasingly unattainable for young people. Some argue that governments should therefore concentrate on improving the quality and security of rented housing rather than on helping young people buy homes. I largely agree with this view.

One key reason is that schemes to help first-time buyers often fail to achieve their aims. Grants or subsidised loans increase the amount that buyers can spend, but if the supply of housing does not increase, the main effect is simply to push prices higher. Such schemes also tend to benefit those who were already close to affording a home, while doing little for young people on lower incomes, who may never be able to buy.

By contrast, improving the rental sector would benefit a much larger number of people. In many cities, a growing proportion of young adults rent for most of their twenties and thirties, yet they often live in poorly maintained properties and face sudden rent increases or eviction at short notice. Introducing minimum standards for housing quality, longer tenancy agreements and limits on excessive rent rises would give tenants the stability to settle, start families and plan for the future. In several European countries, where renting is secure and well regulated, it is considered a normal long-term option rather than a temporary stage.

That said, home ownership remains important for financial security, particularly in retirement, when people without property must continue paying rent on a reduced income. Governments should therefore not abandon support for buyers entirely, but it should focus on increasing the overall supply of affordable homes.

In conclusion, I agree that improving rented housing should be the priority, since it would help more young people more quickly and effectively. Support for home ownership should be a secondary goal, achieved mainly through building more homes.

Band 8

315 words

Well-reasoned, qualified position fully sustained · ideas extended and logically sequenced · precise, well-managed cohesion · wide, natural vocabulary · wide range of accurate complex structures.

In many countries, soaring property prices have put home ownership beyond the reach of a generation of young adults. One response is to argue that governments should prioritise making rented housing better and more secure, rather than trying to help young people onto the property ladder. I agree with this view to a considerable extent, although I believe the two goals are more connected than the statement suggests.

The weakness of many home-ownership schemes lies in their effect on prices. When governments offer deposit grants or subsidised mortgages without increasing the supply of homes, they largely add to demand, and much of the benefit is absorbed by higher prices. These policies also tend to favour those already on the verge of buying, offering little to young people on modest or insecure incomes, and they can be costly for the public purse.

Improving the rental sector, in contrast, would directly benefit the millions of young people who rent, many of them for far longer than previous generations did. Too often they face damp or poorly insulated homes, unpredictable rent increases and the constant possibility of being asked to leave. Enforceable quality standards, longer and more secure tenancies and protection against arbitrary eviction would allow tenants to put down roots, enrol children in local schools and plan their lives with confidence. Where renting is well regulated, as in parts of continental Europe, it is regarded as a respectable long-term choice rather than a precarious stopgap.

Ownership nonetheless matters, not least because retired people who rent must meet housing costs from a reduced income. The most effective way to support it, however, is not through demand-side subsidies but by building more homes, which would also ease pressure on rents.

In conclusion, governments should make secure, decent rented housing their immediate priority, while pursuing wider access to ownership through increasing housing supply rather than through subsidies for individual buyers.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

National food self-sufficiency

Topic: Globalisation · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_opinion_18

In a globalised world, it is no longer necessary for every country to produce enough food to feed its own population. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

283 words

Clear position with relevant ideas · examples general and not fully extended · conclusion slightly repetitive · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors that do not block meaning.

Today countries trade with each other more than ever before, and food can be imported easily from all over the world. Some people believe that because of this, it is not necessary for each country to produce enough food for its own people. I disagree with this idea.

The main reason is that depending on other countries for food is risky. If there is a war, a natural disaster or a political problem, the imports can stop suddenly. For example, during the pandemic, many countries closed their borders and some food products became very expensive or difficult to find in the shops. If a country cannot produce its own food, its people can suffer from hunger in this kind of situation.

Another reason is that farming gives jobs to many people, especially in the countryside. If a country buy all its food from abroad, the farmers will lose their jobs and they will move to the cities to find work. This can make the cities more crowded and the villages will become empty. Also, the traditional way of life in rural areas will disappear.

On the other hand, it is true that some countries cannot produce all their food because they have a dry climate or not enough land. For them, import is necessary and it can be cheaper. But I think they should still try to produce the most important foods, such as rice or wheat, as much as possible.

In conclusion, I do not agree that it is no longer necessary for countries to produce enough food for their people. Although import is useful, every country should try to be independent in food so that they are safe in difficult times.

Band 7

313 words

Clear partly-agree position maintained · ideas extended and supported · logical organisation · range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary · frequent error-free sentences with one agreement slip.

Global trade has made it possible for countries to import food from almost anywhere, leading some to argue that national self-sufficiency in food is no longer necessary. I partly agree with this view: complete self-sufficiency is unrealistic and often inefficient, but I believe every country should still maintain a significant capacity to feed its population.

It is true that international trade brings important benefits. Countries differ greatly in climate, soil and water resources, and it makes economic sense for each to specialise in what it can produce most efficiently. A desert nation that tried to grow all its own grain would waste enormous amounts of water and money, whereas importing it from countries with fertile land is far cheaper. Trade also gives consumers access to a wider variety of food throughout the year, and it can help stabilise supplies when one region experiences a poor harvest.

However, relying heavily on imports leaves a country vulnerable to events beyond its control. Wars, trade disputes and pandemics can disrupt supply chains suddenly, and in recent years export bans by major producers have caused sharp price rises for staple foods in many importing countries. Poorer nations are particularly exposed, as they may be unable to compete for limited supplies when global prices increase. In such situations, a strong domestic farming sector can act as essential insurance.

Furthermore, agriculture supports rural employment and communities, and abandoning it entirely could lead to economic decline in the countryside and the loss of valuable farming knowledge.

For these reasons, I believe the sensible approach is a balance: countries should trade for food where it is efficient, but ensure that they can produce enough of their basic staples, or hold sufficient reserves, to cope with a crisis.

In conclusion, although globalisation means that total self-sufficiency is no longer essential, I do not think countries can safely abandon domestic food production altogether.

Band 8

311 words

Nuanced, precisely stated position · ideas fully extended and logically sequenced · effective cohesion and paragraphing · wide, accurate vocabulary · varied complex structures with no noticeable errors.

The expansion of global trade has transformed how food reaches our tables, and some now argue that national food self-sufficiency has become an outdated goal. I agree that complete self-sufficiency is neither necessary nor, for many countries, achievable. However, I disagree with the broader implication that nations can safely neglect their capacity to feed themselves.

There is a strong economic logic to relying on trade. Agricultural conditions vary enormously, and forcing every country to grow all its own food would be highly inefficient. Arid or densely populated states would need to divert scarce water and land to crops that can be produced far more cheaply elsewhere, raising prices for their own citizens. Open markets allow resources to be used where they are most productive and can cushion the impact of a failed harvest in any one region by drawing on supplies from others.

Yet the assumption that global markets will always function smoothly is a dangerous one. Food supply chains are long and interdependent, and they have repeatedly proved fragile in the face of conflict, extreme weather and pandemics. When supplies tighten, exporting countries often prioritise their own populations by restricting sales abroad, precisely when importers need them most. Nations with weak domestic production and limited purchasing power are the first to suffer, and food shortages can quickly lead to social unrest.

Climate change is likely to heighten these risks, as droughts and floods disrupt harvests in major producing regions more frequently. In this context, maintaining a viable farming sector, diversifying import sources and holding strategic reserves are prudent forms of insurance rather than economic nationalism.

In conclusion, globalisation has made total self-sufficiency unnecessary, but it has not removed the need for food security. Each country should aim for sufficient domestic capacity and resilience to withstand disruption, even if it continues to rely on trade for much of what it consumes.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Do we still need libraries?

Topic: Public services · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_opinion_19

Public libraries are no longer necessary because most information is now available online. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

286 words

Clear, consistent position · relevant main ideas with some personal illustration · development limited in places · mechanical linking (Firstly, Secondly, Thirdly) · adequate vocabulary · several determiner and agreement errors.

Nowadays people can find almost any information on the internet with their phones or computers. For this reason, some people think that public libraries are not necessary any more. I strongly disagree with this opinion.

Firstly, not everyone has access to the internet at home. Some families are poor and they cannot pay for a computer or a good internet connection. For these people, the library is the only place where they can use computers for free, search for jobs or do their homework. If libraries are closed, this people will have fewer chance to improve their life.

Secondly, libraries are not only a place for books. They are also a quiet place for students to study, especially for those who live in small houses with big families. In my city, the library is always full of university students during exam period, because they can concentrate there better than at home. Also, libraries organise many activities like reading clubs for children, language classes and events for old people. These activities help people to meet each other and feel part of the community.

Thirdly, not all information on the internet is reliable. There are many fake news and wrong information online. In the library, the books are chosen carefully and librarians can help people to find good sources for their research.

Some people say that libraries cost a lot of money for the government. But I think this money is a good investment because libraries give education and support to everyone.

In conclusion, I disagree that public libraries are no longer necessary. Even though a lot of information is online, libraries still provide free access, a place to study and community activities, so we should keep them.

Band 7

303 words

Strong position maintained throughout · main ideas extended and supported · clear paragraph topics and logical progression · good range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary · few errors.

With the vast amount of information now available online, some people claim that public libraries have become unnecessary. I strongly disagree with this view, as libraries provide important services that the internet cannot replace.

Firstly, libraries play a crucial role in providing equal access to information. Although internet use is widespread, a significant number of people still lack a reliable connection or a suitable device at home, particularly the elderly people and low-income families. For them, the local library offers free computers, printing and Wi-Fi, allowing them to apply for jobs, access government services and complete school assignments. Without libraries, the gap between those who are connected and those who are not would likely widen.

Secondly, the internet contains a great deal of information, but much of it is inaccurate or misleading. Librarians are trained to help people find reliable sources and to evaluate what they read, which is an increasingly valuable skill in the age of misinformation. Libraries also give free access to books, academic journals and databases that would otherwise be expensive, which benefits students and researchers alike.

In addition, libraries serve as community spaces. They offer a quiet environment for studying, host activities such as story sessions for young children and digital skills classes for older adults, and provide a safe, welcoming place for people to meet. In an era where many people feel isolated, these functions are arguably more important than ever.

Admittedly, libraries need to adapt to changing habits, for example by expanding their digital collections and offering more flexible opening hours. However, this is a reason to modernise them, not to close them.

In conclusion, I firmly believe that public libraries remain necessary despite the growth of online information. They ensure fair access to knowledge, support reliable research and strengthen local communities in ways the internet cannot.

Band 8

312 words

Fully developed, well-argued position · ideas extended and logically sequenced · premise of the statement challenged skilfully · cohesion managed smoothly · wide, precise vocabulary · varied structures with no noticeable errors.

The claim that public libraries have been rendered obsolete by the internet rests on the assumption that their sole purpose is to supply information. I disagree with this view. While the internet has undoubtedly changed how people find information, libraries continue to fulfil social, educational and democratic functions that online resources cannot replicate.

Perhaps the most important of these is ensuring equal access. It is easy to assume that everyone is online, yet many households still lack a reliable connection, an adequate device or the skills needed to use them effectively. As more essential services, from job applications to benefit claims, move online, a library's free computers and trained staff become a lifeline for those at risk of being left behind. Closing libraries would therefore deepen existing inequalities at the very moment when digital participation has become essential.

Libraries also address a problem the internet has intensified rather than solved: the difficulty of distinguishing reliable information from falsehood. Librarians guide users towards credible sources and help them develop the critical skills to evaluate what they read. Moreover, much high-quality content, including many academic journals and recent books, remains behind paywalls, and libraries make it freely available to anyone.

Beyond information, libraries function as some of the few remaining public spaces that are open to everyone and require no payment. Students without a quiet place to study at home, parents attending reading sessions with toddlers and older people seeking company all rely on them. In an increasingly fragmented society, such shared spaces help sustain a sense of community.

This is not to suggest that libraries should remain unchanged. They must continue to evolve, expanding digital lending and offering training in technology. But adaptation is an argument for investment, not closure.

In conclusion, public libraries remain necessary because their value extends far beyond information retrieval, encompassing equality of access, digital literacy and community life.

☐ Approved	☐ Needs changes	Notes:
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Discouraging overconsumption

Topic: Consumerism · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_opinion_20

Governments should take action to discourage people from buying more goods than they actually need. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Band 6

290 words

Partly-agree position clear though not strongly developed · relevant ideas on both sides with general support · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement, comparative and quantifier errors that do not block meaning.

In modern society, many people buy more things than they really need, such as clothes, electronic devices and household items. Some people think that the government should do something to stop this behaviour. I agree with this idea to some extent.

On the one hand, buying too many goods is bad for the environment. Factories use a lot of energy and natural resources to make products, and they produce pollution. When people throw away things that they don't use, the rubbish goes to the landfill and it takes many years to break down. For example, many people buy new clothes every month and wear them only a few times. If the government reduces this, the environment will be cleaner.

Also, overconsumption can cause problems for people themselves. Some people spend all their money on shopping and they have debts because of their credit cards. The government can help them by teaching about money management in schools or by controlling advertisements which make people want to buy more.

On the other hand, I think the government should not control people's life too much. People work hard and they have the right to decide how to spend their own money. Moreover, if people buy less, many shops and factories will have less customers and workers can lose their jobs. This can be bad for the economy of the country.

In my opinion, the government can encourage people to buy less by education and by making companies produce products that last longer, but it should not force people.

In conclusion, I partly agree that the government should discourage people from buying things they don't need. It can use soft methods like education, but people should still be free to make their own choices.

Band 7

293 words

Clear position throughout · ideas extended with relevant, specific measures · counter-argument addressed · logical paragraphing · range of cohesive devices · some less common vocabulary · mostly accurate with one verb-form slip.

In many wealthy societies, people routinely buy clothes, gadgets and other goods that they rarely use, and some argue that governments should take steps to discourage this. I agree with this view to a large extent, as excessive consumption causes environmental and social problems that individuals alone are unlikely to solve.

The most serious consequence of overconsumption is its impact on the environment. Every product requires raw materials, energy and transport, and many items, such as cheap fashion and short-lived electronics, are thrown away after a short period. This contributes to pollution, the depletion of natural resources and overflowing landfill sites. Since these costs are not

reflected in the price consumers pay, there is a strong case for government intervention to correct this.

Governments are also well placed to influence behaviour on a large scale. They could require manufacturers to make products that last longer and can be repaired, introduce taxes on goods with a high environmental impact, or restrict aggressive advertising techniques that create artificial needs. Supporting repair shops, second-hand markets and rental services would make it easier for people to consume less without feeling they are missing out.

Critics argue that such measures interfere with personal freedom and could harm economic growth, as many jobs depend on consumer spending. These concerns are valid, and governments should avoid telling people what they may or may not buy. However, encouraging more sustainable habits does not mean banning shopping; it means shifting the economy towards durable goods and services, which can also create employment, for example in repair and recycling.

In conclusion, I believe governments should discourage people from buying more than they need, mainly by encouraging durability, reducing waste and regulating advertising. Such measures can protect the environment while still respecting individual choice.

Band 8

318 words

Clear, well-qualified position throughout · ideas extended with precise examples · objections evaluated rather than merely listed · skilful cohesion · wide, natural vocabulary · accurate, varied complex structures.

Consumer culture in many prosperous countries encourages people to buy far more than they need, from fast fashion to frequently upgraded phones. The suggestion that governments should actively discourage this behaviour raises questions about both sustainability and personal freedom. On balance, I agree that intervention is justified, provided it targets the systems that drive overconsumption rather than policing individual purchases.

The environmental argument is compelling. The production, shipping and disposal of consumer goods account for a considerable share of resource use and emissions, and the problem is aggravated by products designed to be replaced rather than repaired. A garment worn a handful of times before being discarded, or a device abandoned because a single component has failed, represents a significant waste of materials and energy. Because these environmental costs are largely borne by society rather than by the buyer, the market alone has little incentive to correct them.

Governments possess tools that individuals do not. Legislation requiring durability, access to spare parts and a right to repair would extend the life of countless products. Tax policy could make repair and second-hand goods cheaper relative to new ones, while tighter rules on advertising, particularly the targeted online promotions that exploit impulse buying, would reduce the constant pressure to acquire more. Measures of this kind reshape the choices available without dictating what anyone must buy.

The main objections are that such policies infringe personal liberty and threaten economic growth. The first is less persuasive when intervention focuses on product standards and marketing rather than consumer decisions. The second deserves more attention, since many jobs depend on retail spending, but a shift towards repair, refurbishment and services can generate employment of its own.

In conclusion, governments are right to discourage excessive consumption, though the most effective and legitimate way to do so is by changing how goods are made and marketed, rather than by restricting what people are allowed to buy.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Foreign languages in primary school

Topic: Education · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_discussion_01

Some people believe that children should begin learning a foreign language at primary school. Others think it is better for them to start at secondary school. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

295 words

Discusses both views and gives a clear opinion · ideas relevant but rather general · mechanical linking (Firstly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · several errors in comparatives, articles and agreement that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, learning a foreign language is very important in the modern world. Some people think children should start to learn it in primary school, while other people believe secondary school is a better time. In this essay I will discuss both views and give my opinion.

On the one hand, there are some reasons why starting at secondary school can be better. Firstly, older students are more mature and they can understand grammar rules more easier. For example, a twelve years old student can study by himself and use a dictionary. Secondly, young children already have many subjects to learn, like maths and their mother language, so adding another language can make them confused. Also, many primary schools do not have enough qualified teachers, so the lessons may be not good quality.

On the other hand, many people think that primary school is the best time. Young children can learn new sounds very quickly and they are not shy to speak. That is why children who learn English early usually have a better pronunciation than adults. In addition, if they start early, they will have more years to practise, and by the time they finish school they can speak fluently. Learning language can also be fun for children because teachers use songs and games.

In my opinion, I believe that it is better to start at primary school. Although older students understand grammar better, the advantage of young age is more important, especially for speaking and listening. However, the government should make sure there is enough good teachers.

In conclusion, both views have some good points. Older students can learn grammar easily, but young children learn speaking more naturally. I think children should begin a foreign language in primary school if the teaching is good.

Band 7

308 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant support · logical paragraphing with a clear central idea · some less common collocations · mostly error-free sentences with one agreement slip.

There is ongoing debate about the ideal age at which children should start studying a foreign language. While some argue that secondary school is the more appropriate stage, I believe that introducing languages in primary school brings greater long-term benefits, provided it is done well.

Those who favour a later start point to the cognitive maturity of older pupils. Teenagers are able to grasp abstract grammatical concepts, use learning strategies such as keeping vocabulary notebooks, and take responsibility for their own progress. As a result, they can often

cover in two or three years what younger learners take much longer to achieve. There is also a practical argument: primary timetables are already crowded with literacy and numeracy, and some educators worry that a second language might distract young children from mastering their mother tongue.

However, advocates of an early start emphasise the natural advantages of youth. Young children tend to imitate sounds effortlessly and are far less self-conscious about making mistakes, which means they are more willing to speak. A child who hears and repeats a language from the age of six or seven is likely to develop more accurate pronunciation and greater confidence than someone who begins at thirteen. Furthermore, an early start gives learners many more years of exposure, which is arguably the most important factor in achieving fluency.

In my view, the benefits of starting in primary school outweigh the drawbacks. The concern about overloading children can be addressed by keeping lessons short, playful and focused on listening and speaking, with formal grammar introduced later. The real challenge is the shortage of well-trained teachers, and this is something that governments need to invest in.

In conclusion, although older learners have certain analytical advantages, I am convinced that children should begin learning a foreign language at primary school, as long as the teaching suits their age.

Band 8

333 words

Fully addresses both views with well-developed, supported arguments · skilful sequencing and paragraphing · precise, flexible vocabulary · wide range of accurate complex structures · nuanced opinion sustained throughout.

Few educational questions generate as much debate as when a child should first encounter a foreign language. Some maintain that it should be introduced in primary school, whereas others contend that it is more sensible to wait until secondary level. Having weighed both positions, I would argue that an early start is preferable, although its success depends on how it is implemented.

The case for delaying language study rests largely on the capabilities of older learners. By the age of eleven or twelve, pupils have developed the analytical skills needed to understand how a language is structured, and they can apply techniques such as comparing its grammar with that of their first language. This allows them to make rapid, systematic progress. Moreover, deferring a second language gives younger children time to consolidate reading and writing in their mother tongue, a foundation on which all later learning depends. From this perspective, early lessons may consume valuable classroom time without producing meaningful results.

Nevertheless, there are compelling reasons to begin sooner. Young children acquire language largely through imitation and play, and they are generally uninhibited about experimenting with unfamiliar sounds. Consequently, those who start early often develop more natural pronunciation and a more intuitive feel for the language than learners who begin in adolescence, when embarrassment can hold them back. An early start also provides more years of exposure, and sustained contact over a long period is what ultimately produces confident, fluent speakers.

On balance, I find the second argument more persuasive. The concerns raised about primary-level teaching are genuine, but they relate to poor delivery rather than to the principle itself. If lessons are brief, oral and enjoyable, and are led by properly trained teachers, they complement rather than compete with literacy in the first language.

In conclusion, while older pupils learn grammar more efficiently, the advantages of early exposure are difficult to replicate later in life. Children should therefore begin a foreign language in primary school, with formal study left to secondary level.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

The purpose of universities

Topic: Universities · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_02

Some people think that the main purpose of a university is to prepare students for employment. Others believe that universities should give people the opportunity to pursue knowledge for its own sake. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

284 words

Both views covered and an opinion given · supporting points relevant but general · repetitive conclusion · mechanical linking (Firstly, Secondly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors.

In today's society, many students go to university. Some people say that the main aim of university is to prepare students for a job, but others think it should be a place where people can learn knowledge for its own sake. This essay will discuss both opinions.

Firstly, people who think university is for employment have strong reasons. University education is very expensive and many students take a loan to pay the fees. So they expect to find a good job with high salary after graduation. Also, companies need workers who has practical skills, for example in engineering, medicine or computer science. If universities only teach theory, the graduates will not be ready for work and the economy will suffer.

Secondly, other people believe that university should be a place for learning any subject which students are interested in. Subjects like history, philosophy or literature does not lead directly to a job, but they help people to think critically and understand the world. In addition, many important discoveries in science was made by researchers who were only curious and did not think about money. If universities focus only on jobs, this kind of research may disappear.

In my opinion, I think both purposes are important, but preparing for employment should be the main purpose. Most of students go to university because they want a better career, and it is fair that universities help them. However, universities should still keep some space for pure knowledge and research.

In conclusion, some people think universities are for jobs, and others think they are for knowledge. Although both views have advantage, I believe employment is the main purpose, but knowledge for its own sake should not be forgotten.

Band 7

298 words

Clear position maintained · both views developed with relevant examples · well-organised paragraphs with clear topics · good range of collocations · frequent error-free sentences with one minor slip.

Universities today face competing expectations. Many people see them primarily as training grounds for the workforce, while others insist that their true value lies in the pursuit of knowledge for its own sake. Although I accept that employability matters, I believe universities should not be reduced to vocational institutions.

Supporters of the employment-focused view make a reasonable case. Higher education has become costly, and students who graduate with considerable debt understandably want courses that lead to secure, well-paid work. Employers, too, frequently complain that graduates lack practical skills such as teamwork, project management or familiarity with industry software. From this perspective, a university that ignores the job market is failing both its students and the wider economy.

On the other hand, there are strong arguments for protecting learning that has no immediate practical purpose. Disciplines such as philosophy, history and pure mathematics develop the ability to analyse complex problems, question assumptions and communicate ideas clearly, qualities that are valued in almost any career. Moreover, much of the research that has transformed modern life began as curiosity-driven enquiry, with no commercial application in mind at the time. If funding and teaching are directed only towards what is currently profitable, society risks losing the foundations of future innovation.

In my opinion, the two goals are less opposed than they first appear. A literature student can still gain transferable skills through internships and careers guidance, while an engineering student benefits from exploring the ethical and historical context of their field. Universities should therefore offer practical preparation without abandoning their commitment to independent thought.

To conclude, while preparing graduates for employment is an important function of universities, I believe it should not be the main or only one, since the pursuit of knowledge itself brings long-term benefits to individuals and to society.

Band 8

333 words

Both views fully explored with extended, well-supported reasoning · clear, nuanced position · logical progression and well-managed paragraphs · sophisticated, precise vocabulary · wide range of structures, virtually error-free.

The role of higher education has become increasingly contested as tuition costs rise and labour markets change. One camp holds that a university exists chiefly to equip students for employment; another maintains that it should be a place where knowledge is pursued for its own sake. In my view, a university that sacrifices the latter in favour of the former undermines what makes it distinctive.

It is easy to see why the employment argument resonates. For most undergraduates, a degree represents a substantial financial commitment, and it is reasonable for them to expect that it will improve their career prospects. Governments that subsidise higher education likewise want a return on that investment in the form of skilled professionals, whether doctors, engineers or data analysts. Seen in this light, courses detached from the needs of the economy can appear to be an expensive luxury.

However, this view rests on a narrow conception of usefulness. Many of the capabilities employers prize most, such as the capacity to evaluate evidence, construct an argument and adapt to unfamiliar problems, are cultivated precisely through open-ended academic study rather than job-specific training. Furthermore, skills tailored to today's labour market may be obsolete within a decade, whereas a deep understanding of a discipline endures. At the level of society, fundamental research undertaken without any commercial aim has repeatedly laid the groundwork for later technological breakthroughs.

For these reasons, I believe the pursuit of knowledge should remain at the heart of a university's mission, with employability treated as a valuable by-product rather than the overriding objective. This does not mean ignoring students' career needs; work placements and professional guidance can sit comfortably alongside rigorous academic study. What should be resisted is the notion that a subject is worthwhile only if it leads directly to a particular job.

In conclusion, although universities clearly have a role in preparing people for work, their deeper and more enduring purpose is to advance and share knowledge, which ultimately serves both individuals and the economy better.

☐ Approved	☐ Needs changes	Notes:
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Smartphones for young children

Topic: Children / Technology · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_discussion_03

Some people think that children should be given their own smartphone as soon as they start school. Others believe that children should not have one until they are teenagers. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

283 words

Addresses both views with a clear opinion · relevant points but limited development · simple, mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary with some repetition · several errors in articles, pronouns and verb forms.

Nowadays smartphones are part of everyday life, even for children. Some people think that children should have their own phone when they start school, but others believe they should wait until they become teenager. I will discuss both sides and give my own opinion.

There are some reasons why parents give phones to young children. The main reason is safety. If a child has a phone, parents can call them anytime and know where they are, especially when they walk to school alone. In addition, smartphones have many educational apps which can help children to learn maths or reading in an interesting way. Some parents also think that if all other children in the class has a phone, their child will feel left out without one.

However, many people think young children are too young for smartphones. Firstly, spending a lot of time on screen is bad for children's eyes and it can reduce the time they spend playing outside or sleeping. Secondly, children cannot protect themselves on the internet. They might see violent videos or talk to strangers without understand the danger. Moreover, phones can be very addictive and children may lose the concentration in class.

In my opinion, children should not have their own smartphone until they are teenagers. For safety, parents can give them a simple phone that can only make calls and send messages. When they are older, they are more responsible and parents can teach them how to use internet safely.

In conclusion, smartphones have some benefits for young children, like safety and learning, but the dangers are more serious. So I believe it is better for children to wait until teenage years before they get a smartphone.

Band 7

306 words

Clear position throughout · both sides extended and supported · logical organisation with clear paragraph topics · good collocations (screen time, online risks) · mostly accurate complex sentences with two minor slips.

Deciding when a child should receive their first smartphone has become a common dilemma for modern parents. Some argue that phones should be given as soon as children start school, while others feel they should be delayed until the teenage years. In my view, the latter approach is wiser, although a basic phone may be useful earlier.

Those who favour giving smartphones at a young age usually stress safety and convenience. A phone allows parents to contact their children at any time and, with location-sharing apps, to know exactly where they are. This can be particularly reassuring for working parents whose children travel to school or activities independently. Supporters also point out that many educational apps make learning interactive and enjoyable, and that children who grow up with

technology will be better prepared for a digital world.

Nevertheless, there are serious concerns about young children owning such devices. Smartphones are designed to hold attention, and a six-year-old has limited ability to control how long they spend on games or videos. Excessive screen time is widely linked to poor sleep, reduced physical activity and difficulty concentrating. In addition, young children are poorly equipped to recognise online risks, such as inappropriate content or contact from strangers, and parental controls are rarely fool proof.

In my opinion, the risks for young children clearly outweigh the benefits. The safety argument is valid, but it can be met with a simple phone that only makes calls and sends texts. By the early teenage years, children are more mature, and parents can gradually introduce a smartphone with clear rules and open conversations about responsible use.

In conclusion, while early smartphone ownership offers some practical advantages, I believe children should generally wait until they are teenagers, using a basic phone in the meantime if they need to stay in contact with their parents.

Band 8

332 words

Both views thoroughly developed and weighed · well-reasoned opinion with practical alternatives · seamless cohesion and logical sequencing · wide, precise vocabulary · wide range of accurate complex structures.

The age at which children should be given a smartphone is a question that divides parents and educators. One view is that a child should have their own device from the first day of school; the opposing view is that ownership should be postponed until adolescence. While both positions reflect genuine concern for children's welfare, I believe that delaying full smartphone access is the more responsible course.

Advocates of early ownership frame the issue in terms of security and preparation. A smartphone enables parents to stay in touch with their children throughout the day and to track their location, which offers considerable peace of mind. There is also an argument that digital literacy is now as fundamental as reading, and that children who become familiar with technology early will navigate it more competently later. Finally, some parents fear that a child without a phone will be socially isolated if most classmates already own one.

Those who favour waiting, however, raise concerns that are harder to dismiss. Young children lack the self-discipline to limit their own screen time, and devices engineered to maximise engagement can easily displace sleep, outdoor play and face-to-face interaction, all of which are vital for healthy development. Equally worrying is children's vulnerability online: a seven-year-old is unlikely to recognise manipulative content or the risks of communicating with strangers, and even well-configured parental controls can be circumvented.

Weighing these arguments, I am persuaded that the risks of early ownership outweigh its advantages. The legitimate need for contact can be met by a basic handset without internet access, and digital skills can be taught under supervision at school or at home. Once children reach their early teens, a smartphone can be introduced gradually, with agreed limits that are relaxed as they demonstrate responsibility.

In conclusion, although giving young children smartphones offers reassurance and convenience, these benefits can be achieved in safer ways. Postponing ownership until the teenage years allows children to develop the maturity they need to use such devices wisely.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

AI in recruitment decisions

Topic: Artificial intelligence · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_discussion_04

Some people argue that decisions about which job applicants to employ should be made by artificial intelligence because it is more objective than humans. Others believe that such decisions should always be made by people. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

278 words

Both views discussed and opinion stated · relevant ideas with simple examples but limited depth · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several article, agreement and word-order errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays many companies use technology in recruitment. Some people think artificial intelligence should decide which job applicants to hire because it is more objective than humans. However, others believe people should always make this decision. This essay will discuss both views.

On the one hand, AI has some advantages in choosing employees. Human managers sometimes have bias, for example they may prefer a candidate who is from same city or university as them. A computer program does not have feelings, so it can judge all applicants by the same rules. In addition, AI can read thousands of CVs in few minutes, which save a lot of time and money for big companies.

On the other hand, there are many reasons why humans should make the final decision. Firstly, AI learns from old data, and if the old data was unfair, the AI will also be unfair. For instance, if a company hired mostly men in the past, the system may choose men again. Secondly, a computer cannot understand personality or motivation very well. A good employee need skills like communication and teamwork, and it is difficult for a machine to measure these things. Also, applicants may feel it is not fair to be rejected by a machine without explanation.

In my opinion, I think AI can be useful but people should make the final decision. Companies can use AI to check CVs quickly, and then managers can interview the best candidates and choose.

In conclusion, AI is fast and can be more objective in some ways, but it has also problems. Therefore, I believe that decisions about employing people should be made by humans, with help from technology.

Band 7

306 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant reasoning · logical paragraphing and good range of linking · less common vocabulary (accountability, impartial) · mostly error-free with one minor slip.

As artificial intelligence becomes more sophisticated, some companies have begun using it to screen and select job applicants. Supporters claim that software is more impartial than human recruiters, while critics insist that hiring decisions must remain in human hands. I believe AI can play a useful supporting role, but the final decision should be made by people.

The argument for AI-led recruitment is based largely on the problem of human bias. Interviewers are often influenced, even unconsciously, by factors such as an applicant's appearance, accent or background, which have little to do with their ability to do the job. An

algorithm, by contrast, can be programmed to assess every candidate against identical criteria. It can also process huge numbers of applications quickly and consistently, which is a clear advantage for large organisations.

However, the claim that AI is objective is questionable. These systems are trained on past hiring data, so if a company has historically favoured certain groups, the software may simply learn to reproduce that pattern on a larger scale. Moreover, many of the qualities that make someone a good colleague, such as integrity, adaptability and the ability to work in a team, are difficult to measure through data alone. There is also the question of accountability: when a qualified candidate is rejected by an algorithm, it is often unclear who is responsible or how the decision was reached.

In my view, the most sensible approach is to combine both. AI tools could be used to organise applications and highlight relevant experience, but trained managers should conduct interviews and make the final choice, while regularly checking the software for signs of bias.

In conclusion, although artificial intelligence can make recruitment faster and reduce some form of human prejudice, it is not truly neutral, and decisions that affect people's livelihoods should ultimately be taken by people.

Band 8

312 words

Both views critically examined with well-extended support · clear, nuanced position · skilful cohesion and paragraphing · precise, sophisticated vocabulary (veneer, quantification) · wide range of structures with no noticeable errors.

The use of artificial intelligence in recruitment has prompted a lively debate. Proponents argue that algorithms can assess candidates more objectively than human interviewers, whereas opponents maintain that decisions of such consequence should always rest with people. Although AI has a legitimate role in the hiring process, I would argue that handing it the final say would be a mistake.

The appeal of automated selection lies in its apparent neutrality. Human judgement is notoriously susceptible to prejudice: recruiters may warm to candidates who resemble themselves, or be swayed by first impressions that bear no relation to competence. A well-designed system, by contrast, applies the same criteria to every application without fatigue or favouritism. For organisations that receive thousands of applications, this consistency, combined with the speed of automated screening, is highly attractive.

Yet the promise of objectivity is, in practice, difficult to fulfil. Algorithms learn from historical data, and if past recruitment favoured particular genders, ethnic groups or educational backgrounds, the software is likely to absorb and even amplify those preferences while giving them a veneer of scientific authority. Furthermore, the qualities that often distinguish an outstanding employee, such as judgement, resilience and the capacity to collaborate, are precisely those that resist quantification. Finally, automated rejection raises a serious problem of accountability, since applicants are rarely able to learn why they were turned down or to challenge the outcome.

For these reasons, I believe AI should inform rather than determine hiring decisions. It can usefully handle routine tasks such as sorting applications or flagging relevant qualifications, but the assessment of a person's suitability requires human insight, and those making the decision must be answerable for it.

In conclusion, while artificial intelligence can reduce certain inconsistencies in recruitment, it is neither as impartial nor as perceptive as its advocates suggest. The responsibility for choosing who to employ should therefore remain firmly with people.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Technology or lifestyle change

Topic: Environment · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_05

Some people believe that new technology will solve the world's environmental problems. Others think that the only real solution is for people to change the way they live. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

276 words

Addresses both views and gives an opinion · relevant examples but ideas stay general · repetitive linking (Also, Moreover) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and word-form errors that do not impede understanding.

Environmental problems like global warming and pollution is becoming more serious every year. Some people think that new technology will solve these problems, while others think that people must change their lifestyle. I will discuss both opinions in this essay.

Many people believe technology is the answer. For example, electric cars do not produce smoke, and solar panels and wind turbines can make clean energy instead of coal. Scientists are also developing new ways to recycle plastic and to grow food with less water. People who agree with this view say that it is very difficult to ask everyone to change their habits, so it is better to invent machines which can do the job for us.

However, other people argue that technology is not enough. New technology is often expensive, and poor countries cannot afford it. Also, it takes a long time to develop, but the environment need help now. Moreover, even if we have electric cars, people still buy too many things, throw away food and fly on holiday many times in a year. If people do not change these habits, the problems will continue. Simple actions like using public transport, eating less meat and reuse bags can make a big different if millions of people do them.

In my opinion, both technology and changing lifestyle are necessary, but changing the way we live is more important. Technology can help, but it cannot work alone if people continue to waste resources.

To sum up, some people think technology will save the environment and others believe people must change their behaviour. I think we need both, but individuals must take more responsibility for there actions.

Band 7

296 words

Clear, consistent position · both views extended with relevant examples · logical progression with clear paragraph focus · good collocations (efficiency gains, large-scale use) · frequent error-free sentences with one pronoun slip.

How humanity should respond to environmental damage is one of the defining questions of our time. Some are confident that technological innovation will provide the answers, whereas others argue that nothing less than a change in how people live will be effective. In my view, technology is essential but insufficient on its own.

Those who place their faith in technology can point to impressive progress. The cost of renewable energy such as solar and wind power has fallen dramatically, electric vehicles are becoming mainstream, and researchers are developing methods to capture carbon and produce food more efficiently. The attraction of this approach is that it does not require billions of people to give up comforts they value. Instead, it allows economies to keep growing while

their environmental impact declines.

On the other hand, critics argue that relying on future inventions is a risky strategy. Many promising technologies are still expensive or years away from large-scale use, while the damage to ecosystems is happening now. Moreover, efficiency gains are often cancelled out by rising consumption: cars have become cleaner, for instance, but there are far more of them on the roads. Unless people reduce waste, buy fewer disposable products and rethink habits such as frequent flying, even the cleanest technology may simply allow us to consume more.

I believe the most realistic solution combines both approaches. Governments should invest heavily in green technology, but they also need to encourage lifestyle changes through measures such as better public transport and incentives for repairing rather than replacing goods. Technology can make sustainable choices easier, but people must still be willing to make it.

In conclusion, while new technology will undoubtedly play a major role in solving environmental problems, lasting change also depends on individuals adapting the way they live.

Band 8 312 words

Both views fully developed and evaluated · well-argued position that integrates the two sides · logical sequencing and cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary used naturally · wide range of accurate complex structures.

Faced with mounting evidence of environmental decline, societies are divided over where the solution lies. Some believe that technological progress will eventually resolve the crisis, while others insist that meaningful change can only come from altering the way people live. Although both perspectives contain important truths, I would argue that neither is adequate without the other.

The optimism surrounding technology is not without foundation. In recent decades, renewable energy has become cheaper and more widely available, battery technology has improved considerably, and innovations in areas such as building insulation and precision farming have reduced waste. Crucially, technological solutions do not depend on persuading billions of individuals to sacrifice their comfort, which makes them politically and socially more achievable than widespread behavioural change. From this perspective, human ingenuity offers the most practical route to a sustainable future.

However, relying solely on innovation carries significant risks. Many of the most ambitious technologies remain unproven at scale, and waiting for them to mature may squander time that the planet does not have. There is also a well-documented tendency for efficiency gains to be offset by increased consumption: as products become cheaper and cleaner to run, people often simply use more of them. Without a shift in attitudes towards consumption, waste and travel, technology risks treating the symptoms of environmental damage rather than its underlying causes.

In my view, the two approaches are mutually reinforcing. Technology is most effective when it makes sustainable behaviour convenient, as affordable public transport or efficient home heating does, and lifestyle changes are easier to sustain when practical alternatives exist. Policy should therefore pursue both, funding research while also using regulation and incentives to discourage wasteful habits.

In conclusion, while technological advances are indispensable in tackling environmental problems, they cannot succeed in isolation. A genuine solution requires people to reconsider

how they live, supported by innovations that make greener choices easier.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Paying for climate action

Topic: Climate / International development · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_discussion_06

Some people believe that wealthy countries should pay most of the cost of tackling climate change. Others argue that the cost should be shared equally by all countries. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

273 words

All parts addressed with a clear opinion · relevant main ideas but underdeveloped · basic, repetitive linking · adequate but plain vocabulary · several agreement, pronoun and article errors that do not block meaning.

Climate change is a global problem which affect every country in the world. Some people think that rich countries should pay most of the money to solve it, but other people believe all countries should pay the same. In this essay I will look at both sides and give my opinion.

On the one hand, there are good reasons for wealthy countries to pay more. These countries started to use factories and cars much earlier than other nations, so they have produced most of the pollution in the past. Also, they have more money and better technology, so it is easier for them to pay. In contrast, many poor countries are still trying to provide basic things like electricity and clean water for its people, so they cannot spend a lot on climate problems.

On the other hand, some people argue that everyone should pay equally. Today, some developing countries, especially big ones, produce a large amount of pollution because their industries are growing fast. If only rich countries pay, these countries may not try to reduce the emissions. Furthermore, climate change will affect all of us, so it seem fair that every country share the responsibility.

In my opinion, rich countries should pay the most of the cost, but other countries should also do something. Wealthy nations caused more of the problem and they have more money. However, developing countries should also make promises to reduce pollution, according to what they can afford.

In conclusion, both views have reasons. I believe that the wealthy countries should pay more because it is fairer, but all countries must work together to stop climate change.

Band 7

312 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended and supported · coherent paragraphs with a range of linking devices · good topic vocabulary (emitters, historical responsibility) · mostly accurate complex sentences with one minor slip.

Tackling climate change will require enormous investment, and there is disagreement over how this burden should be distributed. Some believe that wealthy nations should cover most of the cost, while others argue that every country should contribute equally. In my opinion, richer countries should pay the larger share, although all nations must play some part.

The case for wealthy countries paying more rests on both history and capacity. Industrialised nations have been burning fossil fuels for over two centuries, so they are responsible for a large proportion of the greenhouse gases already in the atmosphere. They have also benefited economically from this development. Furthermore, they have the financial resources and technical expertise to fund clean energy projects, whereas many poorer countries are struggling to provide basic services such as healthcare and electricity for their citizens.

Those who support equal contributions, however, raise valid points. Several fast-growing economies are now among the largest emitters, and if they are not required to pay, there may be little incentive for them to limit their emissions. Some also argue that since climate change threatens everyone, every country has an equal interest in solving it and should therefore carry an equal responsibility. There is a concern too that citizens in rich countries may be unwilling to support policies which appear to place the whole burden on them.

On balance, I believe that an equal split would be unfair and unrealistic. Asking a low-income country to pay the same as a wealthy one ignores huge differences in wealth and historical responsibility. A better system would be based on a combination of past emissions and current income, so that each country contributes in proportion to its ability and impact.

In conclusion, although all nations share the consequences of climate change, the costs of tackling it should fall mainly on wealthy countries, with developing countries contributing according to their means.

Band 8

329 words

Both positions thoroughly explored and weighed · sophisticated, well-justified opinion · excellent logical progression and cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (inequitable, decarbonisation) · wide range of complex structures, error-free.

As the costs of addressing climate change mount, so does the question of who should bear them. One view holds that wealthy nations should shoulder most of the financial burden; another insists that the costs should be divided equally among all countries. I believe that a fair arrangement must reflect differences in both responsibility and capacity, which means that richer countries should pay considerably more.

The argument for placing the main burden on wealthy countries is rooted in historical responsibility. The nations that industrialised first have emitted the bulk of the carbon dioxide that has accumulated in the atmosphere, and their current prosperity was built, in large part, on that fossil-fuel-driven growth. It therefore seems just that they should now fund a substantial share of the transition. They are also far better placed to do so, possessing the capital, infrastructure and research capacity that many developing countries lack.

Advocates of equal contributions nevertheless make a case that deserves serious consideration. Emissions are no longer concentrated in the traditional industrial powers; several rapidly developing economies now produce a significant proportion of global emissions. Exempting them from financial responsibility could weaken their commitment to decarbonisation and breed resentment among taxpayers in wealthier states. Moreover, since climate change threatens every country, some would argue that a shared problem demands an equally shared solution.

In my view, however, treating unequal nations equally would itself be inequitable. Requiring a country where much of the population lacks reliable electricity to contribute as much as one of the world's richest economies would hinder its development while doing little for the climate. A more defensible approach would scale contributions according to historical emissions, current emissions and national income, ensuring that every country participates while the heaviest costs fall on those most able to bear them.

In conclusion, although all nations have a stake in combating climate change, fairness requires that wealthy countries fund the greater part of the effort, with others contributing in proportion to their means.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Roads or public transport

Topic: Transport · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_discussion_07

Some people think that governments should build more roads to reduce traffic problems. Others believe that the money would be better spent on railways and other forms of public transport. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

279 words

Both views addressed and a clear opinion given · relevant but fairly general support · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement, article and verb-form errors that do not block meaning.

Traffic jam is a big problem in many cities around the world. Some people think the government should build more roads to solve this problem, while others believe it is better to spend the money on trains and public transport. This essay will discuss both views and give my opinion.

On the one hand, building more roads has some benefits. When there are more roads and wider highways, cars can move faster and people spend less time in traffic. This is important for businesses, because lorries need to deliver goods on time. Also, in countryside areas there is often no train or bus, so people have to use car and they need good roads.

On the other hand, many people believe public transport is a better investment. A train or bus can carry many people at the same time, so it reduce the number of cars on the road. For example, in cities which have a good metro system, many people leave their car at home and travel to work by train. Public transport also produce less pollution than private cars. In addition, some experts say that new roads only solve traffic for a short time, because more people start to drive when the roads are better.

In my opinion, governments should spend most of the money on public transport. It is good for environment and it helps more people, including those who cannot afford a car. However, roads in rural areas still need to be repaired and improve.

In conclusion, more roads can help traffic in short term, but public transport is a better long-term solution. Therefore, I believe the money should mainly go to railways and buses.

Band 7

292 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant explanation · well-organised paragraphs with a clear focus · good collocations (relieve bottlenecks, road capacity) · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

Traffic congestion has become a serious issue in many growing cities, and governments must decide how best to address it. Some argue that building additional roads is the answer, while others believe investment in railways and public transport would be more effective. I am of the opinion that the second approach offers greater long-term benefits.

Supporters of road building make several reasonable points. New or wider roads can relieve bottlenecks and reduce journey times, at least in the short term. They are also essential for freight, as most goods are still delivered by lorry, and delays cost businesses a considerable amount of money. Furthermore, in rural areas where public transport is limited or non-existent, people depend on cars, and good roads are the only realistic way to connect these communities.

However, building roads rarely solves congestion permanently. When road capacity increases, driving becomes more attractive, and the extra space is often filled with new traffic within a few years. Public transport, by contrast, moves large numbers of people using much less space. A single train can replace hundreds of cars, reducing both congestion and air pollution. In cities which have invested in reliable metro or tram networks, commuters are often happy to leave their cars at home, which benefit the whole population.

In my view, the most effective strategy is to prioritise public transport in urban areas while maintaining the existing road network. Money should be directed towards frequent, affordable services that give people a genuine alternative to driving, and new roads should only be built where there are no practical alternatives.

In conclusion, although more roads can provide quick relief and remain important in rural regions, investing in railways and public transport is a more sustainable way of tackling traffic problems.

Band 8

311 words

Both views thoroughly developed with precise reasoning · clear, qualified position · logical sequencing and seamless cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (induced demand, space-efficient) · wide range of structures, error-free.

Congested roads impose significant costs on economies and on the quality of urban life, and governments face a choice about how to respond. One view is that expanding the road network is the most direct solution; another is that the same funds would achieve more if spent on railways and other forms of public transport. While road investment has its place, I believe that public transport represents the better use of money in most circumstances.

The argument for building roads is intuitive. If traffic is heavy, providing more lanes should, in principle, allow vehicles to move more freely and reduce journey times. Roads are also indispensable for the movement of goods, emergency services and residents of rural areas, where population densities are too low to support frequent bus or rail services. For these communities, well-maintained roads are not a luxury but a lifeline.

Nevertheless, the benefits of road expansion in cities tend to be short-lived. Additional capacity makes driving more convenient, which encourages more people to drive and gradually recreates the original congestion, a phenomenon often described as induced demand. Public transport, by contrast, is inherently more space-efficient: a single rail line can carry far more passengers than a lane of private cars. Well-designed networks also bring wider advantages, including cleaner air, lower carbon emissions and greater mobility for those who cannot afford to drive or are unable to.

In my view, therefore, governments should concentrate urban transport spending on rail, trams and buses, while reserving road construction for areas where no viable alternative exists and for essential maintenance. The key is to make public transport sufficiently frequent, reliable and affordable that it becomes the natural choice rather than a last resort.

In conclusion, although building roads can offer temporary relief and remains vital in rural areas, investment in public transport provides a more lasting and equitable solution to traffic problems.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Green space versus development

Topic: Cities · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_08

Some people believe that land in cities should be used mainly for parks and other green spaces. Others think that this land is better used for housing and businesses. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

267 words

Addresses both views with a stated opinion · relevant ideas but limited extension · formulaic linking (Firstly, Secondly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · several comparative, word-form and agreement errors that do not impede meaning.

In many cities, there is not enough space and land is very expensive. Some people think city land should be used mostly for parks and green areas, but others believe it is better to use it for houses and businesses. In this essay, I will discuss both views.

Firstly, parks and green spaces are very important for people who live in cities. They give people a place to relax, do exercise and meet friends. For children, parks are safe places to play, because many families live in small flats without garden. Also, trees help to make the air more cleaner and reduce the temperature in summer. If a city has no green space, people may feel stressed and unhealthy.

Secondly, other people think housing and business are more important. The population of cities is growing fastly, and many people cannot find a home they can afford. If the government build more flats, the prices will go down and young people can live near their work. Businesses also need land for offices, shops and factories, which create jobs for local people. Without jobs, the city cannot develop.

In my opinion, I believe that land should be used for both, but housing is a little more important. People need a home before they can enjoy a park. However, the government should make sure that every new area has at least a small park, so residents have somewhere to go.

In conclusion, parks improve health and environment, while housing and business help people to live and work. I think cities need a balance, but homes should be the first priority.

Band 7

297 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant examples · logical paragraphing and varied linking · some less common vocabulary (disused industrial sites) · frequent error-free sentences with two minor slips.

As urban populations grow, the question of how to use limited city land has become increasingly important. Some people believe it should be devoted mainly to parks and green spaces, while others think housing and commercial development should take priority. In my view, both are essential, but green space should not be sacrificed simply to meet short-term demand for buildings.

Those who favour housing and businesses make a practical argument. In many large cities, property prices have risen so sharply that ordinary workers, such as nurses and teachers, can no longer afford to live near their jobs. Building more homes on available land would help to ease this shortage. In addition, businesses need space for offices and shops, which generate employment and tax revenue. From this perspective, leaving valuable land undeveloped could seem like a luxury that crowded cities can't afford.

On the other hand, supporters of green space argue that parks are not a luxury but a necessity. They provide opportunities for exercise and relaxation, which contributes to both physical and mental health. Trees and plants also improve air quality, reduce flooding by absorbing rainwater, and help to lower temperatures during heatwaves. Once a park is built on, it is almost never restored, so losing green space is effectively permanent.

I believe the solution lies in smarter planning rather than choosing one use over the other. Cities can increase housing by building upwards and redeveloping disused industrial sites, rather than using existing parks. At the same time, new developments should be required to include green areas, so that residents benefit from nature on their doorstep.

In conclusion, while the need for housing and businesses is urgent, I believe cities should protect and expand their green spaces, since they are vital for the long-term wellbeing of residents.

Band 8

328 words

Both views fully developed and critically weighed · clear, nuanced position with practical proposals · skilful cohesion and paragraphing · wide, precise vocabulary (dispensable amenity, encroaching) · wide range of accurate structures.

Land in cities is a scarce and valuable resource, and how it is allocated shapes the lives of millions of residents. Some argue that it should be used predominantly for parks and other green spaces, whereas others believe that housing and commercial premises should take precedence. In my view, although the demand for homes is pressing, green space must be treated as essential infrastructure rather than as a dispensable amenity.

The case for prioritising housing and business is compelling in many cities. Chronic shortages of affordable accommodation force workers to endure long commutes or to leave urban areas altogether, which harms both their quality of life and the local economy. Commercial development, meanwhile, generates employment, attracts investment and provides the tax revenue that funds public services. Seen from this angle, reserving large areas for parks might appear to be an indulgence that a growing city can ill afford.

However, this reasoning underestimates the tangible value of green space. Parks offer residents, particularly those living in flats without gardens, a place to exercise, socialise and escape the pressures of urban life, with well-documented benefits for physical and mental health. They also perform important environmental functions: vegetation absorbs rainwater, mitigating the risk of flooding, and helps to counteract the heat that builds up in densely built areas. Crucially, once green space is developed, it is rarely, if ever, recovered.

Rather than framing the issue as a stark choice, I believe cities should pursue housing growth in ways that preserve and even enhance green areas. Building at higher densities, redeveloping former industrial land and converting underused offices into homes can all increase supply without encroaching on parks. New developments, in turn, can be required to incorporate gardens, tree-lined streets and shared open spaces.

In conclusion, while the need for homes and businesses is undeniable, green space is too important to be treated as expendable. Careful planning allows cities to meet both needs, but existing parks should be protected rather than sacrificed.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Job loyalty or job changes

Topic: Employment · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_09

Some people think that it is better to stay with the same employer for many years. Others believe that changing jobs frequently brings greater benefits. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6 280 words

Both views covered with a clear opinion · relevant ideas but underdeveloped · mechanical sequencing (Firstly, Secondly, Moreover) · adequate vocabulary · frequent subject-verb agreement and article errors that do not block meaning.

In the past, most people worked for one company for all their life, but now many people change their job often. Some people think it is better to stay with the same employer, while others believe changing jobs brings more benefits. I will discuss both views and give my opinion.

There are several advantages of staying in one company for a long time. Firstly, employees can get job security, which means they do not need to worry about losing their income. Secondly, if a worker stay for many years, the company trust him and he can get promotion to a higher position. For example, a person who start as a junior staff can become a manager after ten years. Moreover, they can build strong relationship with their colleagues.

On the other hand, changing jobs frequently also have many benefits. When people move to a new company, they usually get a higher salary than before. They also learn new skills and experience different ways of working, which make their CV more attractive. In addition, if someone is not happy in their job, it is better to leave and find a job they enjoy instead of feeling bored for many years.

In my opinion, changing jobs is better for young people, but staying with one employer is better later in life. When people are young, they should try different jobs to find what they are good at. After that, they can stay with a good company and build their career there.

In conclusion, both staying and changing jobs have advantages. I think people should change jobs when they are young and then stay with one employer when they find the right place.

Band 7 295 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended and supported · logical organisation with clear topic sentences · good collocations (negotiate a pay rise, professional network) · mostly accurate structures with one agreement slip.

Attitudes to careers have changed considerably, and people now debate whether loyalty to one employer or regular job changes is the better path. While each approach has its merits, I believe that changing jobs periodically, rather than constantly, offers the greatest benefits for most people.

Remaining with the same organisation for many years can be highly rewarding. Long-serving employees develop an in-depth understanding of how their company works, which often makes them strong candidates for promotion to senior roles. They also tend to enjoy greater job security and build strong, trusting relationships with colleagues and managers. In addition, stability of this kind can make it easier to plan major life decisions, such as buying a home or starting a family.

On the other hand, people who change jobs more frequently often progress faster in terms of salary and responsibility. Moving to a new employer is frequently the quickest way to negotiate a significant pay rise, and each new role exposes the worker to different systems, technologies and working cultures. This variety helps them to develop a broad set of skills and a wider professional network, both of which is increasingly important in a fast-changing job market. Staying in one place for too long, by contrast, can lead to complacency and outdated skills.

In my opinion, the ideal lies somewhere between these extremes. Changing jobs every few months can suggest a lack of commitment, but remaining in the same position for decades may limit personal growth. Spending a few years in each role, long enough to make a real contribution, allows people to gain both depth and breadth of experience.

In conclusion, although long-term loyalty brings security and recognition, I believe that moving between employers at sensible intervals generally offers greater opportunities for development and advancement.

Band 8

314 words

Both views thoroughly explored with extended support · clear, qualified opinion · logical progression and well-managed paragraphs · precise, natural vocabulary (long tenure, indispensable) · wide range of complex structures without errors.

Whereas a single lifelong employer was once the norm, many workers today move between organisations several times during their careers. This has sparked debate over whether long-term loyalty or frequent change is more advantageous. Having considered both sides, I would argue that the answer depends partly on career stage, but that a willingness to move is generally more beneficial.

There is much to be said for staying with one employer. Over time, an employee accumulates detailed knowledge of the organisation's systems, clients and culture, which can make them indispensable and position them well for internal promotion. Long tenure also tends to bring stability, both financial and emotional, together with close working relationships that can make the workplace more fulfilling. Employers, for their part, often reward such commitment with additional benefits and greater trust.

Nevertheless, frequent job changes carry advantages that are difficult to ignore. Moving to a new organisation is often the most effective way to secure a substantial increase in salary, since external candidates can negotiate from a stronger position than existing staff. Each move also exposes the employee to unfamiliar challenges, methods and colleagues, accelerating the acquisition of skills and broadening their professional network. In a labour market where entire industries can be transformed within a decade, such adaptability is arguably a greater form of security than loyalty to a single firm.

On balance, I believe that moving between employers is more beneficial, particularly in the early and middle stages of a career, when breadth of experience matters most. That said, changing jobs too often can undermine credibility and prevent people from seeing projects through to completion. The most rewarding pattern is perhaps to stay long enough in each role to achieve something meaningful before moving on.

In conclusion, while long service offers stability and recognition, periodic job changes generally provide faster growth, higher earnings and greater resilience in an uncertain economy.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Profit and social responsibility

Topic: Business · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_10

Some people believe that the main purpose of a business is to make a profit for its owners. Others argue that businesses also have a responsibility to benefit society as a whole. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

273 words

Both views addressed and position stated early · relevant but general ideas · simple linking (Also, So, However) · adequate vocabulary with some repetition · several agreement and article errors that do not block meaning.

Businesses play a big role in our society. Some people think a company only exist to make money for its owners, while others believe businesses should also help society. This essay will discuss both views, and I think businesses should do both.

People who believe profit is the main purpose have some good reasons. A business is not a charity, and the owners invest their money because they want to earn more. If a company does not make profit, it will close and all the workers will lose their job. Also, when companies are successful, they pay tax to the government, and the government can use this money for schools and hospitals. So making profit is already helping society in an indirect way.

However, other people argue that companies have a bigger responsibility. Big companies use a lot of natural resources and sometimes they pollute rivers and air. Some also pay very low salaries or sell unhealthy products to people. Because they have so much power, they should think about the effect on society, for example by protecting the environment, treating workers fairly and support local communities. Many customers today prefer to buy from companies who are responsible.

In my view, making profit is important, but it should not be the only goal. A company can be successful and also be good for society at the same time. For example, a factory can use clean energy and still earn money.

In conclusion, although profit is necessary for any business to survive, I believe businesses also has a responsibility to society. The best companies are the ones which can balance both of these things.

Band 7

303 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant support · logical progression with clear central topics · good collocations (retain talented employees, reputational damage) · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

The role of business in modern society is often debated. Some people argue that a company's primary purpose is to generate profits for its owners and shareholders, whereas others believe businesses have wider obligations to the communities in which they operate. In my opinion, profit is essential, but it should be pursued in a socially responsible way.

Those who emphasise profit argue that this is simply what businesses are designed to do. Investors risk their capital in the expectation of a return, and managers have a duty to use that money efficiently. Moreover, profitable companies already benefit society indirectly by creating jobs, paying taxes and developing products that people want. Some also suggest that social problems are better handled by governments and charities, which are directly accountable to

the public.

On the other hand, many people believe that large companies have too much influence to ignore their wider impact. Business activities can damage the environment, exploit low-paid workers or harm consumers' health, and these costs are often paid by society rather than by the company itself. For this reason, it seems reasonable to expect businesses to reduce pollution, pay fair wages and behave ethically. Such behaviour can also be good for profits, since customers and employees increasingly prefer to be associated with responsible brands.

I believe these two goals are not necessarily in conflict. A company that treats its staff well tends to retain talented employees, and one that respects the environment avoids costly fines and reputational damage. Therefore, social responsibility should be seen as part of long-term business success rather than as an optional extra.

In conclusion, while making a profit is the fundamental aim of any business, I believe companies also have a clear responsibility to benefit society, and the most successful ones will be those that manage to achieve both.

Band 8 331 words

Both views fully developed and evaluated · sophisticated, consistent position · skilful cohesion and paragraph management · wide, precise vocabulary (commercially wise, legitimacy) · wide range of complex structures, error-free.

The question of what businesses are ultimately for has become more pressing as corporations grow in size and influence. One school of thought maintains that the sole purpose of a business is to maximise returns for its owners; another holds that companies bear a broader responsibility to society. While I accept that profitability is indispensable, I would argue that a narrow focus on shareholder returns is neither ethically defensible nor, in the long run, commercially wise.

Advocates of the profit-centred view make a coherent case. Owners and shareholders provide the capital that allows a company to exist, and they do so on the understanding that it will be managed in their financial interest. A profitable enterprise also contributes to society as a matter of course, by employing people, paying taxes and supplying goods and services that meet genuine demand. On this view, asking companies to pursue social goals risks diluting their efficiency and allowing unelected executives to make decisions that properly belong to governments.

However, this argument overlooks the extent to which business activity affects people who have no say in it. Pollution, unsafe working conditions and misleading marketing all impose costs on communities, workers and consumers, often while the company itself profits. Given the power that large firms wield, it is reasonable to expect them to take responsibility for these consequences. Moreover, responsible conduct increasingly aligns with self-interest: firms with strong ethical reputations tend to attract loyal customers and talented staff, and are better protected against regulatory and reputational risks.

In my view, then, profit and social responsibility should be seen as complementary rather than competing aims. A business must be financially sound to survive, but its legitimacy ultimately depends on the trust of the society in which it operates, and that trust must be earned.

In conclusion, although generating profit is a fundamental objective, businesses have a duty to consider their wider impact, and those that embrace this duty are likely to prove more successful and sustainable over time.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Who is responsible for health?

Topic: Health · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_11

Some people believe that individuals should be responsible for their own health. Others think that governments should play a major role in encouraging people to lead healthy lives. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

275 words

Both views discussed with an opinion throughout · relevant ideas, some underdeveloped · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several errors in articles, agreement and comparatives that do not impede communication.

Nowadays, many people suffer from health problems such as obesity and heart disease. Some people believe that everyone should take care of their own health, but others think the government should play an important role to encourage healthy lifestyle. In my opinion, both individuals and governments has responsibility, but the government role is very important.

On the one hand, it is true that people should be responsible for their own health. Adults can decide what they eat, how much they exercise and whether they smoke or not. Nobody can force another person to go to the gym or eat vegetables. If someone chooses an unhealthy lifestyle, it is their own decision and they should accept the results. Also, some people do not like when the government tells them how to live.

On the other hand, the government can help people a lot. Many people do not know enough about healthy food, so government can run campaigns on TV and in schools to educate them. In addition, the government can put higher taxes on cigarettes and sugary drinks, which make these products less attractive. It can also build parks and sports centres so people have more chance to do exercise. When people are healthier, the country spend less money on hospitals.

In my view, individuals must make the final choice, but government should make the healthy choice easier. For example, if fruit and vegetables are cheap and there are safe places for cycling, more people will live healthily.

To conclude, personal responsibility is important, but governments also need to play a major role. Working together, they can help people to live longer and more healthy lives.

Band 7

302 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant examples · logical organisation and good range of linking · less common vocabulary (patronising, food labelling) · frequent error-free sentences with one agreement slip.

Rising rates of lifestyle-related illnesses such as diabetes and heart disease have raised the question of who should be responsible for people's health. Some believe this is a matter of personal choice, while others argue that governments should take an active role in promoting healthy living. I believe that although individuals must take responsibility for their choices, governments have an important part to play in shaping those choices.

Those who emphasise individual responsibility argue that adults have the right to decide how they live. Eating habits, exercise and smoking are personal decisions, and many people resent being told what to do by the state. In addition, when people take ownership of their health, they are more likely to maintain positive habits over time than if they are simply following official advice. From this perspective, government campaigns can seem patronising and a waste of

public money.

However, there are strong reasons for governments to intervene. Individual choices are heavily influenced by the environment people live in. Unhealthy food is often cheaper and more heavily advertised than healthier options, and many neighbourhoods lack safe spaces for walking or cycling. Governments can address these issues through measures such as taxes on sugary drinks, clear food labelling and investment in parks and sports facilities. Moreover, since poor health places enormous pressure on public healthcare systems, the state has a legitimate interest in prevention.

In my view, the most effective approach combine both perspectives. People should remain free to make their own decisions, but governments should make healthy options easier, cheaper and more attractive, so that the responsible choice is also the convenient one.

In conclusion, while individuals are ultimately responsible for how they live, I believe governments should play a major role in encouraging healthier lifestyles, as this benefits both citizens and society as a whole.

Band 8

323 words

Both views fully examined with well-supported reasoning · nuanced, clearly argued position · logical sequencing and skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (paternalistic, autonomy) · wide range of accurate complex structures.

Few would dispute that good health depends heavily on everyday behaviour, yet there is considerable disagreement about who should take responsibility for it. Some maintain that health is essentially a personal matter, whereas others believe governments should actively encourage citizens to lead healthier lives. In my view, individual responsibility and state involvement are not mutually exclusive, and the latter is often necessary for the former to be meaningful.

The argument for personal responsibility rests on the principle of autonomy. Adults are entitled to make decisions about their own diet, activity levels and habits, even when those decisions carry risks, and government intervention in such matters can easily become paternalistic. There is also a practical point: lasting change in behaviour tends to come from personal motivation rather than external pressure, so public campaigns may achieve little if people are not genuinely committed to improving their health.

Nevertheless, this view underestimates how strongly circumstances shape behaviour. People on low incomes may find nutritious food less affordable and less accessible than processed alternatives, while those living in areas without parks or safe streets have fewer opportunities to exercise. Commercial pressures, such as the aggressive marketing of high-sugar products to children, further tilt the balance towards unhealthy choices. Governments are uniquely placed to counteract these influences through regulation, taxation, urban planning and education. Furthermore, because the cost of treating preventable illness is largely borne by taxpayers, the state has a clear interest in reducing it.

For these reasons, I believe governments should play a major role, not by dictating how people live, but by creating conditions in which healthy choices are realistic for everyone. Individuals would still be responsible for their decisions, but they would make them in an environment that supports rather than undermines their wellbeing.

In conclusion, while personal responsibility remains important, it cannot be exercised equally when circumstances differ so widely. Active government involvement is therefore essential to

enabling people to lead healthier lives.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Referendums or representatives

Topic: Government · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_discussion_12

Some people think that important national decisions should be made directly by the public through referendums. Others believe that such decisions are better left to elected politicians and experts. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

274 words

Addresses both views and reaches a clear opinion · relevant ideas with limited development · basic linking · adequate vocabulary for the topic · several errors in agreement, articles and comparatives that do not block meaning.

In democratic countries, important decisions are usually made by the government. However, some people think that the public should decide important national issues directly by voting in referendums, while others believe politicians and experts should make these decisions. I will discuss both side in this essay.

Some people support referendums because they are the most democratic way to decide. In a referendum, every citizen can vote, so the result shows what the majority of people really want. This can make people feel more involved in politics and trust the government more. Also, politicians sometimes do not keep their promises, so a referendum give ordinary people more power to control important decisions.

However, there are also problems with referendums. Many national issues are very complicated, for example economy or international agreements, and most people do not have enough knowledge to understand them. As a result, people may vote because of emotions or false information on social media. In contrast, experts have studied these topics for many years and politicians have advisers to help them, so they can make more better decisions. Moreover, organising a referendum is very expensive and take a long time.

In my opinion, most decisions should be made by elected politicians with the help of experts. This is why we vote for politicians, because we trust them to make difficult decisions for us. However, for some very important issues, such as changing the constitution, a referendum can be useful.

In conclusion, referendums are democratic but they have some risks. I believe that elected politicians and experts should make most national decisions, but people can vote directly for a few very important issues.

Band 7

310 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended and well supported · logical organisation with varied cohesive devices · good topic vocabulary (legitimacy, misinformation) · mostly accurate complex sentences with one agreement slip.

In most democracies, citizens elect representatives who then make decisions on their behalf. However, some people argue that major national issues should be decided directly by the public through referendums, while others maintain that such decisions are better left to politicians and experts. In my view, representative decision-making should remain the norm, with referendums used only in exceptional cases.

Supporters of referendums see them as the purest form of democracy. When citizens vote directly on an issue, the outcome clearly reflects the will of the majority, which gives the

decision strong legitimacy. Referendums can also increase public engagement in politics, as people are encouraged to research and discuss the issues at stake. In addition, they offer a way to settle questions on which politicians are deeply divided or seem out of touch with voters.

On the other hand, there are significant drawbacks. Many national decisions, such as trade agreements or economic reforms, are highly complex and involve consequences that are difficult to predict. Most voters do not have the time or expertise to study these in detail, so campaigns are often dominated by simplified slogans or even misinformation. Furthermore, a referendum reduces a complicated issue to a simple yes-or-no choice, which leaves little room for compromise. Elected politicians, by contrast, can consult experts, negotiate and adjust policies over time, and they can be removed at the next election if the public are dissatisfied.

In my opinion, the advantages of representative democracy outweighs those of direct voting for most decisions. Referendums may be appropriate for fundamental constitutional questions, but even then the public should be given clear, balanced information before they vote.

In conclusion, although referendums give citizens a direct voice, I believe important national decisions are generally better made by elected politicians guided by expert advice, as they are better placed to deal with complexity and to be held accountable.

Band 8

320 words

Both views thoroughly developed and critically weighed · clear, qualified position · excellent logical progression · wide, precise vocabulary (binary format, alienated, scrutinised) · wide range of complex structures, error-free.

The question of how far ordinary citizens should be directly involved in national decision-making goes to the heart of what democracy means. Some believe that major issues should be settled by referendum, giving the public the final word, whereas others argue that such matters are better entrusted to elected representatives and specialists. While referendums have a place in a healthy democracy, I believe they are poorly suited to most important decisions.

The appeal of direct democracy is easy to understand. A referendum allows every voter to express a view on a specific question, producing a result that carries considerable moral authority. It can also re-engage citizens who feel alienated from mainstream politics, and it provides a means of resolving contentious issues that parliaments have been unable or unwilling to settle. From this perspective, entrusting decisions to politicians risks allowing a narrow political class to disregard public opinion.

However, the practical limitations of referendums are considerable. Many national questions involve intricate trade-offs, uncertain long-term consequences and technical detail that few voters have the time or background to evaluate thoroughly. In such circumstances, campaigns tend to reward emotive messaging over careful analysis, and misleading claims can prove decisive. Moreover, the binary format of a referendum forces a nuanced issue into a simple choice, leaving no scope for amendment or compromise, and the result can be extremely difficult to reverse. Representative institutions, by contrast, allow policies to be scrutinised, refined and revisited, while voters retain the power to remove politicians who fail them.

On balance, I believe that elected representatives, informed by expert advice, should make most important national decisions. Referendums can be justified for questions of fundamental constitutional significance, provided that voters have access to impartial information, but they should remain the exception rather than the rule.

In conclusion, although referendums offer a direct expression of the popular will, representative democracy is generally better equipped to handle complex decisions responsibly and accountably.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Parents and career choices

Topic: Family · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_discussion_13

Some people think that parents should guide their children towards a particular career. Others believe that young people should be free to choose their own career. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

284 words

Both views discussed with a clear opinion · relevant examples but general development · simple linking (Also, In addition) · adequate vocabulary · several errors in articles, word form and possessives that do not block meaning.

Choosing a career is one of the most important decision in a person's life. Some people think parents should guide their children to a particular job, but others believe young people should be free to choose. This essay will discuss both opinions.

There are some reasons why parents should guide their children. Parents have more experience of life and they know which jobs have good salary and security. Young people often do not know much about the job market and they may choose a job only because it looks exciting on TV. For example, a teenager may want to become a famous singer, but this is very difficult and most people cannot success. Also, parents usually pay for their children education, so they want them to choose a useful subject.

On the other hand, many people think young people should decide by themselves. Everyone has different interests and talents, and a job which is good for the father may not be suitable for the son. If a person is forced to study medicine or law when they are not interested, they will be unhappy and maybe they will not do the job well. In addition, the world is changing very fast, and many new jobs did not exist when the parents were young.

In my opinion, young people should choose their own career, but parents can give advice. Parents can share their experience and help their children to understand different options, but the final decision should belong to the child because they are the one who will do this job every day.

In conclusion, parents' guidance can be helpful, but I believe that young people should have freedom to choose the career they like.

Band 7

314 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant reasoning · coherent paragraphs with clear topics · good collocations (long-term prospects, financial stability) · frequent error-free sentences with one article slip.

Deciding on a career is a major step for any young person, and families often disagree about how much influence parents should have. While some argue that parents should steer their children towards a specific profession, others believe young people must be free to follow their own path. In my view, parents should offer guidance, but the final choice should rest with their children.

There are understandable reasons why parents want to direct their children's careers. Having experienced the world of work themselves, they often have a realistic understanding of which professions offer financial stability and long-term prospects. Teenagers, by contrast, may base their decisions on limited information or on idealised images of certain jobs. Parents who have

invested heavily in their children's education may also feel they have a right to ensure that this investment leads to a secure future.

However, pushing a young person into a career they have not chosen can have serious consequences. People tend to perform best in work that matches their interests and abilities, and someone who studies engineering to please their parents may lack the motivation needed to succeed. They may even abandon the career later, having wasted years of training. Furthermore, the job market is changing rapidly, and the professions that parents regard as safe may not offer the same security in the future, while new fields are emerging that parents might know little about.

I believe the most constructive role for parents is that of an adviser rather than decision-maker. They can help their children explore options, arrange work experience and discuss the realities of different jobs, while respecting that it is the young person who will live with the consequences.

In conclusion, although parental guidance can prevent unrealistic choices, I believe young people should ultimately be free to choose their own careers, since genuine interest is the strongest basis for long-term success and satisfaction.

Band 8

330 words

Both views fully developed with insightful support · clear, nuanced position · logical sequencing and well-managed paragraphs · precise vocabulary (precarious, well-founded) · wide range of complex structures used accurately.

The extent to which parents should influence their children's choice of career is a question on which cultures and families differ considerably. Some believe that parents, with their greater experience, should direct their children towards a particular profession, while others hold that young people must be free to make this decision for themselves. My own view is that parental guidance is valuable, but only when it informs rather than overrides a young person's choice.

The argument for parental direction is not without merit. Parents generally have a clearer picture than teenagers of the practical realities of working life, including the stability, income and progression that different fields offer. Young people, meanwhile, may be drawn to glamorous but precarious occupations, or may simply lack the information to make a well-founded decision. Parents who have made sacrifices to fund their children's education can therefore feel both entitled and obliged to ensure that it leads somewhere secure.

Nevertheless, the costs of directing a child into an unwanted career can be considerable. Motivation is a powerful determinant of success, and a person who has chosen their field is far more likely to persevere through the demanding early years of a career than one who is fulfilling someone else's ambitions. Moreover, parents' knowledge of the job market is often rooted in the past; occupations that once seemed secure may be vulnerable to automation, while entirely new fields are opening up. A choice imposed on the basis of outdated assumptions may prove neither fulfilling nor safe.

Weighing these considerations, I believe parents should act as well-informed advisers. By encouraging their children to explore different options, seek work experience and think realistically about their strengths, they can help them make a sound decision without taking it out of their hands.

In conclusion, while parental experience can be a valuable resource, young people should ultimately be free to choose their own careers, since a career that is genuinely chosen is more

likely to be both successful and satisfying.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Punishment or rehabilitation

Topic: Crime · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_14

Some people believe that the main purpose of prison is to punish offenders. Others think that prisons should focus on helping offenders to return to society as law-abiding citizens. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

264 words

Addresses both views with a clear opinion · relevant ideas but limited depth · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors (steal, find a work, this reduce) that do not block meaning.

Crime is a serious problem in every society, and prisons are one way to deal with it. Some people believe prisons should mainly punish criminals, while others think they should help prisoners to become good citizens again. In this essay I will discuss both views.

People who support punishment believe that criminals must pay for what they did. If someone hurts another person or steal their property, it is fair that they lose their freedom. Also, hard punishment can stop other people from committing crimes because they are afraid of going to prison. Victims and their families may also feel that justice is done when the criminal is punished strictly.

On the other hand, many people think that rehabilitation is more important. Most prisoners will return to society one day, so if they learn nothing in prison, they may commit crime again after they are released. If prisons give them education and job training, they can find a work and live normal life. For example, a prisoner who learn to be a mechanic or a cook has a better chance to get a job. This is also cheaper for government, because keeping people in prison costs a lot of money.

In my opinion, prisons should focus more on helping prisoners to change. Punishment is necessary, but it is not enough to solve the problem of crime. However, for very dangerous criminals, protecting the public should be the first priority.

In conclusion, although punishment is important, I believe that prisons should mainly help offenders return to society, because this reduce crime in the long term.

Band 7

304 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended and supported · logical organisation with clear central ideas · good topic vocabulary (reoffend, deterrent, vocational training) · mostly accurate structures with one article slip.

Societies differ in how they view the purpose of prison. Some people believe that its main function is to punish those who break the law, while others argue that prisons should concentrate on rehabilitating offenders so that they can return to society as law-abiding citizens. I believe that while punishment has its place, rehabilitation should be the primary goal.

Those who see punishment as the main purpose argue that justice requires offenders to suffer consequences in proportion to the harm they have caused. Victims often feel that a harsh sentence acknowledges their suffering, and the public expects serious crimes to be treated seriously. In addition, supporters of this view claim that the threat of an unpleasant prison experience deters potential criminals. If prisons are seen as too comfortable, they argue, this deterrent effect may be lost.

On the other hand, advocates of rehabilitation point out that the vast majority of prisoners are eventually released. If they leave prison with no qualifications, no job prospects and the same attitudes that led them to crime, there is a high risk that they will reoffend. Education, vocational training and counselling can give former prisoners the skills and confidence to build a new life, which ultimately protects the public more effectively than punishment alone. There is also a financial argument, as reducing reoffending lowers the enormous cost of repeatedly imprisoning the same people.

In my view, the loss of freedom is itself a significant punishment, and time in prison should be used constructively. Although some dangerous offenders must be kept away from society for long periods, even they should be given opportunity to change.

In conclusion, while punishment is a necessary element of any justice system, I believe prisons should focus mainly on rehabilitation, since this is the most effective way to reduce crime and make communities safer.

Band 8

330 words

Both views thoroughly explored and critically evaluated · well-argued, qualified position · excellent logical progression · wide, precise vocabulary (deprivation of liberty, custody) · wide range of complex structures, error-free.

How a society treats those it imprisons reveals a great deal about its values. One view holds that the principal purpose of prison is to punish offenders for their crimes; another maintains that prisons should prioritise preparing inmates to return to society as law-abiding citizens. Although punishment is an unavoidable element of imprisonment, I would argue that rehabilitation should be its central aim.

The case for punishment rests on principles of justice and deterrence. Many people feel that those who inflict harm on others deserve consequences proportionate to their actions, and that a sentence perceived as lenient fails to respect victims. It is also argued that the prospect of a harsh prison regime discourages potential offenders, and that prioritising prisoners' welfare sends the wrong message about the seriousness of crime.

However, this approach has significant limitations. Since the great majority of prisoners are eventually released, the question is not whether they will rejoin society but in what condition. An offender who leaves prison without skills or support, and with stronger links to criminal networks, is highly likely to reoffend, creating new victims and returning to custody at great public expense. Rehabilitation programmes, by contrast, address the underlying causes of offending, whether a lack of education, unemployment or addiction, and thereby offer more lasting protection for the public. Moreover, the deterrent value of harsh conditions is questionable, as many crimes are committed impulsively or by people who do not expect to be caught.

For these reasons, I believe that the deprivation of liberty should be regarded as the punishment itself, and that time spent in prison should be used to reduce the likelihood of future offending. This does not mean ignoring the need to protect the public from genuinely dangerous individuals, but even in such cases the goal of reform should not be abandoned.

In conclusion, while punishment has a legitimate role, prisons best serve society when they focus on rehabilitation, as this ultimately leads to fewer crimes and fewer victims.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Celebrities as role models

Topic: Media / Society · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_15

Some people think that famous people have a responsibility to act as role models for young people. Others believe that celebrities should be free to live their lives as they wish. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

272 words

Both views addressed and an opinion given · relevant ideas with limited extension · somewhat repetitive conclusion · adequate vocabulary · several agreement, article and punctuation errors that do not impede meaning.

Today, celebrities such as singers, actors and sports players are very popular, especially among young people. Some people think famous people must be role models, while others believe they should be free to live how they want. I will discuss both views and give my own opinion.

On one hand, many people believe that celebrities have a responsibility to behave well. Young people follow them on social media every day and often copy their clothes, their language and their behaviour. If a famous footballer takes drugs or a singer drink too much alcohol, teenagers may think that it is cool to do the same. Also, celebrities earn a lot of money because of their fans, so they should give something back by being a good example.

On the other hand, some people argue that celebrities are normal human who make mistakes like everyone else. They did not choose to be role models, they only wanted to be a good actor or athlete. It is not fair that their private life is always in the newspapers. Furthermore, parents and teachers should be the main role models for children, not people on the television.

In my opinion, celebrities should try to behave responsibly in public, because they have big influence on young people. However, they also deserve some privacy in their personal life. The media should not report every small mistake they make.

In conclusion, both views have some points. I believe that famous people have some responsibility to be a good role model, but they should also have freedom in their private life, and parents should teach children not to copy celebrities blindly.

Band 7

315 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant examples · logical paragraphing and varied cohesion · good collocations (media scrutiny, glamorises reckless behaviour) · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

In an age of social media, celebrities have more influence over young people than ever before. Some believe that this influence brings a responsibility to act as a positive role model, while others argue that famous people should be free to live as they choose. In my opinion, celebrities do have some responsibility, but it should be limited to their public behaviour.

Those who expect celebrities to set a good example point to the powerful effect they have on young fans. Teenagers frequently imitate the appearance, attitudes and lifestyles of the stars they admire, and a famous person who glamorises reckless behaviour, such as dangerous driving or excessive drinking, may encourage others to copy them. Moreover, celebrities benefit enormously from public attention, earning fame and wealth through the support of their fans. It therefore seems reasonable that they should accept certain obligations in return.

On the other hand, many argue that it is unfair to impose such expectations. Most celebrities became famous because of a particular talent, such as acting, singing or playing sport, not because they wanted to guide young people's moral development. They are ordinary human beings who inevitably make mistakes, and constant media scrutiny of their private lives can cause them considerable stress. Critics of the role-model idea also suggest that responsibility for young people's values lie primarily with parents, teachers and communities.

I believe a balanced position is most appropriate. Celebrities should be aware of their influence and avoid promoting harmful behaviour in their public statements, performances and social media posts. However, their private lives should be respected, and it is unrealistic to expect them to be perfect.

In conclusion, although celebrities should not be forced to act as moral guides in every aspect of their lives, I believe they have a responsibility to use their public platform in a way that does not harm the young people who admire them.

Band 8

332 words

Both views fully developed and balanced · clear, carefully qualified position · skilful cohesion and logical sequencing · wide, precise vocabulary (impressionable, by-product, intrusive) · wide range of accurate complex structures.

The influence of celebrities on young people has grown enormously with the rise of social media, prompting debate about what, if anything, famous people owe their audiences. Some argue that celebrity brings with it a duty to act as a role model, whereas others contend that public figures are entitled to live as they please. In my view, celebrities have a genuine but limited responsibility, one that applies to their public conduct rather than to every aspect of their lives.

Those who believe celebrities should be role models emphasise the scale of their influence. Young people often identify closely with the stars they follow, adopting their styles, opinions and habits, and when a well-known figure normalises behaviour such as heavy drinking or casual cruelty online, the effects can ripple through a large and impressionable audience. Furthermore, celebrities derive their wealth and status from public admiration, so it seems fair to expect them to recognise the obligations that accompany such privilege.

On the other hand, there are strong grounds for resisting this expectation. Fame is frequently a by-product of talent in a particular field, and a gifted athlete or musician has not necessarily chosen, or trained, to serve as a moral example. Demanding flawless conduct from them is not only unrealistic but can also justify intrusive media coverage of their private lives. Moreover, placing the burden of guiding young people on celebrities risks diverting attention from those who should bear it primarily, namely parents, educators and communities.

Balancing these arguments, I believe celebrities should be expected to exercise care in how they use their public platforms, avoiding the promotion of harmful behaviour, while their private lives should largely remain their own. At the same time, young people should be taught to admire achievement without uncritically imitating the individuals behind it.

In conclusion, although celebrities cannot reasonably be required to be perfect, their considerable influence carries a responsibility to act with care in public, even as they retain the right to a private life.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Immigrants and cultural identity

Topic: Culture · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_16

Some people believe that people who move to live in another country should adopt the customs and way of life of their new home. Others think that they should maintain their own cultural traditions. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

281 words

Both views covered with a clear but simple opinion · relevant, general support · formulaic linking (On the one hand, Also, Moreover) · adequate vocabulary · several comparative and agreement errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, many people move to live and work in another country. Some people think that immigrants should follow the customs and lifestyle of their new country, while others believe they should keep their own traditions. This essay will discuss both sides before giving my opinion.

On the one hand, there are reasons why immigrants should adapt to the new culture. If they learn the local language and customs, it is more easy for them to find a job and make friends with local people. It also help them to feel part of the community. In addition, local people may be more welcoming if newcomers respect the rules and traditions of the country. If immigrants live in separate groups and do not mix with others, it can cause misunderstanding and conflicts.

On the other hand, many people believe immigrants should keep their own culture. Traditions such as language, food, festivals and religion are part of a person's identity, and it is very difficult to forget them. Also, children of immigrants can learn two cultures and two languages, which is a big advantage for them. Moreover, when different cultures live together, the society become more interesting and diverse. For example, in many big cities people can enjoy food and music from all over the world.

In my opinion, immigrants should do both. They should respect the laws and learn the language of the new country, but they can also keep their traditions at home and in their community. I think this is the best way for everyone to live together peacefully.

In conclusion, adapting to a new culture and keeping traditions are both important. I believe immigrants should find a balance between them.

Band 7

314 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant support · logical progression with clear paragraph focus · less common vocabulary (assimilation, heritage) · frequent error-free sentences with one article slip.

International migration has made many societies multicultural, raising questions about how newcomers should relate to the culture of their adopted country. Some believe immigrants should embrace local customs, while others think they should preserve their own traditions. In my view, the most successful approach involves a combination of both.

Those who argue for adopting local customs emphasise the importance of integration. Immigrants who learn the language and understand social norms are likely to find employment more easily, build relationships with their neighbours and participate fully in public life. In contrast, communities that remain isolated may face misunderstanding and even hostility from the wider population. From this perspective, adapting to the new way of life is not only practical

but also a sign of respect towards the host society.

On the other hand, many people believe that expecting immigrants to abandon their heritage is both unfair and unrealistic. Cultural traditions, including language, religion, cuisine and family customs, are a central part of personal identity, and giving them up can lead to a painful sense of loss. Moreover, the diversity that immigrants bring can enrich the host country, introducing new ideas, foods and festivals. Many of the world's most dynamic cities owe much of their character to generations of migrants who kept their traditions alive.

I believe integration does not require assimilation. Newcomers should respect the laws and core values of their new home and make a real effort to learn the language, as these are essential for living together harmoniously. However, they should also feel free to maintain the traditions that are meaningful to them, and host society should see this diversity as a strength instead of a threat.

In conclusion, although adapting to the local way of life is important for immigrants' success, I believe they should not have to give up their own cultural traditions, and a balance between the two benefits everyone.

Band 8

333 words

Both views thoroughly developed · sophisticated position that reframes the debate · excellent cohesion and paragraphing · wide, precise vocabulary (social cohesion, civic foundations) · wide range of complex structures, error-free.

As migration reshapes societies around the world, the question of how newcomers should relate to the culture of their adopted country has become increasingly prominent. Some maintain that immigrants ought to adopt the customs and way of life of their new home, while others believe they should retain their own cultural traditions. In my view, this is a false choice: successful integration involves adapting in some respects while preserving one's heritage in others.

The argument for adopting local customs centres on social cohesion and personal opportunity. Newcomers who master the language and understand prevailing norms are far better placed to secure employment, access public services and form friendships beyond their own community. Where migrant groups remain largely separate, mutual suspicion can develop on both sides, fuelling prejudice and limiting social mobility. Adapting to the host culture can therefore be seen as both a practical necessity and a gesture of goodwill.

Those who favour preserving cultural traditions, however, raise equally important points. A person's language, faith, cuisine and customs are deeply bound up with their sense of self, and pressure to abandon them can be alienating, particularly for older migrants. Moreover, cultural diversity is a source of vitality for host societies, enriching their food, arts and ideas; many of the world's most vibrant cities are defined precisely by the traditions that successive waves of migrants have brought with them.

For these reasons, I believe a distinction should be drawn between shared civic foundations and private cultural life. Immigrants should respect the law, embrace fundamental values such as equality, and make a genuine effort to learn the local language, since these form the basis of a common public life. Beyond this, they should be free to maintain the traditions that give their lives meaning, and host societies should welcome rather than merely tolerate them.

In conclusion, rather than choosing between assimilation and separation, immigrants and their new communities benefit most from a balance in which shared civic values coexist with a

diversity of cultural traditions.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Home or office working

Topic: Work-life balance · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_discussion_17

Some people believe that working from home is better for employees. Others think that working in an office alongside colleagues is more effective. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

278 words

Both views discussed with a clear opinion · relevant examples but limited development · mechanical linking (Firstly, Secondly, In addition) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and word-order errors that do not block meaning.

Since the pandemic, many companies allow their staff to work from home. Some people think this is better for employees, but others believe working in an office with colleagues is more effective. This essay will discuss both views and give my opinion.

There are many advantages of working from home. Firstly, employees do not need to travel to work every day, so they save time and money. For example, a person who spend two hours in traffic every day can use this time to sleep more or spend with his family. Secondly, people can organise their own schedule and work in a quiet place without interruption from colleagues. Many workers also say they feel less stress at home.

However, working in an office also has important benefits. When people work together in the same place, it is easier to communicate and solve problems quickly. New employees can learn from experienced colleagues by watching them and asking questions. In addition, some people feel lonely when they work at home alone for a long time, and they miss the chance to make friend at work. It can be also difficult to separate work and private life, because the office is in the living room.

In my opinion, the best solution is to mix both ways. Employees can work from home two or three days a week and go to the office on other days for meetings and teamwork. This give workers flexibility and also keep good communication in the company.

In conclusion, working from home and working in an office both have advantages. I believe that a combination of the two is the most effective way for employees and companies.

Band 7

299 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant detail · logical organisation and varied linking · good collocations (daily commute, open-plan office) · frequent error-free sentences with one agreement slip.

Remote working has become far more common in recent years, and opinions differ on whether it is a positive development. Some people believe working from home benefits employees, while others argue that an office environment is more productive. In my view, both arrangements have clear strengths, and a flexible combination is the most effective option.

Supporters of home working highlight the improvement it brings to employees' quality of life. Without a daily commute, workers save considerable time and money, which they can spend on rest, exercise or family commitments. Many people also find they can concentrate better at home, away from the noise and constant interruptions of an open-plan office. Furthermore, remote work allows people to live further from expensive city centres, and it makes employment more accessible for parents and those with disabilities.

On the other hand, there are important advantages to working alongside colleagues. Face-to-face contact makes communication quicker and more natural, and informal conversations often lead to new ideas that would never come up in scheduled video calls. Office working is particularly valuable for younger employees, who learn a great deal simply by observing more experienced staff. In addition, some people struggle with isolation at home and find it difficult to switch off when their workplace is also their living space.

In my opinion, the question is not which option is better, but how to combine them effectively. A hybrid model, in which employees spend part of the week at home for focused tasks and come into the office for collaboration and training, offers most of the benefits of each approach while reducing their drawbacks.

In conclusion, although working from home offers greater freedom and comfort, the office remains important for teamwork and learning, and I believe a hybrid arrangement serve both employees and employers best.

Band 8

320 words

Both views fully developed with precise support · clear, well-reasoned position · skilful cohesion and paragraphing · wide, natural vocabulary (proximity, sustained concentration) · wide range of complex structures, error-free.

The widespread adoption of remote working has prompted a reassessment of where work is best done. Some believe that working from home is clearly preferable for employees, while others maintain that an office shared with colleagues is more effective. In my view, each setting suits different kinds of work, and the most productive arrangement is one that combines them deliberately.

The case for home working rests largely on autonomy and wellbeing. Eliminating the commute gives employees back hours each week and reduces both travel costs and stress. Many find that a quiet home environment enables sustained concentration that is difficult to achieve amid the distractions of a busy office. Remote work also widens access to employment, allowing people with caring responsibilities, health conditions or homes far from urban centres to participate more fully in the workforce.

Nevertheless, the office offers benefits that are not easily replicated online. Collaboration is often more fluid in person, where questions can be resolved in moments and chance conversations can spark ideas that would never surface in a scheduled video call. For those early in their careers, proximity to experienced colleagues is an invaluable, if informal, form of training. There is also a social dimension: prolonged remote working can leave people isolated, and the blurring of boundaries between home and work can make it hard to switch off.

Framing the issue as a choice between the two is therefore unhelpful. Tasks requiring deep concentration are often best carried out at home, whereas teamwork, mentoring and relationship-building benefit from shared physical space. Organisations should adopt hybrid arrangements designed around the nature of the work rather than habit, giving employees flexibility while preserving the collaborative culture that offices foster.

In conclusion, while working from home offers clear advantages for employees' comfort and focus, the office remains essential for collaboration and learning. A thoughtfully designed combination of the two is likely to serve both employees and organisations best.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Funding an ageing population

Topic: Population · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_discussion_18

Some people think that the best way to support an ageing population is to raise the retirement age. Others believe that younger working people should pay higher taxes instead. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

279 words

Both views addressed and a clear opinion given · relevant ideas but general support · basic, repetitive linking · adequate vocabulary · several errors in comparatives, agreement and verb patterns that do not block meaning.

In many countries, the number of old people is increasing and there are fewer young workers. To pay for the pensions and health care of older people, some people think the government should raise the retirement age, while others believe young workers should pay more taxes. This essay will discuss both views.

On the one hand, raising the retirement age has some benefits. Today people live longer and are healthier than in the past, so many of them can continue working until 67 or 70. If they work longer, they continue to pay taxes and the government pay pensions for a shorter time. Also, older workers have a lot of experience and knowledge which is useful for companies.

On the other hand, some people think that younger people should pay higher taxes. Not all old people are able to work longer, especially people who have physical jobs like builders or farmers. It is unfair to make them to work until they are very old. Moreover, older people have worked hard for many years and paid taxes, so they deserve to rest. If young workers pay a little more tax, the government can take care of the elderly properly.

In my opinion, raising the retirement age is a better solution, but it should be flexible. Young people already have many financial problems, such as expensive housing and student loan, so higher taxes would make their life more harder. However, people with difficult physical jobs should be allowed to retire earlier.

In conclusion, both ideas have advantages and disadvantages. I believe that increasing the retirement age is more fairer for society, but the government must think about workers in different situations.

Band 7

306 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended with relevant reasoning · logical paragraphing with clear central topics · good topic vocabulary (life expectancy, tax revenue) · mostly accurate complex sentences with one agreement slip.

As life expectancy rises and birth rates fall, many countries face the challenge of supporting a growing number of retired people. Some argue that the best solution is to raise the retirement age, while others believe younger workers should pay higher taxes instead. In my opinion, gradually raising the retirement age is the fairer and more sustainable option, provided that exceptions are made for certain groups.

Supporters of higher taxes on younger workers argue that older people have earned the right to retire. Many have spent decades contributing to the economy and paying into the pension system, and they planned their lives around a particular retirement age. Moreover, not everyone is able to work into their late sixties. Those in physically demanding occupations,

such as construction or nursing, may suffer from health problems that make continued employment unrealistic. For these people, a later retirement age could cause real hardship.

On the other hand, there are strong arguments for asking people to work longer. Retirement ages in many countries were set when people typically lived only a few years after leaving work, whereas today many enjoy retirements lasting two decades or more. Keeping experienced people in the workforce for longer increases tax revenue and reduces pension costs at the same time. In contrast, placing the entire burden on younger workers, who often already struggle with high housing costs and student debt, risk creating resentment between generations.

In my view, a gradual increase in the retirement age is the more balanced approach. However, it should be accompanied by flexible options, such as part-time work for older employees and earlier retirement for those whose jobs have damaged their health.

In conclusion, while higher taxes on younger people would protect current retirement plans, I believe raising the retirement age shares the cost of an ageing population more fairly across generations.

Band 8

325 words

Both views fully explored and critically weighed · clear, qualified position · logical sequencing and seamless cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (equitable, longevity, disposable income) · wide range of structures, error-free.

Demographic change is placing growing pressure on pension and healthcare systems, as the proportion of older people rises relative to those of working age. Some believe the most effective response is to raise the retirement age, whereas others argue that younger workers should instead pay higher taxes. In my view, a gradual rise in the retirement age is the more equitable solution, although it must be implemented with sensitivity to differences between occupations.

The argument for increasing taxes on the working population rests on fairness to those approaching retirement. Many older people have contributed to the system throughout their working lives in the reasonable expectation of retiring at a particular age, and changing the rules late in their careers can seem like a breach of trust. Moreover, the capacity to keep working is unevenly distributed: an office worker may comfortably remain employed until seventy, but someone who has spent decades in manual labour may simply be physically unable to do so.

Nevertheless, relying on higher taxes carries significant drawbacks. Younger generations in many countries already face high housing costs and considerable educational debt, and increasing their tax burden further could reduce their disposable income, discourage them from starting families and deepen intergenerational resentment. Furthermore, retirement ages were often fixed when life expectancy was considerably lower; linking them to current longevity simply restores the original balance between working life and retirement. Keeping healthy, experienced people in employment for longer also benefits the economy by retaining valuable skills.

On balance, I believe that raising the retirement age gradually, with plenty of notice, distributes the cost more fairly. Crucially, such a policy should include provisions for earlier retirement in physically demanding jobs and encourage flexible arrangements such as phased or part-time retirement.

In conclusion, although asking younger workers to pay more would spare older people from working longer, a carefully managed increase in the retirement age offers a fairer and more sustainable means of supporting an ageing population.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Responsibility for online content

Topic: Social media · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_discussion_19

Some people think that social media companies should be held responsible for the content that appears on their platforms. Others believe that the individual users who post the content should be responsible. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

290 words

Both views covered with a clear opinion · relevant ideas but underdeveloped · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary with some repetition · several article, agreement and word-form errors that do not block meaning.

Social media is used by billions of people every day, and some of the content on it is harmful, such as fake news or hate speech. Some people think social media companies should be responsible for this content, while others believe the users who post it should be responsible. I will discuss both views in this essay.

On the one hand, there are reasons to blame social media companies. These companies earn a huge amount of money from advertisements, and they design their platforms to keep people online as long as possible. Sometimes shocking or false posts get more attention, so the companies do not have strong reason to remove them. Also, they have the technology and money to check content and delete harmful posts quickly. If they are responsible by law, they will work harder to protect users, especially children.

On the other hand, many people think the users should be responsible. The person who write a post decides what to say, so it is their fault if the post is harmful or untrue. Every day millions of posts are uploaded, and it is impossible for companies to check all of them. In addition, if companies have to delete many posts, they may also delete normal opinions, and this can reduce the freedom of speech.

In my opinion, both the companies and the users should have responsibility. Users must think carefully before they post something and they should be punished if they break the law. However, companies must also remove dangerous content fastly when people report it.

In conclusion, there are good arguments on both sides. I believe that the responsibility should be shared between social media companies and the users, because both of them can make internet safer.

Band 7

306 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended and well supported · logical organisation with a clear central idea per paragraph · good collocations (legally liable, freedom of expression) · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

The spread of harmful material online, from false information to abusive messages, has raised the question of who should be held accountable. Some argue that social media companies should be responsible for everything that appears on their platforms, while others believe the responsibility lies with the individuals who post it. In my view, both share responsibility, but companies should be held to a higher standard than they currently are.

Those who blame individual users make a straightforward argument. The person who writes a post chooses its content, so they should face the consequences if it is defamatory, threatening or illegal. It is also argued that the sheer volume of material uploaded every minute makes it

impossible for any company to review everything. Furthermore, if platforms were legally liable for all content, they might remove anything controversial to protect themselves, which could seriously limit freedom of expression.

However, there are strong reasons to place significant responsibility on the companies themselves. Social media platforms are not neutral spaces; their algorithms decide which posts are promoted, and content that provokes strong emotions is often spread most widely because it generates more engagement and advertising revenue. In addition, these firms are extremely wealthy and have the technical ability to detect and remove harmful material far more effectively than they do at present. Many users also post anonymously, so holding individuals accountable are often difficult in practice.

I believe the responsibility should be shared. Users who break the law online should face the same penalties as they would offline, but companies should be required to act quickly when harmful content is reported and to be transparent about how their algorithms work.

In conclusion, while individual users remain responsible for what they post, social media companies profit from and amplify this content, and therefore they should also be held accountable for it.

Band 8

331 words

Both views thoroughly developed and critically evaluated · clear, nuanced position · logical progression and skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (perverse, amplified, recommendation systems) · wide range of accurate complex structures.

As social media has become a primary source of news and communication for many people, concern about harmful content, including misinformation, harassment and extremist material, has intensified. Some argue that the companies operating these platforms should be held responsible for what appears on them, while others insist that accountability lies with the individuals who post it. In my view, responsibility must be shared, but the role of the platforms has been significantly underestimated.

The case for holding users responsible rests on a basic principle of personal accountability. Each post is written by an individual who chooses its content, and it would seem perverse to excuse someone who spreads defamatory or threatening material simply because they did so online. There are also practical objections to placing the burden on companies. The volume of content uploaded every day is so vast that comprehensive monitoring is impossible, and platforms facing legal liability might respond by removing anything remotely contentious, with damaging consequences for free expression.

However, this view overlooks the active role that platforms play. They are not passive noticeboards: their recommendation systems determine what users see, and because provocative content tends to generate engagement, it is often amplified far beyond its original audience. Since these companies profit directly from this engagement, it is difficult to argue that they bear no responsibility for its effects. They also possess resources and technical expertise that no individual user could match, and anonymity frequently makes it impossible to identify the original author at all.

For these reasons, I believe a system of shared accountability is most appropriate. Individuals should face legal consequences for unlawful content, just as they would offline, while platforms should be obliged to respond promptly to reported material, limit the promotion of harmful posts and be transparent about how their algorithms operate.

In conclusion, although users are responsible for the content they create, social media companies shape and profit from its distribution, and they should therefore be held accountable for the part they play.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Experiences or possessions

Topic: Money and consumer behaviour · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_discussion_20

Some people believe that it is better to spend money on experiences, such as travel and entertainment. Others think it is wiser to spend money on possessions that last. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Band 6

287 words

Addresses both views and gives a clear opinion · relevant examples but ideas stay general · simple linking (Also, In contrast) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement, quantifier and preposition errors that do not block meaning.

People today have many choices about how to spend their money. Some people believe it is better to spend money on experiences like travelling and concerts, while others think buying things that last for a long time is wiser. In this essay I will discuss both views and give my opinion.

On the one hand, spending money on experiences has many advantages. When people travel to other countries, they can learn about different cultures, try new food and meet new people. These memories stay with them for their whole life. For example, most of people still remember a family holiday from their childhood, but they have forgotten the toys they had. Also, sharing experiences with friends and family can make the relationship stronger.

On the other hand, buying possessions also has benefits. Things like a house, a car or good furniture can be used for many years and make daily life more comfortable. Some possessions, such as property or gold, can even increase in value, so they are a kind of investment for the future. In contrast, a holiday finishes after one or two weeks and the money is gone. For people who do not have much money, it is more sensible to buy useful things than spending on expensive trips.

In my opinion, experiences are more valuable than possessions, as long as people do not waste money they need for basic things. After buying the necessary items, people should spend their extra money for experiences which make them happy and help them learn.

In conclusion, both experiences and possessions have advantages. I believe experiences give more happiness in the long term, but people should first make sure they have what they need in their daily life.

Band 7

291 words

Clear position throughout · both views extended and supported · logical progression with clear topic sentences · good collocations (disposable income, broaden one's horizons) · frequent error-free sentences with one article slip.

How people choose to spend their disposable income reflects their priorities in life. Some believe that experiences such as travel, concerts and meals out offer the best value, while others argue that it is more sensible to invest in lasting possessions. In my view, experiences generally bring greater long-term satisfaction, although certain durable goods are clearly worthwhile.

Those who favour possessions emphasise their practical and financial value. Items such as a reliable car, quality furniture or a home can be used every day for many years, improving comfort and convenience long after the purchase. Some possessions, particularly property,

may even increase in value and provide financial security in the future. By comparison, the money spent on a weekend away or an expensive concert is gone within days, leaving nothing tangible behind.

On the other hand, supporters of experiences argue that their benefits last longer than they first appear. Memories of travelling to a new country, learning a skill or celebrating with friends can bring pleasure for decades, and they often become part of a person's identity. Material goods, by contrast, tend to lose their appeal quickly as people become used to them or replace them with newer model. Experiences are also frequently shared, which strengthens relationships, whereas possessions can encourage comparison and competition with others.

In my opinion, the wisest approach is to buy durable items that genuinely improve daily life, and then to prioritise experiences with any remaining money. Spending on unnecessary luxury goods, which quickly become old-fashioned, is less rewarding than investing in activities that broaden one's horizons.

In conclusion, while lasting possessions provide comfort and security, I believe experiences such as travel and entertainment usually offer more lasting happiness, and they deserve a significant share of people's spending.

Band 8

323 words

Both views fully developed with thoughtful support · clear, qualified opinion · logical sequencing and well-managed paragraphs · wide, precise vocabulary (appreciate in value, discretionary spending) · wide range of complex structures, error-free.

Decisions about how to spend money reveal much about what people value. Some argue that the wisest use of income is to pay for experiences, such as travel and entertainment, whereas others maintain that it is more prudent to buy possessions that will last. While both have a place in a balanced life, I believe that experiences generally offer the greater and more enduring reward, once essential needs have been met.

The case for durable possessions is grounded in practicality. A well-made coat, a dependable vehicle or a comfortable home provides tangible benefits every day, often for many years, and the cost per use of a quality item can be remarkably low. Certain assets, notably property, may also appreciate in value, offering a degree of financial security that no holiday can match. From this perspective, spending heavily on fleeting experiences might seem short-sighted, particularly for those on modest incomes.

Nevertheless, the value of experiences is frequently underestimated. Although a journey or a concert is over quickly, the memories it creates can be revisited for a lifetime and often grow more cherished with time. Experiences also tend to be shared, strengthening bonds with family and friends, and they can broaden perspectives in ways that possessions rarely do, whether through exposure to another culture or the acquisition of a new skill. By contrast, the pleasure derived from a new purchase often fades as people grow accustomed to it, prompting a cycle of further buying that brings diminishing satisfaction.

In my view, therefore, the most sensible approach is to invest in a limited number of durable, genuinely useful items and to devote discretionary spending largely to experiences. This avoids accumulating possessions that bring little lasting joy, while still providing the stability that essential goods offer.

In conclusion, although possessions that last can deliver comfort and security, experiences tend to provide richer and longer-lasting fulfilment, and they therefore represent the wiser use of

money beyond life's necessities.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Taking a gap year

Topic: Education · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_advantages_01

Many students now take a year off between finishing school and starting university. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

269 words

Clear position with a judgement · relevant advantages and disadvantages but ideas are general and underdeveloped · mechanical linking (Firstly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, many young people decide to take a year off after they finish school and before they start university. In my opinion, the advantages of this gap year are more than the disadvantages, although there are some problems too.

On the one hand, a gap year have several benefits. Firstly, students can work and save money for their studies. University is very expensive in many countries, so if a student work for one year, he can pay some of his fees and he will not need to borrow so much money. Secondly, a year off give them time to think about what they really want to study. Many students choose a subject quickly and later they regret about it. Also, travelling to other countries can make young people more independent and confident.

On the other hand, there are some disadvantages. The main problem is that some students lose their motivation to study. After one year of working or travelling, it can be difficult to go back to books and exams, and some of them never go to university at all. In addition, travelling abroad is costly, so only students from rich family can enjoy this kind of gap year. Another problem is that they will finish their degree one year later than their friends.

In conclusion, I believe that taking a year off between school and university is more positive than negative. Although some students may lose interest in studying, most of them can gain money, experience and a clearer idea about their future. Therefore, I think the advantages outweigh the disadvantages if the student plan the year carefully.

Band 7

311 words

Clear position maintained throughout · both sides extended and supported, with some generalisation · logical organisation with a range of linkers · good collocation · mostly error-free with a minor preposition slip.

It has become increasingly common for school leavers to spend a year working, volunteering or travelling before they begin a university degree. While this break can create certain risks, I would argue that its benefits are considerably greater, provided that the year is used purposefully.

Admittedly, a year out of education has some clear drawbacks. Some students find it hard to return to academic study after a long break, since the habits of revision and concentration they built at school may fade. Others treat the year simply as an extended holiday, which achieves little beyond delaying their education and their entry into work. There is also a financial aspect: travelling abroad can be expensive, and students from less wealthy families may not be able to afford the kind of gap year that is often promoted in the media.

Despite this, the advantages are more significant. The most important is that a gap year allows young people to make a more informed choice about their future. At eighteen, many students

select a course simply because of their exam results or pressure from parents, and some later drop out when they realise the subject does not suit them. Spending time in the workplace or doing voluntary work gives them a clearer picture about their strengths and interests. Moreover, experiences such as living away from home or managing a budget help them develop the maturity and independence that university life demands. A student who works locally for part of the year, for instance, can save money and gain useful experience without losing contact with learning.

In conclusion, although a gap year may reduce motivation for some and is not equally accessible to everyone, the chance to mature and choose a degree more carefully outweighs these disadvantages. The key is that the year should have a clear purpose rather than being time simply spent waiting.

Band 8

331 words

Fully developed response with a clear, qualified judgement · ideas extended and well supported · skilful paragraphing and cohesion · precise, natural vocabulary · wide range of structures, virtually error-free.

The practice of postponing university for a year, once associated mainly with affluent students travelling overseas, has become a mainstream option for school leavers. In my view, when the year is structured rather than aimless, the benefits it offers clearly outweigh the drawbacks.

Perhaps the strongest argument in favour of a gap year is that it leads to better-informed decisions about higher education. Students who move straight from school to university often commit to a three- or four-year course on the basis of limited self-knowledge, and a poor match between student and subject is a common reason for dropping out. A year spent in employment or volunteering exposes young people to the realities of working life, allowing them to test their interests before investing heavily in a degree. Equally valuable is the personal growth that comes from handling responsibilities outside the protective environment of school: someone who has held down a job, paid rent or organised their own travel is likely to arrive at university more self-reliant and more focused.

That said, the disadvantages should not be dismissed. A break of twelve months can erode study habits, and a minority of students never return to education at all, particularly if a job offers an immediate income that seems more attractive than further study. The year also postpones graduation and entry into a career, which carries a real cost in lost earnings. Furthermore, the more glamorous forms of gap year, such as extended travel abroad, remain out of reach for many families, which means the experience can reinforce existing inequalities.

On balance, however, most of these risks stem from poor planning rather than from the gap year itself. Where students set clear goals, combining paid work with volunteering or skills development, they tend to return to education with greater purpose.

Overall, therefore, I believe the advantages of a well-planned gap year outweigh its disadvantages, since the maturity and clarity it provides can shape the rest of a student's academic and professional life.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Online university courses

Topic: Universities / Technology · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_02

In many universities, online courses are increasingly replacing traditional classroom teaching. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this trend?

Band 6

278 words

Addresses both advantages and disadvantages · relevant but list-like ideas with limited development · mechanical sequencing (Firstly, Secondly, Finally) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and preposition errors.

These days, a lot of universities are using online courses instead of the traditional classes in a classroom. This trend has both advantages and disadvantages, and I will discuss them in this essay.

The first advantage is that online courses are very flexible. Students can watch the lectures at any time and in any place, so they can study and work at the same time. This is very helpful for students who has a part-time job or a family to look after. Another advantage is the cost. Students do not need to pay for transport or rent a room near the university, so they can save a lot of money. Also, universities can teach more students because they do not need big lecture halls.

However, there are also some disadvantages of online learning. Firstly, students do not have much contact with their teachers and classmates. In a classroom, they can ask questions immediately and discuss about ideas with other students, but online it is more difficult. As a result, some students feel lonely and lose their motivation. Secondly, not every students have a good computer or a fast internet connection, especially in the countryside. This means that some students cannot follow the lessons properly. Finally, some subjects like medicine or engineering need practical work in a laboratory, and this is not possible on a screen.

In conclusion, online courses are flexible and cheap, and they help many people to study who could not go to university before. But they also reduce the communication between students and teachers and they are not suitable for all subject. I think universities should use a mix of both online and classroom teaching.

Band 7

314 words

Both sides clearly presented with extended support · clear central topic in each paragraph · range of cohesive devices · good collocation (widen access, hands-on work) · frequent error-free sentences, one agreement slip.

Across the world, a growing number of universities are moving their teaching from lecture theatres to digital platforms. This shift brings real benefits in terms of access and flexibility, but it also raises concerns about the quality of learning and the student experience.

One major advantage of online courses is that they make higher education available to people who would otherwise be excluded. Mature students with full-time jobs, parents with young children and those living far from a campus can all follow lectures at a time and place that suits them. In addition, recorded lessons allows learners to pause, replay and review difficult material at their own pace, which can be particularly helpful for those studying in a second language. From the institution's point of view, digital delivery reduces the need for expensive buildings, and these savings could be passed on to students through lower fees.

On the other hand, replacing classrooms entirely has significant drawbacks. Face-to-face teaching allows lecturers to notice when students are confused and adapt their explanations immediately, while online, many learners simply stop engaging without anyone realising. The social side of university is also lost: discussions with classmates, study groups and informal conversations with tutors all contribute to both learning and wellbeing, and these are hard to reproduce through a screen. Furthermore, practical subjects such as nursing, chemistry or architecture depend on hands-on work that cannot be done remotely.

A further problem is that online study demands a high level of self-discipline. Younger students who have just left school often struggle to organise their time without the structure of regular classes, and they may fall behind as a result.

In conclusion, online courses widen access and offer valuable flexibility, but they weaken interaction and are unsuitable for practical disciplines. For this reason, a blended approach is likely to serve most students better than a complete move away from the classroom.

Band 8

331 words

Sufficiently addresses both advantages and disadvantages with well-developed, relevant support · logical sequencing and well-managed paragraphs · wide, precise vocabulary used flexibly · wide range of accurate structures.

The steady replacement of lecture halls with virtual classrooms is one of the most visible changes in higher education in recent years. Although this trend has made university study more accessible and adaptable, it also risks diluting some of the most valuable aspects of a traditional education.

The principal benefit of online provision is its capacity to widen participation. Because lectures can be accessed from anywhere, students in remote regions, those with disabilities that make travel difficult and adults balancing study with employment are no longer disadvantaged by geography or rigid timetables. Digital materials are also more flexible as learning tools: a recorded lecture can be revisited before an examination, subtitled or slowed down, giving learners greater control over how they absorb information. For universities, meanwhile, online delivery allows a single course to reach thousands of students without a corresponding increase in staff or facilities.

Yet these gains come at a cost. Learning at university is not merely the transfer of information; it is also shaped by debate, questioning and collaboration, which tend to flourish in shared physical spaces. In a live seminar, a tutor can challenge a weak argument or draw a quiet student into the discussion, whereas in an online forum such interaction is often delayed, superficial or absent altogether. Isolation is a related concern, as students who rarely meet their peers may feel less connected to their institution and more likely to abandon their studies. There are practical limitations too: laboratory work, clinical training and studio-based design cannot be meaningfully replicated at a distance.

Equally important is the issue of unequal access to technology. A course delivered entirely online assumes a reliable device and a stable internet connection, which not every student can take for granted.

In summary, online courses offer flexibility, reach and efficiency, but at the expense of interaction, community and practical training. The most effective universities are likely to be those that combine digital tools with meaningful face-to-face teaching rather than abandoning the classroom altogether.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

AI in medical diagnosis

Topic: Artificial intelligence / Health · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_03

In many countries, artificial intelligence is now being used to help doctors identify illnesses. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

260 words

Relevant position with a clear judgement · main ideas relevant but general and briefly supported · basic linking (First, Second, Moreover) · adequate vocabulary · agreement, comparative and spelling errors that do not impede meaning.

Today in many countries, doctors are using artificial intelligence to find out what illness a patient have. I believe that this technology has more advantages than disadvantages, but we should be careful how we use it.

The main advantage is that AI can be very accurate. A computer program can look at thousands of X-rays and scans and it can learn to notice small problems which a human doctor might miss. For example, it can find early signs of cancer, and this can save many lives. Another benefit is speed. Doctors in busy hospitals do not have enough time for every patient, but AI can check the results in a few seconds, so patients get their diagnosis more faster. This is also useful in poor areas where there is not many doctors.

However, there are some disadvantages. First, AI is not perfect and sometimes it makes mistakes. If the doctor trust the computer too much, the patient can get the wrong treatment. Second, patients' medical information is very private, and if it is stored in computer systems, it can be stolen by hackers. Moreover, many people prefer to talk with a real doctor, because a machine cannot understand their feelings or explain things in a kind way.

In conclusion, I think using artificial intelligence to help doctors is a good idea because it makes the diagnosis quicker and more accurate. The problems like mistakes and privacy are important, but they can be reduced if doctors always check the results of AI. So the advantages outweigh the disadvantages in my opinion.

Band 7

315 words

Clear position throughout with a definite judgement · ideas extended with relevant examples, though some claims are generalised · logical progression · good range of vocabulary · mostly accurate, one preposition slip.

Artificial intelligence is increasingly being introduced into hospitals and clinics to support doctors in diagnosing disease. Although this development raises understandable concerns, I believe that its benefits are greater, as long as the final decision remains in human hands.

Admittedly, relying on AI in medicine involves several risks. No system is completely reliable, and an error in diagnosis could have serious consequences for a patient. There is also a danger that doctors become too dependent to software and gradually lose some of their own diagnostic skills. In addition, these systems need huge amounts of patient data to be trained, which creates concerns about privacy and about who controls such sensitive information. Finally, some patients may feel uneasy if they believe a machine rather than a person is responsible for their care.

Despite these issues, the advantages are more significant. AI tools are able to analyse medical images, such as scans and X-rays, extremely quickly and can often detect subtle patterns that

even experienced specialists overlook. This means that serious conditions like cancer or heart disease may be identified at an earlier stage, when treatment is more likely to succeed. Furthermore, AI can reduce the heavy workload of doctors, allowing them to spend more time talking to patients and planning treatment. In regions where specialists are in short supply, a diagnostic tool on a computer or phone could provide an expert first opinion that would otherwise not be available at all.

Most of the disadvantages can also be managed. If AI is used as an assistant rather than a replacement, doctors can check its suggestions, and strict laws on data protection can reduce the risk to privacy.

In conclusion, while artificial intelligence in diagnosis brings risks of error, over-reliance and loss of privacy, its ability to detect illness faster and more accurately makes it a valuable tool. On balance, therefore, the advantages clearly outweigh the drawbacks.

Band 8

328 words

Fully addresses the question with a clear, well-justified judgement · ideas logically sequenced and thoroughly developed · cohesion managed skilfully · wide, precise vocabulary · wide range of structures, error-free.

The use of artificial intelligence to assist in diagnosing illness has moved rapidly from experimental research to everyday clinical practice in many countries. While the technology is not without its hazards, I am convinced that, used responsibly, it offers benefits that far outweigh its drawbacks.

The most compelling case for diagnostic AI lies in its accuracy and consistency. Algorithms trained on vast collections of medical images can identify minute abnormalities in scans that might escape a tired or inexperienced clinician, and unlike humans, they do not become less attentive at the end of a long shift. Earlier detection of conditions such as tumours can transform a patient's prognosis, turning a potentially fatal illness into a treatable one. AI also addresses a practical problem faced by health systems almost everywhere: a shortage of specialists. By screening routine cases, it frees doctors to concentrate on complex diagnoses and on the human side of medicine, and it can extend a degree of specialist expertise to rural clinics that have no radiologist on site.

The concerns, nevertheless, are real. Diagnostic systems are only as good as the data used to build them, so a tool developed mainly with records from one population may perform poorly for others, potentially widening existing inequalities in care. There is also the question of accountability: when an algorithm contributes to a misdiagnosis, it is unclear whether responsibility lies with the doctor, the hospital or the software developer. Moreover, the large-scale collection of health records required to train these systems inevitably raises questions of confidentiality.

Crucially, though, none of these problems is inherent to the technology. They can be mitigated through rigorous testing on diverse patient groups, clear legal frameworks and the principle that AI supports, rather than replaces, clinical judgement.

In conclusion, the risks associated with AI in diagnosis demand careful regulation, but they are outweighed by its potential to detect disease earlier, ease pressure on doctors and bring expert assessment to those who currently lack it.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Living in high-rise apartments

Topic: Housing · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_advantages_04

More and more people in cities now live in high-rise apartment buildings. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

274 words

Clear judgement given · relevant points on both sides but development is limited and general · simple, mechanical linking · adequate but repetitive vocabulary · word form and agreement errors that do not block meaning.

In many cities today, more people are living in tall apartment buildings. There are some good points and bad points about this type of housing, but I think the advantages are bigger than the disadvantages.

The first reason is that high-rise buildings use land very efficient. Cities have a lot of people but not much space, so building upwards means that many families can live on a small piece of land. This can help to reduce the housing problem and keep the price of flats lower. Also, people who live in these buildings are usually close to the city centre, so they can go to work, school and shops easily and they do not need to drive a long distance every day. Many modern apartment blocks also have facilities like a gym, a swimming pool and security guards, which makes life more comfortable.

On the other hand, living in a high-rise building have some problems. For example, there is often no garden or green space, so children do not have a safe place to play outside. In addition, people in big buildings often do not know their neighbours, and some of them feel lonely and isolated. Another problem is safety. If there is a fire or the lift stop working, it can be very dangerous and difficult for old people to get out.

In conclusion, although high-rise apartments have some disadvantages such as the lack of green space and loneliness, I believe they are necessary for modern cities because they save land and are convenient. So in my opinion, the advantages outweigh the disadvantages, especially if the government make sure the buildings are safe.

Band 7

296 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported, with a paragraph addressing the drawbacks · logical organisation and varied linking · good collocation · mostly error-free, one article slip.

As urban populations continue to grow, high-rise apartment blocks have become the most common form of housing in many cities. Although this way of living has certain drawbacks, I believe the advantages are greater overall.

The main benefit of tall residential buildings is that they make efficient use of limited land. By housing hundreds of families on a single plot, they reduce the pressure to build on surrounding countryside and help to keep housing more affordable than it would otherwise be. Moreover, because high-rise blocks are usually located in central districts, residents can live close to their workplaces, schools and public transport. This not only saves time on commuting but also reduces the number of cars on the roads, which is better for environment. Many newer developments also provide shared facilities such as gyms, playgrounds and security staff that individual houses rarely have.

However, apartment living also has disadvantages. The most frequently mentioned is a weaker sense of community: residents may share a lift with dozens of people every day and yet hardly know any of them. Families with young children often complain about the lack of private outdoor space, while elderly residents can find themselves trapped if lifts break down. There are also concerns about safety in the event of fire, as evacuating a tall building is more difficult than leaving a house.

Nevertheless, most of these problems can be reduced through good design and regulation. Communal gardens, shared rooftop areas and strict fire-safety standards can make high-rise living both more sociable and more secure.

In conclusion, while tall apartment buildings can feel impersonal and present particular safety challenges, their efficient use of land and convenient locations make them an essential solution for crowded cities. For these reasons, I believe the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

Band 8

297 words

Well-developed, fully relevant response with a clear judgement · ideas logically sequenced and extended · skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (urban sprawl, footprint, economically viable) · wide range of error-free structures.

Across the world's major cities, the skyline is increasingly dominated by residential towers, and a growing share of urban households now live many floors above the street. Although vertical living has undeniable shortcomings, I would argue that, in densely populated cities, its advantages prevail.

The strongest case for high-rise housing is a practical one. Land in city centres is scarce and expensive, and building upwards allows far more homes to be created on the same footprint than low-rise development ever could. This density has wider benefits: it limits urban sprawl into farmland and green belts, and it makes public transport, shops and services economically viable because enough people live within walking distance of them. For residents, the result is often a shorter commute and easier access to employment, education and leisure, which can significantly improve quality of life.

The drawbacks, however, are genuine. Tall buildings can be socially isolating, since the anonymity of long corridors and shared lifts rarely encourages the casual encounters that build neighbourly relationships. Families may struggle without private gardens, and older or disabled residents are particularly vulnerable when lifts fail. Safety is a further concern: evacuating hundreds of people from upper floors during a fire is inherently more complex than escaping from a house, and poorly maintained towers can become hazardous.

Yet these issues largely reflect how such buildings are designed and managed rather than the concept itself. Well-planned developments incorporate communal green spaces, community rooms and robust fire-safety systems, demonstrating that high-density living can be both safe and socially vibrant.

In conclusion, high-rise apartments may compromise privacy, outdoor space and, at times, community spirit, but these costs can be mitigated through thoughtful design. Given their efficient use of land and the accessibility they offer, I believe their advantages clearly outweigh their disadvantages.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Multinationals in developing countries

Topic: Globalisation · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_advantages_05

Large international companies are increasingly opening factories and offices in developing countries. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages for the people of these countries?

Band 6

264 words

Addresses both sides with a clear judgement · relevant ideas, some supported by simple examples, others underdeveloped · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors that do not impede meaning.

Nowadays, many big international companies are building factories and offices in developing countries. This has both advantages and disadvantages for the local people. In my opinion, the advantages are more important.

The biggest advantage is jobs. When a foreign company open a factory, it needs hundreds of workers, so many people who was unemployed can get a job and earn a regular salary. This helps families to pay for food, education and health care. Also, international companies often pay higher wages than local companies. Another advantage is that workers can learn new skills and technology. For example, if an employee works in a car factory, he can learn how to use modern machines, and later he can use this knowledge in other jobs. Moreover, the government gets more money from taxes, which it can spend on roads and schools.

However, there are also some disadvantages. Some companies pay very low salary and the working conditions are bad, for example people work for long hours without enough rest. In addition, the factories can cause pollution to the rivers and air, and this is harmful for the people's health who live nearby. Finally, the most of the profit goes back to the company's home country, so the developing country does not get all the benefit.

In conclusion, international companies bring both good and bad effects to developing countries. They create jobs and teach new skills, but they can also cause pollution and pay low wages. I believe that the advantages outweigh the disadvantages, but the government should make strict rules to protect workers and the environment.

Band 7

297 words

Clear position throughout · both sides developed with relevant support, though some points are generalised · clear paragraph topics · good range of vocabulary (scarce, exploitation) · mostly accurate, one agreement slip.

In recent decades, multinational corporations have moved a growing share of their manufacturing and service operations to developing nations. While this trend can create problems for local communities, I believe that, overall, the benefits for ordinary people in these countries are greater than the costs.

The most obvious advantage is employment. Foreign firms often create thousands of jobs in regions where work is scarce, giving people a steady income and the chance to escape poverty. These jobs frequently pay more than local alternatives, and they may come with training that local employers cannot afford to provide. Over time, employees gain technical and managerial skills which they can take to other companies or use to start their own businesses. In addition, the presence of large international firms tends to improve local infrastructure, as roads, ports

and power supplies are upgraded to serve them.

On the other hand, there are serious disadvantages. Some corporations are attracted mainly by cheap labour and weak regulations, and as a result workers may face long hours, low pay and unsafe conditions. Environmental damage is another concern, since factories can pollute rivers and air in countries where laws are poorly enforced. Furthermore, large foreign companies can drive small local businesses out of the market, and a significant part of the profits is sent back abroad rather than reinvested locally.

However, these negative effects are not unavoidable. When governments set and enforce minimum standards for wages, safety and pollution, foreign investment can bring benefits without the worst forms of exploitation.

In conclusion, although multinational companies can exploit workers and damage the environment, the jobs, skills and infrastructure they bring represent a major opportunity for people in developing countries. For this reason, I believe the advantages outweigh the disadvantages, provided that effective regulation are in place.

Band 8

316 words

Sufficiently addresses the question with a nuanced, clearly argued judgement · ideas extended and logically linked · cohesion well managed · wide, precise vocabulary used naturally · wide range of accurate complex structures.

The relocation of factories and offices by multinational corporations to lower-income countries is one of the defining features of the global economy. Its impact on local populations is mixed, but I would contend that, where host governments regulate effectively, the advantages for ordinary citizens outweigh the disadvantages.

The most immediate gain is employment. In economies with high levels of informal or subsistence work, a job with a foreign firm often provides the first regular wage a household has received, together with a degree of stability that enables families to plan, save and invest in their children's education. Beyond income, these positions frequently involve formal training, exposing workers to modern production methods, management practices and quality standards. Such knowledge rarely stays within one company; it spreads as employees move on or establish suppliers of their own, gradually raising the productivity of the wider economy. Foreign investment can also stimulate improvements in transport and energy that benefit the whole population.

The costs, however, can be severe. Some corporations deliberately seek out countries with lax labour and environmental laws, and the consequences can include excessive working hours, dangerous workplaces and serious contamination of land and water. There is also the risk of dependency: an economy built around foreign-owned plants is vulnerable if a company decides to relocate again in search of even cheaper costs, leaving entire towns without work. Moreover, much of the value generated flows back to shareholders overseas rather than being reinvested locally.

Importantly, these harms are largely a function of governance rather than of foreign investment itself. Countries that enforce labour rights, require environmental safeguards and encourage links with domestic suppliers tend to capture far more of the benefits.

In conclusion, multinational investment carries real risks of exploitation and instability, yet the jobs, skills and infrastructure it brings can transform living standards. On balance, and with sound regulation, its advantages for local people outweigh its disadvantages.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Short-term employment contracts

Topic: Employment · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_06

Many companies now employ workers on short-term contracts rather than offering them permanent jobs. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this for workers?

Band 6

270 words

Covers advantages and disadvantages for workers · relevant ideas with simple examples but limited development · formulaic linking · adequate vocabulary · several errors in agreement, articles and prepositions that do not block meaning.

Nowadays many companies prefer to give workers short-term contracts instead of permanent jobs. This situation has some advantages but also many disadvantages for the workers, which I will discuss in this essay.

On the one hand, short-term contracts can be good for some workers. First of all, they give people more freedom. If a worker does not like the job or the company, he can simply leave when the contract finish and look for something better. Also, young people can try different jobs and get experience in many areas before they decide their career. For example, a graduate can work six months in marketing and then six months in sales. Moreover, some contracts pay a higher salary per hour because the company do not need to pay for holidays or pension.

On the other hand, the disadvantages are serious. The biggest problem is that there is no job security. Workers do not know if they will have a job next year, so it is difficult for them to plan the future, for example to buy a house or start a family. Banks also do not like to give loan to people without permanent job. In addition, temporary workers often do not receive the same benefits like sick pay, training or promotion. As a result, they may feel stressed and not part of the company.

In conclusion, short-term contracts give workers flexibility and the chance to gain different experiences, but they also create insecurity and fewer benefits. In my opinion, they are suitable for young people at the start of their career, but for most workers a permanent job is better.

Band 7

293 words

Both sides addressed with a clear overall view · ideas extended and supported with relevant examples · logical paragraphing and linking · good range of vocabulary (job security, fixed-term) · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

It is becoming increasingly common for employers to hire staff on fixed-term contracts instead of offering them permanent positions. For workers, this arrangement brings some genuine benefits, but in my view these are outweighed by the insecurity it creates for most people.

There are some advantages to short-term employment. Firstly, it offers flexibility, which suits certain groups such as students, parents returning to work or people who want to travel between contracts. Secondly, it allows workers to gain experience across a range of organisations and industries in a relatively short time, which can make their CV more attractive and help them discover what kind of work suits them best. In some sectors, such as information technology, skilled contractors are also able to charge higher rates than permanent staff because employers value their specialist knowledge.

However, for the majority of employees, the disadvantages are more significant. The lack of job security is the most serious issue, as workers cannot be sure whether their contract will be renewed. This uncertainty makes it difficult to make long-term commitments, such as taking out a mortgage or starting a family, and it can cause considerable stress. In addition, temporary staff are often excluded from benefits like paid holidays, sick leave and pension schemes, and they rarely receive the training or promotion opportunities which is offered to permanent colleagues. Because they know they may soon leave, they may also feel less loyal to the company and less valued by their managers.

In conclusion, short-term contracts can be attractive for highly skilled professionals and for people who want flexibility at a particular stage of life. For most workers, though, the loss of security, benefits and career development makes this type of employment a less desirable option than a permanent job.

Band 8

306 words

Fully addresses advantages and disadvantages for workers with insightful, well-supported ideas · clear progression · cohesion managed skilfully · wide, precise vocabulary (bargaining power, entitlements) · wide range of error-free structures.

The shift away from permanent employment towards fixed-term and project-based contracts has reshaped working life in many economies. For employees, this change offers a certain degree of freedom, but it also transfers much of the risk that employers once carried onto individual workers.

On the positive side, short-term contracts can suit people whose priorities do not fit a conventional career path. A recent graduate, for example, may use a series of placements to sample different industries before committing to one, while a parent may value the ability to work intensively for several months and then take time off. For those with scarce, in-demand skills, contract work can be financially rewarding, as employers are often willing to pay a premium for expertise they need only temporarily. Moving between organisations also broadens professional networks and exposes workers to a variety of practices, which can make them more adaptable.

The drawbacks, however, fall most heavily on those with the least bargaining power. Without the assurance of continued employment, workers find it hard to plan ahead: securing a mortgage, supporting dependants or even booking a holiday becomes a gamble when income may stop within months. Temporary staff frequently miss out on entitlements such as sick pay, pension contributions and parental leave, and employers have little incentive to invest in training someone who may soon leave. Over time, this can trap people in a cycle of insecure jobs with limited prospects for promotion. The psychological toll should not be overlooked either, as persistent uncertainty is a well-known source of stress.

To sum up, short-term contracts can offer flexibility, variety and, for skilled professionals, higher earnings. For the majority of workers, however, these advantages come at the price of financial insecurity, reduced benefits and weaker career development, which is why such arrangements work best when they are genuinely chosen rather than imposed.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Supermarkets replacing local shops

Topic: Business · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_advantages_07

In many towns, small local shops are being replaced by large supermarkets and shopping centres. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

258 words

Clear position with a judgement · relevant ideas on both sides, some only briefly developed · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · word-form, agreement and countability errors that do not block meaning.

In many towns, the small shops are closing and large supermarkets and shopping centres are taking their place. In my opinion, this change has some advantages, but the disadvantages are more serious.

To begin with, there are some benefits of supermarkets. They are usually cheaper than small shops because they buy products in large quantity. This is important for families who have a low income. Also, supermarkets are very convenient, because customers can buy everything they need in one place, such as food, clothes and electronic, and they can park their car easily. Many of them are open for long hours, so people who works late can still do their shopping.

However, I think the disadvantages are more important. When small shops close, the owners lose their business and many local people lose their jobs. The money which people spend in supermarkets often goes to big companies in other cities, not to the local community.

Moreover, the town centre become less attractive, because there are many empty shops and fewer people walking in the streets. Small shops also give a personal service. The shopkeeper knows his customers and can give them advices, but in a big supermarket nobody knows you. Finally, old people who cannot drive find it difficult to go to shopping centres outside the town.

In conclusion, supermarkets and shopping centres are cheap and convenient, but they damage local businesses and change the character of towns. For these reasons, I believe that the disadvantages outweigh the advantages, and local governments should help small shops to survive.

Band 7

266 words

Clear position maintained · advantages acknowledged and disadvantages extended with relevant support · logical organisation with a range of linkers · good collocation (under one roof, far-reaching) · one article slip.

Across many towns, independent shops are gradually disappearing as large supermarkets and out-of-town shopping centres take over. Although this development offers consumers some clear benefits, I believe the loss to local communities is greater.

It is true that large retailers bring certain advantages. Because they buy goods in enormous quantities, they can offer lower prices than small shops, which is especially important for households on tight budget. They also provide convenience: shoppers can buy groceries, clothing and household items under one roof, often late into the evening and with free parking. In addition, supermarkets tend to offer a much wider range of products, including foreign foods that small local stores would rarely stock.

Nevertheless, the disadvantages are more far-reaching. When independent businesses close, the effect goes beyond the owners themselves. High streets that were once busy become lined

with empty premises, which makes town centres less attractive and can even encourage vandalism. More of the money spent also leaves the area, as profits go to national chains rather than circulating among local families. Moreover, small shops often play a social role that supermarkets cannot replace; a local grocer who greets customers by name offers a sense of connection that is particularly valuable for elderly people living alone. Finally, shopping centres built on the edge of town encourage car use, which increases traffic and puts residents without transport at a disadvantage.

In conclusion, supermarkets and shopping centres undoubtedly make shopping cheaper and more convenient. However, since they weaken local economies, damage town centres and reduce community life, I believe that on balance their disadvantages outweigh their advantages.

Band 8

304 words

Clear, well-reasoned judgement · ideas fully extended with precise supporting detail · logical sequencing and skilful cohesion · wide, idiomatic vocabulary (economies of scale, footfall) · wide range of accurate structures.

The decline of the independent high-street shop in the face of competition from supermarkets and shopping centres is a familiar story in many towns. While the change has undoubtedly benefited shoppers in certain respects, I would argue that, taken as a whole, its advantages are outweighed by its costs.

The case for large retailers rests largely on price and convenience. Economies of scale allow supermarkets to negotiate lower prices from suppliers and pass at least some of these savings on to customers, which matters considerably to families whose budgets are stretched. Their extended opening hours, extensive product ranges and ample parking also suit modern lifestyles, in which many people have little time to visit several separate shops. For consumers, then, the immediate benefits are tangible.

The disadvantages, however, are broader and longer-lasting. Independent shops are typically owned by local residents, so the money spent in them tends to circulate within the community, supporting other local businesses and jobs. When they are replaced by national chains, a greater share of that spending is channelled elsewhere. The physical fabric of towns suffers too: once enough shops close, footfall declines, remaining businesses struggle and high streets can enter a spiral of decline marked by vacant units. There is also a social dimension that is easily overlooked. Small shops often serve as informal meeting points where neighbours exchange news, and for older or less mobile residents, a daily visit to a nearby store may be an important source of human contact. Out-of-town shopping centres, by contrast, are designed around the car and can leave such people isolated.

In conclusion, supermarkets and shopping centres offer genuine savings and convenience, but these gains are largely private and short-term, whereas the erosion of local economies and community life affects entire towns. For this reason, I believe the disadvantages outweigh the advantages.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Paid social media promotion

Topic: Advertising · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_08

Companies are increasingly paying popular social media users to promote their products. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

267 words

Clear judgement given · relevant ideas with simple examples but limited development · paragraphing present, linking mechanical · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and word-form errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, many companies pay famous people on social media, who are called influencers, to advertise their products. There are both advantages and disadvantages of this, but I believe the advantages are greater.

Firstly, this kind of advertising is very effective for companies. Influencers have thousands or even millions of followers, and many of them are young people who do not watch television anymore. So if a company want to reach young customers, it is a good way. Also, it is often cheaper than a TV advert, especially for small businesses. For example, a small clothes shop can pay a local influencer to wear their clothes in a video, and after that the sales can increase quickly.

Secondly, customers can also get benefit. Influencers usually show how a product works in real life, so people can understand it better than in a normal advertisement. They can also find new products which they did not know before.

On the other hand, there are some disadvantages. Sometimes influencers do not say clearly that they are paid, so their followers think it is their honest opinion. This is not fair for the customers. In addition, many followers are teenager, and they can be easily influenced to buy expensive things which they do not really need. Some influencers even promote products that is not safe, for example diet pills.

In conclusion, paying social media users to promote products have some problems, especially when the advertising is not honest. However, I think it is a modern and effective way of marketing that helps both companies and customers, so the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

Band 7

298 words

Clear position throughout · advantages acknowledged and disadvantages well extended, with some generalisation · logical progression · good collocation (blurs the line, idealised lifestyle) · frequent error-free sentences, one agreement slip.

The practice of companies paying popular social media personalities to advertise their goods has grown rapidly in recent years. Although this form of marketing has clear benefits for businesses, I believe that its negative effects on consumers are more significant.

From a commercial point of view, influencer marketing is highly attractive. It enables companies to reach specific groups of consumers, particularly young people who rarely watch television or read magazines. Because followers often feel a personal connection with the influencer, a recommendation from them can seem more trustworthy than a traditional advertisement. For smaller brands, it can also be more affordable than a national advertising campaign, allowing them to compete with larger rivals.

However, it is precisely this sense of trust that makes the practice problematic. Many followers cannot easily tell the difference between a genuine opinion and a paid promotion, especially when the commercial relationship is not clearly disclosed. As a result, consumers may be persuaded to buy products based on what they believe is honest advice, when in fact the influencer has been paid to praise them. This is particularly concerning because many social media users are teenagers, who are more vulnerable to pressure to follow trends. Influencers also tend to present an idealised lifestyle, which can encourage excessive spending and make young people feel dissatisfied with their own appearance or possessions. In some cases, products of poor quality or with unproven health benefits are promoted simply because the influencer was well paid to do so.

In conclusion, paying social media users to promote products is an efficient and relatively cheap marketing tool for companies. Nevertheless, because it often blurs the line between advertising and personal opinion and targets vulnerable young audiences, I believe the disadvantages outweigh the advantages, unless strict rules on transparency is enforced.

Band 8

308 words

Sufficiently addresses both sides with a clear, well-argued judgement · ideas logically sequenced and fully extended · cohesion managed skilfully · wide, precise vocabulary (persuasive intent, scrutiny) · wide range of error-free structures.

Influencer marketing, in which brands pay popular social media users to feature their products, has become one of the fastest-growing forms of advertising. While it offers undeniable advantages to businesses and, to a lesser extent, to consumers, I would argue that its disadvantages ultimately carry more weight.

The appeal for companies is easy to understand. Influencers command highly engaged audiences, often defined by specific interests such as fitness, gaming or cookery, so a brand can place its message directly in front of the people most likely to buy. This precision makes campaigns more cost-effective than broad television advertising, and it gives small and new businesses a realistic route to visibility. Consumers may benefit too, since a detailed video demonstration can reveal more about how a product performs than a polished thirty-second commercial.

Nevertheless, the model rests on a fundamental tension. Its effectiveness depends on audiences perceiving the influencer as an authentic, independent voice, yet the content is, by definition, paid for. When sponsorship is concealed or disclosed only in small print, followers are effectively misled into treating advertising as personal recommendation. The problem is compounded by the age profile of many audiences: children and teenagers are less equipped to recognise persuasive intent and more susceptible to the carefully curated lifestyles on display, which can fuel both overconsumption and insecurity about body image. Furthermore, because influencers are rewarded for promotion rather than expertise, products such as dubious supplements or risky financial schemes can reach large audiences with little scrutiny.

Admittedly, clearer labelling requirements could reduce some of these harms, but enforcing them across millions of posts remains extremely difficult.

In conclusion, paid promotion on social media is an efficient and accessible marketing channel, yet its reliance on blurring commerce and personal opinion, combined with its reach among young people, means that in my view the disadvantages outweigh the advantages.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

City centre congestion charges

Topic: Transport · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_09

Some cities charge drivers a fee to enter the city centre at busy times of day. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

267 words

Clear position and judgement · relevant main ideas but support is brief and general · mechanical linking (The first, The second, Also) · adequate vocabulary · agreement and countability errors that do not impede meaning.

In some cities, drivers have to pay money if they want to drive into the city centre during the busy times of the day. I think this policy has more advantages than disadvantages.

The first advantage is that it reduce traffic. When people have to pay every day, many of them will decide to use the bus, the train or a bicycle instead of their car. As a result, the roads in the centre are less crowded and the journeys become faster for buses, taxis and delivery vans. The second advantage is about the environment. Less cars means less air pollution and less noise, so the city centre become a healthier and more pleasant place for people who live and work there. In addition, the government can use the money from the charge to improve public transport, for example by buying new buses.

However, this system also has some disadvantages. It is unfair for people with low income, because rich people can pay the fee easily but poor people cannot. Also, some people have no choice and they must use their car, for example workers who start very early in the morning when there is no buses. Shop owners in the centre are also worried that fewer customers will come to their shops.

In conclusion, charging drivers to enter the city centre can cause some problems, especially for poor people and small shops. However, I believe the benefits for traffic and the environment are more important, so the advantages outweigh the disadvantages. The government should use the money to make public transport cheaper and better for everyone.

Band 7

296 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported, with counter-arguments addressed · clear topic in each paragraph · good range of vocabulary (peak hours, transport links) · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

Several major cities have introduced congestion charges, which require motorists to pay a fee for driving into the centre during peak hours. Although this measure can place a burden on some groups, I am convinced that its benefits outweigh its drawbacks.

The principal advantage is a reduction in traffic. Faced with a daily charge, many commuters switch to public transport, cycling or car-sharing, and the remaining traffic can move more freely. This benefits not only drivers but also buses and emergency vehicles, which are otherwise delayed by congestion. A second benefit is environmental. Fewer vehicles in central areas leads to cleaner air and less noise, improving the health and quality of life of residents and people who work there. In addition, the money raised can be invested directly in public transport, creating a positive cycle in which better services encourage even more people to leave their cars at home.

On the other hand, critics raise some valid points. The fee affects low-income drivers far more than wealthy ones, who may simply regard it as a minor expense. People who have little choice but to drive, such as those working night shifts or living in areas with poor transport links, may feel they are being punished. Some businesses in the centre also worry that the charge will discourage shoppers and push them towards out-of-town shopping centres.

However, these concerns can be addressed through careful design of the scheme. Discounts for residents, exemptions for disabled drivers and improvements to bus services before the charge is introduced can make the system considerably fairer.

In conclusion, although congestion charges may be unfair to certain groups and could affect some businesses, they are an effective way to cut traffic and pollution. On balance, therefore, I believe the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

Band 8

318 words

Fully developed response with a clear, reasoned judgement · counter-arguments evaluated rather than listed · skilful paragraphing and cohesion · precise, sophisticated vocabulary (regressive, ring-fenced) · wide range of accurate structures.

Charging motorists to enter city centres at peak times has been adopted by a number of cities seeking to tackle congestion and pollution. Although the policy raises legitimate questions of fairness, I believe that, when well designed, its advantages clearly outweigh its disadvantages.

The rationale for such charges is that road space in a city centre is a scarce resource which, when provided free, is inevitably overused. By attaching a price to driving at the busiest times, a congestion charge encourages motorists to reconsider journeys that are not essential, to travel at quieter times or to switch to public transport. The result is faster, more reliable journeys for buses, deliveries and emergency services, whose efficiency is vital to the functioning of a city. The environmental gains are equally significant: reduced traffic means lower emissions and less noise in precisely the places where people are most concentrated. Moreover, the revenue generated can be ring-fenced for improving public transport, so that the alternatives to driving become steadily more attractive.

The main objection is that a flat fee is regressive. For a well-paid professional, the charge may be a trivial inconvenience, whereas for a low-paid worker who depends on a car, it can represent a substantial share of their daily earnings. Retailers in central districts also fear a loss of trade if shoppers choose to drive to suburban malls instead.

These concerns deserve serious attention, but they are arguments for refining the scheme rather than rejecting it. Exemptions for residents and disabled drivers, discounts for essential workers and investment in affordable public transport can all reduce the unequal impact, while a less congested, more pleasant centre may in fact attract more visitors on foot.

In conclusion, although congestion charges can bear more heavily on those with lower incomes, their capacity to reduce traffic, cut pollution and fund better transport makes them, on balance, a worthwhile policy whose benefits outweigh its costs.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Holidays in your own country

Topic: Tourism · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_advantages_10

Many people now choose to take their holidays in their own country rather than travelling abroad. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this?

Band 6

280 words

Addresses both advantages and disadvantages · relevant but general ideas with limited extension · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary with some repetition · comparative, word-form and agreement errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays a lot of people prefer to spend their holidays in their own country instead of going abroad. This trend has several advantages, but there are also some disadvantages.

One advantage of domestic holidays is that they are usually cheaper. People do not need to buy expensive flight tickets, and they do not have to change money or pay for a visa. As a result, families with a limited budget can travel more often. Another advantage is that it is more easy and comfortable. Travellers speak the same language as local people, they understand the culture and they know what kind of food they will eat, so they feel more relax. Also, when people travel inside their own country, they help the local economy, because the money they spend goes to local hotels, restaurants and shops.

However, there are also some disadvantages. The main one is that people miss the chance to learn about other cultures. When you travel abroad, you can see different traditions, try new food and meet people from other countries, and this can open your mind. In addition, the weather in some countries are not very good, so people who want sunshine and beaches may be disappointed if they stay at home. Finally, popular places in their own country can become very crowded during the holidays season because everyone goes to the same places.

In conclusion, spending holidays in your own country is cheaper, easier and good for local economy. On the other hand, people cannot experience new cultures and sometimes the weather and crowds are a problem. I think both types of holiday are useful, and people should choose depend on their budget and interests.

Band 7

295 words

Both sides clearly addressed and extended with relevant support · logical organisation with clear paragraph topics · good range of vocabulary (broaden their outlook, peak season) · mostly error-free, one unnatural phrase.

In recent years, a growing number of people have chosen to spend their holidays exploring their own country rather than travelling overseas. This choice offers a number of practical and economic benefits, although it also means missing out on some valuable experiences.

The most obvious advantage of holidaying at home is cost. Without international flights, visas or currency exchange fees, a domestic trip is generally far more affordable, which allows families to take holidays more frequently. It is also less stressful, since travellers do not have to deal with unfamiliar languages, long security queues or complicated travel documents. Furthermore, domestic tourism supports the national economy, as money spent on hotels, restaurants and attractions stays within the country and helps to sustain jobs in rural and coastal areas. There is an environmental benefit too: travelling by train or car over shorter distances usually produces far less carbon than flying abroad.

On the other hand, there are some disadvantages. Perhaps the most significant is that people lose the opportunity to experience different cultures at first hand. Travelling abroad exposes people to new languages, customs and ways of thinking, which can broaden their outlook and make them more tolerant. Domestic holidays may also offer less variety; a person from a small country might feel they have already seen most of what it has to offer. In addition, when large numbers of people holiday at home at the same time, popular destinations can become overcrowded and prices for accommodation may rise sharply during peak season.

In conclusion, holidaying in one's own country is cheaper, easier and better for both the national economy and the environment. However, it cannot fully replace the cultural enrichment which comes from visiting other countries, so an occasional trip abroad still has an important value.

Band 8

301 words

Sufficiently addresses both advantages and disadvantages with well-developed, relevant ideas · logical sequencing and well-managed paragraphs · wide, natural vocabulary (further afield, carbon footprint) · wide range of error-free structures.

Choosing to explore one's own country instead of heading overseas has become an increasingly popular way to take a holiday. This preference brings clear financial, practical and environmental benefits, although it can also limit the broader horizons that international travel provides.

Chief among the advantages is affordability. Domestic trips avoid the expense of long-haul flights and foreign currency, and they can often be arranged at short notice, making regular breaks accessible to households that could not stretch to an annual trip abroad. They are also considerably less demanding: there are no language barriers, visa applications or unfamiliar healthcare systems to navigate, which is particularly reassuring for older travellers and families with young children. From a national perspective, domestic tourism keeps spending within the country, sustaining small hotels, guesthouses and restaurants in regions that may have few other sources of income. Finally, shorter journeys, especially by rail, generally have a far smaller carbon footprint than international flights.

Yet something is undeniably lost. Travelling abroad confronts people with different languages, values and ways of life, and this exposure can challenge assumptions and foster a more open-minded outlook in a way that familiar surroundings rarely do. Domestic holidays may also lack novelty for those who have grown up visiting the same resorts, and residents of smaller countries in particular may find the range of landscapes and climates limited. A further, more practical drawback is congestion: when large numbers of people holiday at home during the same school breaks, popular beauty spots can become overcrowded and local infrastructure stretched.

In conclusion, holidaying in one's own country is economical, convenient and comparatively sustainable, and it provides welcome support for local economies. Its main limitation is that it offers fewer opportunities for cultural discovery, which is why many people may still value an occasional journey further afield.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Renewable energy on farmland

Topic: Environment · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_advantages_11

In some areas, large areas of farmland and countryside are being used for solar and wind energy projects. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

269 words

Clear judgement · relevant ideas on both sides but explanation is simple and general · mechanical linking (Firstly, Secondly, Also) · adequate vocabulary, some imprecise · agreement and word-form errors that do not block meaning.

In some places, big areas of farmland and countryside are now used for solar panels and wind turbines. Some people think this is a good idea, but others disagree. In my opinion, the advantages are more than the disadvantages.

The main advantage is that solar and wind energy are clean. They do not produce carbon dioxide like coal and oil, so they help to reduce global warming and air pollution. Because climate change is a very serious problem for the world, every country need to produce more green energy. Also, the sun and the wind will never finish, so this energy is sustainable for the future. Another advantage is for farmers. They can rent their land to energy companies and receive money every year, which is useful when the farming income is low.

On the other hand, there are some disadvantages. Firstly, when the land is covered with solar panels, it cannot be used for growing food. If many farms do this, the country may need to import more food from other countries. Secondly, many people think that wind turbines are ugly and they destroy the beauty of countryside. Tourists may not want to visit these areas anymore. Also, the building of these projects can damage the habitat of animals and birds, and some birds are killed by the turbines.

In conclusion, using farmland and countryside for solar and wind energy have some negative effects on food production and nature. However, I believe that the fight against climate change are more important, so the advantages outweigh the disadvantages. The government should choose the places careful to reduce the problems.

Band 7

307 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported, with realistic mitigation · clear paragraph focus and varied linking · good collocation (tackle climate change, visual impact) · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

In a number of regions, extensive areas of farmland and open countryside are being converted into solar farms and wind energy sites. While this raises concerns about food production and the landscape, I believe the advantages outweigh the disadvantages, provided that locations are chosen carefully.

The strongest argument in favour of these projects is the urgent need to reduce carbon emissions. Solar and wind power generate electricity without burning fossil fuels, so expanding them is one of the most effective ways for a country to tackle climate change and improve air quality. Large rural sites are often ideal for this purpose because they receive plenty of sunlight or strong winds and have space for installations that would be impossible in cities. Moreover, these projects can support rural economies. Farmers who lease part of their land to energy companies gain a stable income that does not depend on the weather or crop prices, which can

allow them to keep farming the rest of their land.

Nevertheless, there are genuine disadvantages. Covering productive farmland with solar panels reduces the amount of land available for growing food, which could make a country more dependent on imports. Many residents also object to the visual impact of large turbines and rows of panels on landscapes they value, and in some areas this may harm tourism. There are environmental costs as well, since construction can disturb wildlife habitats, and turbines can pose a risk to birds.

However, many of these problems can be reduced. Energy projects can be located on poorer-quality land, and some farms successfully combine solar panels with sheep grazing beneath them.

In conclusion, although using countryside for renewable energy has some impact on agriculture, scenery and wildlife, the need to cut emissions and the economic benefits for rural communities is more pressing. Therefore, I believe the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

Band 8 309 words

Clear, well-supported judgement · ideas fully extended and logically sequenced · drawbacks evaluated rather than dismissed · wide, precise vocabulary (decarbonise, finite resource, fragment habitats) · wide range of error-free structures.

As countries race to decarbonise their energy systems, farmland and open countryside are increasingly being given over to solar arrays and wind turbines. This has provoked fierce local opposition in some areas, yet I believe that, if sited thoughtfully, such projects deliver benefits that outweigh their costs.

The central argument for these developments is environmental necessity. Replacing coal and gas with renewable electricity is essential if the worst effects of climate change are to be avoided, and generating that electricity at scale requires space that dense urban areas simply cannot provide. Rural sites offer open exposure to sun and wind, relatively low land costs and room for installations large enough to supply thousands of homes. Such projects can also strengthen the rural economy: rental payments from energy companies give farmers a reliable income that cushions them against poor harvests and volatile food prices, while local communities may receive funds for shared facilities.

The objections, however, are not trivial. Agricultural land is a finite resource, and converting large areas of fertile fields to energy generation could undermine a country's capacity to feed itself. Landscapes that have been valued for generations may be transformed by industrial-scale structures, affecting both residents' attachment to their surroundings and the tourism on which some rural areas depend. Poorly planned schemes can also fragment habitats and endanger bird populations.

Crucially, though, most of these drawbacks depend on where and how projects are built rather than on renewable energy itself. Prioritising lower-grade farmland, combining solar panels with grazing, and avoiding sensitive habitats and migration routes can substantially reduce the conflict between energy, food and nature.

In conclusion, the loss of some farmland and scenic value is a genuine cost, but it must be weighed against the far greater threat posed by climate change. With careful planning, the advantages of rural renewable energy projects clearly outweigh the disadvantages.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Adult children living at home

Topic: Family · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_12

Increasingly, young adults are continuing to live with their parents after they have finished their education. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this for both the young adults and their parents?

Band 6

274 words

Covers both groups · relevant ideas but explanation is brief and general · simple, mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary with some awkward collocation · agreement and word-form errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, many young people continue to live with their parents after they finish their studies. This situation has some advantages and disadvantages for both the young adults and their parents.

For young adults, the biggest advantage is money. Rent is very expensive in most cities, so if they live at home they can save a big part of their salary. Later they can use this money to buy their own house or car. Also, they do not have to do all the housework alone, because the mother often cook and clean for the family. For parents, it can also be good. They can spend more time with their children and they do not feel lonely, especially if they are old. Moreover, the children can help them with shopping or with technology, for example using a smartphone.

However, there are also some disadvantages. Young adults who stay at home may not become independent. They do not learn how to pay bills, manage their own money or solve problems by themselves. They also have less privacy, and sometimes they cannot invite friends to the house. For the parents, the problem is that they have to pay more for food and electricity, and they cannot enjoy their free time after retirement. In addition, there can be many arguments, because parents and children have different lifestyle and opinions.

In conclusion, living together helps young adults to save money and gives the parents company. But it can also stop young people from becoming independent and cause conflicts in the family. I think it is fine for a short time, but young people should move out when they are ready.

Band 7

294 words

Addresses both sides for both groups · ideas extended with relevant examples, some generalisation · clear central topic in each paragraph · good collocation (pay off loans, life skills) · mostly error-free, one article slip.

It is increasingly common for young people to remain in the family home after completing their education, rather than moving into a place of their own. This arrangement has both benefits and drawbacks, not only for the young adults themselves but also for their parents.

For young adults, the most significant advantage is financial. With rents and property prices rising in many cities, living with parents allows them to save money for a deposit on a home or to pay off student loans more quickly. It can also provide emotional support during a stressful period, such as the search for a first job. Parents, too, can benefit. Many enjoy the continued companionship of their children, and as they grow older, having an adult son or daughter at home means there is someone to help with household tasks, shopping or unexpected health problems.

On the other hand, the arrangement has clear disadvantages. Young people who stay at home for too long may delay developing important life skills, such as budgeting, cooking and managing a household, and they may become overly dependent on their parents. A lack of privacy and personal space can also make it harder for them to build independent social lives. For parents, supporting an adult child can put pressure on their finances just when they are planning for retirement. Moreover, disagreements over household rules, chores or lifestyle are common when two adult generations share the same space, and these tensions can damage family relationships.

In conclusion, living together can offer young adults financial security and give parents company and practical help. However, it may also slow the development of independence and create financial and emotional strains on both sides. Ideally, such arrangement should be temporary and based on clear agreements about responsibilities.

Band 8

308 words

Fully addresses all parts for both generations · well-developed, relevant ideas in logical sequence · skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (safety net, self-reliance, co-residence) · wide range of error-free structures.

In many societies, the age at which young people leave the family home is steadily rising, with growing numbers remaining with their parents well after they have completed their education. This trend carries a mixture of advantages and disadvantages for both generations, and its overall impact depends heavily on how the arrangement is managed.

For young adults, the benefits are largely economic. At a time when housing costs absorb an ever-larger proportion of starting salaries, living at home enables graduates to build savings, repay debts and accept lower-paid but career-enhancing positions that they could not otherwise afford. The family home can also serve as a safety net during an uncertain transition into working life. Parents may gain as well: the presence of an adult child can provide companionship, particularly for those who live alone, and practical assistance with everything from home repairs to navigating online services. In some cultures, multigenerational living is valued in its own right as a way of preserving close family ties.

The disadvantages, however, are equally real. Remaining under the parental roof can postpone the development of self-reliance, since many of the responsibilities that force young people to mature, such as paying rent and running a household, are absorbed by others. Limited privacy may also constrain their social lives. For parents, the arrangement can mean extra expense and a delayed opportunity to enjoy the freedom they may have anticipated once their children had grown up. Perhaps most significantly, adults with different routines and expectations sharing a home can generate friction, and unresolved tensions may strain relationships that would otherwise be harmonious.

In conclusion, continued co-residence offers young adults financial breathing space and parents companionship and support, but it risks delaying independence and generating conflict. The arrangement tends to work best when it is treated as a temporary stage, with clear expectations on both sides.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Health tracking technology

Topic: Health · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_13

Many people now use smartwatches and mobile phone apps to monitor their health and fitness. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

266 words

Clear judgement · relevant points on both sides with simple examples, limited development · mechanical linking (Firstly, Secondly, Finally) · adequate vocabulary · several word-form, agreement and countability errors that do not block meaning.

These days, a lot of people use smartwatches and apps on their mobile phones to check their health and fitness. I believe that this technology has more advantages than disadvantages.

The main advantage is that these devices motivate people to be more active. For example, a smartwatch can count how many steps you walk every day and remind you to move if you sit for a long time. When people see their progress on the screen, they feel happy and they want to do more exercise. Also, many apps help people to control what they eat and how many calories they take. Another advantage is that some smartwatches can check the heart rate and the sleep. If there is something unusual, the user can visit a doctor early before the problem become serious.

On the other hand, there are some disadvantages. Firstly, the information from these devices is not always correct, so people may worry about nothing or they may ignore a real problem. Secondly, some people become too obsess with the numbers. They check their phone all the time and feel stressed if they do not reach their target. Finally, these apps collect a lot of personal information about the users, and the companies can sell this informations to other companies without permission.

In conclusion, smartwatches and health apps have some problems, such as privacy and wrong information. However, they encourage people to live more healthy lifestyle and they can help to find health problems early. Therefore, I think the advantages outweigh the disadvantages, but people should use them careful and not trust them completely.

Band 7

299 words

Clear position throughout · both sides extended, with drawbacks conceded then outweighed · logical progression and clear paragraph topics · good collocation (falsely reassured, long-term illnesses) · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

Wearable devices and smartphone applications that track steps, heart rate, sleep and diet have become part of everyday life for millions of people. Although these tools have certain drawbacks, I believe their advantages are greater.

Admittedly, there are some concerns. The data produced by consumer devices is not always accurate, and users may be falsely reassured or unnecessarily alarmed by the figures they see. Some people also become fixated on hitting daily targets, which can turn exercise from an enjoyable activity into a source of anxiety. Privacy is another issue, since these apps gather highly personal information about users' bodies and habits, and it is not always clear how technology companies store or share it.

Nevertheless, the benefits are more significant. The most important is that health tracking encourages people to take responsibility for their own wellbeing. Simple features, such as a

daily step count or a reminder to stand up after an hour of sitting, can gradually change habits, and seeing progress over time is a powerful motivation to keep going. In addition, some devices can warn users about irregular heartbeats or poor sleep patterns, prompting them to seek medical advice before a condition becomes more serious. For people with long-term illnesses such as diabetes, apps can make it much easier to record information and share it with doctors, leading to better management of the condition.

Moreover, most of the disadvantages depend on how the technology is used. If people treat the data as a general guide rather than a medical diagnosis, and if governments introduces clear rules on data protection, the risks can be greatly reduced.

In conclusion, although health-monitoring technology raises questions about accuracy, obsession and privacy, its ability to motivate healthier lifestyles and detect potential problems early means that the advantages clearly outweigh the disadvantages.

Band 8

305 words

Clear, well-justified judgement · ideas extended with precise, relevant support · logical sequencing and skilful cohesion · wide, natural vocabulary (preoccupation, negate, third parties) · wide range of error-free structures.

The use of smartwatches and mobile applications to record everything from daily steps to sleep quality and heart rhythm has become commonplace. While this constant self-monitoring has its downsides, I would argue that, for most users, the advantages outweigh them.

The chief benefit is behavioural. Many people know in principle that they should move more, sleep better and eat more sensibly, but struggle to translate that knowledge into action. By turning vague intentions into concrete, measurable goals and providing immediate feedback, fitness trackers make healthy behaviour visible and rewarding, and features such as streaks or friendly competitions can sustain motivation over months. Beyond motivation, some devices can flag potentially significant irregularities, such as an unusually high resting heart rate, prompting users to consult a doctor sooner than they otherwise would. For people managing chronic conditions, digital records can also give doctors a far richer picture than occasional clinic visits allow.

There are, however, legitimate reservations. Consumer devices are not medical instruments, and inaccurate readings can either create needless anxiety or offer false reassurance. For some individuals, the constant stream of data fosters an unhealthy preoccupation with numbers, turning exercise and even sleep into sources of pressure. Most troubling, perhaps, is the question of privacy: health data is extraordinarily sensitive, and users often have little understanding of how it may be stored, analysed or shared with third parties such as advertisers or insurers.

These concerns warrant stronger regulation and greater user awareness, but they do not negate the value of the technology. Treated as a guide rather than a diagnosis, and protected by robust data laws, health trackers can play a genuinely positive role.

In conclusion, despite issues of accuracy, obsession and data security, the capacity of smartwatches and apps to encourage healthier habits and support earlier medical attention means that their advantages outweigh their disadvantages.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Security cameras in public places

Topic: Crime · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_advantages_14

Many cities have installed large numbers of security cameras in public places in order to reduce crime. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

268 words

Clear position and judgement · relevant ideas on both sides but mostly listed rather than developed · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · comparative, agreement and passive errors that do not block meaning.

In many cities around the world, the government has put a lot of security cameras in public places like streets, stations and shopping centres. The aim is to reduce crime. In my opinion, this has more advantages than disadvantages.

The first advantage is that cameras can stop people from committing crimes. If a thief knows that a camera is watching him, he will probably not steal anything because he is afraid to be caught. So the streets become safer. Secondly, when a crime happens, the police can watch the video and find the criminal more quickly. The recordings can also be used as evidence in court. Moreover, people feel more safe when they walk at night in areas with cameras, especially women and old people.

However, there are also some disadvantages. The most important one is privacy. Many people do not like that they are watched all the time when they are in public. They feel like the government is controlling them. Also, the information from cameras can be used in a wrong way, for example if someone share the videos on the internet. Another disadvantage is the cost. Installing and checking thousands of cameras is very expensive, and some people think that the money should spent on more police officers. In addition, criminals can simply move to other areas where there is not cameras.

In conclusion, security cameras have some problems such as privacy and cost. But I believe they help to reduce crime and make people feel safe, so the advantages outweigh the disadvantages. However, the government must make rules about how the videos are used.

Band 7

306 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported, counter-arguments acknowledged · logical organisation · good collocation (act as a deterrent, value for money) · frequent error-free sentences, one agreement slip.

In an effort to fight crime, many cities have installed extensive networks of surveillance cameras in streets, transport hubs and other public spaces. While this raises concerns about privacy and cost, I believe the advantages are greater.

The most important benefit of CCTV is its role in solving crimes. When an offence takes place in a monitored area, footage can help the police to identify suspects, trace their movements and provide strong evidence in court. This increases the chance that offenders are caught and punished, which in turn may discourage others. Cameras can also act as a deterrent in themselves; people planning to commit theft or vandalism are likely to think twice if they know they are being recorded. In addition, surveillance can help authorities respond quickly to emergencies, such as accidents or fights in crowded places, and it gives many members of the public a greater sense of security, particularly at night.

On the other hand, there are some drawbacks. The most frequently mentioned is the loss of privacy, as ordinary citizens are recorded constantly while going about their daily lives. There is a risk that footage could be misused, for example to monitor peaceful protesters or be leaked online. Critics also argue that cameras do not really reduce crime but simply move it to areas without surveillance. Finally, installing and monitoring thousands of cameras requires a considerable amount of public money that could be spent on other services.

Despite these concerns, I would argue that the problems can be managed through clear laws on who can access footage and how long it is kept.

In conclusion, although security cameras raise legitimate questions about privacy and value for money, their contribution to detecting and preventing crime makes them a worthwhile tool. Therefore, the advantages outweighs the disadvantages, as long as their use is properly regulated.

Band 8

315 words

Sufficiently addresses both sides with a clear, qualified judgement · ideas logically sequenced and fully extended · cohesion managed skilfully · wide, precise vocabulary (corroborate, displaced, oversight) · wide range of error-free structures.

Surveillance cameras have become a familiar feature of streets, stations and squares in many cities, justified primarily as a means of reducing crime. Although their spread raises serious questions about privacy and civil liberties, I believe that, under proper regulation, their advantages outweigh their disadvantages.

The strongest argument for public CCTV lies in its investigative value. Footage can establish a clear sequence of events, identify suspects and corroborate or challenge witness statements, often transforming cases that would otherwise remain unsolved. This is particularly important for crimes such as street robbery, where victims may have only a fleeting glimpse of the offender. Cameras may also exert a deterrent effect, especially in car parks and transport hubs, where opportunistic offences are common. Beyond crime, surveillance systems allow authorities to manage crowds at large events, locate missing people and coordinate rapid responses to accidents.

The disadvantages, nonetheless, deserve careful consideration. Blanket surveillance changes the nature of public space: people who know they are constantly observed may feel less free to gather, protest or simply behave spontaneously. The potential for misuse is considerable, whether through unauthorised access, the leaking of footage or, more worryingly, the combination of cameras with facial recognition to track individuals without their knowledge. Critics also point out that cameras are less effective against impulsive crime than their supporters claim, and that some offending is merely displaced to unmonitored streets, which raises doubts about whether the substantial public expenditure is justified.

These risks, however, point to the need for firm safeguards rather than the removal of cameras altogether. Strict limits on data retention, independent oversight and transparent rules on facial recognition can preserve most of the benefits while protecting civil liberties.

In conclusion, security cameras are not a complete solution to crime, and their misuse could threaten personal freedom. Nevertheless, their value in solving and deterring offences means that, carefully regulated, their advantages outweigh their disadvantages.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Recruiting skilled foreign workers

Topic: Population / Employment · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_advantages_15

Some countries encourage skilled workers from abroad to settle there in order to fill shortages in the labour market. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages for the receiving country?

Band 6

270 words

Clear judgement for the receiving country · relevant ideas but support is general and somewhat repetitive · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors that do not impede meaning.

Nowadays, some countries invite skilled workers from other countries to come and live there because they do not have enough workers in some jobs. In my opinion, this policy has more advantages than disadvantages for the receiving country.

The first and most important advantage is that it solve the problem of labour shortages. For example, many countries do not have enough doctors, nurses or engineers, and training new people takes many years. When skilled workers come from abroad, hospitals and companies can continue to work well. Also, these workers pay taxes, which help the government to pay for public services like schools and pensions. This is very important in countries where the population is getting older and there is fewer young workers. In addition, people from different countries bring new ideas and cultures, which can make the society more interesting.

However, there are also some disadvantages. Some local workers may feel that the newcomers are taking their jobs or that they reduce the salaries. This can cause tension between local people and the new arrivals. Moreover, the new workers need houses, schools for their children and health services, so there can be more pressure on these services. Another problem is that the government may not train its own citizens because it is easier to bring workers from other country.

In conclusion, encouraging skilled workers from abroad can cause some problems such as tension and pressure on public services. However, I think the benefits for the economy and important services like health care is bigger. So the advantages outweigh the disadvantages, but the government should also invest in training local people.

Band 7

302 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported, with sensible mitigation · clear topic in each paragraph · good range of vocabulary (ageing populations, domestic workforce) · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

Faced with shortages in key professions, a number of countries actively encourage qualified workers from overseas to settle permanently. Although this approach can create some social and economic challenges, I believe it brings greater benefits to the receiving country.

The most direct advantage is that skilled migrants fill gaps that cannot be filled quickly from within the domestic workforce. Training a doctor or an engineer can take many years, whereas recruiting experienced professionals from abroad allows hospitals, construction projects and technology firms to operate effectively in the meantime. This helps to maintain the quality of public services and prevents businesses from losing opportunities because they lack staff. Furthermore, many developed countries have ageing populations, and working-age migrants

contribute taxes that help fund pensions and healthcare for older citizens. Skilled newcomers can also bring fresh ideas and international connections, which may stimulate innovation.

However, there are some potential drawbacks. If large numbers of people arrive in a short period, they can put pressure on housing, schools and transport, particularly in major cities where most newcomers tend to settle. There may also be concerns among local workers that competition from abroad will reduce wages or limit their own job opportunities, which can lead to social tension if it is not managed carefully. In addition, relying on foreign recruitment may reduce the incentive for governments and employers to invest in training their own citizens.

These disadvantages, though, can be managed through sensible planning. Governments can match recruitment to genuine shortages, invest in infrastructure where newcomers settle and continue funding domestic training programmes at the same time.

In conclusion, while attracting skilled workers from abroad can strain public services and cause some local resentment, its contribution to filling vital roles and supporting an ageing population make it highly beneficial. On balance, the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

Band 8

322 words

Fully addresses the question from the receiving country's perspective with a clear judgement · ideas well developed and logically sequenced · wide, precise vocabulary (skills gaps, underemployed) · wide range of error-free structures.

Many economies now rely on targeted immigration schemes to attract qualified professionals from abroad, particularly in sectors such as healthcare, engineering and technology. Although this strategy is not without complications, I would argue that, for the receiving country, its advantages clearly outweigh its disadvantages.

The most compelling benefit is the speed with which skills gaps can be closed. Domestic training pipelines take years to respond to changes in demand, and in the meantime shortages of nurses or software engineers can lengthen waiting lists, delay infrastructure projects and deter investment. Recruiting professionals who are already qualified allows these needs to be met almost immediately, and without the host country bearing the cost of their education. Skilled migrants also tend to be of working age and in well-paid employment, so they make a substantial contribution to public finances, which is increasingly valuable in societies where a shrinking workforce must support a growing number of retirees. Moreover, diverse teams often bring new perspectives, languages and international networks that strengthen innovation and trade.

The disadvantages are nonetheless significant. Rapid population growth in particular regions can outpace the supply of housing and school places, and if this pressure coincides with stagnant wages in some sectors, it can fuel resentment and social division. Employers may also come to regard overseas recruitment as a cheaper alternative to developing local talent, leaving domestic workers without opportunities to acquire in-demand skills. Finally, successful integration requires sustained investment in language support and the recognition of foreign qualifications, without which highly trained migrants may end up underemployed.

Crucially, these problems stem mainly from poor planning rather than from skilled migration itself, and they can be addressed through coordinated housing policy, parallel investment in domestic training and effective integration programmes.

In conclusion, attracting skilled workers from abroad carries social and practical challenges, but its contribution to essential services, public finances and economic dynamism means that its

advantages outweigh its disadvantages for the receiving country.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Government spending on space research

Topic: Science · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_16

Some governments are investing large sums of money in space research programmes. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this?

Band 6

269 words

Addresses both advantages and disadvantages · relevant ideas with simple examples, some underdeveloped · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement, article and verb-pattern errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, some governments spend a huge amount of money on space research programmes. There are some advantages and disadvantages of this, which I will explain in this essay.

The first advantage is that space research brings new technology which is useful in our daily life. For example, satellites help us with weather forecast, mobile phones and GPS navigation. Many inventions that was first made for astronauts are now used in hospitals and homes. Secondly, space programmes can make a country proud and they encourage young people to study science and engineering. When children see astronauts on television, they may dream to become scientists in the future. Also, space research help us to understand more about the universe and about our own planet, such as climate change.

On the other hand, the main disadvantage is the cost. Space programmes are extremely expensive, and many people think that this money should be spent on more urgent problems on earth. For instance, in many countries there are still people who do not have enough food, clean water or good hospitals. It seems unfair to spend billions on sending rockets to the space while these people are suffering. Moreover, space missions can be dangerous, and some astronauts have died in accidents. Another problem is that rockets and old satellites create pollution and rubbish in space.

In conclusion, investing in space research has benefits such as new technology and scientific knowledge, but it is also very expensive and some people believe the money should use for poor people. In my opinion, governments should continue space research but spend reasonable amount of money on it.

Band 7

275 words

Both sides clearly addressed with extended, relevant support · logical organisation and clear paragraph topics · good range of vocabulary (debris, pursue careers) · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

A number of governments are committing large budgets to space exploration and research. While these programmes can deliver significant scientific and economic benefits, they are also criticised for their high cost at a time when many problems on Earth remain unsolved.

One of the main advantages of space research is the technology it produces. Satellites, which were developed through space programmes, now support weather forecasting, global communications and navigation systems that people rely on every day. In addition, many innovations originally designed for space missions, such as improved materials and medical equipment, have later found uses in everyday life. Space research also expands scientific knowledge, helping us to understand the origins of the universe and to monitor changes in Earth's climate from above. Furthermore, ambitious space projects can inspire young people to

pursue careers in science and engineering, which benefits the wider economy in the long term.

On the other hand, the most common criticism is the enormous expense involved. Critics argue that the money spent on launching rockets could instead be used to improve healthcare, education or housing, or to reduce poverty, which would have a more immediate impact on people's lives. There are also environmental concerns, since rocket launches produce emissions and the growing amount of debris orbiting the planet could damage working satellites. Finally, space missions involve considerable risks, and failures can waste vast sums of money in a matter of seconds.

In conclusion, government investment in space research brings valuable technological progress, scientific understanding and inspiration for future generations. However, its high cost and environmental impact means that governments need to balance this spending carefully against more urgent needs on Earth.

Band 8

299 words

Sufficiently addresses advantages and disadvantages with well-developed, relevant ideas · logical sequencing and skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (underpin, indispensable, proportionate) · wide range of error-free structures.

Space research has long been one of the most expensive and ambitious undertakings a government can pursue, and several countries are now expanding their programmes considerably. The merits of such investment are substantial, but so too are the objections, particularly regarding cost and priorities.

The case in favour rests first on the practical returns. Much of modern life depends on infrastructure that emerged from space programmes: satellites underpin weather forecasting, telecommunications, navigation and disaster monitoring, while technologies developed for spaceflight have been adapted for use in medicine and materials science. Space-based observation is also indispensable for understanding our own planet, providing long-term data on ice cover, sea levels and deforestation that would be impossible to gather from the ground. Beyond these tangible benefits, space exploration pushes the boundaries of human knowledge and, perhaps just as importantly, captures the public imagination, encouraging young people to pursue careers in science and engineering.

Against this, critics raise a powerful moral argument. When public resources are finite, allocating vast sums to exploring distant planets can appear difficult to justify while citizens lack adequate healthcare, housing or education. The benefits of space research are often long-term and uncertain, whereas the needs of the poor are immediate and pressing. There are environmental and practical concerns as well: each launch consumes enormous quantities of fuel, and the accumulation of debris in orbit increasingly threatens the satellites on which everyday services depend. Moreover, national prestige can sometimes drive spending more than genuine scientific value.

In conclusion, government investment in space research yields important technologies, scientific insight and inspiration, yet it competes with urgent social needs and carries environmental risks. The challenge for policymakers is therefore not whether to fund space programmes at all, but how to ensure that such spending remains proportionate and delivers clear public benefit.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Organised activities versus free play

Topic: Children · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_advantages_17

Many children now spend much of their free time in organised activities, such as sports clubs and music lessons, rather than playing freely. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

270 words

Clear judgement · relevant ideas on both sides with brief examples, limited extension · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · agreement, pronoun and plural errors that do not block meaning.

Today, many children spend most of their free time in organised activities like football clubs, swimming or piano lessons, instead of playing freely with their friends. I think this has more advantages than disadvantages.

The first advantage is that children can learn useful skills. For example, in a music lesson they learn to play an instrument, and in a sports club they learn the rules of a game and how to work in a team. These skills can be helpful for their future and maybe even for their career. Secondly, organised activities are safe, because there is always a teacher or a coach who look after the children. Parents who work all day do not need to worry about where their children is. Also, these activities teach children discipline, because they must come on time and practise regularly.

On the other hand, there are some disadvantages. Children need time to relax and play, but if they have too many activities, they can feel tired and stressed. When children play freely, they use their imagination and create their own games, which is important for their development. In organised activities, the adults decide everything, so children have less chance to be creative. In addition, some activities are expensive, so poor families cannot pay for it.

In conclusion, organised activities have both good and bad sides. They can make children tired and less creative, but they also teach them important skills, discipline and keep them safe. In my opinion, the advantages outweigh the disadvantages, but parents should not choose too many activity for their children and should leave some time for free play.

Band 7

290 words

Clear position throughout · both sides extended with relevant support, some generalisation · clear central topic in each paragraph · good collocation (perseverance, heavy burden) · mostly accurate, two agreement slips.

Nowadays, many children's free time is filled with structured activities such as sports training, music lessons and language classes, leaving little opportunity for unstructured play. Although these activities offer real benefits, I believe that when they replace free play almost entirely, the disadvantages are greater.

There is no doubt that organised activities can be valuable. They allow children to develop specific talents, whether in football, swimming or playing the violin, under the guidance of qualified instructors. Regular practice also teaches perseverance and time management, and team sports in particular help children learn to cooperate and cope with both winning and losing. For working parents, clubs and lessons provide a safe and supervised environment, which is reassuring when children cannot be left alone at home.

However, free play offers benefits that structured activities cannot provide. When children invent their own games, they have to negotiate rules, solve disagreements and use their imagination without an adult telling them what to do. These experiences develop creativity, independence and social skills that are important throughout life. If every afternoon is scheduled, children lose these opportunities and may become dependent on adults to organise their entertainment. Moreover, a busy timetable of activities can cause stress and tiredness, especially when combined with homework, and some children feel pressured to perform well rather than simply enjoying themselves. There is also a financial aspect, as fees for lessons and equipment can be a heavy burden for many families.

In conclusion, organised activities help children to develop skills and discipline in a safe setting. Nevertheless, as free play is essential for creativity, independence and wellbeing, I believe the drawbacks of filling children's free time with structured activities outweighs the advantages, and a better balance between the two are needed.

Band 8

298 words

Clear, well-reasoned judgement · ideas fully extended with insightful support · logical sequencing and skilful cohesion · wide, natural vocabulary (left to their own devices, back-to-back commitments) · wide range of error-free structures.

In many families, children's leisure time is now carefully organised around sports clubs, music lessons and tutoring sessions, with unstructured play increasingly squeezed out. While organised activities undoubtedly have value, I would argue that when they come to dominate childhood, their disadvantages outweigh their advantages.

The benefits of structured activities are clear. Expert coaching allows children to acquire skills, from swimming to playing an instrument, that they would be unlikely to master alone, and the discipline of regular practice teaches persistence and the satisfaction of gradual improvement. Team sports and ensembles also foster cooperation and a sense of belonging, while giving children the experience of both success and disappointment in a supportive setting. For parents with demanding jobs, supervised activities offer the additional reassurance that their children are safe and productively occupied.

Free play, however, contributes to development in ways that adult-led activities cannot replicate. When children are left to their own devices, they must invent games, agree on rules and resolve conflicts among themselves, exercising creativity, negotiation and problem-solving in a genuinely independent way. Unstructured time also allows them to explore their own interests rather than those chosen for them, and simply to rest. A childhood filled with back-to-back commitments risks producing young people who are accomplished but anxious, accustomed to constant evaluation and uncomfortable with boredom, which is itself an important stimulus for imagination. The cost of multiple activities can also place considerable strain on family budgets and widen the gap between children from wealthier and poorer households.

In conclusion, organised activities provide valuable skills, discipline and safety, but they cannot substitute for the independence and creativity that free play nurtures. When structured activities largely replace unsupervised play, I believe the disadvantages outweigh the advantages, and families should deliberately protect time for children simply to play.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Private companies running public services

Topic: Public services · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_18

In some countries, public services such as water supply, electricity and railways are run by private companies rather than by the government. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

268 words

Clear judgement · relevant ideas on both sides but support is general · paragraphing present, linking mechanical · adequate vocabulary · article, agreement and word-form errors that do not block meaning.

In some countries, important public services like water, electricity and trains are run by private companies and not by the government. There are some advantages of this system, but I believe the disadvantages are more.

On the one hand, private companies can be more efficient than government. They want to make profit, so they try to reduce waste and use their money carefully. Also, because of competition, companies must give a good service or customers will choose another company. For example, if there are different electricity companies, people can change to the one which is cheaper. In addition, private companies often invest in new technology, for example new trains, which can make the service better.

On the other hand, there are many disadvantages. The most important is that private companies care about profit more than people. They may increase the prices, and poor families will find it difficult to pay their bills for water and electricity, which is basic needs. Moreover, companies may not want to provide service in places where they cannot make money, such as small villages in the countryside. Another problem is that there is often no real competition, especially for water and railways, because only one company control the service in each area. So customers have no choice and must accept high prices and bad service.

In conclusion, private companies can bring efficiency and new technology to public services. However, I think these services are too important to be run only for profit. For this reason, the disadvantages outweigh the advantages, and the government should keep controlling of important services like water and electricity.

Band 7

294 words

Clear position throughout · opposing view presented then challenged with extended support · logical progression · good range of vocabulary (natural monopolies, underinvestment) · frequent error-free sentences, one agreement slip.

In a number of countries, essential services such as water, electricity and rail transport have been transferred from state control to private companies. Although privatisation can bring certain benefits, I believe that, for services of this kind, the disadvantages are more significant.

Supporters of privatisation argue that private firms are more efficient than state organisations. Because they need to make a profit, companies have a strong incentive to cut unnecessary costs, reduce bureaucracy and modernise their operations. Where there is genuine competition, as in some electricity markets, customers can switch providers, which encourages companies to keep prices competitive and improve customer service. Privatisation can also relieve governments of the huge cost of maintaining infrastructure, allowing public money to be spent elsewhere.

However, these advantages are often limited in practice. Water supply and railways are natural monopolies: it is not practical to build competing pipelines or rail lines, so customers in a particular area usually have only one provider. Without real competition, a private company may raise prices while failing to invest in maintenance, since its main responsibility is to its shareholders. Moreover, profit-driven companies may reduce services that are unprofitable, such as rural train routes, even though these are vital for the communities that depend on them. Because water and electricity are basic necessities, sharp price rises can push low-income households into serious hardship, and people cannot simply choose to stop using them.

For these reasons, even where private companies are involved, strong government regulation is essential to protect the public interest.

In conclusion, private ownership may improve efficiency in some cases, but for essential services that operate as monopolies and serve basic needs, the risks of higher prices, underinvestment and reduced access are too great. Therefore, I believe the disadvantages outweighs the advantages.

Band 8

318 words

Fully addresses the question with a clear, well-argued judgement · counter-argument evaluated rather than listed · logical sequencing and cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (accountability, defer maintenance) · wide range of error-free structures.

The transfer of utilities and railways from state ownership to private operators has been one of the most contested economic policies of recent decades. While private management can bring genuine improvements in efficiency, I would argue that, for services on which every citizen depends, the disadvantages ultimately prevail.

The principal argument for privatisation is that the discipline of the market drives better performance. State-run organisations are sometimes criticised for overstaffing, slow decision-making and political interference, whereas private firms, answerable to shareholders, have a clear incentive to control costs and innovate. Private capital can also fund investment in new trains, power stations or treatment plants without adding to public debt, and in sectors where competition is feasible, such as electricity retail, consumers may benefit from lower prices and more responsive service.

The weakness of this argument is that many essential services do not lend themselves to meaningful competition. A household cannot choose between rival water networks, and a commuter cannot select an alternative railway line; in such cases privatisation simply replaces a public monopoly with a private one. Once the pressure of competition is absent, the profit motive may encourage operators to raise charges, pay generous dividends and defer costly maintenance, leaving the public to deal with the consequences, from leaking pipes to unreliable trains. Accountability is also weakened: citizens can vote out a government that mismanages public services, but they have far less influence over a private company. Furthermore, because these services are necessities rather than optional purchases, price rises fall disproportionately on the poorest households.

Strict regulation can moderate some of these problems, but regulators often struggle to match the expertise and resources of the companies they oversee.

In conclusion, although private operators may deliver efficiency gains and fresh investment, the monopoly nature of many essential services, weaker accountability and the risk to vulnerable households mean that, in my view, the disadvantages of privatisation outweigh its advantages.

☐ Approved	☐ Needs changes	Notes:
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Online news sources

Topic: Media · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_advantages_19

Many people now get their news mainly from online sources rather than from newspapers or television. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this?

Band 6

258 words

Addresses both sides · relevant ideas with some simple examples, development limited · mechanical linking (Also, In addition, Moreover) · adequate vocabulary, some imprecise choices · agreement and countability errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, most people get their news from the internet instead of reading newspapers or watching television. This change has both advantages and disadvantages.

The main advantage of online news is that it is fast. When something important happens in the world, people can read about it on their phone in a few minutes, but newspapers have to wait until the next day. Another advantage is that most online news is free, so people do not need to buy a newspaper every day. Also, people can choose the topics they are interested in, for example sport, technology or business, and they can read news from many different countries. In addition, readers can write comments and share their opinion with other people.

However, online news also has some disadvantages. The biggest problem is fake news. Anyone can write something on the internet or on social media, and many people believe it without checking. This can cause confusion and even danger, for example when false information about health spreads quickly. Moreover, many websites use shocking titles to attract more clicks, so the news is not always serious or accurate. Another disadvantage is that social media shows people only the news which they already agree with, so they do not see other opinions.

In conclusion, getting news online is quick, cheap and convenient, and people have more choice than before. However, there is a big risk of false information and one-sided news. I think people should read news from reliable websites and always check the facts before they believe or share something.

Band 7

294 words

Both sides clearly presented and extended with relevant support · clear central topic in each paragraph · range of cohesive devices · good collocation (breaking stories, go viral) · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

Over the last two decades, the internet has overtaken newspapers and television as the main source of news for many people. This shift has made information more accessible than ever before, but it has also created new problems regarding reliability and balance.

One clear advantage of online news is its speed. Breaking stories are reported within minutes and constantly updated, whereas printed newspapers can only report events the following day. Online news is also highly convenient and usually free, since readers can access it on their phones wherever they are. Another benefit is variety: people can compare coverage from many different outlets, including international sources, and focus on topics that interest them. Furthermore, the internet gives ordinary people a voice, as eyewitnesses can share photos and videos of events as they happen, sometimes before professional journalists arrive.

On the other hand, the move online has several drawbacks. The most serious is the spread of misinformation. Unlike established newspapers and broadcasters, which employ editors to check facts, many websites and social media accounts publish claims without any verification, and false stories can go viral before they are corrected. In addition, because many online outlets depend on advertising revenue, they are tempted to use sensational headlines to attract clicks, which can lower the quality of journalism. Algorithms on social media also tend to show users content that matches their existing views, so people may be exposed to only one side of an issue, which can increase division in society.

In conclusion, online news offers speed, convenience and a wide range of perspectives, but it also makes it harder to separate reliable reporting from rumours and can reinforce people's existing beliefs. For this reason, readers need to develop the skills to evaluate the sources they relies on.

Band 8

319 words

Sufficiently addresses both advantages and disadvantages with well-developed ideas · logical sequencing and skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (democratised, echo chambers, insidiously) · wide range of error-free structures.

The way people consume news has been transformed in a single generation, with websites, apps and social media now replacing the morning paper and the evening bulletin for a large share of the population. This transition has democratised access to information, yet it has also weakened some of the safeguards that traditional media provided.

The advantages are considerable. Online platforms deliver news almost instantaneously, allowing readers to follow developing stories in real time rather than waiting for the next edition or broadcast. Much of this content is free and available on a device most people carry at all times, which has made current affairs accessible to groups who might never have bought a newspaper. The sheer breadth of sources is also valuable: a reader can compare how a single event is covered by outlets in different countries, consult specialist analysis on niche subjects and even see footage captured by eyewitnesses on the ground. In this sense, the internet has diversified the range of voices that shape public debate.

However, the same openness brings serious drawbacks. Because anyone can publish, the traditional filters of editorial oversight and fact-checking are frequently absent, and misleading or entirely fabricated stories can circulate widely before they are challenged. The economic model of much online journalism compounds the problem: revenue depends on clicks, which rewards sensationalism over careful reporting. Perhaps most insidiously, the algorithms that curate news feeds tend to prioritise content that confirms users' existing views, gradually enclosing them in so-called echo chambers and contributing to a more polarised society. The shift has also undermined the finances of many local newspapers, leaving some communities with little independent coverage of local affairs.

In conclusion, online news offers unprecedented speed, accessibility and diversity, but these gains are accompanied by a decline in reliability and a tendency towards polarisation. Its value therefore depends heavily on readers' willingness to seek out trustworthy sources and a range of perspectives.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

The shift to cashless payments

Topic: Money and consumer behaviour · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_advantages_20

In many countries, people are increasingly using cards and mobile phone apps to pay for things instead of cash. Do the advantages of this outweigh the disadvantages?

Band 6

274 words

Clear judgement · relevant ideas on both sides but briefly developed · mechanical linking and a repetitive conclusion · adequate vocabulary · several verb form and agreement errors that do not block meaning.

In many countries today, people use bank cards and mobile phone apps to pay for things more than cash. In my opinion, this change has more advantages than disadvantages.

The first advantage is that paying by card or phone is very quick and easy. You only need to touch the card on the machine and the payment is finish in a second. People do not need to carry a lot of coins and notes in their wallet, and they do not need to go to the bank to take out money. Secondly, it is safer. If a person lose his wallet with cash, the money is gone forever, but if he lose his card, he can call the bank and block it. Also, the apps show all the payments, so people can check how much money they spend every month and control their budget.

However, there are some disadvantages as well. Some old people do not know how to use smartphone apps and they prefer to pay with cash, so they may find it difficult in shops which only accept cards. In addition, some people spend more money when they pay by card, because they do not see the money leaving their hands. Another problem is that hackers can steal the information of bank accounts online. Finally, if there is a problem with the internet or electricity, people cannot pay at all.

In conclusion, using cards and mobile apps have some disadvantages, such as problems for elderly people and the risk of online crime. However, I believe that the advantages like speed, convenience and safety are more important, so the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

Band 7

298 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported, with drawbacks acknowledged · logical progression and varied linking · good collocation (contactless payments, cyber-attacks) · frequent error-free sentences, one agreement slip.

In many parts of the world, cash is gradually being replaced by debit cards, contactless payments and mobile phone apps. Although this trend creates difficulties for certain groups, I believe that its advantages are greater than its disadvantages.

The most obvious benefit of digital payments is convenience. Paying with a card or phone takes only a few seconds, there is no need to search for the correct change, and people can shop online or transfer money to friends instantly. This also benefits businesses, which save the time and expense of counting, storing and transporting cash. Secondly, electronic payment is generally safer. Carrying large amounts of cash makes people a target for theft, whereas a lost card can be cancelled immediately. In addition, every digital transaction is recorded, which makes it harder for criminals to avoid paying tax or to hide illegal earnings. Banking apps also allow users to monitor their spending in detail, which can help them manage their finances more responsibly.

Nevertheless, there are some drawbacks to a cashless society. Elderly people and those without bank accounts or smartphones may be excluded if shops and services stop accepting cash. It is often argued that people spend more when they pay digitally, since tapping a card feels less real than handing over notes. There are also concerns about privacy, as banks and technology companies can collect detailed information about where and how people spend their money, and about vulnerability to cyber-attacks or technical failures.

However, these problems can be reduced if governments ensure that cash remains available for those who need it and introduce strong rules on data protection.

In conclusion, although digital payments raise issues of exclusion, overspending and privacy, their speed, safety and transparency make them a positive development. Overall, the advantages clearly outweighs the disadvantages.

Band 8

330 words

Clear, qualified judgement sustained throughout · ideas well developed at individual and societal level · skilful cohesion and paragraphing · wide, precise vocabulary (legal tender, launder the proceeds) · wide range of error-free structures.

The steady decline of cash in favour of cards, contactless technology and mobile wallets has been one of the quieter revolutions in everyday life. Although this shift poses genuine risks for certain groups, I am convinced that its advantages outweigh its disadvantages, provided that access to cash is not abolished altogether.

For consumers, the appeal of digital payments lies chiefly in their convenience. Transactions are completed in seconds, purchases can be made online or across borders without exchanging currency, and money can be sent to friends or family at the touch of a button. Electronic payments also offer greater security for individuals: a stolen wallet full of notes is usually lost for good, whereas a card can be frozen instantly and fraudulent transactions are often refunded. At a wider level, a largely cashless economy is more transparent. Because every payment leaves a record, it becomes considerably harder to conceal income from tax authorities or to launder the proceeds of crime, which ultimately benefits honest taxpayers. Businesses, meanwhile, save on the costs of handling, securing and banking physical money.

The drawbacks, however, should not be underestimated. Those who are elderly, on low incomes or living in areas with poor connectivity may find themselves excluded from essential services if cash ceases to be accepted. Digital payments can also make spending feel less tangible, which may encourage some people to overspend or fall into debt. Furthermore, a society dependent on electronic systems is exposed to cyber-attacks and outages, and the detailed data generated by every transaction raises legitimate questions about surveillance and privacy.

These concerns, though serious, argue for safeguards rather than a rejection of digital payments. Guaranteeing that cash remains legal tender and widely accepted, while enforcing robust data-protection standards, would address the most significant risks.

In conclusion, the move away from cash brings efficiency, security and transparency that benefit individuals and society as a whole. As long as vulnerable groups are protected, the advantages of this trend clearly outweigh its disadvantages.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Phones in the classroom

Topic: Education · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_problem_01

In many schools, students are becoming increasingly distracted by mobile phones during lessons. What problems does this cause, and what can be done to solve them?

Band 6

280 words

Both parts addressed with relevant ideas · examples are simple and some points underdeveloped · mechanical linking (Firstly, Secondly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement, article and word-form errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, many students bring their mobile phones to school and they are often distracted by them during the lessons. This essay will discuss the main problems of this situation and suggest some solutions to solve them.

The first problem is that students cannot concentrate on what teacher is saying. When a phone vibrates or they receive a message, they want to check it immediately, so they miss important informations. As a result, their marks in exams can become lower. Another problem is that it disturb other students in the class. For example, if one student is watching videos or playing games, the students who sit next to him will also look at the screen and stop listening. Also, teachers have to stop the lesson many times to tell students to put away phones, and this waste a lot of time.

However, there are some solutions for these problems. Firstly, schools can make a clear rule that phones are not allowed during lessons. Students could leave their phones in a box at the start of the class and take them back at the end of the day. Secondly, parents should also help. They can talk to their children about the dangers of using phone too much and explain why it is important to focus in school. Finally, teachers can make lessons more interesting, because when the lesson is boring, students are more likely to use their phones.

In conclusion, mobile phones cause many problems in the classroom, such as poor concentration and wasting of time. I think schools, parents and teachers should work together to solve this problem, and if they do this, students will be more focus on their studies.

Band 7

311 words

Clear position throughout · problems and solutions extended with explanation · clear topic in each paragraph · range of linking with minor punctuation slips · good collocation (consistently enforced policy) · mostly error-free complex sentences.

Mobile phones have become a constant presence in the lives of teenagers, and it is now common for students to be distracted by them even in the middle of a lesson. This habit creates difficulties for both learners and teachers, but I believe it can be managed through a combination of school policy and better classroom practice.

The most obvious problem is the damage to students' learning. Checking a notification may take only a few seconds, but each interruption breaks a student's concentration, and it can take several minutes to fully refocus on a difficult explanation. Over time, pupils who are frequently distracted tend to develop gaps in their understanding, which is often reflected in lower exam results. A second issue concerns the class as a whole. When teachers have to repeatedly ask students to put their phones away, valuable teaching time is lost and the atmosphere of the lesson can become tense. In addition, a student secretly watching videos can easily distract the

classmates sitting around them.

There are, however, practical ways of tackling these problems. The most effective is probably a clear and consistently enforced policy, such as requiring students to hand in their phones at the start of the day or keep them switched off in lockers. Such rules only work if every teacher applies them, otherwise students quickly learn in which lessons they can ignore them. At the same time, schools could teach pupils about healthy technology habits, so that they understand why constant phone use harms their attention. Teachers can also reduce the temptation by designing more interactive lessons, since students who are actively involved are less likely to reach for their phones.

In conclusion, phone use during lessons weakens concentration and wastes valuable teaching time. Firm school rules, supported by education about digital habits and engaging teaching, offer the best chance of solving the problem.

Band 8

317 words

Both parts fully developed with extended, well-supported ideas · logical sequencing and well-managed paragraphing · precise, flexible vocabulary (erosion, fractures, complementary role) · wide range of structures, virtually error-free.

In classrooms across the world, the smartphone has become a persistent rival for students' attention. While the device itself is not inherently harmful, its presence during lessons undermines both individual learning and the functioning of the class, and addressing this requires action from schools, teachers and families alike.

The most serious consequence is the erosion of sustained concentration. Learning complex material, whether an algebraic proof or the causes of a historical conflict, depends on following a line of reasoning without interruption. A single glance at a message may seem trivial, yet it fractures that reasoning, and a student who is interrupted repeatedly is left with a fragmented grasp of the topic that later surfaces as poor performance in assessments. Beyond the individual, phones damage the shared environment of the classroom. Teachers forced to police screen use lose time that should be spent teaching, and the constant tension between enforcement and instruction can sour relationships between staff and pupils. Moreover, distraction is contagious: one student scrolling through videos can draw the attention of an entire row.

The most direct remedy is an unambiguous, school-wide policy. Requiring phones to be stored in lockers or sealed pouches during the school day removes the temptation altogether, and applying the rule uniformly prevents the inconsistency that students are quick to exploit. However, restriction alone treats the symptom rather than the cause. Schools should also build digital literacy into the curriculum, helping young people understand how apps are designed to capture attention and how to regain control over their own habits. Parents have a complementary role in reinforcing these messages at home, while teachers can reduce the appeal of the phone by making lessons more participatory and less reliant on passive listening.

In short, mobile phones weaken concentration, waste teaching time and strain classroom relationships. A consistent ban, combined with education that equips students to manage technology themselves, offers the most durable solution.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Overcrowding in large cities

Topic: Cities · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_02

Many large cities are becoming overcrowded as people move from rural areas to find work. What problems does this cause, and what measures could be taken to deal with them?

Band 6

267 words

Addresses problems and measures · relevant but general ideas with limited development · clear paragraphs with basic linking (First, Second, Also) · adequate vocabulary · frequent article and agreement errors that do not impede meaning.

In recent years, a lot of people have moved from the countryside to big cities because they want to find a job. Because of this, many cities become overcrowded. In this essay I will explain the problems which this causes and some measures to deal with them.

The main problem of overcrowding is housing. When too many people come to the city, there is not enough houses for everyone, so the rent becomes very expensive. Many poor people have to live in small rooms or in slums with bad conditions, where there is no clean water. Another problem is traffic. The roads are full of cars and buses, and people spend a long time to go to work every day. Also, the air pollution is increasing because of so many vehicles, and this is bad for people health.

There are several measures that government can take. First, they should build more cheap apartments for low-income workers, so they do not need to live in slums. Second, the public transport must be improved. If there are more metro lines and buses, less people will use their own cars and the traffic will be reduced. In addition, the government can create jobs in the rural areas, for example by building factories or supporting farmers. In this way, young people will not need to move to the city to find a work.

In conclusion, overcrowding in cities causes problems such as expensive housing, traffic jams and pollution. I believe that the government should build cheap housing, improve transport and develop the countryside, because this will make life better for everyone.

Band 7

288 words

Clear position and logical organisation · main problems and measures extended with examples · good range of cohesive devices, one comma splice · less common vocabulary (informal settlements, relocate) · mostly accurate complex sentences.

The steady movement of people from rural areas to cities in search of employment has left many urban centres struggling to cope with their growing populations. This essay will examine the main difficulties that overcrowding creates and suggest some measures that could ease them.

Perhaps the most serious problem is the shortage of affordable housing. As demand for accommodation rises faster than new homes can be built, rents increase sharply, and many newcomers on low wages are forced into cramped, poorly maintained buildings or informal settlements that lack basic services such as sanitation. Overcrowding also places enormous pressure on infrastructure. Roads become congested, public transport is packed at peak times and hospitals and schools are often unable to serve everyone, which lowers the quality of life for long-term residents as well as new arrivals.

To deal with these issues, governments need to act on two levels. Within cities, authorities should invest in large-scale social housing and expand public transport networks, for example by building new metro lines that connect affordable suburbs with business districts. This would allow people to live further from the centre without spending hours commuting. However, such measures only address the symptoms, therefore it is also important to reduce the pressure to migrate in the first place. Investing in rural areas, by improving roads, internet access and local industries, would give people realistic opportunities to earn a living without leaving their hometowns. Tax incentives could also encourage companies to relocate to smaller cities, which spreads economic growth more evenly.

In conclusion, rural-urban migration leads to housing shortages and overloaded public services in large cities. A combination of better urban planning and genuine investment in the countryside is the most effective way to tackle these problems.

Band 8

306 words

Fully addresses both parts with well-developed, logically sequenced ideas · skilful cohesion and paragraphing · wide, precise vocabulary (outpaces, overstretched, viable livelihoods) · wide range of structures, essentially error-free.

Across much of the world, cities continue to swell as rural residents arrive in pursuit of work. Although this migration fuels economic growth, it frequently outpaces the capacity of urban areas to absorb newcomers, producing social and environmental strains that demand a coordinated policy response.

The most visible consequence is a crisis of housing. When population growth exceeds the rate of construction, prices rise beyond the reach of low-paid workers, who are pushed into overcrowded rented rooms or informal settlements on the urban fringe. These districts typically lack reliable water, sanitation and electricity, creating conditions in which disease spreads easily. A second set of problems stems from overstretched infrastructure. Transport networks designed for far smaller populations become gridlocked, lengthening commutes and worsening air quality, while schools and clinics struggle to meet demand. The result is a decline in living standards not only for migrants but for established residents too, which can in turn breed resentment between the two groups.

Tackling these difficulties requires measures both inside and outside the city. Within urban areas, governments should prioritise the construction of affordable housing and pair it with mass transit, so that new residential zones are connected to centres of employment rather than isolated from them. Upgrading informal settlements with basic services, rather than simply clearing them, is often a more humane and cost-effective approach. Equally important, however, is reducing the imbalance that drives migration in the first place. Investment in rural infrastructure, agricultural modernisation and regional industry can create viable livelihoods outside the major cities, while incentives for businesses to establish themselves in secondary towns would distribute economic opportunity more evenly.

In conclusion, rapid urban migration strains housing, transport and public services, lowering the quality of life for many residents. The most lasting solution lies in combining well-planned urban investment with a serious commitment to developing rural regions.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Housing for essential workers

Topic: Housing · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_03

In many cities, housing has become so expensive that essential workers, such as nurses and teachers, can no longer afford to live near their workplaces. What problems does this cause, and what solutions can you suggest?

Band 6

271 words

Both parts covered with relevant points · solutions listed rather than developed · mechanical sequencing (Firstly, Secondly, Thirdly) · adequate vocabulary · repeated subject-verb agreement and preposition errors that do not block meaning.

In many big cities, the price of houses and flats is very high, and workers like nurses and teachers cannot afford to live close to where they work. This situation causes several problems, and in this essay I will discuss them and suggest some solutions.

The first problem is that these workers have to travel very long distances every day. For example, a nurse who lives outside the city may need to spend two hours in a train to arrive to the hospital. This makes them very tired and stressed, and a tired nurse or teacher cannot do their job well. Another problem is that many of them decide to leave their job or move to a cheaper city. As a result, hospitals and schools in the city do not have enough staffs, and people who live there receive worse service. For instance, classes become bigger and patients must wait longer for treatment.

There are some solutions to this problem. Firstly, the government can build special houses for essential workers with lower rent. This is already happening in some countries and it helps workers to stay near their workplace. Secondly, employers such as hospitals could give their staff extra money for housing or for transport. Thirdly, the government should control the rent prices, so the landlords cannot increase them too much every year.

In conclusion, the high cost of housing in cities makes it difficult for essential workers to live near their job, which causes tiredness and a shortage of staff. I think the best solution is to build affordable housing for these workers and also give them some financial support.

Band 7

298 words

Clear position throughout · problems for workers and the city extended and supported · logical progression with varied linking · good collocations (priced out, underlying problem) · frequent error-free sentences with one agreement slip.

In many major cities, property prices and rents have risen so steeply that key workers such as nurses, teachers and police officers are being priced out of the areas they serve. This trend has serious consequences for both the workers themselves and the wider community, although there are several ways in which it could be addressed.

For individual workers, the main problem is the burden of long commutes. Many essential staff are forced to live in distant suburbs or neighbouring towns, which means spending several hours travelling each day, often on shifts that start early in the morning or finish late at night. This leads to exhaustion and stress, and it is not surprising that many eventually decide to leave the profession or relocate to cheaper regions. The consequences for the city are equally serious. Hospitals and schools struggle to recruit and keep staff, resulting in larger classes, longer waiting times and a greater dependence on expensive temporary workers.

One effective solution would be for local governments to build or subsidise housing reserved specifically for essential workers, offered at rents linked to their salaries rather than to the market. Public employers could also play a role, for example by converting unused land owned by hospitals into staff accommodation. In addition, a housing allowance for those working in high-cost areas would help to close the gap between wages and living expenses. In the longer term, governments need to increase the overall supply of affordable homes, since the underlying problem is that there are simply not enough housing for ordinary earners.

In conclusion, unaffordable housing leaves essential workers exhausted and cities short of vital staff. Dedicated affordable housing, targeted allowances and a broader increase in housing supply would together help to keep these workers close to where they are needed.

Band 8

316 words

Sufficiently addresses both parts with extended, well-supported ideas · solutions evaluated, not just listed · cohesion managed skilfully · precise, natural vocabulary (imposes a heavy toll, continuity of care) · wide range of accurate structures.

The soaring cost of urban housing has created a paradox in many cities: the people whose work keeps them functioning, including nurses, teachers and care staff, increasingly cannot afford to live in them. This essay argues that the problem damages both the wellbeing of these workers and the quality of public services, and that it calls for targeted housing policy alongside broader reform.

At a personal level, being priced out imposes a heavy daily toll. Essential workers displaced to distant towns face lengthy commutes that, combined with irregular shifts, leave little time for rest or family life. Chronic fatigue is not merely unpleasant; in professions where alertness matters, such as nursing, it can compromise the safety of those in their care. Unsurprisingly, many eventually conclude that the sacrifice is not worth it and either leave the profession or move to cheaper regions. For the city, the cumulative effect is a persistent shortage of skilled staff. Schools rely on a rotating cast of supply teachers, hospitals spend heavily on agency nurses, and residents experience longer waits and less continuity of care. Emergency services, too, become less resilient when those who staff them live an hour or more away.

The most direct response is to provide housing designated for key workers, with rents set as a proportion of income rather than market value. Public bodies are often well placed to do this, since hospitals, universities and councils frequently own land that could be developed for staff accommodation. Location-based salary supplements can offer further relief, although they risk being absorbed by rising rents if supply remains constrained. Ultimately, therefore, such measures must be accompanied by a sustained expansion of affordable housing, achieved through planning reform and public construction.

In conclusion, unaffordable housing exhausts essential workers and weakens the services cities depend on. Dedicated key-worker housing offers immediate relief, but lasting improvement depends on building enough homes for ordinary earners.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Reducing food waste

Topic: Environment / Consumerism · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_problem_04

Large amounts of food are wasted every day by households, restaurants and supermarkets. What are the causes of this problem, and what can be done to reduce it?

Band 6

281 words

Causes and solutions both addressed · ideas relevant but explained simply · repetitive, mechanical linking · adequate everyday vocabulary · several errors in agreement, comparatives and word choice that do not block meaning.

Every day, a huge amount of food is thrown away by families, restaurants and supermarkets. This is a serious problem because many people in the world do not have enough to eat. This essay will discuss the causes of food waste and what can be done to reduce it.

There are some reasons why people waste food. The first reason is that many families buy more food than they need. When they go shopping, they see special offers like buy one get one free, so they buy a lot and later the food goes bad in the fridge. Another reason is that people are confused about the date on the food packet. They think the food is dangerous after the date, so they throw it away even if it is still good to eat. In restaurants, the portions are often too big, and customers cannot finish their meal. Also, supermarkets throw away fruit and vegetables which do not look perfect, because customers do not want to buy them.

There are several ways to reduce this problem. Firstly, people should plan their meals before shopping and make a list, so they only buy what they really need. Secondly, the government could make the labels more clear and explain the difference between use by and best before. Thirdly, supermarkets and restaurants should give their extra food to charities or food banks instead of throwing it away. Some countries already have laws about this and it is very useful.

In conclusion, food waste is caused by buying too much, confusion about dates and big portions in restaurants. If families, business and government all take action, the amount of food waste can be reduced a lot.

Band 7

290 words

Clear focus on causes and solutions · household and commercial causes distinguished and supported · logical paragraphing with good referencing · less common vocabulary (perishable, multi-buy promotions) · one minor agreement slip.

A significant proportion of the food produced around the world never reaches anyone's plate, being discarded instead by households, restaurants and retailers. This essay will outline the main reasons for this waste and suggest how it could be reduced.

At the household level, the key cause is poor planning combined with the relatively low cost of food in many countries. Shoppers often buy more than they need, particularly when tempted by multi-buy promotions, and perishable items such as bread and salad are then forgotten until they have spoiled. Confusion over date labels makes the situation worse, as many consumers treat a best-before date as a strict deadline and throw away food that is perfectly safe. In the commercial sector, the causes are somewhat different. Restaurants frequently serve portions that are larger than customers can eat, while supermarkets reject large quantities of fruit and vegetables for cosmetic reasons and discard stock once it passes its display date.

Reducing this waste requires action from several directions. Firstly, clearer labelling would make a considerable difference; if packaging only showed a use-by date where there is a genuine safety risk, consumers would throw away far less. Public campaigns that teaches simple habits, such as checking the fridge before shopping and freezing leftovers, could also change behaviour over time. For businesses, governments could introduce regulations requiring large supermarkets to donate unsold but edible food to charities rather than sending it to landfill. Restaurants, meanwhile, could offer smaller portions at lower prices and encourage diners to take leftovers home.

In conclusion, food waste results mainly from overbuying, misunderstanding of labels and commercial practices that put appearance and convenience before efficiency. A mixture of better information, changes in consumer habits and sensible regulation could reduce it substantially.

Band 8

310 words

Causes and solutions fully developed and matched to each other · skilful organisation and cohesion · precise vocabulary (compound the problem, misshapen produce, redistribute surplus) · wide range of accurate complex structures.

Despite widespread concern about food insecurity, vast quantities of edible food are discarded daily in homes, restaurants and supermarkets. The causes differ across these settings, but in each case waste stems from habits and systems that prioritise convenience over efficiency, and it can be reduced considerably through a mix of education, regulation and incentives.

In households, waste is largely a product of how people shop and store food. Relatively low prices in wealthier countries mean that discarding a half-used loaf carries little financial sting, while bulk promotions encourage people to buy more than they can realistically consume before it spoils. Misleading date labels compound the problem: many consumers fail to distinguish between a use-by date, which concerns safety, and a best-before date, which relates only to quality, and so throw away food that is still perfectly edible. The commercial sector has its own drivers. Supermarkets impose strict cosmetic standards that exclude misshapen produce before it even reaches the shelves, and they routinely overstock to avoid empty displays. Restaurants, for their part, often serve generous portions as a marker of value, much of which is left uneaten.

Tackling these causes calls for measures tailored to each. Simplifying date labelling, and removing best-before dates from items such as fresh fruit altogether, would prevent a great deal of unnecessary disposal at home, particularly if accompanied by public campaigns on meal planning and storage. For retailers, legislation obliging large stores to redistribute surplus edible food to charities has proved workable in several countries and could be adopted more widely. Supermarkets could also be encouraged to sell imperfect produce at a discount, and restaurants to offer flexible portion sizes.

In conclusion, food waste arises from overbuying, confusing labels and commercial practices that value appearance and abundance. Clearer information, redistribution laws and changes to retail and catering practice together offer a realistic path to reducing it.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Preparing for extreme weather

Topic: Climate · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_problem_05

Extreme weather events, such as floods and heatwaves, are becoming more common in many parts of the world. What problems does this create for local communities, and how can communities be better prepared?

Band 6

280 words

Both questions answered with relevant problems and preparations · limited development of ideas · basic but clear paragraphing · adequate vocabulary with some imprecision (electrical things) · several agreement, preposition and word-form errors.

In the last few years, extreme weather such as floods and heatwaves are happening more often in many countries. These events create a lot of difficulties for local communities. This essay will look at these problems and how communities can be more prepared.

The first problem is damage to homes and buildings. When there is a big flood, water enter into houses and destroys furniture and electrical things, and some families lose everything. Roads and bridges can also be broken, so people cannot go to work or school for many days. The second problem is health. During a heatwave, old people and small children can become very ill because of the high temperature, and some of them even die. After floods, the water is often dirty and it can spread diseases. In addition, farmers can lose their crops, and this make food more expensive for the whole community.

However, communities can prepare better for these events. One way is to build stronger infrastructure, for example flood walls and better drainage systems in the cities. Also, the local government should not allow people to build new houses in areas which flood very often. Another way is to give people information. If there is a good warning system on the phone and on television, people will have time to leave their homes before the flood arrive. For heatwaves, towns can open cool public buildings where old people can stay during the hottest part of day.

In conclusion, extreme weather causes damage to property, health problems and loss of crops. I think the best way to be prepare is to have strong infrastructure and a good warning system, so communities can protect themselves.

Band 7

285 words

Clear position · problems and preparation measures extended with relevant examples · clear central idea in each paragraph · good range of vocabulary (floodplains, resilient) · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

As the climate changes, extreme weather events like floods, storms and heatwaves are occurring with increasing frequency in many regions. These events pose serious challenges for local communities, but careful planning can significantly reduce their impact.

The most immediate problem is the physical damage that such events cause. Floods can destroy homes, businesses and essential infrastructure within hours, leaving families homeless and cutting off access to hospitals, schools and workplaces. Rebuilding is often slow and expensive, and in poorer communities where few people have insurance, the financial losses can take years to recover from. Extreme heat creates a different but equally serious threat to public health. Elderly people, young children and those with existing medical conditions are especially vulnerable, and hospitals can quickly become overwhelmed during a prolonged

heatwave. Furthermore, both floods and droughts can devastate local agriculture, which affects farmers' incomes and pushes up food prices for everyone.

Communities can prepare more effectively in several ways. First of all, investment in protective infrastructure, such as flood barriers, improved drainage and buildings designed to stay cool, would reduce the damage when disasters strike. Planning authorities should also stop approving new housing on floodplains, which only increase the number of people at risk. Secondly, early warning systems are essential. Sending alerts directly to mobile phones gives residents time to move valuables, evacuate or check on vulnerable neighbours. Finally, local councils could prepare detailed emergency plans, for example by identifying cooling centres for heatwaves and organising volunteers who know which residents live alone and might need help.

In conclusion, extreme weather threatens people's homes, health and livelihoods. By combining stronger infrastructure, sensible planning and effective warning systems, communities can become far more resilient to these growing risks.

Band 8

317 words

Both parts sufficiently addressed with extended, well-supported ideas · preparation discussed at several levels in logical sequence · wide, precise vocabulary (render uninhabitable, permeable drainage) · varied, accurate complex sentences.

Floods, storms and prolonged heatwaves, once regarded as rare events, are now a recurring feature of life in many parts of the world. Their consequences for local communities are wide-ranging, affecting property, health and livelihoods, but much of the harm can be mitigated if communities invest in preparation rather than simply reacting after disaster strikes.

The most tangible impact is the destruction of homes and infrastructure. A single severe flood can render entire streets uninhabitable, sever transport links and knock out power and water supplies, isolating residents from essential services. The costs of recovery fall disproportionately on low-income households, which are less likely to be insured and more likely to live in vulnerable locations. Heatwaves, though less visibly destructive, can be even more deadly. Prolonged high temperatures place severe strain on older people and those with chronic illnesses, particularly in densely built urban areas where heat is retained overnight. There are also slower economic consequences: repeated crop failures erode farmers' livelihoods, and small businesses forced to close again and again may never reopen.

Preparation must therefore operate on several levels. Physical adaptation is the foundation, from flood defences and permeable drainage to building codes that require better insulation and shading. Land-use planning matters just as much, since continuing to build on floodplains simply multiplies future losses. Infrastructure alone is insufficient, however, without effective communication. Reliable early warning systems, delivered through mobile networks and local media, give residents time to act, while clearly marked evacuation routes ensure that warnings translate into safety. Finally, strong community networks can make a decisive difference. Neighbourhood schemes that identify isolated or elderly residents, together with designated cooling centres, help ensure that the most vulnerable are not overlooked.

In conclusion, extreme weather damages property, endangers health and undermines local economies. Communities that combine resilient infrastructure, prudent planning and well-organised warning and support systems will be far better equipped to withstand these growing threats.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Tackling traffic congestion

Topic: Transport · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_problem_06

Traffic congestion is a growing problem in many towns and cities. What problems does it cause, and what can be done to solve them?

Band 6

274 words

Problems and solutions both covered · several solutions listed with little explanation · mechanical linking (Firstly to Finally) · adequate vocabulary with some repetition · verb pattern and agreement errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, traffic congestion is becoming a big problem in many towns and cities around the world. This essay will discuss the problems that traffic jams cause and some solutions to solve them.

One of the main problem is that people waste a lot of time. Many workers spend one or two hours in their car every day, and this make them tired and stressed before they even start working. Also, when goods cannot be delivered on time, companies lose money, so it is bad for the economy too. Another serious problem is pollution. When many cars are stuck in traffic, their engines are still running and they produce a lot of smoke. This smoke is harmful for people who live near busy roads, especially children and old people, and it can cause breathing problems.

There are some ways to solve these problems. Firstly, the government should improve public transport. If buses and trains are cheap, fast and comfortable, many people will leave their cars at home. Secondly, cities can build more cycle lanes, so people can go to work by bicycle safely. This is also good for their health. Thirdly, some cities make drivers to pay money when they drive into the city centre at busy times. I think this is a good idea because it reduce the number of cars on the road. Finally, companies can let their employees to work from home some days of the week.

In conclusion, traffic congestion waste people's time, damages the economy and causes pollution. However, if governments and companies take the right actions, like better public transport and charges for drivers, this problem can be solved.

Band 7

294 words

Clear position throughout · economic and health problems extended and supported · solutions explained with reasons · wide range of linking, slightly formulaic (Firstly, Secondly) · good collocation · one agreement slip.

Traffic congestion has become a daily reality in many towns and cities, as the number of vehicles on the roads continues to grow faster than the capacity of the road network. This essay will discuss the main problems caused by congestion and propose some practical solutions.

Firstly, congestion has significant economic costs. Commuters lose hours each week sitting in traffic, which reduces the time they have for work, family and rest, and delayed delivery vehicles increase costs for businesses, which are eventually passed on to consumers. Secondly, and perhaps more seriously, heavy traffic damages the environment and public health. Vehicles moving slowly or idling in queues release large amounts of exhaust fumes, contributing to poor air quality in city centres and to respiratory illnesses such as asthma. The

noise and stress associated with constant traffic also lowers the quality of life for people who live along busy roads.

There are several ways in which these problems could be tackled. The most effective long-term solution is to invest in reliable, affordable public transport, so that taking the bus or train becomes a more attractive option than driving. Cities which have developed efficient metro and tram systems generally have fewer cars on their streets. Alongside this, authorities could introduce congestion charges, which require drivers to pay to enter the busiest areas at peak times. This not only discourages unnecessary journeys but also raises money that can be reinvested in transport. Finally, encouraging cycling and walking through safe, separated lanes and pedestrian-friendly streets would provide a healthy alternative for shorter journeys.

In conclusion, traffic congestion wastes time and money and harms both the environment and people's health. A combination of better public transport, congestion charging and support for cycling offers the most realistic way to reduce it.

Band 8

300 words

Fully addresses problems and solutions with well-developed arguments · evaluates an obvious solution before proposing better ones · skilful cohesion · precise, natural vocabulary (ripple through, segregated cycle routes) · wide range of error-free structures.

As car ownership has risen, the road networks of many towns and cities have become chronically congested, with rush-hour gridlock now an accepted part of urban life. This situation carries substantial economic, environmental and social costs, yet it is far from inevitable, and a number of well-tested measures can relieve it.

The economic burden of congestion is considerable. Time spent stationary in traffic is time lost to productive work or leisure, and unpredictable journey times make it harder for businesses to schedule deliveries and for employees to arrive punctually. These inefficiencies ripple through the economy, raising costs for firms and ultimately for consumers. The environmental and health consequences are equally serious. Stop-start driving is particularly inefficient, so congested streets generate disproportionate levels of exhaust emissions, degrading air quality and contributing to respiratory and heart disease. Residents of busy corridors also endure persistent noise, while heavy traffic discourages walking and cycling, reinforcing sedentary lifestyles.

Expanding road capacity might appear to be the obvious answer, but new roads tend to attract additional traffic and soon fill up again. A more effective strategy is to reduce demand for car travel. Frequent, affordable and reliable public transport is central to this, since people will only abandon their cars if a genuine alternative exists. Congestion charging, under which drivers pay to enter central zones at peak times, can then discourage non-essential journeys while generating revenue to fund transport improvements. Cities can further reshape travel habits by building safe, segregated cycle routes and by encouraging employers to adopt flexible hours and remote working, which spreads demand more evenly across the day.

In conclusion, congestion wastes time, burdens the economy and damages public health. Rather than building ever more roads, authorities should reduce reliance on cars through high-quality public transport, pricing mechanisms and support for active travel.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Young people and jobs

Topic: Employment · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_problem_07

Many young people find it difficult to get a job after they finish their education. What are the reasons for this, and what can be done to help them?

Band 6

279 words

Reasons and help both addressed · relevant ideas but some are over-simplified · clear paragraphs with mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · noticeable errors in tense, agreement and word form that do not block meaning.

These days, many young people finish school or university but they cannot find a job easily. There are several reasons for this situation, and in this essay I will explain them and suggest what can be done to help.

The main reason is lack of experience. Most companies want to hire people who already have experience, but young graduates only have studied in the classroom. So it is like a circle: they cannot get experience without a job, and they cannot get a job without experience. Another reason is that what students learn at university is sometimes not useful for the job market. For example, many students study subjects like history or literature, but companies are looking for people with skills in technology or engineering. In addition, in some countries the economy is weak and there is not many jobs available for anyone, not only for young people.

There are some things that can help young people. Firstly, universities and colleges should work together with companies to give students internships during their study. In this way, students can get real experience and they will have more chance to get a job after graduate. Secondly, the government can give money to companies which employ young people, so that companies are more willing to hire them. Also, schools should give students better career advice, so they can choose a subject which have good job opportunities in the future.

In conclusion, young people find it difficult to get a job because they have no experience and their skills do not match what employers need. I believe that internships, government support and better advice can help them a lot to start their career.

Band 7

297 words

Clear position · three reasons developed and linked to matching solutions · logical progression with a good range of cohesive devices · appropriate topic vocabulary (entry-level, apprenticeships) · mostly accurate with one agreement slip.

In many countries, young people who have recently completed their education face considerable difficulty in finding employment. This essay will examine the main reasons for this and suggest some measures that could improve their prospects.

One major reason is the gap between the skills that young people acquire in education and those that employers actually require. Many school and university courses remains largely theoretical, so graduates may understand their subject well but lack practical abilities such as teamwork, communication or familiarity with workplace software. A related problem is the widespread demand for previous experience. Even entry-level positions often ask for one or two years of relevant work, which places young applicants in a frustrating situation where they cannot gain experience without first being employed. Finally, in periods of economic uncertainty, companies tend to reduce recruitment, and young people, who have the shortest

work history, are usually the first to be affected.

To address these problems, educational institutions should work more closely with employers. Work placements and internships built into degree programmes would allow students to develop practical skills and graduate with genuine experience on their CV. Vocational courses and apprenticeships should also be given more status, since they prepare young people directly for specific careers. Governments, meanwhile, could offer financial incentives, such as reduced tax contributions, to companies that hire and train recent graduates, which would lower the risk of taking on inexperienced staff. In addition, better careers guidance in schools would help students to choose courses with realistic job prospects.

In conclusion, young people struggle to find work mainly because of a mismatch in skills, a lack of experience and weak economic conditions. Closer links between education and industry, combined with government incentives and better guidance, could make the transition from study to employment much smoother.

Band 8

312 words

Reasons and solutions both fully developed and logically connected · well-managed paragraphing and cohesion · precise, flexible vocabulary (interlocking causes, experience trap, sluggish growth) · wide range of error-free structures.

For many young people, the move from education into the workforce has become a prolonged and discouraging process, with months or even years passing before they secure stable employment. This difficulty has several interlocking causes, but it can be eased through closer cooperation between educators, employers and governments.

A fundamental cause is the mismatch between what education provides and what the labour market demands. Academic curricula often prioritise theoretical knowledge, leaving graduates ill-prepared for the practical and interpersonal demands of the workplace, while rapid technological change means that some skills are outdated almost as soon as they are taught. Compounding this is the so-called experience trap: employers, reluctant to invest in training, advertise even junior roles as requiring prior experience, which school leavers and graduates by definition do not possess. Structural factors play a part as well. In economies with sluggish growth, firms freeze recruitment, and because young people lack the seniority and networks of older workers, they bear a disproportionate share of the impact. The expansion of higher education has also intensified competition, as a degree no longer distinguishes an applicant in the way it once did.

Solutions should therefore target the transition itself. Embedding work placements and industry-led projects within courses would give students both relevant skills and demonstrable experience before they graduate. High-quality apprenticeships, which combine paid employment with structured training, offer an equally valuable route and deserve the same prestige as university study. Governments can reduce the risk employers perceive in hiring newcomers by subsidising wages or training costs for a limited period. Finally, careers guidance that draws on up-to-date labour market information would enable young people to make informed decisions about what to study.

In conclusion, youth unemployment stems from skills mismatches, the experience trap and wider economic weakness. By bridging the gap between education and work, societies can help young people establish themselves far more quickly.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Sedentary modern lifestyles

Topic: Health · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_08

In many countries, people are spending more time sitting down and less time being physically active. What problems does this cause, and how can people be encouraged to become more active?

Band 6

284 words

Both parts answered with relevant problems and ideas · points listed with limited extension · formulaic linking (First, Second, Finally) · adequate vocabulary with some repetition · errors in agreement, articles and comparatives.

Nowadays, many people spend most of their day sitting in front of a computer or watching TV, and they do not do much exercise. This lifestyle cause several problems, and in this essay I will discuss them and suggest how people can become more active.

The biggest problem is health. When people sit for many hours and do not move, they can easily put on weight, and this can lead to serious illnesses like heart disease and diabetes. Also, sitting too long is bad for the back and neck, especially for office workers who use computer all day. Another problem is mental health. Exercise helps people to feel relaxed and happy, so people who never do sport are more likely to feel stressed or depressed. Furthermore, when many people are ill, the country has to spend more money on hospitals, which is a problem for everyone.

There are some ways to encourage people to be more active. First, the government should build more parks, sports centres and cycle paths, and make them free or cheap, so everybody can use them. Second, companies can help their workers, for example by giving them a break every hour to walk around or by offering free gym membership. In addition, schools should have more PE lessons, because if children enjoy sport when they are young, they will continue it when they grow up. Finally, there should be advertisements on TV and social media to show people the benefit of exercise.

In conclusion, sitting too much can cause health problems for people and extra costs for the country. I think the government, companies and schools should all encourage people to do more physical activity and have more healthy lifestyle.

Band 7

312 words

Clear position · problems for individuals and society extended with explanation · solutions organised by setting · good range of linking and topic vocabulary (sedentary, subsidising) · one agreement slip.

Modern lifestyles have become increasingly sedentary, with many people spending most of their working day at a desk and much of their free time in front of screens. This trend has serious consequences for individuals and society, although there are a number of ways to encourage people to move more.

The most significant problem is the impact on physical health. A lack of regular activity is closely linked to weight gain, which in turn raises the risk of conditions such as heart disease, type 2 diabetes and high blood pressure. Long periods of sitting can also cause back and joint pain, a common complaint among office workers. Physical inactivity affects mental wellbeing too, since exercise is known to reduce stress and improve mood, so people who rarely exercise may be more likely to experience anxiety or low energy. At a national level, these health

problems place a heavy burden on healthcare systems, and they also reduce productivity when employees need time off due to illness.

Encouraging people to be more active requires making exercise easier and more appealing. Local authorities could invest in safe cycle lanes, well-maintained parks and affordable sports facilities, so that physical activity become part of everyday life rather than something requiring special effort. Employers also have a role to play, for instance by providing standing desks, encouraging walking meetings or subsidising gym membership. Schools are perhaps the most important place to start, because children who develop an enjoyment of sport are more likely to stay active as adults. Finally, public health campaigns could highlight that even small changes, such as taking the stairs or walking short distances, bring real benefits.

In conclusion, sedentary behaviour harms both physical and mental health and increases the pressure on public services. By making activity more accessible at home, at work and at school, governments and organisations can help people lead healthier lives.

Band 8

306 words

Both parts sufficiently addressed with extended, relevant support · argues why simple persuasion fails before offering solutions · skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (musculoskeletal, exhortation) · wide range of accurate structures.

Over recent decades, daily life in many countries has become strikingly sedentary. Desk-based jobs, car-dependent commuting and screen-based leisure mean that many adults now spend the majority of their waking hours seated. This shift carries significant costs, but carefully designed interventions can make physical activity a more natural part of everyday routines.

The most serious consequences are for health. Prolonged inactivity is a major risk factor for obesity, cardiovascular disease and type 2 diabetes, and it contributes to musculoskeletal problems such as chronic back pain. The effects are not solely physical: regular movement is associated with better sleep, lower stress and improved mood, so its absence can leave people more vulnerable to anxiety and depression. These individual problems accumulate into a wider social burden. Health services must treat a growing number of preventable, long-term conditions, while employers face reduced productivity and higher rates of absence.

Simply urging people to exercise more has limited effect, because inactivity is largely a product of how environments and routines are structured. The most promising approach is therefore to design activity back into daily life. Towns that provide continuous cycle networks, pleasant walking routes and accessible green spaces make active travel the convenient choice rather than a sacrifice. Workplaces can contribute by offering flexible breaks, sit-stand desks and facilities such as showers and bicycle storage that make active commuting practical. Schools arguably have the greatest long-term influence, since a positive early experience of sport and play shapes habits for life; ensuring that physical education is varied and inclusive, rather than purely competitive, is key. Subsidised leisure centre membership can further lower barriers for low-income groups.

In conclusion, sedentary lifestyles damage physical and mental health and impose broader economic costs. Rather than relying on exhortation, societies should reshape their built environments, workplaces and schools so that being active becomes the easiest option.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Loneliness in old age

Topic: Society · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_09

Loneliness is becoming increasingly common among older people in many societies. What problems does this cause, and what can be done to address it?

Band 6

279 words

Problems and solutions both addressed · ideas relevant but not fully extended · mechanical sequencing (Firstly, Secondly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors that do not block meaning.

In many countries today, more and more old people feel lonely. Their children often live far away and many of their friends have already died. This essay will discuss the problems which loneliness causes and what can be done to solve it.

Firstly, loneliness is very bad for old people's health. When they have nobody to talk with, they can become sad and depressed, and some of them lose interest in life. Loneliness can also make physical problems worse, for example heart disease or high blood pressure. Secondly, lonely elderly people are more at risk if something happens to them. For instance, if an old man falls down at home and lives alone, maybe no one will find him for a long time. Also, because they are lonely, some of them visit the doctor more often just to talk to someone, and this puts pressure on the health system.

There are several things that can be done. The first solution is that families should spend more time with their elderly parents and grandparents. Even if they live far away, they can call them regularly or use video calls. Moreover, local government can organise community centres where old people can meet each other, play games and join activities like dancing or painting. Another good idea is volunteer programmes, in which young people visit elderly people at their home and help them with shopping or technology. This is good for both of them.

In conclusion, loneliness among old people causes mental and physical health problems and puts them in danger. I think families, the government and volunteers should all work together to make elderly people feel more connected to the society.

Band 7

294 words

Clear position throughout · health, safety and social costs extended and supported · solutions logically sequenced from family to community · good range of vocabulary (befriending schemes, intergenerational) · one agreement slip.

As populations age and family structures change, loneliness has become a growing concern among older people in many societies. This essay will consider the problems that social isolation creates and suggest some ways of tackling it.

The most serious effects of loneliness are on health. Older people who have little contact with others are more likely to suffer from depression and a sense that they are no longer valued, and long-term isolation is also thought to be linked to physical conditions such as heart disease and a faster decline in memory. Loneliness can also create practical dangers. An elderly person living alone who falls or becomes suddenly ill may not receive help for many hours. Moreover, these problems have a wider cost for society, as isolated older people tend to rely more heavily on health and care services, sometimes visiting their doctor partly for the social contact.

Addressing loneliness requires efforts from families, communities and governments. Families are clearly the first source of support, and even when relatives live far away, regular phone or video calls can make a significant difference. However, not every older person has close family, so community initiatives are equally important. Local councils could fund day centres, clubs and classes that give older residents a reason to leave the house and meet others with similar interests. Befriending schemes, in which volunteers make regular visits or phone calls, has also proved valuable. Another promising idea is intergenerational projects, such as bringing schoolchildren to care homes, which benefit both age groups.

In conclusion, loneliness among the elderly damages their mental and physical wellbeing and increases the demand on public services. A combination of family involvement, community activities and volunteer schemes would help older people to remain connected and active members of society.

Band 8

314 words

Fully addresses problems and solutions with well-extended, relevant ideas · coherent progression from individual to collective effects · precise vocabulary (cognitive decline, susceptible, housebound) · wide range of structures used accurately.

In many societies, a combination of longer life expectancy, smaller families and greater geographical mobility has left a growing number of older people living alone with limited social contact. The resulting loneliness is far more than a private sorrow; it has serious consequences for health and public services, and it demands a response from families, communities and the state.

The most profound impact is on wellbeing. Prolonged isolation is strongly associated with depression and a loss of purpose, and it is increasingly recognised as a risk to physical health in its own right. Older people without regular social interaction may also experience faster cognitive decline, as conversation and shared activity help to keep the mind engaged. Isolation creates practical vulnerabilities as well: someone who lives alone and has few visitors may lie undiscovered for hours after a fall, and may be more susceptible to fraud or neglect. These individual harms translate into collective costs, since lonely older people tend to make greater use of doctors, hospitals and residential care.

Addressing the problem means rebuilding the social connections that modern life has eroded. Families remain central, and even regular calls can provide reassurance and a sense of being valued. Yet many older people have no close relatives nearby, so community provision is essential. Local authorities and charities can sustain lunch clubs, exercise groups and learning opportunities that give people both a reason and a means to leave home, provided that accessible transport is available. Volunteer befriending services offer companionship to those who are housebound, while intergenerational schemes, such as pairing students with older residents, foster mutual understanding and benefit both parties. Doctors, too, can refer isolated patients to such activities rather than relying solely on medication.

In conclusion, loneliness in later life undermines health and places growing pressure on services. Sustained investment in community networks, supported by families and volunteers, offers the most effective remedy.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Protecting people from fraud

Topic: Crime / Technology · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_10

Online fraud and identity theft are increasing as more people use the internet for shopping and banking. What problems does this cause, and what measures could be taken to protect people?

Band 6

277 words

Problems and measures both covered with relevant examples · development is fairly general · adequate linking but some repetition · adequate vocabulary with awkward phrasing · errors in agreement, articles, pronouns and verb patterns.

With the growth of online shopping and internet banking, the number of online fraud and identity theft cases is increasing. This essay will discuss the problems this situation causes and some measures that can protect people.

The most obvious problem is that people lose their money. For example, a criminal can steal someone's bank details from a fake website and then use them to buy things or take money from the account. Some victims lose all their savings and it is very difficult to get it back. Another problem is stress. When someone's identity is stolen, criminals can open new accounts or take loans in their name, and the victim have to spend months to solve the problem with banks and police. Also, because of these crimes, many people especially older people are afraid to use the internet, so they cannot enjoy the benefits of online services.

There are several measures that can be taken. First of all, banks and online shops should use stronger security, for example sending a code to the customer's phone every time they make a payment. Secondly, people need to be more careful. They should not click on links in strange emails, and they should use different password for different websites. The government and banks can teach people about these dangers through advertisements and short courses, especially for elderly people. Finally, the police need more special officers who understand technology, so they can catch the criminals and punish them strongly.

In conclusion, online fraud cause financial loss, stress and fear of using internet. I believe that better security, public education and stronger police action can help to protect people from this crime.

Band 7

286 words

Clear position · financial and personal problems extended with explanation · measures grouped logically by responsibility · good topic vocabulary (two-factor authentication, cybercrime units) · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

As more people rely on the internet for shopping and banking, criminals have found increasingly sophisticated ways to steal money and personal data. This essay will discuss the main problems created by online fraud and identity theft and suggest measures that could offer better protection.

The most direct consequence is financial loss. Victims may find that money has been taken from their accounts or that purchases have been made using their card details, and although banks sometimes refund these losses, this is not always the case, especially when the customer has been tricked into authorising a payment themselves. Identity theft can be even more damaging, since criminals may use stolen personal information to open accounts or take

out loans in the victim's name, which can harm their credit record for years. Beyond the financial harm, these crimes causes considerable anxiety, and some people, particularly the elderly, may lose confidence in using online services altogether.

Protecting the public requires action from businesses, governments and individuals. Banks and online retailers should continue to strengthen security, for instance through two-factor authentication and systems that detect unusual spending patterns and block suspicious transactions. At the same time, awareness campaigns are essential, because many scams succeed not by breaking technology but by deceiving people. Teaching users to recognise fake emails, avoid sharing passwords and check website addresses would prevent a large number of crimes. Governments, meanwhile, should ensure that police forces have specialist cybercrime units and should cooperate internationally, as many fraudsters operate from other countries.

In conclusion, online fraud and identity theft lead to financial losses, long-term difficulties and a loss of trust in digital services. Stronger security, better public awareness and effective law enforcement together offer the best protection.

Band 8

313 words

Sufficiently addresses both parts with well-developed ideas at personal and societal levels · solutions tied logically to the nature of the problem · wide, precise vocabulary (insidious, anomalous transactions) · virtually error-free complex structures.

The convenience of online shopping and banking has come at a price: as more of our financial lives move onto digital platforms, fraudsters and identity thieves have found ever more opportunities to exploit them. The resulting harm extends well beyond individual losses, and countering it requires coordinated effort from institutions, governments and users themselves.

The immediate damage is financial. Victims may see their savings drained or discover purchases made with cloned card details, and while banks often reimburse unauthorised transactions, those who were manipulated into making a payment themselves may receive nothing. Identity theft can be more insidious still. Using stolen personal information, criminals can open accounts, apply for credit or commit further offences in another person's name, leaving the victim to spend months restoring their financial reputation. The psychological toll is also significant; many victims describe feelings of violation and shame, and some withdraw from online services entirely. At a societal level, widespread fraud erodes trust in digital commerce and imposes substantial costs on businesses, which are ultimately passed on to consumers.

Because modern fraud targets both systems and people, protection must address both. Financial institutions should adopt robust authentication, such as one-time codes and biometric checks, alongside monitoring systems that flag anomalous transactions in real time. Regulators can reinforce this by requiring companies to meet minimum security standards and to compensate customers fairly when those standards fail. Yet technology alone cannot stop a victim from being persuaded to hand over details voluntarily. Sustained public education, particularly aimed at older and less experienced users, is therefore vital in teaching people to recognise phishing messages and pressure tactics. Finally, since many fraud networks operate across borders, police forces need specialist expertise and effective international cooperation to pursue offenders.

In conclusion, online fraud inflicts financial, psychological and economic damage. Combining secure technology, sensible regulation, public awareness and international enforcement offers the most credible defence.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

False information online

Topic: Social media · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_11

False information can now spread very quickly through social media. What problems does this cause, and what can be done to reduce the spread of false information?

Band 6

277 words

Addresses both problems and solutions · relevant points with simple examples and limited depth · clear but mechanical organisation · adequate vocabulary · several errors in word form, pronoun reference and articles.

Nowadays, false information, or fake news, can spread very fast on social media. This situation causes many problems for people and society. In this essay I will explain these problems and suggest some ways to reduce it.

The first problem is that people can make wrong decisions. For example, during a health crisis, some people read false information online about medicines and they believe it, so they do not follow the advice of doctors. This can be very dangerous for their health. Another problem is that fake news can make people angry with each other. Sometimes a false story about a group of people or a politician is shared thousands of times, and people start to hate each other without knowing the truth. As a result, the society becomes more divided. Also, when there is so much false information, people do not know what to believe and they stop trusting even the real news.

There are some ways to solve this problem. Firstly, social media companies should check the posts more carefully and remove false information quickly. They can use technology and also employ more people to do this job. Secondly, schools should teach students how to check if information is true or not, for example by looking at the source and comparing it with other websites. Thirdly, people themselves need to be responsible. Before they share something, they should think carefully if it is true or it is only a rumour.

In conclusion, false information on social media can cause dangerous decisions, conflict and lack of trust. I believe that social media companies, schools and users must work together to stop the spreading of fake news.

Band 7

297 words

Clear position throughout · three problems extended with consequences · solutions balanced across platforms, schools and users · good cohesion and collocation (social harmony, media literacy) · one minor agreement slip.

The rise of social media has transformed the way news is shared, but it has also allowed false information to reach millions of people within hours. This essay will examine the problems this causes and suggest several measures that could limit the spread of misleading content.

One serious problem is the risk to public health and safety. When false claims about medical treatments or vaccines circulate widely, some people may ignore professional advice and make decisions that endanger themselves and others. False information can also damage social harmony. Rumours that target particular communities or individuals can provoke anger and, in extreme cases, violence, while misleading political content can influence how people vote. Perhaps most worrying in the long term is the loss of trust. When people are constantly exposed to contradictory claims, they may begin to doubt all sources of information, including

reliable journalism and official advice, which makes it harder for societies to respond to real crises.

Reducing the spread of false information requires a combination of approaches. Social media platforms have a clear responsibility, and they should invest more in detecting and labelling misleading posts, as well as reducing the visibility of accounts that repeatedly share false content. However, platforms cannot solve the problem on their own. Education is perhaps the most sustainable solution, and schools should teach media literacy so that young people learn to question sources, check facts and recognise manipulated images. Independent fact-checking organisations also play an important role and deserves greater support. Finally, individuals should develop the habit of pausing before sharing content, particularly when it provokes a strong emotional reaction.

In conclusion, false information on social media endangers health, divides communities and undermines trust. Responsible platforms, media literacy education and careful individual behaviour are all needed to reduce its spread.

Band 8

329 words

Both parts fully addressed with extended, well-reasoned ideas · solutions linked to the causes of spread and qualified sensibly · skilful cohesion · precise vocabulary (corrosive, scapegoat, amplify) · wide range of accurate structures.

Social media has made it possible for a rumour posted in one country to reach millions of screens worldwide before any journalist has had the chance to verify it. The speed and scale at which falsehoods now travel create problems that go well beyond individual misunderstanding, and tackling them requires action on several fronts.

The most immediate danger concerns decisions that affect health and safety. False claims about miracle cures or the risks of established treatments can lead people to reject sound medical advice, with consequences not only for themselves but for those around them. Misinformation also has a corrosive effect on social cohesion. Fabricated stories that scapegoat minority groups can inflame hostility, and online rumours have at times been followed by real-world violence. In the political sphere, deliberately misleading content can distort public debate and undermine confidence in elections. Underlying all of these is a gradual erosion of trust: when accurate and inaccurate information circulate side by side, many people become cynical about every source, making it harder for legitimate institutions to communicate during genuine emergencies.

Since the problem stems partly from how platforms are designed, the companies behind them must bear much of the responsibility. Algorithms that reward engagement tend to amplify sensational content, so platforms should adjust them to reduce the reach of material flagged as false and invest in faster moderation. Transparent labelling, linking disputed claims to reliable sources, can also help users judge what they read. Regulation may be needed to ensure these commitments are honoured, though it must be carefully framed to avoid restricting legitimate expression. In the longer term, the most durable defence is a public able to evaluate information critically. Media literacy should be embedded in school curricula, teaching students to check sources, recognise manipulated images and notice when content is designed to provoke outrage.

In conclusion, misinformation threatens health, social cohesion and trust in institutions. Better platform design, careful regulation and widespread media literacy together offer the most effective response.

☐ Approved	☐ Needs changes	Notes:
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Protecting minority languages

Topic: Culture · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_12

Many minority languages are disappearing because fewer young people are learning to speak them. What problems does this cause, and what can be done to protect these languages?

Band 6

288 words

Relevant problems and solutions presented · ideas stated more than explained · basic sequencing (Firstly, Secondly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · several errors in agreement, adverb form and articles that do not block meaning.

In many parts of the world, minority languages are disappearing because young people prefer to learn and speak the main language of their country or English. This essay will discuss the problems caused by this situation and what can be done to protect these languages.

The main problem is that culture is lost. Every language has its own songs, stories and traditions, and when nobody speak the language any more, these things also disappear. For example, old people in a village may know many traditional stories, but if their grandchildren cannot understand the language, the stories will not be passed to the next generation. Another problem is the relationship between generations. Sometimes grandparents only speak the minority language well, while the children only speak the national language, so they cannot communicate good with each other. In addition, young people may lose their sense of identity and feel that they do not belong to their community.

There are several things that can be done to protect these languages. Firstly, the government should support schools to teach the minority language, at least as one subject, so children can learn it from young age. Secondly, parents should speak the language at home with their children, because this is the most natural way to learn. Also, it is important to record the language, for example by making dictionaries, books and videos, so it will not be forgotten. Finally, media such as TV programmes and websites in the minority language can make it more attractive to young people.

In conclusion, the loss of minority languages causes the loss of culture and problems between the generations. I think the government, schools and families should work together to keep these languages alive for the future.

Band 7

311 words

Clear position · cultural, family and identity problems extended with explanation · range of practical measures well organised · good vocabulary (oral literature, bilingual education) · frequent error-free sentences, one preposition slip.

Across the world, many minority languages are in decline as younger generations increasingly adopt the dominant national language or a global language such as English. This essay will discuss the problems that result from this trend and suggest ways in which these languages could be protected.

The most significant loss is cultural. A language is not simply a means of communication; it carries a community's history, oral literature, songs and ways of seeing the world, many of which cannot be fully translated. When the last fluent speakers die, much of this knowledge disappears with them. Language loss can also weaken family and community bonds. In some

households, grandparents who are most comfortable in the minority language struggle to have meaningful conversations with grandchildren who speak only the majority language, which creates a sense of distance between generations. Furthermore, young people who lose touch with their ancestral language may feel disconnected with their heritage and identity.

Several measures could help to reverse this decline. Governments can give minority languages official recognition and fund their teaching in schools, ideally through bilingual education in areas where they are traditionally spoken. Parents also play a crucial role, since children who hear a language at home from an early age are far more likely to become fluent speakers. In addition, making the language visible and relevant in modern life is important. If young people can find music, television programmes, apps and social media content in their heritage language, they are more likely to see it as something living rather than old-fashioned. Finally, linguists and communities should work together to record elderly speakers, creating an archive that can support future learning.

In conclusion, the disappearance of minority languages leads to cultural loss and a weakening of identity and family ties. Through education, family commitment and modern media, these languages can be given a better chance of survival.

Band 8

330 words

Both parts sufficiently addressed with extended, insightful support · measures evaluated rather than simply listed · well-managed paragraphing · wide, precise vocabulary (resists translation, immersion schooling) · wide range of accurate structures.

Many of the world's minority languages may fall silent within a generation or two, largely because children are no longer acquiring them. The disappearance of such a language is not merely a technical loss; it has cultural, social and personal consequences, and while reversing the decline is difficult, it is by no means impossible.

At the broadest level, each language represents a unique store of human knowledge. Oral histories, poetry, traditional understanding of the local environment and distinctive ways of categorising experience are embedded in vocabulary and grammar, and much of this resists translation. When a language dies, this heritage is largely lost not only to its community but to humanity as a whole. The consequences are also felt within families. Where grandparents are most at ease in the heritage language and grandchildren speak only the dominant one, conversations may be reduced to practical exchanges, weakening the transmission of values and memories between generations. For young people themselves, losing an ancestral language can mean losing a vital link to their identity, sometimes leaving them feeling that they belong fully to neither their own community nor the wider society.

Efforts to protect endangered languages are most effective when they combine institutional support with community ownership. Official recognition and funding for bilingual or immersion schooling can give children fluency at the age when language is most easily acquired. However, schooling alone rarely succeeds unless the language is also spoken at home, so programmes that support parents are equally important. A language also needs a modern presence if young people are to value it: broadcasting, digital content and music in the language signal that it belongs to the present rather than the past. Finally, documentation through recordings, dictionaries and grammars provides a foundation for revival should the number of speakers fall further.

In conclusion, the decline of minority languages erodes cultural knowledge, family bonds and personal identity. Sustained investment in education, family use and contemporary media can

give these languages a genuine future.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Switching off from work

Topic: Work-life balance · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_problem_13

Many employees work long hours and find it difficult to stop thinking about work in their free time. What problems does this cause for individuals and their families, and what solutions can you suggest?

Band 6

279 words

Problems for individuals and families plus solutions all addressed · ideas relevant but general · clear paragraphing with mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary with awkward phrasing · errors in adverbs, agreement and word form.

Nowadays, many people work very long hours, and even when they go home, they continue to think about their work. This situation creates problems for these workers and also for their families. In this essay I will discuss these problems and suggest some solutions.

The first problem is for the health of the workers. When people work too much and do not rest, they feel stressed and tired all the time. Some of them cannot sleep good at night because they are worrying about their tasks for the next day. After a long time, this can cause serious illness such as depression or heart problems. The second problem is for the family. If parents come home late and always check their emails, they do not have time to play with their children or to talk to their partner. Children may feel that their parents does not care about them, and couples can have more arguments.

There are some solutions for this problem. Firstly, companies should not expect workers to answer emails or phone calls after working hours. Secondly, employers can give more flexible hours, so that people can finish work earlier or work from home some days. Thirdly, workers themselves should learn to relax, for example by doing sport, having hobbies or switching off their phones in the evening. It is also important that they plan their free time with their family, like having dinner together everyday.

In conclusion, long working hours and thinking about work all the time cause stress and health problems, and it also damage family relationships. I believe that both companies and workers should take action to have a better balance between work and life.

Band 7

308 words

Clear position · effects on individuals and families extended and supported · solutions from employers and individuals logically presented · good collocation (switch off, set firmer boundaries) · one preposition slip.

In today's competitive working environment, many employees put in long hours and find it hard to switch off from work, even at weekends. This essay will discuss the effects of this on individuals and their families and propose some possible solutions.

For individuals, the most serious consequence is the damage to their physical and mental health. Working long hours without proper rest leads to chronic stress and fatigue, and people who constantly think about unfinished tasks often have trouble sleeping. Over time, this can result in burnout, anxiety and even conditions such as high blood pressure. Ironically, overwork can also reduce productivity, as exhausted employees make more mistakes and find it harder to concentrate. The effects on family life are equally significant. Parents who arrive home late and spend the evening answering emails have little time or energy left for their children, who may miss out attention and guidance. Partners, too, may feel neglected, and tension over work

commitments is a common source of conflict in relationships.

There are several ways in which this situation could be improved. Employers should take the lead by making it clear that staff are not required to respond to messages outside working hours, and some governments have even introduced a legal right to disconnect. Flexible working arrangements, including remote work and adjustable start times, could also help employees to fit their jobs around family responsibilities. On a personal level, individuals can set firmer boundaries, such as turning off work notifications in the evening and scheduling regular time for exercise and family activities. Managers should also lead by example, because staff are unlikely to switch off if their boss sends emails at midnight.

In conclusion, excessive working hours harm people's health and put pressure on family relationships. Supportive workplace policies, combined with healthier personal habits, would help employees achieve a more sustainable balance.

Band 8

323 words

All parts fully addressed with well-developed, perceptive ideas · solutions qualified and prioritised · skilful cohesion and paragraphing · natural, precise vocabulary (detachment, squeezed out, breed resentment) · error-free range of structures.

For a growing number of employees, work no longer ends when they leave the office. Long hours, combined with smartphones that keep them permanently reachable, mean that professional concerns now spill into evenings, weekends and holidays. This essay examines the toll this takes on individuals and their families, and suggests how a healthier balance might be restored.

For the individual, the absence of genuine recovery time is profoundly harmful. The mind needs periods of detachment to recover from sustained effort, and when these are lost, stress accumulates into chronic exhaustion and, eventually, burnout. Disrupted sleep is a common early sign, as people lie awake rehearsing tomorrow's deadlines. Paradoxically, the pattern is also counterproductive for employers, since fatigued staff tend to be less creative, more error-prone and more likely to take sick leave or resign. The impact on families can be just as damaging. Children whose parents are physically present but mentally preoccupied may feel that they come second to a screen, and the everyday rituals that sustain family life, from shared meals to bedtime conversations, are gradually squeezed out. Between partners, an unequal burden of household responsibilities can breed resentment.

Addressing the problem requires change at both organisational and personal levels. Employers can set explicit policies discouraging out-of-hours communication, and several countries have legislated a right to disconnect, giving employees legal protection when they choose not to respond. Realistic workloads matter just as much, because a ban on evening emails achieves little if the volume of work cannot be completed within normal hours. Leadership culture is decisive here: when senior staff visibly protect their own time, others feel permitted to do the same. Individuals, in turn, can create clear boundaries, such as disabling work notifications and reserving certain times for family and leisure.

In conclusion, overwork undermines health, productivity and family relationships. Sensible workplace policy, backed by leaders who model balance and individuals who guard their personal time, offers the most realistic solution.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Ageing rural communities

Topic: Population · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_problem_14

In many rural areas, young people are leaving to live in cities, leaving behind an increasingly elderly population. What problems does this cause for rural communities, and what can be done to solve them?

Band 6

280 words

Both parts addressed with relevant problems and solutions · explanation is limited and conclusion rather general · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement, article and plural errors that do not block meaning.

In many countries, young people are moving from villages to cities to study or to find better jobs, and only old people stay in the countryside. This situation causes several problems for rural communities, and in this essay I will discuss them and suggest some solutions.

The first problem is the economy. When young people leave, there are not enough workers for farms and local business, so many of them have to close. For example, a village shop or a small factory cannot continue if there is no customers or employees. Another problem is that the elderly people need more care, but there is nobody to look after them. Their children live far away in the city, and often there are not enough doctors and nurses in rural area. Also, services like schools, banks and bus routes are closed because there are not enough people to use them, and this make life even more difficult for the ones who stay.

There are some solutions for these problems. Firstly, the government should create more jobs in the countryside, for example by giving money to companies which open offices or factories there. Secondly, it is important to have fast internet in the villages, because then young people can work online from home and they do not need to move away. In addition, the government can improve health services for old people, like mobile clinics which visit different villages every week.

In conclusion, when young people move to cities, rural areas suffer from economic problems and poor care for the elderly. I believe that with more jobs, better internet and better services, the countryside can become a good place for young people again.

Band 7

312 words

Clear position · three problems extended, including a cycle of decline · solutions address both young people and elderly residents · good cohesion and vocabulary (outflow, connectivity) · one agreement slip.

In many parts of the world, rural areas are experiencing a steady outflow of young people who move to cities in search of education, jobs and a more exciting lifestyle. As a result, many villages are left with an ageing population, which creates serious difficulties. This essay will outline these problems and suggest some possible solutions.

The most immediate problem is economic decline. When young adults leave, local farms and businesses lose both workers and customers, and many are eventually forced to close. This in turn makes the area even less attractive to newcomers, creating a cycle of decline. A second problem concerns the care of the elderly. Older residents often need more medical support, yet rural areas typically has fewer doctors and hospitals, and the relatives who might once have cared for them now live far away. Finally, as the population falls, services such as schools, post offices and public transport become harder to justify financially and are often withdrawn,

leaving remaining residents increasingly isolated.

Tackling these issues requires making rural areas places where young people can build a future. Investment in high-speed broadband is particularly important, since it would allow people to work remotely for city-based employers while living in the countryside. Governments could also offer incentives, such as tax reductions or grants, to businesses that set up in rural regions, and support young farmers with loans and training. At the same time, services for the elderly must be adapted to rural conditions. Mobile health clinics, online consultations and community transport schemes could ensure that older residents receive care without long journeys. Encouraging volunteer networks within villages would also help to reduce isolation.

In conclusion, the migration of young people to cities leaves rural communities facing economic decline, pressure on elderly care and the loss of services. Better connectivity, economic incentives and adapted services could help to reverse this trend.

Band 8

316 words

Both parts sufficiently addressed with well-developed, interconnected ideas · solutions clearly matched to problems · skilful cohesion · precise vocabulary (self-reinforcing, exodus, social fabric) · wide range of accurate structures.

Across many countries, the countryside is emptying of its young. Drawn by universities, better-paid work and the amenities of urban life, school leavers and young adults depart in large numbers, and relatively few return. The communities they leave behind grow steadily older, facing a combination of economic, social and practical difficulties that call for deliberate intervention.

The economic consequences are often the first to appear. Farms struggle to find successors and seasonal labour, while shops and small firms lose both staff and customers. Each closure makes the area less appealing to potential residents, so decline tends to become self-reinforcing. Demographic ageing then compounds the problem. Older residents typically require more health and social care, yet rural areas are already poorly served by doctors and hospitals, and the adult children who might once have provided informal support now live hours away. As numbers fall further, schools, bank branches and bus routes are withdrawn on grounds of cost, leaving those who remain, particularly people who no longer drive, isolated and dependent.

Reversing this trend requires giving young people genuine reasons to stay or return. The most powerful lever is probably digital infrastructure: reliable high-speed broadband makes remote work viable, allowing professionals to hold city-based jobs while living rurally. Targeted incentives, such as grants for rural start-ups, affordable housing reserved for local families and support for young farmers, can reinforce this. Services, meanwhile, must be redesigned rather than simply withdrawn. Remote consultations, visiting clinics and shared community hubs that combine a post office, café and health point can maintain access at a sustainable cost. Intergenerational initiatives, such as young volunteers assisting older neighbours, can also strengthen the social fabric.

In conclusion, the exodus of young people leaves rural communities economically fragile, short of care and increasingly isolated. With investment in connectivity, targeted incentives and imaginative service provision, the countryside can once again offer a viable future to the young.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

The brain drain

Topic: International development · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_problem_15

Many developing countries are losing skilled professionals, such as doctors and engineers, who move to work in wealthier countries. What problems does this cause for developing countries, and what can be done about it?

Band 6

291 words

Addresses problems and solutions with relevant ideas · limited development and some repetition · list-like linking (First, Second, Third) · adequate vocabulary · repeated subject-verb agreement errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, many skilled workers like doctors and engineers leave developing countries to work in rich countries, because they can earn more money and have better conditions. This is often called brain drain. In this essay I will discuss the problems this cause for developing countries and suggest some solutions.

The biggest problem is that there are not enough professionals in the home country. For example, if many doctors move abroad, the hospitals in poor countries do not have enough staff, and patients must wait a long time or cannot get treatment at all. This is very serious in the countryside. Another problem is that the government lose the money which it spent on education. In many developing countries, university is free or cheap, so the country pay for training these doctors and engineers, but another country get the benefit. Also, without engineers and scientists, it is difficult for the country to develop new industries and improve the economy.

There are some ways to solve this problem. First, the government should increase the salaries and improve working conditions for professionals, so they will want to stay. For instance, hospitals need modern equipment and doctors should not work too many hours. Second, students who receive free education could be asked to work in their own country for some years after they graduate. Third, the government can encourage people who went abroad to come back, by giving them good jobs or other benefits. Finally, wealthy countries also have responsibility, and they should not take too many workers from poor countries.

In conclusion, brain drain causes a shortage of skilled workers, a waste of money and slower development. I think that developing countries should give professionals better conditions and reasons to stay in their homeland.

Band 7

309 words

Clear position throughout · problems in health, development and finance extended · solutions at national and international level · good vocabulary (underserved, recruit ethically) · mostly accurate with one agreement slip.

In recent decades, large numbers of highly trained professionals, including doctors, nurses and engineers, have left developing countries to work in wealthier nations, attracted by higher salaries and better working conditions. This so-called brain drain has serious consequences for the countries they leave behind, but there are measures that could reduce its impact.

The most obvious problem is a shortage of skilled staff in essential sectors. When doctors and nurses emigrate, hospitals and clinics in their home countries struggle to provide adequate care, and rural areas, which are already underserved, are usually the worst affected. The

departure of engineers and scientists similarly slows the development of infrastructure and new industries. In addition, brain drain represents a significant financial loss. Governments often invest heavily in educating these professionals, only to see richer countries benefit from their skills without having paid for their training. Over time, this can widen the gap between rich and poor nations.

Addressing this problem requires both national and international action. Developing countries could make it more attractive for professionals to stay by improving pay, investing in modern equipment and offering clear career progression, since many people leave not only for money but because of poor facilities and limited opportunities. Some governments have also introduced schemes that require graduates of publicly funded courses to work in the country for a fixed period. Another approach is to encourage emigrants to return, or to share their expertise through teaching visits and online collaboration. At the same time, wealthy countries should recruit ethically, for example by avoiding active recruitment of health workers from countries facing severe shortages, and could contribute to training programmes in those countries.

In conclusion, the emigration of skilled professionals deprives developing countries of vital services and wastes public investment. Better conditions at home, return incentives and responsible recruitment by richer nations could together reduce the damage.

Band 8

312 words

Fully addresses both parts with extended, nuanced ideas · responses targeted at the root causes and qualified · skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (fiscal dimension, entrench, diaspora) · virtually error-free complex structures.

The migration of skilled professionals from developing to wealthier countries is driven by understandable personal ambitions: higher salaries, better equipment and clearer career paths. Yet the cumulative effect of these individual decisions can be severe for the countries they leave, and mitigating it requires action from both sending and receiving nations.

The most acute consequence is a shortage of expertise precisely where it is most needed. Health systems in lower-income countries, already under strain, lose doctors and nurses they can ill afford to lose, with rural populations typically suffering most as the remaining staff concentrate in cities. The departure of engineers, scientists and academics likewise weakens a country's capacity to build infrastructure, innovate and train the next generation. There is also a significant fiscal dimension. Developing countries often subsidise higher education heavily, so each departing graduate represents a public investment whose returns are enjoyed elsewhere; in effect, poorer nations end up subsidising the workforce of richer ones. Over time, this can entrench global inequality.

Since the causes are largely economic and professional, the most effective responses address working conditions rather than simply restricting movement. Improving salaries, investing in facilities and creating transparent paths to promotion can persuade many professionals that a rewarding career is possible at home. Bonding schemes, under which graduates of state-funded programmes serve domestically for a set period, can secure a return on public investment, provided they are fair rather than punitive. Governments can also cultivate their diaspora, offering incentives for return and channels through which emigrants contribute knowledge remotely. Receiving countries bear responsibility too: adhering to ethical recruitment codes and co-funding training in source countries would help ensure that migration benefits both sides.

In conclusion, the loss of skilled professionals weakens essential services, wastes public investment and deepens global inequality. A combination of better domestic conditions,

well-designed retention schemes and responsible recruitment abroad offers the most balanced solution.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

AI and job security

Topic: Artificial intelligence · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_problem_16

As artificial intelligence is used more widely in the workplace, many people are worried that their jobs will disappear. What problems might this cause, and how can governments and individuals prepare for these changes?

Band 6

279 words

Covers problems and both government and individual preparation · individual section underdeveloped · clear paragraphing with basic linking · adequate vocabulary · several errors in quantifiers, relative clauses and verb patterns.

Nowadays, artificial intelligence (AI) is used more and more in offices, factories and shops. Many people are worried that they will lose their job because computers can do their work faster and cheaper. This essay will discuss the problems this might cause and how governments and individuals can prepare.

The main problem is unemployment. If companies use AI to do tasks like answering customers, writing reports or checking documents, they will need less workers. Many people, especially who do simple and repetitive jobs, can lose their income. This can lead to poverty and stress for families. Another problem is that the gap between rich and poor may become bigger. The owners of technology companies will earn a lot of money, but normal workers will earn less or nothing. As a result, some people may feel angry and there can be problems in the society.

To prepare for these changes, governments have an important role. Firstly, they should give free training courses for adults, so workers can learn new skills, for example using technology or working in health care, where humans are still needed. Secondly, governments should support people who lose their jobs by giving them money for a period while they are looking for another job.

Individuals also need to prepare. They should keep learning during all their life and not think that their education finish at university. For example, an accountant can learn how to use AI tools, so he can work together with the technology instead to be replaced by it.

In conclusion, AI may cause unemployment and more inequality. However, if governments provide training and support, and individuals continue learning, people can adapt to these changes.

Band 7

302 words

Clear position · problems extended at personal and social level · separate, focused paragraphs for governments and individuals · good collocation (social safety nets, lifelong learning) · one agreement slip.

The rapid spread of artificial intelligence in the workplace has raised widespread concern that many jobs will soon be carried out by machines. This development could create serious problems, and both governments and individuals need to prepare for it.

The most obvious risk is job losses, particularly in roles that involve routine tasks. Customer service, data entry, basic accounting and some types of administrative work can already be partly automated, and workers in these areas may find that their skills are no longer in demand. For those affected, losing a job can mean not only financial hardship but also a loss of confidence and identity. On a wider scale, AI could increase inequality. The benefits of

automation are likely to go mainly to companies and highly skilled workers, while people in lower-paid jobs face greater insecurity, which may lead to social tension.

Governments have a key role in managing this transition. They should invest in affordable retraining programmes that allow adults to move into growing sectors, such as healthcare, green energy or technology-related work. Education systems also need to adapt, placing more emphasis on skills that machines find difficult to replicate, such as critical thinking, creativity and interpersonal communication. In addition, stronger social safety nets, including unemployment support linked to training, would help people through periods between jobs.

Individuals, meanwhile, cannot rely entirely on the state. The most important step is to adopt a habit of lifelong learning and to stay informed about how technology is affecting their industry. Rather than seeing AI purely as a threat, workers who learn to use these tools effectively are likely to become more valuable to employers, not less.

In conclusion, AI may cause unemployment and widen inequality, but with retraining, educational reform and a willingness to keep learning, societies can adapt to these changes successfully.

Band 8

316 words

All parts of the question fully addressed, with distinct roles for governments and individuals · well-developed, qualified arguments · skilful paragraphing · precise vocabulary (displacement, distributional, augmented) · wide range of error-free structures.

As artificial intelligence moves from research laboratories into everyday workplaces, anxiety about the future of employment has grown. Although new technologies have historically created new kinds of work as well as destroying old ones, the speed and breadth of AI adoption could make this transition unusually disruptive, and preparing for it is a shared responsibility of governments and individuals.

The most immediate concern is displacement. AI systems can already draft documents, analyse data and handle customer queries, which places many clerical, administrative and even some professional roles at risk. Workers whose skills become redundant in mid-career may struggle to find comparable employment, facing not only a loss of income but a loss of status and purpose. There is also a distributional problem. The gains from automation are likely to flow disproportionately to those who own the technology and to highly skilled specialists, while less qualified workers bear most of the risk, potentially widening inequality and fuelling political discontent.

Governments should focus on easing the transition rather than resisting technological change. Large-scale, accessible retraining, ideally designed with employers so that it leads to real vacancies, would help displaced workers move into expanding fields. Schools and universities need to prioritise capabilities that complement AI, such as judgement, creativity and collaboration, alongside the digital literacy needed to work with intelligent systems. A modernised safety net, linking income support to training, would give people the security to retrain rather than accept the first available job.

Individuals, for their part, can reduce their vulnerability by treating learning as a career-long process. Becoming proficient with the AI tools relevant to their field, and cultivating distinctly human strengths such as persuasion and empathy, makes workers more likely to be augmented by technology than replaced by it.

In conclusion, AI threatens displacement and greater inequality, but coordinated investment in skills and social protection, combined with personal adaptability, can make the transition far more manageable.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Less family time together

Topic: Family · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_17

In many families, parents and children spend less time together than they did in the past. What are the causes of this, and what can be done to improve the situation?

Band 6

270 words

Causes and solutions both addressed with relevant, familiar ideas · limited development · mechanical linking (Firstly, Secondly, Thirdly) · adequate but informal vocabulary (kids) · errors in agreement, articles and comparatives.

In the past, parents and children spent a lot of time together, but nowadays many families do not do this. This essay will explain the causes of this situation and what can be done to improve it.

The first cause is work. In many families, both the father and the mother have full-time jobs, and they often come home late in the evening. When they arrive, they are tired and they still have to cook and clean, so there is not much time left for their children. Another cause is technology. Even when the family is at home together, each person is busy with their own phone, tablet or computer. For example, the children play online games in their room while the parents watch videos or check emails. Also, children today has many activities after school, like extra classes and sports training, so their timetable is very busy.

There are some things that can improve this situation. Firstly, families can make some simple rules, for example no phones during dinner time. This will give them chance to talk about their day. Secondly, parents can plan activities at the weekend which everybody enjoy, such as going to the park, cooking together or visiting relatives. Thirdly, companies could help by giving more flexible working hours, so parents can come home earlier and spend time with their kids.

In conclusion, parents and children spend less time together because of long working hours, technology and busy timetables. I think if families make some rules and plan activities together, and if companies are more flexible, the relationship between parents and children will become more closer.

Band 7

299 words

Clear focus on causes and solutions · each cause explained with its effect · solutions logically grouped inside and outside the home · good vocabulary (absorbed in, unstructured time) · one article slip.

In many modern households, parents and children now share far less time together than previous generations did. This essay will examine the main reasons for this change and suggest some practical ways in which families could reconnect.

The most significant cause is the pressure of work. In many countries, it has become normal for both parents to work full-time, often with long commutes, and the expectation of being available by phone or email means that work frequently continues into the evening. As a result, parents may return home with little time or energy for their children. Children's own schedules have also become busier. Many attend extra tuition, sports clubs and music lessons after school, which leaves fewer free hours to spend with the family. Finally, digital technology has changed the way families use their time at home. Even when everyone is in the same room, each member may be absorbed in a separate screen, so being together physically does not necessarily mean interacting.

Improving the situation requires changes both inside and outside the home. Families could establish simple routines, such as eating at least one meal together each day without phones or television, which gives everyone a regular opportunity to talk. Parents might also consider reducing the number of organised activities their children attend, leaving space for unstructured time together at weekends. Employers have a part to play as well; flexible working hours and the option to work from home would allow parents to be present at key moments, such as after school. Shared hobbies, for example cycling or cooking, can also turn everyday tasks into chance for connection.

In conclusion, demanding jobs, busy schedules and technology have reduced family time. Through deliberate routines, a more balanced approach to children's activities and flexible employers, families can rebuild closer relationships.

Band 8

316 words

Causes and solutions both fully developed and clearly linked · perceptive points (physically together yet disconnected) · well-managed cohesion · precise vocabulary (blurred, overscheduled, pervasive) · wide range of error-free structures.

Many parents today would readily admit that they spend less time with their children than their own parents spent with them. This shift is not the result of indifference but of economic, social and technological pressures, and while these cannot be removed entirely, families and employers can take practical steps to counteract them.

Economic demands are perhaps the most powerful cause. In many households, two incomes are now necessary to meet housing and living costs, and both parents may face long hours and lengthy commutes. The boundary between work and home has also blurred, as smartphones allow employers to reach staff at any time, so even evenings at home can be interrupted by messages and deadlines. Children's lives, meanwhile, have become increasingly scheduled. Parents anxious to give their children every advantage enrol them in tutoring, sport and music, leaving little unstructured time in which the family can simply be together. Technology intensifies the problem within the home itself: households in which each member retreats to a personal screen may be under one roof yet largely disconnected.

Addressing this requires deliberately protecting family time rather than expecting it to occur naturally. Simple, consistent rituals, such as a shared evening meal with devices set aside, create a daily space for conversation. Parents may also benefit from questioning whether every extracurricular activity is essential, since a less crowded timetable leaves room for the spontaneous moments that children often value most. Employers, however, hold considerable influence. Flexible hours, remote working and a culture that respects time off would allow parents to be present when it matters, such as at the end of the school day. Governments can reinforce this through adequate parental leave and protection against excessive working hours.

In conclusion, long working hours, overscheduled childhoods and pervasive technology have eroded family time. Protecting it depends on conscious choices at home, supported by workplaces and policies that value family life.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Hospital waiting times

Topic: Public services · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_problem_18

In many countries, patients have to wait a long time to receive treatment in public hospitals. What are the causes of this problem, and what solutions can you suggest?

Band 6

282 words

Causes and solutions both covered with relevant points · explanations brief and some ideas listed · clear but mechanical organisation · adequate vocabulary · errors with plurals, articles and agreement that do not block meaning.

In many countries, patients must wait for weeks or even months to get treatment in public hospitals. This is a serious problem because some illnesses become worse during this time. In this essay I will discuss the causes of this problem and suggest some solutions.

The main cause is that there are not enough doctors and nurses. In some countries, many medical staff leave public hospitals to work in private clinics or abroad, because the salary is higher. So the remaining staffs have too many patients to treat. Another cause is that the population is getting older. Old people often have more health problems, so they need to visit hospital more often, and this increase the number of patients. In addition, some public hospitals do not have enough money to buy modern equipment or build more rooms, so they cannot treat many patients at the same time. Finally, sometimes people go to hospital for small problems which a local doctor could treat.

There are several solutions to this problem. First, the government should spend more money on public health, to build new hospitals and buy equipment. Second, it is important to train more doctors and nurses and pay them better salary, so they want to stay in public hospitals. Also, the government can open more small clinics in local areas, so people with minor illness can go there instead of the hospital. This will reduce the pressure on big hospitals.

In conclusion, long waiting times are caused by a shortage of staff, an ageing population and lack of money. I think the government should invest more in health care and train more staff, because health is the most important thing for people.

Band 7

302 words

Clear position · causes explained with supporting detail, including bed shortages · solutions matched to causes · good collocation (primary care, free up beds) · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

Long waiting lists have become a familiar feature of public healthcare in many countries, with patients sometimes waiting months for operations or specialist appointments. This essay will examine the main causes of these delays and propose several possible solutions.

One of the key causes is a shortage of medical staff. Training a doctor takes many years, and in some countries public hospitals struggle to keep qualified staff, who may be attracted by the higher salaries offered in private clinics or abroad. Demand for treatment, meanwhile, have risen steadily. Populations are ageing, and older people are more likely to suffer from long-term conditions that require regular care. A further cause is inefficient use of existing resources. In many systems, hospital beds are occupied by elderly patients who are well enough to leave but cannot be discharged because there is no suitable care available at home, which means fewer beds for new patients. Emergency departments are also overloaded by people with minor complaints that could be treated elsewhere.

To reduce waiting times, governments should first invest in the workforce by funding more training places and improving pay and conditions so that staff remain in the public sector. Secondly, strengthening primary care would ease the pressure on hospitals. If local clinics and pharmacies were better equipped to deal with minor illnesses, fewer patients would need hospital treatment. Improving social care is equally important, as it would allow patients who no longer need medical attention to leave hospital sooner and free up beds. Finally, hospitals could make better use of technology, such as online booking systems and remote consultations, to organise appointments more efficiently.

In conclusion, long waiting times result from staff shortages, rising demand and inefficient use of resources. Investment in staff, stronger primary and social care and smarter organisation could significantly shorten these delays.

Band 8

313 words

Causes and solutions fully addressed with a clear analytical frame (demand versus capacity) · logically sequenced, well-extended ideas · precise vocabulary (bottlenecks, throughput, patient flow) · wide range of accurate structures.

In many countries with publicly funded healthcare, lengthy waiting lists have become one of the most visible signs of a system under strain. Patients may wait months for diagnostic tests or surgery, sometimes seeing their condition deteriorate in the meantime. The causes are several and interrelated, and so are the solutions.

At the heart of the problem is a mismatch between rising demand and constrained capacity. Ageing populations mean that more people are living with chronic conditions requiring ongoing treatment, while advances in medicine have expanded the range of procedures that can be offered. Capacity, by contrast, has not kept pace. Medical staff take years to train, and public hospitals often lose experienced doctors and nurses to better-paid private practice or to other countries, leaving those who remain overstretched. Inefficiencies elsewhere in the system compound these shortages. When adequate social care is unavailable, patients who are medically fit to leave hospital occupy beds for days or weeks, creating bottlenecks that ripple back through wards and emergency departments. Similarly, weak primary care means that many conditions which could be managed in the community end up in hospital.

The most sustainable response is to expand and retain the workforce, which means increasing training places while improving pay, working conditions and career development in the public sector. Staffing alone will not suffice, however, unless patient flow is improved. Investing in social care would allow timely discharge, and strengthening local clinics would intercept minor complaints before they reach hospital. Hospitals can also increase throughput by separating planned surgery from emergency services, so that routine operations are not cancelled whenever emergency admissions surge. Digital scheduling and remote follow-up appointments offer further gains in efficiency.

In conclusion, long waits stem from rising demand, workforce shortages and bottlenecks elsewhere in the system. Addressing them requires sustained investment in staff alongside reforms that allow patients to move through care more smoothly.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Debt from buying on credit

Topic: Money and consumer behaviour · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_19

Many people get into debt because they buy goods on credit that they cannot really afford. What problems does this cause, and what can be done to prevent it?

Band 6

280 words

Problems and prevention both addressed · relevant ideas with simple explanation · clear paragraphs, basic sequencing · adequate vocabulary with some repetition (problem) · agreement, word-form and verb-pattern errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, it is very easy to buy things on credit, for example with a credit card or by paying in instalments. However, many people buy products which they cannot really afford, and they get into debt. This essay will discuss the problems this causes and what can be done to prevent it.

The first problem is financial. When people cannot pay back the money, the interest become higher and higher, so the debt grows very fast. Some people have to borrow more money to pay the old debt, and they cannot escape from this situation. The second problem is stress. People who have big debts are always worried about money, and this can affect their health and their sleep. It can also cause arguments in the family, and in some cases couples even get divorce because of money problems. Moreover, if a person does not pay, the bank can take their house or car, and they may lose everything.

There are several ways to prevent this problem. Firstly, schools should teach children how to manage money, for example how to make a budget and how interest work. If young people learn this early, they will make better decisions in the future. Secondly, banks and shops should check carefully if a customer can pay back before they give them credit. The government can make stricter laws about this. Also, people themselves should think carefully before buying something expensive and ask themselves if they really need it.

In conclusion, buying on credit can lead to growing debt, stress and family problems. I believe that financial education, stricter rules for banks and more careful spending can help people to avoid get into debt.

Band 7

310 words

Clear position throughout · financial, psychological and economic problems extended · prevention measures specific and relevant · good collocation (credit record, small print) · one preposition slip.

Credit cards, store finance and buy-now-pay-later schemes have made it easier than ever to purchase goods without having the money upfront. As a result, many people take on debts they are unable to repay. This essay will discuss the problems this creates and suggest some ways of preventing it.

The most immediate problem is financial difficulty for the borrower. High interest rates mean that a relatively small purchase can turn into a much larger debt if repayments are missed, and some people end up taking out new loans simply to cover existing ones. This can damage their credit record, making it harder to rent a flat or obtain a mortgage in the future. Debt also has a serious psychological cost. People struggling with repayments often experience constant anxiety, which can affect their sleep, their work performance and their relationships. Money worries are a common cause for family conflict, and children in these households may also feel the pressure. At a wider level, widespread personal debt can make an economy more

vulnerable during a recession.

Preventing this problem requires both education and regulation. Financial literacy should be taught in schools so that young people understand how interest works and learn to budget before they receive their first credit card. Governments should also require lenders to carry out proper checks on whether customers can realistically afford repayments, and to present the total cost of credit clearly rather than hiding it in small print. Buy-now-pay-later services, which are often marketed at young consumers, should be regulated in the same way as other forms of borrowing. Finally, free debt advice services can help people who are already struggling before their situation gets out of control.

In conclusion, buying on credit can lead to spiralling debt, stress and family tension. Better financial education, responsible lending rules and accessible advice could help to prevent these problems.

Band 8

317 words

Both parts sufficiently addressed with extended, well-supported ideas · prevention argued in stages, noting the limits of education · skilful cohesion · precise vocabulary (service existing debts, affordability checks) · error-free range of structures.

Access to credit has never been easier. Credit cards, retail finance and instant buy-now-pay-later options allow consumers to acquire goods at the touch of a button, often without fully registering what they will eventually pay. For those who borrow beyond their means, the consequences can be severe, and preventing them requires action from educators, lenders and regulators alike.

The most direct harm is the way debt can escalate. High interest and penalty charges mean that modest purchases can grow into substantial obligations, and borrowers who fall behind may resort to further borrowing to service existing debts, entering a cycle from which escape is difficult. A poor credit history can then restrict access to housing and affordable loans for years. The personal toll extends well beyond finances. Persistent money worries are closely associated with anxiety, sleep problems and depression, and financial strain is a frequent source of tension between partners that affects children as well. On a societal scale, high levels of household debt leave economies more fragile, since heavily indebted consumers cut spending sharply when conditions deteriorate.

Prevention should begin with education. Teaching financial literacy in schools, covering budgeting, compound interest and the true cost of borrowing, equips young people to make informed decisions before they are targeted by lenders. Education alone, however, cannot counter marketing designed to make borrowing feel effortless. Regulators should therefore require rigorous affordability checks, clear disclosure of the total repayable amount and limits on excessive charges, and should bring newer forms of short-term credit under the same rules as conventional loans. Retailers could also be discouraged from presenting finance as the default option at checkout. Finally, free and impartial debt advice helps those already in difficulty to act before their situation worsens.

In conclusion, unaffordable credit can trap people in escalating debt, damage their wellbeing and weaken the wider economy. Financial education, combined with responsible lending rules, offers the most effective safeguard.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Why small businesses fail

Topic: Business · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_problem_20

A large number of small businesses fail within the first few years of opening. What are the reasons for this, and what can be done to help small businesses succeed?

Band 6

282 words

Reasons and help both addressed with relevant ideas · points are listed with brief support · mechanical linking and repetition (money, lack of) · adequate vocabulary · errors in comparatives, countability, agreement and word form.

Many people dream about starting their own business, but a lot of small businesses close after only a few years. This essay will discuss the reasons for this and suggest what can be done to help them to be successful.

The main reason is money. Small businesses often do not have enough money at the beginning, and they need to pay rent, salaries and other costs before they earn any profit. If they have few customers in the first months, they can quickly run out of money. Another reason is lack of experience. Many owners are good at their skill, for example cooking or repairing cars, but they do not know how to manage a business, such as marketing or controlling the budget. Also, the competition is very strong. Small shops must compete with big companies and online stores which can sell the same products more cheaper.

There are several things that can help small businesses. Firstly, the government can give loans with low interest to new businesses, or reduce the taxes for the first few years. This will give them more time to grow. Secondly, there should be free courses and advices for new business owners, where they can learn how to write a business plan and how to manage money. Thirdly, local people can support small business by buying from them instead of big companies. Finally, owners should research the market carefully before they open, to make sure there is enough customers for their product.

In conclusion, small businesses fail because of lack of money, lack of experience and strong competition. However, with support from the government and local community, and more careful planning, more of them can be success.

Band 7

309 words

Clear position · three reasons developed with examples · solutions from government, councils and owners · good topic vocabulary (capital, mentoring schemes, buy in bulk) · frequent error-free sentences with one verb-pattern slip.

Although many people are keen to start their own businesses, a large proportion of new small firms close within their first few years. This essay will consider the main reasons for this high failure rate and suggest some measures that could help these businesses survive.

A lack of sufficient funding is often the most important factor. Many new businesses underestimate how long it will take to become profitable, and while they are building a customer base, they must still pay for rent, stock, wages and equipment. Without enough capital to cover this period, even a promising business can run out of cash. Another common problem is limited management experience. Owners may be skilled in their trade, such as baking or web design, but have little knowledge of accounting, marketing or pricing, which leads to costly mistakes. In addition, small businesses face intense competition from large

companies and online retailers, which can offer lower prices because they buy in bulk.

Several measures could improve the chances of success. Governments and banks could make affordable finance more accessible, for example through low-interest start-up loans or temporary reductions in business taxes during the first years of trading. Equally important is practical support. Free business training, mentoring schemes that pair new owners with experienced entrepreneurs and advice on writing realistic business plans would help founders avoiding common errors. Small firms can also compete more effectively by focusing on what large companies cannot offer, such as personal service, local knowledge or specialised products, and by using social media to reach customers cheaply. Finally, local councils could support independent shops by keeping town centre rents and parking charges reasonable.

In conclusion, small businesses often fail because of insufficient funding, inexperience and strong competition. Better access to finance, practical guidance and a clear focus on their unique strengths would help many more of them to succeed.

Band 8

321 words

Reasons and support fully developed and directly matched · well-sequenced paragraphs with skilful cohesion · precise vocabulary (business acumen, cash-flow crisis, undercut) · wide range of complex structures, error-free.

Opening a small business is, for many people, the realisation of a long-held ambition, yet a considerable share of new ventures close within a few years. Their failure rarely has a single cause; rather, it usually reflects a combination of financial fragility, gaps in expertise and a difficult competitive environment, each of which can be addressed.

Financial weakness is the most common underlying factor. Founders frequently underestimate both their start-up costs and the time needed to reach profitability, so that fixed expenses such as rent, wages and loan repayments consume their capital before revenue has had a chance to build. Late payments from larger clients can then create a cash-flow crisis even for a business that is fundamentally viable. A second factor is the gap between technical skill and business acumen. An excellent chef or designer may have little experience of pricing, bookkeeping or marketing, and misjudgements in these areas can prove fatal. Finally, small firms operate at a structural disadvantage against large chains and online platforms, whose purchasing power allows them to undercut prices, while high commercial rents in many town centres add to the pressure.

Support is therefore most effective when it tackles these weaknesses directly. Access to patient, affordable finance, whether through government-backed loans or temporary relief from business taxes, would give new firms a longer runway to establish themselves. Legislation requiring prompt payment by large companies would protect smaller suppliers from avoidable cash-flow problems. Just as important is building capability: mentoring schemes that pair founders with experienced entrepreneurs, alongside practical training in finance and marketing, can prevent many costly errors. Small businesses themselves can strengthen their position by competing on qualities that large firms struggle to match, such as personal service, specialist knowledge and local loyalty.

In conclusion, small businesses fail mainly because of undercapitalisation, limited management experience and unequal competition. Targeted finance, fair payment practices and accessible mentoring could allow far more of them to thrive.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Adults returning to education

Topic: Education · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_two-part_01

Many adults decide to return to education later in life. Why do they do this? What difficulties might they face?

Band 6

275 words

Answers both questions with relevant reasons and difficulties · ideas stay fairly general · mechanical linking (Firstly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · several errors in agreement, articles and word form that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, it is quite common to see adults who go back to study at college or university after many years of working. In this essay I will explain the reasons why they do this and the problems which they may face.

There are several reasons why adults decide to return to education. Firstly, many people want to get a better job or a promotion. For example, a person who work in an office for ten years may need a degree in management to become a manager. Secondly, the job market is changing very fast, so some workers have to learn new skills like computer programming, otherwise they can lose their job. Also, some adults did not have chance to study when they were young because their family was poor, so they want to achieve their dream now.

However, adult learners can face many difficulties. The first problem is time. Most adults have full-time job and a family, so it is hard to find time for attending classes and doing homework. For instance, a mother with two children may only study late at night when she is very tired. Another difficulty is money, because courses can be expensive and they may have to pay by themselves. In addition, some older students feel nervous to study with younger people and they think they are not so good at using technology.

In conclusion, adults return to education mainly for better career and to learn new skills or to follow an old dream. But they can face problems such as lack of time, money and confidence. I think that if they are well organised, these difficulties can be overcome.

Band 7

299 words

Both questions answered clearly with extended, supported points · clear central idea in each paragraph · good range of linking · some less common collocations · mostly error-free with one minor agreement slip.

A growing number of people are choosing to resume their studies in their thirties, forties or even later. This essay will examine the main motivations behind this decision and the obstacles that mature students commonly encounter.

The most common reason adults re-enter education is to improve their career prospects. In many industries, qualifications that were sufficient twenty years ago are no longer enough, and employees who wish to be promoted or change profession often need a formal certificate. A nurse, for example, might take a part-time degree in order to move into a management role. Apart from professional motives, some people return to education simply for personal fulfilment. Those who left school early because of financial pressure may feel that they missed an opportunity, and completing a course later in life can give them a strong sense of achievement.

Nevertheless, returning to study as an adult is rarely straightforward. The most obvious challenge is balancing academic work with existing responsibilities. Unlike younger students, most mature learners have jobs, children or elderly parents to look after, which leaves them with limited time and energy for reading and assignments. Financial pressure is another issue, since tuition fees must often be paid while supporting a family, and reducing working hours may not be an option. Finally, some adults lack confidence after a long period away from the classroom. They may feel that their study skills are out of date or worry that they will not keep up with younger classmates, particularly when courses rely heavily on unfamiliar digital tools.

In conclusion, adults go back to education mainly to advance their careers and to fulfil personal ambitions. However, they have to overcome considerable difficulties, including limited time, financial strain and a lack of self-confidence, and they deserve flexible support from colleges and employers.

Band 8

330 words

Fully addresses both questions with well-developed, logically sequenced ideas · skilful cohesion · precise, natural vocabulary (obsolete, unfinished business, juggling act) · wide range of accurate complex structures.

Lifelong learning, once regarded as unusual, has become an increasingly familiar pattern, with many people enrolling on courses long after they have left school. Their reasons tend to be both practical and personal, but the path back into education is often complicated by commitments and anxieties that younger students rarely face.

Economic change is perhaps the strongest driving force. As automation and new technologies reshape the labour market, skills that once guaranteed secure employment can quickly become obsolete, and workers who wish to remain employable may have little choice but to retrain. Someone who has spent fifteen years in retail, for instance, might study accounting or data analysis to move into a more stable sector. Yet not every decision is driven by necessity. For many, returning to education is a matter of unfinished business: they may have abandoned their studies to support a family or to start earning, and a degree taken in middle age represents a goal finally achieved rather than a mere qualification.

The difficulties these learners face are, however, considerable. Time is the most pressing constraint, as coursework has to be fitted around full-time jobs, childcare and household responsibilities, often leaving study for late evenings or weekends. This juggling act can be exhausting, and it is one of the main reasons mature students withdraw before completing their courses. Money presents a further obstacle, because fees must usually be met from a household budget that is already stretched, and cutting working hours to study is a luxury few can afford. Less visible, but equally significant, is the psychological barrier. Adults who have not written an essay for decades may doubt their abilities and feel out of place among classmates half their age.

In short, adults return to education to keep pace with a changing economy and to fulfil long-held aspirations. Although lack of time, financial pressure and self-doubt can make the experience demanding, these obstacles are far easier to overcome when institutions offer flexible timetables and targeted support.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Technology and independent thinking

Topic: Technology · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_02

People increasingly rely on technology, such as search engines and navigation apps, rather than their own memory and knowledge. Why has this happened? What effect does it have on people's ability to think for themselves?

Band 6

268 words

Both questions addressed with a clear view · examples relevant but general · repetitive linking and word choice (people, think) · several errors with verb forms and articles that do not impede communication.

These days, many people use technology like Google or GPS apps instead of remember information by themselves. This essay will discuss why this happen and how it affects people's ability to think independently.

There are some reasons for this situation. The main reason is that technology is very convenient and fast. If someone want to know the capital of a country or a recipe, they can find the answer in a few seconds on their smartphone. In the past, people had to go to library or ask other people, which took long time. Another reason is that modern life is very busy and there is too much information to remember, so people prefer to let their phone remember it for them. For example, most people today do not remember phone numbers of their friends because they are saved in the phone.

In my opinion, this trend has a negative effect on people's ability to think by themselves. When people always use navigation apps, they do not learn the roads in their city, and if the phone battery is finish they can get lost easily. Similarly, students who copy answers from the internet do not really understand the topic and they cannot solve problems without help. However, technology can also have some positive effect, because people can find more information and compare different ideas quickly.

In conclusion, people depend on technology because it is quick and easy and life is busy. Although it has some benefits, I believe that it mostly makes people less able to think independently, so people should try to use their own brain more often.

Band 7

305 words

Clear position throughout · both questions answered with extended examples · logical paragraphing and varied cohesive devices · good collocation (information overload, sheer convenience) · occasional slip such as a missing article.

In recent years, people have become increasingly dependent on digital tools such as search engines and GPS applications to answer questions and find their way. This essay will explain why this shift has occurred and argue that, while it frees people from memorising facts, it can weaken their capacity for independent thought.

The main reason for this dependence is the sheer convenience of modern technology. With a smartphone in almost every pocket, any piece of information can be retrieved within seconds, so there seems little point in storing it in one's own memory. Why would a driver study a map when an app can calculate the fastest route and warn about traffic in real time? In addition, the amount of information people are expected to deal with has grown enormously, and handing routine facts over to devices allows them to cope with a demanding lifestyle. Many people no longer even know their close family members' phone numbers.

The effect on independent thinking is, in my view, largely negative. When answers are always available instantly, people have fewer reasons to work through a problem, evaluate evidence or remember what they have learnt. A student who immediately searches online for the solution to a maths question may get the correct answer but gains little understanding of the method behind it. Moreover, search engines rank results according to algorithms, so users often accept the first information they see without questioning its reliability. That said, technology can support critical thinking if it is used as a starting point for research rather than a substitute for it.

To conclude, people rely on technology because it is fast, convenient and helps them manage information overload. However, this habit can reduce people's ability to analyse and remember, and individuals should make conscious effort to think problems through before reaching for their phones.

Band 8

324 words

Both questions fully developed with a nuanced, consistent position · ideas logically sequenced and well supported · sophisticated vocabulary used precisely (ubiquity, delegate, disoriented) · varied, virtually error-free complex structures.

Few people today would set off for an unfamiliar destination without a navigation app, and even fewer would try to recall an obscure fact when a search engine can supply it instantly. This growing reliance on technology stems largely from its convenience and ubiquity, and although it has clear benefits, I believe it risks eroding people's capacity to think independently.

The shift can be explained by several interrelated factors. The most obvious is accessibility: smartphones have placed vast quantities of information within constant reach, making the effort of memorisation seem unnecessary. At the same time, the pace of modern life encourages people to delegate routine mental tasks. A commuter juggling work messages and family arrangements has little incentive to learn a route by heart when an app will not only guide them but also adjust for traffic. Furthermore, these tools are generally accurate, so people have come to trust them more than their own, sometimes unreliable, recollection.

The consequences for independent thought are more troubling. Memory and reasoning are closely linked; people who store knowledge internally are better able to make connections, spot inconsistencies and form original judgements. When everything is looked up on demand, this internal framework is never built. Navigation offers a telling example: drivers who follow turn-by-turn instructions often develop little sense of how a city fits together and can become disoriented as soon as the signal drops. More broadly, search engines present information that has already been filtered and ranked, which can encourage passive acceptance rather than critical evaluation. Admittedly, technology can also stimulate thinking by exposing users to a wider range of sources, but this depends on people actively questioning what they find.

In conclusion, dependence on digital tools has arisen because they are fast, reliable and constantly available. While they undoubtedly save time, habitual reliance on them can weaken memory and discourage critical reasoning, so they are best treated as aids to thinking rather than replacements for it.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

AI and human creativity

Topic: Artificial intelligence · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_two-part_03

Artificial intelligence can now produce paintings, music and stories. How does this affect the value that people place on human creativity? Should there be limits on the use of artificial intelligence in creative industries?

Band 6

291 words

Addresses both questions with a relevant position · points sensible but underdeveloped · basic linking (On the one hand, Firstly) · simple vocabulary (nice, make) · errors in articles, agreement and word form.

Nowadays artificial intelligence (AI) can make pictures, songs and even stories in few seconds. This essay will discuss how this change the way people value human creativity and whether we should limit AI in creative industries.

On the one hand, AI may reduce the value of human creativity for some people. When a computer can create a nice painting very quickly and cheap, some customers do not want to pay an artist for many hours of work. For example, a small company may use AI to design their logo instead of hiring a designer. As a result, people can think that creativity is not special anymore. On the other hand, I think many people will value human art even more because it is made by a real person with real feelings and experience. A song which is written by a singer about his own life have a meaning that a machine cannot copy.

In my opinion, there should be some limits on AI in creative industries. Firstly, AI programs learn from the works of human artists, and often these artists do not give permission or get any money. This is not fair and governments should make rules to protect them. Secondly, people should know if a book or a picture was made by AI, so companies must put a clear label on it. However, I do not think AI should be banned completely, because it can be a useful tool for artists to get new ideas.

In conclusion, AI can make some people think human creativity is less important, but others will value it more. I believe that there should be limits, such as protecting artists work and labelling AI products, but AI can still be used as a helpful tool.

Band 7

314 words

Clear position on both questions · main ideas extended with apt comparisons, though some generalisation · well-organised paragraphs · good range of vocabulary (commission, authenticity, premium) · rare minor errors such as an article slip.

The ability of artificial intelligence to generate artwork, music and fiction has raised important questions about the status of human creativity. In my view, AI is changing how creativity is valued in two opposite directions, and I believe some limits on its use in creative industries are necessary.

On one side, the availability of AI-generated content can make human creativity seem less valuable. Since an image or a piece of background music can now be produced in seconds at almost no cost, businesses may see little reason to commission professional illustrators or composers. When creative work becomes so easy to obtain, the public may start to regard it as a cheap product rather than the result of skill and effort. On the other side, this abundance could actually increase appreciation for genuinely human work. Many audiences value art because it reflects a person's emotions and experiences, and a novel inspired by the author's

own struggles carries an authenticity that machine-generated text lacks. In the same way that handmade furniture is valued more highly than mass-produced items, human-created art may become a premium product.

As for regulation, I believe certain limits should be introduced. The most pressing issue is that AI systems are trained on huge collection of existing work, often without the consent of the original artists, who receive no payment. Laws should ensure that creators can decide whether their work is used and are compensated if it is. Furthermore, AI-generated content should be clearly labelled so that consumers know what they are buying. However, banning AI entirely from creative fields would be unrealistic and would deprive artists of a tool which can help with tasks such as editing or brainstorming.

In conclusion, AI may reduce the value people place on creativity in some areas while increasing it in others. Reasonable limits, particularly on training data and transparency, would protect artists without stopping innovation.

Band 8

326 words

Both questions answered with a nuanced, fully supported argument · ideas extended through well-chosen analogy · seamless cohesion · wide, precise lexis (commodity, negligible, blanket ban) · complex structures used accurately and flexibly.

Now that algorithms can compose symphonies, write short stories and produce convincing portraits, the question of what makes human creativity valuable has become more pressing than ever. I would argue that AI is simultaneously cheapening some forms of creative work and deepening appreciation for others, and that carefully designed limits on its use are both justified and necessary.

The most immediate impact is economic. Commercial creativity, such as stock illustrations, advertising jingles or product descriptions, is increasingly treated as a commodity that AI can supply instantly and at negligible cost. In these areas, the perceived worth of human skill is clearly falling, and many freelance designers and writers have already seen demand for their services shrink. Yet this is only part of the picture. Art has never been valued solely for its surface qualities; audiences are also drawn to the intention, experience and vulnerability behind it. A song about loss means more when listeners know that its writer has actually grieved. Paradoxically, therefore, the flood of machine-generated content may make work that is demonstrably human rarer and more prized, much as handcrafted goods gained prestige after industrial production became widespread.

Regarding limits, a blanket ban would be neither practical nor desirable, since AI can be a genuinely useful instrument in the hands of artists. However, two forms of regulation seem essential. First, the data used to train these systems frequently consists of copyrighted work taken without permission, so creators should have the right to opt out and to receive fair payment when their work is used. Second, transparency is crucial: audiences and buyers deserve to know whether a piece was produced by a person or a program, which clear labelling requirements would guarantee.

In conclusion, AI is devaluing routine creative work while potentially elevating the status of authentic human expression. Rather than prohibiting the technology, societies should limit its use through fair rules on training data and mandatory disclosure, protecting artists while allowing innovation to continue.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Second-hand clothing trend

Topic: Consumerism / Environment · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_two-part_04

In many places, people are becoming more interested in buying second-hand clothes. Why is this happening? What other steps can people take to reduce the environmental impact of the clothes they buy?

Band 6

283 words

Both parts covered with relevant reasons and steps · ideas listed rather than developed · mechanical sequencing (Firstly, Secondly, Thirdly) · adequate vocabulary · errors in comparatives, articles and agreement that do not block meaning.

In recent years, buying second-hand clothes has become more popular in many countries. This essay will explain the reasons for this trend and suggest some other ways that people can reduce the environmental damage caused by their clothes.

There are several reasons why people are interested in second-hand clothing. The first reason is money. Used clothes are much more cheaper than new ones, and many people, especially students, do not have a lot of money to spend. Secondly, people are more aware about environmental problems now. They know that fashion industry produces a lot of pollution and waste, so buying used items is a way to help the planet. Also, it is very easy to buy second-hand clothes today because there are many websites and apps where people can sell their old clothes. Some young people also think that vintage clothes look more unique and fashionable.

Apart from buying used clothes, there are other steps people can take. Firstly, they can buy less clothes and choose items with good quality that last for a long time. Cheap fast fashion clothes often break after few months and then they are thrown away. Secondly, people can repair their clothes instead of throwing them when there is a small hole. Thirdly, they can give their unwanted clothes to charity shops or recycle them, so they do not go to landfill. Finally, people can choose brands which use organic cotton or recycled materials.

In conclusion, second-hand clothes are popular because they are cheap, easy to buy and good for the environment. People can also help by buying fewer and better clothes, repairing them and recycling. If everyone do these things, the fashion industry will be less harmful.

Band 7

308 words

Both questions answered with clear, supported points · logical progression with a clear topic per paragraph · good topic vocabulary (pre-owned garments, supply chains) · frequent error-free sentences with one agreement slip.

Second-hand clothing, once associated mainly with people on low incomes, is now attracting a much wider range of buyers. This essay will discuss the reasons behind this change and outline further measures that consumers can take to make their clothing choices more sustainable.

One key reason for the growing popularity of used clothes is greater environmental awareness. Many consumers have learnt through the media that the fashion industry consumes enormous amounts of water and energy and generates vast quantities of textile waste. Buying pre-owned garments allows them to enjoy new outfits without adding to this demand. Financial factors also play a role, as rising living costs have encouraged people to look for affordable alternatives, and good-quality items can often be bought for a fraction of their original price. In addition,

online resale platforms have made the process far more convenient. Instead of searching through crowded charity shops, shoppers can now browse thousands of items on their phone and have them delivered to their door.

There are, however, several other ways people can reduce the environmental impact of their wardrobes. The most effective is simply to buy fewer clothes and to choose durable ones. A well-made coat that lasts ten years is clearly less harmful than several cheap ones which wears out after a single season. People can also extend the life of their clothes by washing them less frequently and at lower temperatures, and by repairing minor damage rather than discarding the item. Finally, consumers can support brands that are transparent about their supply chains and use recycled or organic materials, which puts pressure on the wider industry to change its practices.

In conclusion, the rise of second-hand shopping reflects growing environmental concern, economic pressure and the convenience of online platforms. Alongside this, buying less, caring for clothes properly and choosing responsible brands can make a significant difference.

Band 8

313 words

Fully addresses both parts with well-developed, prioritised ideas · skilful paragraphing and cohesion · wide, idiomatic vocabulary (surge, proposition, purchasing power) · a wide range of structures with no noticeable errors.

Charity shops and online resale platforms are enjoying a surge in popularity, as buyers who would once have insisted on new clothes increasingly choose pre-owned alternatives. This shift reflects a combination of ethical, economic and cultural factors, and while it is a positive development, it is only one of several ways in which consumers can make their clothing habits more sustainable.

Perhaps the most significant driver is a heightened awareness of the environmental cost of fashion. Widespread media coverage has exposed the industry's heavy use of water, its reliance on synthetic fibres and the mountains of discarded garments that end up in landfill, prompting many shoppers to reconsider their habits. Economic pressures reinforce this trend: with household budgets under strain, a designer jacket at a fraction of its retail price is an attractive proposition. Cultural attitudes have also shifted. Among younger consumers in particular, vintage clothing is seen not as a sign of hardship but as a way of expressing individuality, and resale apps have made browsing for such items as effortless as shopping on the high street.

Beyond buying second-hand, the single most effective step is to consume less. Choosing fewer, better-made garments and wearing them for longer reduces demand for new production far more than any recycling scheme. Caring for clothes properly also matters; washing at lower temperatures, air-drying rather than tumble-drying, and carrying out simple repairs can extend a garment's life considerably. When items are no longer wanted, they should be donated, swapped or sold rather than thrown away. Finally, consumers can use their purchasing power to reward manufacturers that are transparent about their supply chains and that use recycled or responsibly sourced materials.

In conclusion, the appeal of second-hand clothing stems from environmental concern, financial prudence and changing tastes. Its benefits can be multiplied if people also buy less, look after what they own and support genuinely responsible brands.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Strangers next door

Topic: Cities / Society · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_05

In many cities today, people hardly know their neighbours. Why is this the case? How can a stronger sense of community be created in cities?

Band 6

280 words

Answers both questions with relevant causes and solutions · ideas general and list-like · repetitive linking (Also, Firstly) · adequate vocabulary · errors in word order, articles and countability that do not block meaning.

In many big cities, people live very close to each other but they do not know even the names of their neighbours. This essay will explain why this is happening and how cities can build a stronger community.

There are a few reasons for this problem. Firstly, people in cities are very busy with their work. They leave home early in the morning and come back late at night, so they have no time for talking with neighbours. Secondly, many people live in big apartment buildings where hundreds of families live, and it is difficult to know everybody. Also, people in cities often move house because of their job or rent, so they do not stay in one place for long time. Finally, technology is another reason. People spend their free time on their phones and social media instead of go outside and meet the people near them.

However, there are some ways to make a stronger community in cities. The local government can organise events like street festivals or sports competitions where neighbours can meet each other. For example, in some cities there are markets at weekends where people from the same area come together. Another idea is to build more parks and community centres, because these places give people chance to talk and make friends. Also, apartment buildings could create online groups for residents so they can share informations and help each other.

In conclusion, people in cities do not know their neighbours because they are busy, they move often and they use technology too much. I believe that events and public spaces can help to create stronger community, but people also need to make an effort themselves.

Band 7

307 words

Both questions answered with clearly extended causes and solutions · logical organisation with clear topic sentences · good collocation (lengthy commutes, casual encounters) · mostly accurate complex sentences with one article slip.

It is often said that city dwellers can live next door to someone for years without ever having a conversation with them. This essay will consider the main reasons for this lack of connection and suggest how urban communities could be strengthened.

The primary cause is the pace of urban life. Long working hours and lengthy commutes mean that many residents spend little time in their neighbourhood apart from sleeping there, leaving few opportunities for casual encounters. The design of modern housing makes the situation worse. In large apartment blocks, residents typically move directly from a car park or lift to their own front door, and there are rarely shared spaces where people might naturally stop and chat. Furthermore, city populations are highly mobile. Young professionals in particular tend to rent for a year or two before moving on, so there is little incentive to invest time in getting to know the people around them.

Despite these obstacles, a stronger sense of community can be encouraged. Urban planners have an important role to play by including communal areas such as small parks, playgrounds and shared gardens in new developments, since these places allow relationships to form gradually through repeated contact. Local councils could also support neighbourhood events, for instance by closing a street for an afternoon so that residents can hold a party or a market. On a smaller scale, digital tools can be helpful when they are used to connect people locally; neighbourhood messaging groups allow residents to lend tools, share recommendations and organise activities, which often leads to face-to-face friendship.

In conclusion, urban residents rarely know their neighbours because of busy lifestyles, isolating building design and frequent relocation. These problems can be reduced through better planning, local events and the sensible use of technology, although individuals also need to be willing to make first move.

Band 8

326 words

Both questions fully developed with causes explicitly linked to solutions · skilful cohesion and paragraphing · wide, precise vocabulary (transience, compounds, put down roots) · varied complex structures, essentially error-free.

Paradoxically, cities pack people together more densely than anywhere else, yet many urban residents could not name the person living on the other side of their wall. This anonymity has social, economic and architectural roots, but it is not inevitable, and there are practical ways in which a sense of community can be rebuilt.

One fundamental reason is the structure of urban working life. Long hours and extended commutes turn many homes into little more than places to sleep, so residents are seldom around at the times when neighbourly contact might occur. Transience compounds the problem. In cities where a large proportion of people rent, tenants may move every year or two, and there is little motivation to build relationships that seem likely to be short-lived.

Architecture also plays a part: high-rise blocks with anonymous corridors and underground parking allow people to travel from their car to their flat without encountering anyone. Finally, online social networks now satisfy much of the need for connection that was once met locally, making it easy to feel sociable while remaining a stranger to one's neighbours.

Rebuilding community therefore requires action on several levels. Planners can design spaces that encourage chance encounters, such as courtyards, shared gardens and pedestrian-friendly streets lined with small shops and cafés, since relationships tend to grow out of repeated informal contact rather than organised gatherings. Local authorities can supplement this by funding regular events, from street parties to volunteering schemes, which give residents a shared purpose. Technology, too, can be turned to advantage; neighbourhood apps that allow people to borrow items or offer help frequently lead to offline friendships. Longer tenancy agreements would also help, giving renters the stability needed to put down roots.

In conclusion, city dwellers remain strangers because of demanding schedules, frequent relocation, isolating architecture and online distractions. Thoughtful urban design, community events and local digital networks, supported by more secure housing, can go a long way towards restoring neighbourly ties.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Choosing self-employment

Topic: Employment · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_two-part_06

Some people choose to work for themselves rather than for an employer. Why do they make this choice? What qualities are needed to be successful when working for yourself?

Band 6

275 words

Both questions answered with relevant reasons and qualities · brief, general support · formulaic sequencing (First of all, Secondly) · repetitive vocabulary · errors in articles, word form and agreement that do not impede meaning.

Nowadays more and more people decide to start their own business or work as freelancer instead of working for a company. In this essay I will explain the reasons for this choice and the qualities which a person need to be successful.

There are many reasons why people want to be self-employed. The biggest reason is freedom. When you work for yourself, you can decide your working hours and you do not have a boss who tells you what to do. For example, a graphic designer who is freelance can work from home and spend more time with his children. Another reason is money. In a company the salary is fixed, but if your own business is successful you can earn much more money. Also, some people are not happy with their job because they have a bad manager or boring tasks, so they decide to leave.

However, working for yourself is not easy and it needs some important qualities. First of all, a self-employed person must be very discipline. Nobody checks their work, so they must manage their time and meet deadlines without anybody help. Secondly, they need to be brave and take risk, because the income is not stable and in some months they can earn very little. Thirdly, good communication skills are important because they have to find customers and talk with them by themselves. Finally, they should be hard-working and ready to work long hours at the beginning.

In conclusion, people choose to work for themselves because they want freedom, more money and to escape from a bad job. To be successful, they need discipline, courage, communication skills and hard work.

Band 7

296 words

Clear answers to both questions with extended, supported ideas · logical progression and good range of linkers · appropriate less common vocabulary (resilience, overlooked for promotion) · mostly error-free with two agreement slips.

An increasing number of people are leaving traditional employment to become freelancers, consultants or small business owners. This essay will outline the main motives behind this decision and discuss the personal qualities that are essential for success in self-employment.

The desire for independence is probably the most important motive. Employees often have little control over their schedules, the projects they work on or the way their performance is judged, whereas self-employed people can decide when, where and how they work. This flexibility is particularly attractive to parents with young children or people who want to combine work with travel. Financial ambition is another factor. While a salaried worker's income is usually limited by a fixed pay scale, a successful entrepreneur can benefit directly from their own effort and ideas. Some people also turn to self-employment out of frustration, for example

after being overlooked for promotion or feeling that their skills are not valued.

Succeeding without an employer, however, demands a particular set of qualities. Self-discipline is the most crucial, since there is no manager to set deadlines or monitor progress, and it is easy to become distracted when working from home. Resilience is equally important, because income can be irregular and setbacks such as losing a major client are common, particularly in the first few years. In addition, independent workers need good interpersonal and marketing skills, as they are responsible for finding customers, negotiating prices and maintaining their reputation. Finally, they must be organised enough to handle practical matters such as taxes and invoices, which is often overlooked by people who is used to having an accounts department.

In conclusion, people choose self-employment mainly for independence, higher earning potential and escape from unsatisfying jobs. To succeed, they need self-discipline, resilience, strong communication skills and good organisation.

Band 8

315 words

Both parts thoroughly addressed with well-developed, illustrated ideas · cohesion managed naturally · wide, idiomatic vocabulary (go it alone, paramount, versatile) · wide range of accurate structures throughout.

For a growing share of the workforce, the security of a regular salary is no longer enough to outweigh the appeal of being one's own boss. People are drawn to self-employment for a mixture of personal and financial reasons, but turning that choice into a sustainable livelihood requires a demanding combination of character traits.

Autonomy lies at the heart of most decisions to go it alone. Working for an employer typically means accepting fixed hours, predetermined tasks and the judgement of a line manager, whereas independent workers can shape their own schedules and choose projects that genuinely interest them. For a parent who wants to be present at the school gate, or someone who does their best work late at night, this freedom can be transformative. There is also the prospect of greater reward: rather than seeing the benefits of their efforts absorbed by a company, the self-employed keep what they earn, and a thriving business may eventually generate far more than a salary ever would. Technology has made the leap less daunting, as online platforms allow even a single freelancer to reach clients around the world.

Yet freedom brings its own pressures, and certain qualities distinguish those who thrive from those who struggle. Self-motivation is paramount; without external deadlines or supervision, procrastination can quietly undermine a promising venture. Equally vital is resilience, since irregular income, demanding clients and unsuccessful pitches are an inevitable part of independent work. Successful freelancers also tend to be versatile, combining expertise in their field with the ability to market themselves, negotiate fees and manage finances. Finally, a degree of tolerance for risk is essential, as there is no guaranteed income at the end of each month.

In conclusion, people become self-employed chiefly to gain autonomy and to benefit directly from their own work. Achieving lasting success, however, depends on self-motivation, resilience, versatility and a willingness to live with uncertainty.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Advertising and manufactured desire

Topic: Advertising · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_07

Advertisements often try to persuade people that they need products they did not previously want. How do advertisers achieve this? Should anything be done to control it?

Band 6

273 words

Both questions addressed with a clear but simply argued position · relevant examples, limited development · basic linking · repetitive vocabulary (adverts, people) · article, agreement and preposition errors that do not block meaning.

Advertisements are everywhere today, on television, on the internet and in the streets. Many of them try to make people believe that they need a product which they did not want before. This essay will explain how advertisers do this and whether it should be controlled.

Advertisers use different methods to persuade people. One common method is to use famous people like actors or footballers. When fans see their favourite star using a product, they want to buy it too because they want to be like him. Another method is to make people feel that their life is not good enough without the product. For example, an advert for a new phone shows happy young people with many friends, so the viewers think they will be more popular if they buy this phone. Also, advertisers use social media to collect information about users and show them ads which is based on their interests, so it is very hard to ignore them.

In my opinion, some control is necessary. Firstly, children are easily influenced by adverts and they often ask their parents to buy toys or unhealthy snacks. Governments should ban adverts for children in some times, for example during cartoons. Secondly, adverts should not give false information or promise things that the product can not do. However, I think adverts cannot be banned completely because companies need to tell people about their products and it helps the economy.

In conclusion, advertisers create new wants by using celebrities, making people feel unhappy with their lives and targeting them online. I believe that governments should control adverts, especially for children, but not stop them totally.

Band 7

307 words

Clear position with both questions answered and supported · well-organised paragraphs with clear central ideas · good range of vocabulary (exploit insecurities, impulse purchase) · frequent error-free sentences, one minor slip (neither ... or).

Modern advertising frequently goes beyond informing consumers about products and instead convinces them that they need things they had never previously considered buying. This essay will explain the main techniques advertisers use to create such desires and argue that some regulation is justified.

One of the most effective strategies is to link a product with an attractive lifestyle or identity. Rather than focusing on what a car or a watch actually does, advertisements often show glamorous, successful people using it, suggesting that buyers will share that status. Advertisers also exploit people's insecurities. Beauty and fitness companies, for instance, may highlight minor imperfections that consumers had never worried about and then present their product as the solution. In addition, digital marketing has made persuasion more powerful than ever. By analysing people's browsing history, companies can target individuals with personalised

advertises at exactly the moment they are most likely to make an impulse purchase, while social media influencers present sponsored products as if they were genuine personal recommendations.

I believe these practices should be controlled to some extent. The strongest case concerns children, who are less able to recognise persuasive intent, so advertising aimed at young audiences, particularly for unhealthy food and expensive toys, should be strictly limited. Transparency is also essential: influencers ought to be required to label paid content clearly, so that followers can distinguish advice from marketing. Furthermore, there should be clearer rules about how personal data can be used for targeting. That said, a total ban on persuasive advertising would be neither practical or desirable, as advertising funds much of the media and allows new businesses to reach customers.

In conclusion, advertisers create new wants by associating products with desirable lifestyles, exploiting insecurities and using personal data. Sensible regulation, especially to protect children and ensure transparency, would reduce the harmful effects without undermining legitimate marketing.

Band 8

317 words

Both questions answered with a balanced, well-supported position · ideas logically sequenced and extended with apt examples · sophisticated, precise lexis (indispensable, susceptible, heavy-handed) · wide range of error-free structures.

Much of modern advertising is not designed to meet existing demand but to manufacture it, persuading consumers that a product they had never heard of is suddenly indispensable. The techniques involved have become increasingly sophisticated, and in my view they warrant a degree of regulation, although not an outright ban.

At the core of most campaigns lies emotional association. Advertisers rarely sell objects on their practical merits; instead they sell the feelings and identities attached to them. A pair of trainers becomes a symbol of athletic success, while a luxury handbag is presented as evidence of sophistication. By repeatedly pairing a product with images of happiness, attractiveness or status, advertisers create a sense that ownership will deliver these qualities. A related tactic is the creation of dissatisfaction. Cosmetic and technology companies in particular are adept at convincing consumers that what they already own is inadequate, so that a perfectly functional phone begins to feel embarrassing the moment a new model is launched. Digital platforms have intensified these methods, allowing firms to target individuals with personalised messages and to reach them through influencers whose endorsements feel like the advice of a friend.

Some control over these practices seems reasonable. Children, who are especially susceptible to persuasion, deserve particular protection, and restrictions on advertising during children's programming or on apps aimed at them would be a sensible starting point. Clear disclosure rules for sponsored content would help adults recognise when they are being marketed to, and stricter limits on the collection of personal data would curb the most intrusive forms of targeting. However, advertising also finances free media and enables smaller companies to compete, so heavy-handed prohibition would do more harm than good.

In conclusion, advertisers generate new desires by attaching emotional meaning to products, fostering dissatisfaction and exploiting personal data. Targeted regulation, focusing on children, transparency and privacy, would limit manipulation while preserving the legitimate benefits of advertising.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Barriers to healthy eating

Topic: Health · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_08

Many people find it difficult to eat a healthy diet, even when they know which foods are good for them. Why is this? Who should be responsible for helping people to eat more healthily?

Band 6

272 words

Answers both questions with a relevant position · reasons and suggestions are sensible but thinly developed · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · several errors in articles, agreement and prepositions that do not obscure meaning.

Most people know that fruit, vegetables and whole grains are good for health, but many of them still eat a lot of junk food. This essay will explain why it is difficult to eat healthily and who should help people to improve their diet.

There are several reasons why people do not eat healthy food. The first reason is time. Many people work long hours and when they come home they are too tired for cooking, so they buy fast food or ready meals which is quick and easy. Secondly, unhealthy food is often cheaper than healthy food. For example, in many supermarket a burger costs less than a salad, so families with low income choose the cheaper option. Another reason is that junk food is very tasty and it is advertised everywhere, so it is difficult to resist it, especially for children.

In my opinion, both the government and individuals should be responsible for this problem. The government can make healthy food cheaper by reducing tax on fruits and vegetables and put higher tax on sugary drinks. They can also teach children about nutrition and cooking at school, so they will have good habits from young age. However, individuals and families also have responsibility, because nobody can force a person to eat well. Parents should cook healthy meals at home and give good example to their children.

In conclusion, people find it hard to eat healthy food because they are busy, healthy food is expensive and junk food is attractive. I believe the government should help by using taxes and education, but people must also take responsibility of their own diet.

Band 7

313 words

Clear position on shared responsibility · both questions answered with extended support · logical paragraphing and good cohesion · good topic vocabulary (overconsumption, subsidising, fresh produce) · largely accurate with one agreement slip.

Although most people are well aware that vegetables are healthier than crisps and fizzy drinks, poor diets remain common. This essay will examine why knowledge alone does not lead to healthy eating and argue that responsibility should be shared between governments, the food industry and individuals.

The gap between knowing and doing has several causes. Convenience is a major factor, as people with demanding jobs often lack the time or energy to prepare meals from fresh ingredients after a long day, and processed food offers a quick alternative. Cost also plays an important role. In many places, fresh produce is more expensive than heavily processed snacks, which makes healthy eating difficult for low-income households. Moreover, the modern food environment is designed to encourage overconsumption. Unhealthy products are heavily advertised, placed at eye level in supermarkets and made highly appealing through large

amounts of sugar, salt and fat, so even people with good intentions find them hard to resist.

In my view, it would be unfair to place the entire burden on individuals when so many external factors shape their choices. Governments should take a leading role, for example by taxing sugary drinks, subsidising fruit and vegetables and requiring clear nutritional labelling. Schools can also contribute by providing nutritious lunches and teaching practical cooking skills. The food industry has a responsibility too, and manufacturers could be encouraged to reduce the sugar and salt content of their products. Nevertheless, individuals cannot be entirely excused, since they still make the final decision about what they buy, and parents shape children's eating habits from an early age.

In conclusion, people struggle to eat well because of busy lifestyles, the higher cost of healthy food and an environment full of tempting alternatives. Improving diets therefore requires a combined effort in which governments and the food industry makes healthy choices easier and individuals take responsibility for their own decisions.

Band 8

330 words

Both questions fully answered with a clear, well-justified position · ideas extended and logically linked · wide, natural vocabulary (palatable, calorie for calorie, accountable) · wide range of structures with no errors.

It is one of the curiosities of modern life that people can recite the benefits of vegetables and the dangers of sugar, yet still reach for a takeaway at the end of the day. The reasons lie less in ignorance than in the circumstances in which food choices are made, and for this reason I believe responsibility for improving diets must be shared, with governments playing the leading role.

Time pressure is a fundamental obstacle. For people working long hours or juggling several jobs, preparing a balanced meal from scratch can feel like an unrealistic demand, whereas ready meals and fast food require no effort at all. Price reinforces this pattern: calorie for calorie, processed food is often cheaper than fresh produce, so households on tight budgets may have little real choice. Perhaps most importantly, the food environment itself works against good intentions. Products high in sugar, salt and fat are engineered to be highly palatable, promoted relentlessly and positioned prominently in shops, which means that choosing the healthy option requires constant willpower. Knowledge, in other words, is rarely a match for convenience, cost and temptation combined.

Given these pressures, it would be unrealistic to expect individuals to solve the problem alone. Governments are best placed to reshape the environment in which choices are made, whether through taxes on sugary drinks, subsidies for fresh produce, restrictions on junk-food advertising or clear front-of-pack labelling. Food manufacturers should also be held accountable, for instance through targets to reduce harmful ingredients. Schools have a role in teaching cooking and providing nutritious meals, thereby shaping habits early. Individuals, of course, retain ultimate control over what they eat, but personal responsibility is far easier to exercise when the healthy choice is also the easy one.

In conclusion, poor diets persist because of time pressure, cost and a food environment designed to tempt. While individuals must play their part, governments, supported by industry and schools, should take the lead in making healthy eating affordable and convenient.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Young people and voting

Topic: Government · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_two-part_09

In many countries, young people are less likely to vote in elections than older people. Why might this be the case? What are the consequences of this for society?

Band 6

276 words

Both questions answered with relevant reasons and consequences · development is limited and repetitive (young people, older people) · mechanical linking · errors in comparison, articles and possessives that do not block meaning.

In many countries, the number of young voters in elections is lower than older voters. This essay will explain some reasons for this and the consequences it has for society.

There are several reasons why young people do not vote. Firstly, many young people are not interested in politics because they think it is boring and complicated. They do not understand the difference between the parties, so they do not know who to choose. Secondly, a lot of young people believe that their vote cannot change anything. They see that politicians make promises before elections but they do not keep them after, so they lose trust. Also, some young people are students who live far from their hometown, and it is not easy for them to register or go to the polling station on election day.

This situation has some serious consequences. The most important one is that politicians focus more on older people, because older people vote more. For example, government may spend more money on pensions and less on education or cheap housing for young families. As a result, young people problems are ignored and they feel even less connected to politics. Another consequence is that the democracy becomes weaker, because the government does not represent the whole population. In the future, if this young people never start voting, the problem will become more serious.

In conclusion, young people vote less because they are not interested, they do not trust politicians and voting is not convenient for them. This leads to policies which favour older people and a weaker democracy. I think schools should teach more about politics to encourage young people to vote.

Band 7

293 words

Both parts answered clearly with extended causes and consequences · logical progression (vicious cycle) · good range of vocabulary (turnout, legitimacy, unrepresentative) · mostly error-free sentences with one agreement slip.

Election results in many countries show that turnout among younger citizens is considerably lower than among older age groups. This essay will explore the reasons for this pattern and discuss its consequences for society as a whole.

One of the main reasons is a sense of disconnection from mainstream politics. Many young people feel that political parties are dominated by older politicians who neither understand nor prioritise their concerns, such as housing costs, job insecurity and climate change. As a result, they conclude that voting will make little difference. Another factor is a lack of political education. Unless they grow up in families that discuss current affairs, young adults may find the system confusing and feel unqualified to make a choice. Practical obstacles also play a role; students and young workers move house frequently, and if registration rules are complicated,

they may simply not be registered in the right place when an election is called.

The consequences of low youth turnout are significant. Since politicians naturally pay attention to those who vote, policies tend to favour older voters, for example through generous pension increases, while issues affecting young people receive less attention and funding. This creates a vicious cycle, because young people then feel even more excluded from the political process and become less likely to participate in future. In the long term, this undermines the legitimacy of democratic institutions, as governments are elected by an increasingly unrepresentative section of the population. It may also encourage some young people to express their frustration through protest rather than through the ballot box.

In conclusion, young people vote less because they feel ignored, lack political knowledge and faces practical barriers. The result is a political system that neglects their interests, which in turn weakens democracy.

Band 8

312 words

Both questions fully answered with sophisticated, well-linked analysis · ideas extended and logically sequenced · precise, wide-ranging vocabulary (abstaining, cumbersome, self-perpetuating) · complex structures used accurately throughout.

In many democracies, a striking generational divide exists at the ballot box, with people in their late teens and twenties voting at markedly lower rates than their parents and grandparents. This gap can be traced to disillusionment, limited political education and practical barriers, and its consequences extend well beyond young people themselves.

Perhaps the most significant factor is a perception that politics is not designed for them. Young voters frequently see parliaments dominated by older figures and debates that seem remote from their immediate concerns, such as unaffordable rents or insecure employment. When the connection between casting a vote and improving one's own life appears weak, abstaining can seem a rational response rather than mere apathy. This detachment is reinforced by inadequate civic education; many school leavers have little understanding of how government works or how party programmes differ, and uncertainty easily turns into disengagement. Practical obstacles add a further layer. Young adults change address frequently for study or work, and cumbersome registration procedures can mean that they are unable to vote even if they wish to.

The consequences for society are considerable. Politicians seeking re-election rationally direct their attention towards the groups most likely to turn out, which can result in policies that protect pensions and property values while underinvesting in education, affordable housing and long-term environmental measures. Such imbalances can deepen intergenerational inequality and, in turn, reinforce young people's belief that the system ignores them, creating a self-perpetuating cycle. More broadly, a government chosen by a narrowing slice of the electorate risks losing legitimacy, and frustration that finds no outlet at the ballot box may emerge instead as distrust or unrest.

In conclusion, low youth turnout stems from disillusionment, limited civic knowledge and practical hurdles. Its effects, from skewed policy priorities to weakened democratic legitimacy, make it a problem for the whole of society rather than for young people alone.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Children and possessions

Topic: Children · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_two-part_10

Many children today own more toys and possessions than children in the past. Why is this? How does this affect their development?

Band 6

269 words

Both questions answered with a clear view · relevant but general support · list-like linking · informal or repeated vocabulary (kids, toys) · errors with countable nouns and agreement that do not block meaning.

Today children usually have much more toys, clothes and electronic devices than children in the past. This essay will explain why this happen and how it affects their development.

There are several reasons for this change. Firstly, many families today are richer than before, so parents can afford to buy more things for their children. Secondly, most families have only one or two children, so parents and grandparents spend all their money on them. Also, toys are cheaper now because factories produce them in large numbers. Another reason is advertising. Children see adverts on television and YouTube and they ask their parents to buy the new toy. Some parents who work long hours also buy presents because they feel guilty that they do not spend enough time with their kids.

In my opinion, having too many possessions has more negative effects than positive effects on children. Children who get everything they want may not learn the value of money and they can become spoiled. For example, when a child has twenty toys, he often gets bored quickly and do not take care of them. Moreover, they have less chance to use their imagination, because in the past children made games with simple things like sticks and boxes. However, some toys, for example puzzles or building blocks, can help children to develop their skills and creativity.

In conclusion, children have more possessions today because families are richer, toys are cheap and advertising is powerful. Although some toys are educational, I believe that too many things can make children spoiled and less creative, so parents should buy less toys for them.

Band 7

308 words

Clear position with both questions addressed and developed · balanced discussion of effects · good cohesion and paragraphing · appropriate less common vocabulary (disposable income, hinder) · largely accurate with one minor slip.

Compared with previous generations, many children today grow up surrounded by a large number of toys, gadgets and other possessions. This essay will examine the main causes of this change and argue that, although some possessions can be beneficial, having too many can hinder a child's development.

The most obvious explanation is rising prosperity. In many countries, households have more disposable income than they did several decades ago, and mass production has made toys and clothing far cheaper. At the same time, families have become smaller, so the attention and spending of parents, grandparents and other relatives are concentrated on fewer children. Commercial pressure also plays a major part. Children are exposed to constant advertising through television, online videos and games, and toy companies regularly release new versions of popular products, which creates a desire to keep up with friends. In addition, busy working parents sometimes use gifts to compensate for limited time spent together.

The effects of this abundance on development are mixed but mostly negative. On the positive side, educational toys, books and construction sets can stimulate curiosity and help children develop problem-solving and motor skills. However, when children have too many possessions, they tend to value each one less and may move quickly from one toy to other without engaging deeply with any of them. Many educators believe that a certain amount of boredom encourages creativity, and a child with only a few simple items is more likely to invent games and stories. Furthermore, receiving new things frequently may lead children to associate happiness with ownership, which can make it harder for them to learn patience and gratitude.

In conclusion, children own more than ever because families are wealthier, goods are cheaper and marketing is more intense. While carefully chosen toys can support learning, an excess of possessions can reduce creativity and encourage materialistic attitudes.

Band 8

326 words

Both questions answered in depth with a clear, qualified position · well-sequenced, fully supported ideas · wide, precise vocabulary (affluence, lavished, flit between) · wide range of accurate structures.

A glance into many modern children's bedrooms reveals shelves crowded with toys, games and electronic devices on a scale that would have astonished earlier generations. This abundance is largely a product of economic and social change, and while it is not wholly harmful, I believe it often works against the qualities that children most need to develop.

Several forces lie behind this shift. Greater affluence and the global manufacturing of inexpensive goods mean that toys which were once special treats are now everyday purchases. Demographic change has amplified the effect: with fewer children per family, and often several grandparents eager to give presents, gifts that were once shared among siblings are now lavished on one or two children. Marketing, meanwhile, has become more direct and persistent. Children encounter advertising through online videos and games as well as television, and the constant release of new models and collectable ranges fuels a sense that what they have is never quite enough. Some parents, pressed for time, may also use gifts as a substitute for attention.

The developmental consequences depend partly on what children own, but quantity matters. Well-chosen toys such as building sets, art materials and books can foster creativity, concentration and fine motor skills. Yet when possessions are plentiful, each one tends to be valued less, and children may flit between them without the sustained engagement that deep play requires. A child with a cardboard box and a few figures is often forced to invent entire worlds, whereas one surrounded by ready-made entertainment has less need for imagination. There is also a risk that a steady stream of new items teaches children to seek satisfaction through acquisition, making patience, gratitude and the ability to cope with disappointment harder to learn.

In conclusion, children own more because of rising wealth, smaller families and relentless marketing. Although some possessions can enrich development, an excess tends to weaken imagination and encourage materialistic habits, so fewer, better-chosen items are generally preferable.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Preventing teenage crime

Topic: Crime · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_11

In some areas, crime committed by teenagers is a growing concern. Why do some young people become involved in crime? What role should schools play in preventing this?

Band 6

270 words

Both questions addressed with relevant causes and school roles · ideas stated rather than explored · simple sequencing · informal phrasing (look cool) · errors in articles, agreement and verb forms.

In some places, the number of crimes committed by teenagers is increasing and people are worried about this. This essay will discuss why some young people become criminals and what schools should do to prevent it.

There are many reasons why teenagers get involved in crime. One reason is family problems. If parents are divorced or they work all the time, children may not get enough attention and guidance, so they spend time on the streets with bad friends. Peer pressure is also a big reason. Teenagers want to be accepted by their group, so if their friends steal or fight, they do the same things to look cool. In addition, poverty can push young people to commit crime. For example, a teenager from a poor family may steal a phone because he cannot afford to buy one.

In my opinion, schools have an important role in preventing youth crime. Firstly, teachers spend many hours with students every day, so they can notice when a student has problems at home or behave badly. Schools should have counsellors who can talk with these students and help them. Secondly, schools can offer after-school activities such as sports, music or drama clubs. These activities keep teenagers busy and give them something positive to do, so they have less time for getting in trouble. Finally, schools should teach students about the law and the results of committing a crime.

In conclusion, teenagers commit crimes because of family problems, peer pressure and poverty. Schools cannot solve this problem alone, but they can help a lot by supporting students, organising activities and teaching them about consequences.

Band 7

312 words

Clear, qualified position · both questions answered with extended, relevant support · logical organisation with a clear focus per paragraph · good lexical range (deprived areas, warning signs) · one minor grammatical slip.

Rising levels of teenage crime have become a concern in a number of communities. This essay will consider the main factors that lead some young people into criminal behaviour and argue that schools have an important, though limited, role in preventing it.

A difficult home environment is often at the root of the problem. Teenagers who lack supervision or who experience conflict and neglect at home may look for a sense of belonging elsewhere, sometimes in gangs that offer loyalty and status. Peer influence is closely connected to this. Adolescents are especially sensitive to the approval of their friends, and within certain groups, activities such as shoplifting or vandalism can be seen as a way of proving oneself. Economic disadvantage also plays a part, since young people growing up in deprived areas may have few legitimate opportunities and see crime as an easy way to obtain money or possessions.

Schools are well placed to address several of these factors. Because teachers see students daily, they are often the first adults to notice warning signs such as persistent absence, aggressive behaviour or sudden changes in friendship groups, and they can refer these students to counsellors or social services at an early stage. Schools can also provide constructive alternatives by running after-school clubs, sports teams and mentoring schemes, which give teenagers both supervision and a positive identity. Moreover, keeping students engaged in learning is itself a form of prevention, as those who are excluded or leave early are far more vulnerable to be drawn into crime. However, schools cannot be expected to solve the problem alone, and they need support from families and local authorities.

In conclusion, teenagers become involved in crime mainly because of family difficulties, peer pressure and poverty. Schools can play a valuable role through early intervention, extracurricular activities and keeping students in education, but prevention requires a wider community effort.

Band 8

332 words

Both questions fully addressed, with causes explicitly matched to school responses · skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (compound, truancy, escalate) · a wide range of structures used accurately and naturally.

Teenage crime attracts considerable public attention, and in some areas it appears to be rising. Although there is no single explanation for why young people offend, the most common causes are social rather than individual, and schools, where adolescents spend much of their time, are in a strong position to help prevent it.

The family environment is frequently the starting point. Young people who grow up with little supervision, or amid conflict and instability, may lack both the guidance and the emotional security that discourage risky behaviour. In such circumstances, the pull of peers becomes especially powerful. Adolescence is a stage at which acceptance by one's group matters intensely, and where that group treats theft or violence as a badge of status, the pressure to participate can be difficult to resist. Poverty and a lack of opportunity compound these influences: in neighbourhoods where jobs are scarce and youth facilities have closed, crime may seem to offer money, excitement and respect that are unattainable by legitimate means.

Schools can respond to each of these pressures. With the most regular contact with young people of any institution, they are ideally placed to identify early warning signs, such as truancy, declining grades or abrupt changes in behaviour, and to connect vulnerable students with counselling before problems escalate. They can also offer the sense of belonging that some teenagers seek elsewhere, through sports teams, creative projects and mentoring by trusted adults. Perhaps most importantly, schools should work hard to keep struggling pupils in education rather than resorting quickly to exclusion, since those who drop out are left with time on their hands and diminished prospects. Nevertheless, schools cannot compensate entirely for problems at home, and their efforts are most effective when coordinated with families and local services.

In conclusion, youth crime is driven largely by family instability, peer pressure and lack of opportunity. Schools can make a significant contribution through early identification, positive activities and inclusive policies, but only as part of a broader, coordinated approach.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

News and echo chambers

Topic: Media · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_12

Many people choose to read or watch only news that supports opinions they already hold. Why do people do this? What effects does this have on society?

Band 6

275 words

Answers both questions with relevant points · ideas generalised and briefly supported · formulaic linking (Firstly, Secondly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · recurring subject-verb agreement and article errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays many people only read news or watch programmes which agree with their own opinions. This essay will explain the reasons for this behaviour and the effects which it has on society.

There are several reasons why people do this. The first reason is that it is more comfortable. When people read something that agree with their ideas, they feel happy and confident, but when they read the opposite opinion they feel angry or uncomfortable. Secondly, social media and websites use algorithms which show users the same kind of news that they clicked before. For example, if someone like a political party and reads about it online, the website will show him more articles supporting this party. Also, many people are busy and they do not have time to search for different sources, so they just follow the news channel their family always watched.

This habit has several negative effects on society. Firstly, people become more extreme in their opinions because they never hear other sides of the argument. Secondly, society becomes divided into groups who do not understand each other and they argue a lot, especially on the internet. For instance, during elections, supporters of different parties often insult each other online instead of discussing. Moreover, it is easier for fake news to spread, because people believe any information that support their view without checking it.

In conclusion, people choose news which match their opinions because it feels comfortable and because of algorithms and lack of time. This makes society more divided and helps fake news to spread. I think people should try to read news from different sources to have more balanced view.

Band 7

303 words

Clear position with both questions answered and extended · coherent paragraphs with a clear central idea · good range of vocabulary (political slant, polarisation, social cohesion) · frequent error-free sentences with one agreement slip.

With a vast range of news sources now available, many people choose to consume only those that confirm their existing beliefs. This essay will explain why this tendency has become so common and discuss its effects on society, which I believe are largely harmful.

One key reason is psychological. People naturally prefer information that supports what they already think, because it makes them feel intelligent and secure, while opposing views can cause discomfort or even anger. The structure of the modern media landscape strengthens this tendency. Social media platforms and news apps use algorithms to recommend content similar to what users have previously clicked on, so a person who reads one article with a particular political slant will be shown many more like it. In addition, some news outlets deliberately

target an audience with a clear political identity, since loyal viewers who share their outlook are commercially valuable.

The consequences for society are serious. First, when individuals are only exposed to one perspective, their opinions tend to become more extreme, as they rarely meet persuasive counter-arguments. This contributes to political polarisation, in which different groups not only disagree but regard each other with suspicion or hostility. Public debate suffers as a result, since it becomes difficult to reach compromise on important issues like climate policy when each side has different facts. Second, selective consumption helps misinformation spread more easily, because people are less likely to question a false story if it fits what they want to believe. Some argue that like-minded communities give people a sense of belonging, but this benefit hardly outweighs the damage to social cohesion.

In conclusion, people choose news that reflects their opinions because it is psychologically comforting and because algorithms and media companies encourage it. This leads to polarisation, weaker public debate and the rapid spread of misinformation.

Band 8

304 words

Both questions answered with a clear, sustained position · ideas developed with precise cause-effect reasoning · sophisticated vocabulary used naturally (validated, inhabit, fertile ground) · wide range of error-free complex structures.

The modern media landscape offers an almost unlimited choice of news sources, yet many people use this freedom to confine themselves to outlets that echo what they already believe. This behaviour has deep psychological roots and is reinforced by technology, and its effects on society are, in my view, predominantly damaging.

At the most basic level, people seek out confirming information because it is reassuring. Having one's views validated produces a sense of certainty and belonging, whereas encountering strong counter-arguments can be unsettling and may even feel like a personal attack. This natural bias is amplified by the design of digital platforms. Recommendation algorithms are optimised for engagement, and since users tend to click on content that aligns with their views, they are fed a steady diet of similar material until alternative perspectives effectively disappear from their screens. Commercial incentives play a role as well: news organisations have discovered that cultivating a loyal audience with a distinct ideological identity can be more profitable than attempting to appeal to everyone.

The social consequences are significant. When citizens inhabit separate informational worlds, they lose not only a shared set of opinions but also a shared set of facts, which makes productive debate extremely difficult. Views tend to harden, since they are rarely tested against opposing evidence, and people increasingly regard those who disagree not as fellow citizens with different priorities but as ignorant or malicious. This polarisation can paralyse decision-making on complex issues that require compromise. Furthermore, echo chambers provide fertile ground for misinformation, because claims that flatter a group's assumptions are shared eagerly and seldom checked.

In conclusion, selective news consumption stems from a desire for reassurance, reinforced by algorithms and commercial strategy. Its effects, including polarisation, the erosion of common ground and the spread of falsehoods, pose a real threat to healthy public discourse.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Engaging with local history

Topic: Culture · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_two-part_13

Many people enjoy learning about the history of the place where they live. Why is this?
How can local history be made more interesting for young people?

Band 6

279 words

Both questions answered with relevant, familiar ideas · limited development and some repetition · mechanical sequencing (Firstly, Second) · adequate vocabulary with some wrong choices (remember dates) · errors in articles, possessives and agreement.

Many people like to learn about the history of their town or city. This essay will explain why people enjoy this and how local history can be more interesting for young generation.

There are some reasons why people are interested in local history. Firstly, it helps them to understand their identity. When people know how their town was built and what happened there in the past, they feel more proud and connected to their home. Secondly, local history is easier to imagine than world history because people can see the old buildings, bridges or monuments every day. For example, if there is an old castle in the city, people are curious to know who lived there. Also, some people learn about local history because their own family lived in the area for many years and they want to know about their grandparents life.

However, many young people think history is boring because they only read books and remember dates at school. There are some ways to change this. First, schools can organise trips to museums and historical places, so students can see things with their own eyes. Second, technology can be used, for example apps or videos which shows how the town looked hundred years ago. Young people love technology, so this will attract them. Another idea is to invite old people from the community to school to tell stories about the past, which is more interesting than a textbook.

In conclusion, people enjoy local history because it gives them identity and it is easy to connect with. To make it interesting for young people, schools should use trips, technology and stories from older people instead of only books.

Band 7

307 words

Both parts answered clearly with extended, well-illustrated ideas · clear topic for each paragraph · good range of vocabulary (tangible, rooted, first-hand accounts) · mostly accurate structures with one agreement slip.

Local history attracts a surprising amount of interest, with many people visiting museums, joining heritage walks or reading about the origins of their town. This essay will discuss the reasons for this interest and suggest ways to make the subject more engaging for younger generations.

One important reason is that local history provides a sense of identity and belonging. Knowing how a community developed, for example why a market town grew up beside a particular river or how local industries shaped the lives of previous residents, helps people feel rooted in the place where they live. Local history is also more tangible than national or global events. People pass historic buildings, statues and street names every day, and learning the stories behind them makes familiar surroundings more meaningful. In addition, many people have a personal connection to the past through their own families, and researching local records can reveal how

their ancestors lived and worked.

Young people, however, often regard history as a dry subject, so it needs to be presented in more active ways. One effective approach is to take learning out of the classroom. Guided visits to historic sites, or projects in which students investigate the history of their own street, allow them to discover information for themselves rather than memorise facts. Technology can also help. Interactive apps could show teenagers how a square looked centuries ago, while local museums could use social media to share short and entertaining stories. Finally, involving older residents is valuable, as hearing first-hand accounts of how the town has changed make the past feel real and personal.

In conclusion, people enjoy local history because it strengthens their identity and connects them with familiar places and their own families. For young people, hands-on projects, digital tools and contact with older generations can transform it into a lively and relevant subject.

Band 8

323 words

Both questions fully answered with well-developed, specific ideas · logical sequencing and seamless cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (continuity, intersects, ownership of their findings) · wide range of error-free structures.

For many people, the history of their own town or region holds an appeal that grand narratives of empires and wars cannot match. This enthusiasm stems largely from the personal and tangible nature of local history, and although young people are often less engaged, there are effective ways of bringing the subject to life for them.

The most fundamental reason is that local history helps people understand who they are. Learning why a village grew up around a particular crossroads, or how a factory once sustained an entire neighbourhood, gives residents a sense of continuity that can be especially valuable in a rapidly changing world. Local history is also immediate in a way that national history rarely is. The evidence is visible in everyday surroundings, from the architecture of the high street to the names of lanes and pubs, so each discovery transforms a familiar route into something richer. Finally, it often intersects with family history; parish records or old photographs may reveal where one's great-grandparents worked or worshipped, creating a direct emotional link with the past.

Engaging young people requires moving away from passive learning. Rather than being presented with dates and summaries, students could act as historians themselves, interviewing elderly residents, examining old maps or investigating the history of their own school. Such projects give them ownership of their findings and reveal that history is made up of real people's lives. Digital technology offers further possibilities: augmented reality apps can overlay historical images onto present-day streets, and short video formats allow students to share what they have uncovered in a style that appeals to their peers. Local museums, too, can attract younger audiences with interactive exhibitions rather than static displays.

In conclusion, local history resonates with people because it strengthens identity, gives meaning to familiar places and connects them with their ancestors. By encouraging active investigation and embracing digital media, schools and museums can make it equally compelling for the young.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Travelling for the photograph

Topic: Tourism · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_14

Many tourists now visit places mainly to take photographs to share online. Why is this happening? How does it change the experience of travelling?

Band 6

280 words

Both questions addressed with a clear view · relevant examples but limited depth · basic linking (Secondly, Also) · simple vocabulary (nice, beautiful) · errors with verb forms, prepositions and quantifiers.

Nowadays many tourists travel to famous places mainly because they want to take photos and post them on social media. This essay will explain why this is happening and how it change the experience of travelling.

There are several reasons for this trend. The main reason is the popularity of social media like Instagram and TikTok. People want to show to their friends and followers where they have been, and they feel happy when they get many likes and comments. Secondly, nowadays every person has a smartphone with a good camera, so taking photos is very easy and cheap. In the past, people used film cameras and they could only take few pictures. Also, some places become famous only because they look beautiful in photos, for example colourful streets or special cafés, so tourists go there to take the same picture which they saw online.

This trend changes travelling in several ways, mostly negative. Firstly, tourists spend a lot of time looking at their phone screens instead of enjoy the place. For example, some people visit a beautiful beach but they spend one hour to take selfies and do not relax. Secondly, famous photo spots become very crowded, and tourists have to wait in long queues only for one picture. This can also be a problem for local people who live there. On the other hand, photos can help people to remember their holiday and share their experience with family.

In conclusion, tourists take many photos for social media because it is popular and easy with smartphones. I think this makes travelling less enjoyable because people do not really experience the place, although photos can be a nice memory.

Band 7

301 words

Clear position with both questions answered and extended · logical progression and effective paragraphing · good range of vocabulary (itineraries, photogenic, overlooked) · frequent error-free sentences with one parallelism slip.

In recent years, many travellers seem more concerned with capturing images for social media than with exploring the places they visit. This essay will examine the causes of this development and discuss how it is changing the nature of travel.

The rise of image-based social media platforms is the most obvious cause. Sharing holiday photographs has become a way of presenting an attractive lifestyle to friends and followers, and the positive feedback in the form of likes and comments can be highly rewarding. Travel has therefore become, for some people, a means of building an online identity. At the same time, the tourism industry has adapted to this demand. Hotels, restaurants and even local councils create colourful murals, viewing platforms and other photogenic spots, knowing that shared images act as free advertising. Smartphones with high-quality cameras have also made it effortless to take hundreds of photographs in a single day.

This shift has altered the travel experience in significant ways. For many tourists, the focus has moved from experiencing a place to documenting it, so they may spend more time arranging the perfect shot than appreciating the atmosphere, talking to local people or learning about the history of a site. Travel itineraries are increasingly shaped by what looks impressive on a screen, which means that lesser-known but interesting places can be overlooked. Popular photo spots, meanwhile, become overcrowded, spoiling the visit for other travellers and creating problems for residents. Nevertheless, photography is not entirely negative; it can encourage people to notice details and helps them to preserve memories.

In conclusion, the desire to share images online, the tourism industry's response and easy access to cameras have made photography central to modern tourism. While it helps people record their journeys, it often turns travel into a performance rather than a genuine experience.

Band 8

331 words

Both questions answered with insight and a nuanced conclusion · ideas extended and logically sequenced · sophisticated, natural vocabulary (self-presentation, capitalise on, converge) · wide range of structures, error-free.

At many famous landmarks, it is now common to see visitors queuing not to enter a building or admire a view, but to reproduce a photograph they have already seen online. This trend reflects the central role of social media in modern life, and it is subtly changing what it means to travel.

The underlying cause is the way image-sharing platforms have turned travel into a form of self-presentation. A holiday was once a private experience, recounted afterwards to a few friends; today it can be broadcast in real time to hundreds of followers, and the approval this generates offers a powerful incentive to seek out striking backdrops. Influencers amplify the effect by popularising particular viewpoints, which then become obligatory stops for their audiences. The tourism industry has been quick to capitalise on this, designing hotels, cafés and attractions with photogenic features precisely because every shared image serves as free promotion. Ubiquitous smartphone cameras, of course, have removed any practical limit on how many pictures can be taken.

The consequences for the experience of travelling are considerable. When the primary goal is to capture an image, attention shifts from the place itself to how it will appear to others, and the unplanned encounters and quiet observation that once defined travel can be crowded out. Itineraries also become more uniform, as visitors converge on the same well-known spots while neighbourhoods without an obvious visual hook are ignored. For residents of popular destinations, this concentration brings congestion, while visitors may arrive only to find a place swamped by others with the same idea. That said, photography can still enrich travel when it encourages people to look closely and preserve meaningful memories rather than simply to accumulate evidence of having been somewhere.

In conclusion, photo-driven tourism has grown out of social media culture, industry marketing and constant access to cameras. While it need not be harmful, it risks turning travel from an act of discovery into a performance staged for an online audience.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Rebuilding trust in science

Topic: Science · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_two-part_15

In some countries, public trust in scientists and experts appears to be declining. Why might this be happening? How could this trust be rebuilt?

Band 6

270 words

Both questions answered with relevant causes and solutions · points explained only briefly · formulaic linking (Firstly, First of all, Also) · adequate vocabulary · errors with uncountable nouns, articles and prepositions.

In some countries, many people do not trust scientists and experts as much as before. This essay will discuss the reasons for this problem and how the trust can be built again.

There are several reasons why people lose trust in scientists. Firstly, the internet and social media spread a lot of false information. Anybody can post an article or video which says scientists are lying, and many people believe it because it looks convincing. Secondly, sometimes experts change their advice. For example, during a health crisis, experts may give one advice at the beginning and then different advice later, so people think that they do not know what they are doing. Another reason is that some people think scientists work for governments or big companies and they only say what these organisations want. This makes people suspicious about their research.

There are some ways to rebuild the trust. First of all, scientists should explain their work in simple language, so ordinary people can understand it. Many research is written with difficult words, so people cannot follow it. Secondly, scientists should be honest when they are not sure about something and explain that science changes when new evidence is found. Also, governments should make clear rules about who pays for research, so people know the scientists are independent. Finally, schools should teach students how to check information online and recognise fake news.

In conclusion, people trust scientists less because of fake news online, changing advice and the belief that experts are not independent. To rebuild trust, scientists must communicate more clearly and honestly, and people need better education about information.

Band 7

305 words

Both questions answered with clear, extended explanations · logical organisation with effective topic sentences · good less common vocabulary (sceptical, credibility, conflicts of interest) · mostly error-free, with an article slip and an agreement slip.

Although science has brought enormous benefits to society, there are signs in some countries that the public is becoming more sceptical about the advice of scientists and other experts. This essay will explore the reasons behind this decline in trust and suggest how it might be restored.

A major reason is the changing way in which information is shared. Social media allows anyone to publish claims that contradict scientific evidence, and because such content is often emotional and simple, it can spread faster than careful explanations. When people see many confident voices questioning experts, it becomes harder for them to know who to believe. Another cause is the way scientific uncertainty is misunderstood. Science develops as new evidence emerges, so recommendations sometimes change, but members of the public may

interpret this as inconsistency or even incompetence. Trust has also been damaged by a perception that experts are connected to political or commercial interests. When research is funded by large companies, some people suspect that conclusions are influenced by those who pay for them.

Rebuilding trust will require several steps. Firstly, scientists need to communicate more directly and accessibly, explaining not only what they have found but also how they reached their conclusions and what remains uncertain. Being open about the limits of knowledge can actually increase credibility, because it shows honesty. Secondly, greater transparency about funding and conflicts of interest would reassure people that research is independent. In addition, education system could place more emphasis on how science works, teaching students to evaluate evidence and identify unreliable sources, so that future citizens are better equipped to judge competing claims.

In conclusion, declining trust in experts stems from the spread of misinformation, misunderstanding of scientific uncertainty and suspicion of hidden interests. Clearer communication, transparency and better science education offers the most promising route to restoring confidence.

Band 8

332 words

Both questions fully addressed with perceptive, well-supported analysis · causes and solutions logically connected · precise academic vocabulary (provisional, candid, hidden agendas) · wide range of complex structures without error.

In several countries, the authority once enjoyed by scientists and other experts appears to be weakening, with some people openly dismissing expert advice on matters ranging from medicine to climate. This decline has multiple causes, some rooted in technology and others in the conduct of experts themselves, and restoring trust will require changes on both sides.

The transformation of the information environment is a central factor. Online platforms allow unverified claims to circulate as widely as peer-reviewed findings, and content that is dramatic or emotionally charged typically travels further than cautious, qualified explanations. In this crowded space, genuine expertise can appear to be merely one opinion among many. A second factor is a widespread misunderstanding of how science works. Scientific knowledge is provisional by nature, so advice is revised as evidence accumulates; however, to those who expect definitive answers, such revisions can look like confusion or deception. Finally, trust has been eroded by perceptions of bias. When experts are seen to be closely aligned with governments, or when research is funded by industries with a financial stake in the outcome, it is easy to suspect that conclusions have been shaped by interests rather than evidence.

Rebuilding confidence must therefore begin with openness. Scientists and public bodies should explain not only what they recommend but why, and be candid about uncertainty rather than projecting a false certainty that later has to be withdrawn. Full disclosure of funding sources would go some way towards addressing suspicions of hidden agendas. Experts also need to engage with communities directly, through local events and accessible media, rather than communicating solely through official statements. In the longer term, education has a vital role: teaching young people how evidence is gathered and assessed would equip them to distinguish credible research from persuasive misinformation.

In conclusion, trust in experts is being undermined by an unregulated information environment, misconceptions about scientific uncertainty and suspicions of bias. Greater transparency, honest communication and stronger scientific literacy offer the best prospect of restoring it.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Technology and free time

Topic: Work-life balance · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_16

Although modern technology saves time on many everyday tasks, many people feel they have less free time than ever. Why is this? What can be done to help people have more free time?

Band 6

272 words

Both questions answered with relevant, practical points · solutions briefly developed · mechanical linking (Firstly, Secondly, Finally) · adequate everyday vocabulary · errors in prepositions, articles and agreement that do not affect understanding.

Today we have many machines and devices which make our daily tasks faster, for example washing machines, dishwashers and online shopping. However, many people say that they have less free time than before. This essay will explain why this happens and what can be done about it.

There are some reasons for this problem. The main reason is that technology makes people work more. Because of smartphones and emails, people can be contacted by their boss in any time, even in the evening or at the weekend, so work never finish. Secondly, people spend a lot of their free time on social media and watching videos, and they do not notice how many hours they lose. For example, someone may plan to check their phone for five minutes but then scroll for one hour. Also, life today is more competitive, so people try to do more activities, such as taking extra courses or working second job, to earn more money.

There are several things that can help people to have more free time. Firstly, companies should make rules that employees do not have to answer emails after working hours. Secondly, people should control how much time they spend on their phones, for example by turning off notifications or using apps which limits screen time. Finally, people should learn to say no to some activities and choose what is really important for them.

In conclusion, people feel they have less free time because technology connects them to work all the time and because they waste time on their phones. I think both employers and individuals needs to make changes to solve this problem.

Band 7

308 words

Both parts answered clearly with extended reasoning · good paragraph organisation and a range of cohesive devices · appropriate collocations (right to disconnect, blurred boundary) · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

Modern technology has dramatically reduced the time needed for many routine tasks, from washing clothes to paying bills. Paradoxically, however, many people complain that they have less leisure time than ever. This essay will explain the reasons for this contradiction and suggest ways of addressing it.

One important reason is that the time saved by technology is often filled with more work. Laptops and smartphones mean that employees can be reached at any hour, and many feel obliged to reply to messages in the evening or at weekends, so the boundary between work and home life has become blurred. In addition, expectations have risen along with efficiency. Because tasks can be completed more quickly, employers and individuals simply try to do more of them, and people end up busier rather than more relaxed. Technology also consumes free

time directly. Social media and streaming services are designed to hold users' attention, and hours spent scrolling often feel neither restful nor satisfying, which increases the impression that there is never enough time.

Several measures could help to address this situation. At the workplace level, companies could introduce clear policies limiting contact outside working hours, and governments could consider a legal right to disconnect. More flexible working arrangements, such as compressed working weeks, might also give employees longer periods of genuine rest. On a personal level, individuals can take control of their digital habits by disabling non-essential notifications, setting limits on app usage and keeping certain times of the day free from screens. Finally, people may benefit from prioritising fewer activities rather than trying to fill every moment productively.

In conclusion, people have less free time despite technological progress because work has expanded into their personal lives, expectations have risen and digital entertainment absorb many hours. Workplace policies and more mindful use of technology could help them regain valuable leisure time.

Band 8

327 words

Both questions answered fully with a well-reasoned explanation of the paradox · ideas logically sequenced and developed · wide, precise vocabulary (drudgery, reabsorbed, curbing) · wide range of accurate structures.

Technology has spared people countless hours of domestic drudgery and administrative effort, yet complaints about a lack of time have never been more common. This apparent contradiction can be explained by the way the time saved is reabsorbed by work and digital distraction, and reclaiming leisure will require action from employers, governments and individuals alike.

The first explanation lies in the erosion of boundaries between work and private life. Devices that make it possible to work from anywhere also make it possible to be contacted everywhere, and in many workplaces an unspoken expectation has developed that emails will be answered promptly, whatever the hour. As a result, even time spent at home is frequently interrupted by professional demands. Secondly, efficiency tends to raise expectations rather than reduce effort: when a task can be completed in half the time, the typical response is to take on more tasks, not to rest. Finally, much of the time technology frees is quietly consumed by technology itself. Social media feeds and streaming platforms are deliberately designed to be absorbing, and hours spent on them rarely feel like genuine leisure, leaving people both occupied and unrefreshed.

Addressing the problem requires structural as well as personal change. Employers could make it clear that staff are not required to respond outside working hours, and legislation guaranteeing a right to disconnect would give such policies greater force. Shorter working weeks, where output can be maintained, would allow productivity gains to be shared with workers as additional free time rather than extra workload. Individuals, too, can reclaim hours by curbing their use of attention-grabbing apps, disabling notifications and deliberately protecting periods of the day for rest, hobbies or social contact.

In conclusion, people feel short of time because technology has extended the reach of work, raised expectations and created new distractions. Firmer boundaries set by employers and governments, combined with more deliberate personal habits, would allow the time saved by technology to become genuine free time.

☐ Approved	☐ Needs changes	Notes:
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The rise of living alone

Topic: Housing / Society · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_17

More and more people are choosing to live alone. Why is this happening? What effects does this trend have on society?

Band 6

276 words

Both questions answered with relevant reasons and effects · ideas stated simply with limited development · mechanical linking (Firstly, Also, First) · adequate vocabulary · errors in agreement and articles that do not block meaning.

In many countries, the number of people who live alone is growing quickly. This essay will explain the reasons for this trend and discuss its effects on society.

There are several reasons why more people live alone. Firstly, people today get married later than in the past, and some decide not to marry at all. Young adults want to focus on their career and enjoy their freedom, so they rent a small flat by themselves. Secondly, many people move to big cities for work, far away from their parents, so they have no choice except living alone. Also, there are more elderly people now because people live longer, and when their husband or wife die, they often continue to live alone in their house. Finally, some people simply prefer privacy and independence.

This trend has both positive and negative effects on society. On the positive side, people who live alone often spend more money on restaurants, entertainment and travel, which is good for the economy. However, there are more negative effects. First, it increase the demand for housing, because one person needs a whole apartment, so house prices become higher. Second, many people who live alone feel lonely, especially old people, and this can cause health problems. For example, an elderly woman who lives by herself may not talk with anyone for several days. As a result, government have to spend more money on social services.

In conclusion, more people live alone because they marry later, move to cities for work and live longer. I believe this trend has more negative effects than positive, because it makes housing more expensive and causes loneliness in the society.

Band 7

305 words

Clear position and both questions answered with extended support · logical organisation with clear topic sentences · good range of vocabulary (outlive, geographical mobility, housing supply) · mostly error-free with one agreement slip.

Single-person households have become increasingly common in many parts of the world. This essay will examine the main reasons for this trend and consider its impact on society, which I believe is mixed but raises some serious concerns.

One of the most significant reasons is a change in social attitudes. In the past, young people usually stayed with their parents until they married, but today marriage often happens later or not at all, and living independently is seen as a normal stage of adult life. Economic growth has also made this possible, since many young professionals earn enough to rent their own apartment. Another factor is the ageing population. As life expectancy increases, more elderly people outlive their partners and continue living in the family home on their own. In addition, greater geographical mobility means that people frequently move to cities far from their relatives for work or study.

This trend has several effects on society. From an economic perspective, it has created new markets for smaller homes, single-portion meals and services aimed at individuals. However, it also puts considerable pressure on housing supply, because more homes are needed to accommodate the same number of people, which pushes up rents and property prices, particularly in large cities. A more worrying consequence is social isolation. Although many people living alone have active social lives, others, especially the elderly, can go days without meaningful contact, and loneliness can harm both physical and mental health. This may increase the demand on healthcare and social services. Finally, weaker family networks means that fewer people can rely on relatives for care and support.

In conclusion, more people live alone because of changing attitudes to marriage, increased wealth, longer lives and greater mobility. While this trend offers freedom and new business opportunities, it also contributes to housing shortages and social isolation.

Band 8

318 words

Both questions fully addressed with a balanced, well-supported judgement · ideas logically sequenced across economic, environmental and social effects · wide, precise vocabulary (demography, dwellings, foster isolation) · consistently accurate complex structures.

Living alone, once associated mainly with widowhood or unusual circumstances, has become a mainstream choice in many societies. This shift reflects profound changes in values, economics and demography, and while it brings certain benefits, its wider effects on society are, on balance, a cause for concern.

Changing social norms are a key driver. Marriage now tends to occur later, if at all, and living independently is widely regarded as a desirable marker of adulthood rather than a temporary stage before settling down. Greater prosperity has enabled people to act on this preference, since many can afford a home of their own. Demographic trends reinforce the pattern: as life expectancy rises, a growing number of older people outlive their partners and choose to remain in familiar surroundings rather than move in with their children. Increased mobility plays a part as well, with people relocating for work to cities where they have no family ties.

The consequences are varied. Economically, single-person households have stimulated demand for compact apartments, convenience products and services tailored to individuals, and living alone allows people to pursue careers and interests with considerable freedom. However, because more dwellings are needed to house the same population, the trend places heavy strain on housing supply and contributes to rising rents in already crowded cities. It also has environmental implications, as people living alone typically consume more energy and space per person. Most significantly, it can foster isolation. Many who live alone lead rich social lives, but for others, particularly the elderly, solitude can turn into loneliness, with damaging effects on wellbeing. As traditional family networks thin out, the responsibility for care increasingly falls on public services.

In conclusion, the rise in solo living stems from evolving attitudes, economic independence, longer lifespans and mobility. Although it offers autonomy and new economic opportunities, its impact on housing, resources and social connection means that societies need to plan for its consequences.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Global brands and local culture

Topic: Globalisation · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_two-part_18

International brands and fast-food chains can now be found in almost every country in the world. Why has this happened? How does it affect local businesses and culture?

Band 6

275 words

Both questions answered with relevant points · effects discussed briefly and generally · repetitive vocabulary (companies, popular) · unclear reference in conclusion · errors in word order, articles and prepositions.

Today we can find international brands and fast-food restaurants almost in every country. This essay will explain why this has happened and how it affects local businesses and culture.

There are several reasons for this situation. Firstly, globalisation made trade between countries much easier than before. Many governments have reduced taxes on foreign companies, so big companies can open branches in other countries without many problems. Secondly, these brands are very popular, especially among young people, because they see them in films, on television and on the internet. For example, many teenagers want to eat in famous burger restaurants or wear sports shoes from well-known brands because they think it is modern and cool. Also, these companies have a lot of money for advertising, so they can attract customers everywhere.

This trend has some negative effects on local businesses and culture. International chains are usually cheaper and more famous, so small local shops and restaurants lose their customers and some of them have to close. For example, a family café may not survive when a big coffee chain opens on the same street. In addition, traditional food and clothes become less popular, especially with young generation, and every city starts to look the same with the same shops. However, there are also some positive effects. International companies create jobs for local people and they sometimes bring new ideas and higher standards of service which local businesses can learn.

In conclusion, international brands are everywhere because of globalisation, their popularity and strong advertising. Although they create jobs, I think they have a bad influence on small local business and traditional culture, so governments should protect them.

Band 7

307 words

Clear position on both questions with extended, relevant support · effective paragraphing and cohesion · good less common vocabulary (economies of scale, trade barriers) · frequent error-free sentences, one agreement slip.

Global brands and fast-food chains have spread to almost every corner of the world, from major capital cities to small towns. This essay will discuss the reasons for this expansion and examine its effects on local businesses and culture, which I believe are largely negative.

The main reason for this spread is economic globalisation. Over recent decades, many countries have opened their markets to foreign investment and reduced trade barriers, making it far easier for multinational companies to operate abroad. Improvements in transport and communication have also allowed these companies to manage supply chains across continents. Another important factor is the power of global media. Through films, television and social media, consumers around the world are exposed to the same brands, which become associated

with a modern, attractive lifestyle. As a result, a well-known coffee chain or clothing label can have instant appeal in a new market even before it opens its first store.

The effect on local businesses is often damaging. Multinational companies benefit from enormous marketing budgets and economies of scale, allowing them to offer lower prices and more consistent quality than small independent firms. Family-run cafés, restaurants and shops may therefore struggle to compete and eventually close down. Culturally, the growing dominance of global chains can weaken local traditions. When young people prefer international fast food to traditional dishes, or when high streets in different countries fill with identical shops, the distinctive character of a place begins to disappear. On the other hand, global brands do provide employment and sometimes encourage local firms to raise their standards, and some chains adapt their menus to local tastes.

In conclusion, international brands have spread because of open markets, better logistics and the influence of global media. While they create jobs, they often put pressure on local businesses and contribute to a loss of cultural diversity.

Band 8

315 words

Both questions answered with a clear, qualified position · well-developed ideas in logical sequence · wide, sophisticated vocabulary (courted, franchising, indistinguishable) · wide range of structures with no errors.

From burger chains to coffee houses and sportswear labels, a handful of international brands have established a presence in almost every country on earth. Their spread is the product of economic liberalisation and global media, and its effects on local enterprises and cultural identity are, in my view, more harmful than beneficial, although not uniformly so.

The expansion has been driven above all by the opening of national markets. As governments have lowered trade barriers and actively courted foreign investment, multinational corporations have found it increasingly straightforward to establish outlets abroad, often through franchising arrangements that limit their financial risk. Advances in logistics mean that products can be sourced and distributed across continents with remarkable efficiency. Equally important is cultural reach. Films, television and social media have familiarised audiences everywhere with the same logos, and for many consumers, particularly the young, these brands carry an aura of modernity and cosmopolitan status long before a branch opens nearby.

For local businesses, the arrival of a global chain can be devastating. Such companies enjoy economies of scale, sophisticated marketing and the ability to absorb initial losses, advantages that independent restaurants and shops simply cannot match. Where these smaller enterprises close, profits that once circulated within the community are instead transferred abroad. The cultural consequences are subtler but equally significant. As international menus and products become the norm, traditional cuisine and crafts may come to seem old-fashioned, and town centres across the world grow increasingly indistinguishable. Nevertheless, the picture is not entirely bleak: multinationals provide employment and training, many adapt their offerings to local tastes, and competition can prompt local firms to differentiate themselves by emphasising authenticity.

In conclusion, global brands have proliferated because of open markets, efficient supply chains and the influence of global media. Although they bring jobs and some healthy competition, they frequently undermine independent businesses and erode the cultural distinctiveness that makes places unique.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Foreign aid that works

Topic: International development · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_two-part_19

Wealthy countries often give financial aid to poorer countries. Why do they do this? What kind of help do you think is most effective in the long term?

Band 6

275 words

Both questions answered with a clear opinion · reasons relevant but briefly explained · simple linking (Secondly, Also, For instance) · adequate vocabulary · errors in articles and subject-verb agreement that do not block meaning.

Rich countries often give money to poor countries to help them. This essay will explain the reasons why they do this and which kind of help I think is the most effective in the long term.

There are several reasons for giving financial aid. The first reason is humanitarian. When there is a natural disaster like an earthquake or a flood, people in poor countries need food, water and medicine urgently, and rich countries want to help them because it is right thing to do. Secondly, wealthy countries also get benefits from giving aid. For example, they can build good relationship with the other country and later they can do business or trade with it. Also, some rich countries give aid because they want to have political influence in that region.

In my opinion, the most effective help in the long term is not only giving money but helping poor countries to develop themselves. Money can be spent quickly or can be stolen by corrupt officials, so the problem continue. Instead, rich countries should invest in education and training, so that people can get better jobs and earn their own money. For instance, building schools and training teachers will help a whole generation. Also, they can help to build infrastructure like roads, hospitals and clean water system, and share their technology with local farmers so they can grow more food.

In conclusion, wealthy countries give aid because they want to help people and also for their own economic and political benefits. I believe that education, infrastructure and technology is more useful than just money, because it helps poor countries to become independent in the future.

Band 7

312 words

Clear position with both questions answered and developed · logical progression from motives to solutions · good range of vocabulary (self-sufficient, diplomatic ties, dependency) · mostly accurate with one agreement slip.

Wealthy nations commonly provide financial assistance to less developed countries. This essay will explore the motives behind such aid and argue that support which builds long-term capacity, particularly in education and infrastructure, is more effective than direct financial transfers.

Wealthy countries give aid for a combination of moral and practical reasons. The most obvious motive is humanitarian: when poorer nations are affected by famine, conflict or natural disasters, there is a strong ethical case for helping those in need, and public opinion in donor countries usually approves. However, aid is also a tool of foreign policy. By supporting a developing country, a donor can strengthen diplomatic ties and gain influence in a strategically important region. There are economic motives as well, since growth in poorer countries can create new markets for the donor's exports, and some aid is even tied to the purchase of goods

or services from the donor nation. Finally, reducing poverty abroad may help to limit global problems such as the spread of disease.

As for long-term results, I believe aid which helps countries to become self-sufficient is the most valuable. Emergency funding is essential in a crisis, but continuous cash transfers can create dependency and are sometimes lost through corruption. By contrast, investment in education equips people with skills they can use for decades, and support for healthcare produces a healthier, more productive workforce. Projects such as roads, electricity networks and irrigation systems enable local businesses and farmers to increase their output and reach new markets. Such help works best when it is designed in partnership with local communities, so that projects meet genuine needs and is maintained after foreign experts leave.

In conclusion, wealthy countries give aid out of humanitarian concern as well as political and economic self-interest. In the long run, assistance that develops education, health and infrastructure is far more effective than simply providing money.

Band 8

327 words

Both questions answered with a sophisticated, clearly argued position · ideas extended and logically organised · precise, wide-ranging vocabulary (altruistic, diverted, pays dividends) · varied complex structures, error-free.

Financial aid from wealthy to poorer nations is a long-established feature of international relations, yet the reasons behind it are rarely purely altruistic, and the forms it takes vary greatly in their lasting impact. In my view, aid that strengthens a country's own capacity to generate wealth and provide services is by far the most effective over time.

The motives of donor countries are typically a blend of principle and self-interest. On a moral level, there is a widely shared sense that prosperous nations have an obligation to relieve suffering, particularly in the aftermath of disasters or during famines. At the same time, aid serves diplomatic ends. Supporting a developing country can secure its goodwill, strengthen alliances and extend a donor's influence in regions of strategic importance. Economic calculation also plays a role: a more prosperous partner becomes a larger market for exports and a more stable place to invest, and some aid is explicitly tied to contracts for the donor's own firms. Lastly, since epidemics and instability rarely respect borders, reducing poverty abroad can serve donors' own security.

When it comes to long-term effectiveness, the crucial distinction is between assistance that meets immediate needs and assistance that builds lasting capability. Emergency relief is indispensable in a crisis, but sustained cash transfers to governments risk fostering dependency and can be diverted by corruption. Investment in education, by contrast, pays dividends for generations, while support for primary healthcare raises productivity as well as wellbeing. Infrastructure such as reliable electricity, roads and irrigation enables farmers and entrepreneurs to expand, creating employment that no donation could sustain. These projects are most successful when shaped by local communities, which ensures that they reflect genuine priorities and continue once foreign involvement ends.

In conclusion, wealthy countries give aid out of a mixture of compassion, diplomacy and economic interest. The most effective long-term help is not money alone but investment in the education, health and infrastructure that allow poorer nations to prosper independently.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Young people and saving

Topic: Money and consumer behaviour · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_two-part_20

Many young people today find it difficult to save money. Why is this? What could encourage young people to save more?

Band 6

272 words

Both questions answered with relevant causes and suggestions · limited development of each idea · formulaic linking (Firstly, Secondly, Also) · some collocation errors · article and structure errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays many young people have problem to save money, even when they have a job. This essay will explain the reasons for this and suggest some ways to encourage them to save more.

There are several reasons why young people find it difficult to save. Firstly, the cost of living is very high today, especially in big cities. Rent, transport and food are expensive, so after paying all the bills, there is not much money left. Secondly, young people are influenced by social media and advertising. They see their friends or influencers buying new clothes, phones and going on holidays, and they want to do the same. Also, online shopping and credit cards make spending very easy, because you can buy something with one click and pay later. Another reason is that many young people did not learn how to manage money at school or at home.

There are some ways to encourage young people to save. Firstly, schools should teach financial education, for example how to make a budget and why saving is important. If students learn this early, they will have good habits in the future. Secondly, banks can offer special saving accounts for young people with higher interest, so saving becomes more attractive. There are also mobile apps which can save small amount of money automatically every time you spend. Finally, parents should give a good example and talk with their children about money.

In conclusion, young people find it hard to save because of high living costs, social pressure and easy spending. Financial education, special accounts and apps can help them to save more money for the future.

Band 7

311 words

Both questions answered clearly with extended, relevant support · logical organisation and good cohesion · less common vocabulary used appropriately (put money aside, incentives, overspend) · mostly error-free with one verb-form slip.

Many young adults today struggle to put money aside, even when they are in full-time employment. This essay will examine the main reasons for this difficulty and suggest measures that could encourage younger people to develop better saving habits.

The most significant factor is the high cost of living. In many cities, rents have risen much faster than wages, so a large proportion of a young person's income is spent on accommodation before other essential expenses such as transport and food are even considered. For those who are also repaying student loans, the money available for saving is even smaller. Consumer culture adds to the problem. Social media constantly exposes young people to images of fashionable products, restaurants and holidays, creating pressure to keep up with their peers. At the same time, contactless payments and 'buy now, pay later' services make spending so effortless that many people lose track of how much they have spent. Finally, a lack of financial education means that many young adults have never been taught how to

budget effectively.

Several steps could help to change this situation. Schools could make personal finance a compulsory part of the curriculum, teaching students how to plan a budget, understand interest and avoid unnecessary debt. Banks and technology companies also have a role to play; apps that automatically round up purchases and transfer the difference into a savings account make saving almost effortless. Governments could offer incentives, such as tax-free savings accounts or bonuses for young people saving towards their first home, which would give them a clear goal to work towards. In addition, clearer regulation of short-term credit would reduce the temptation to overspend.

In conclusion, young people find saving difficult because of high living costs, social pressure and easy access to credit. Financial education, smart technology and government incentives could encourage them to build more secure financial futures.

Band 8

322 words

Both questions fully answered with perceptive, well-developed ideas · skilful sequencing from causes to matching solutions · precise, natural vocabulary (outpaced, frictionless, harnessed) · wide range of accurate complex structures.

For many young adults, building up savings now feels like an unattainable goal. The explanation lies partly in economic conditions beyond their control and partly in a consumer environment that makes spending effortless, but there are practical ways in which saving could be made both easier and more appealing.

Structural pressures are the most obvious obstacle. Housing costs in many cities have far outpaced wages, so rent alone can absorb a substantial share of a young worker's income, and entry-level jobs are increasingly insecure or poorly paid. Loan repayments for education leave even less room for anything else. These constraints are compounded by the culture in which young people live. Social media presents a constant stream of holidays, restaurants and new products, making modest living feel like missing out, while frictionless digital payments and instalment schemes disguise the true cost of purchases. Furthermore, many young adults leave school without ever having been taught to budget, so even those with some spare income may lack the habits needed to retain it.

Encouraging saving therefore requires a combination of education, design and incentives. Personal finance should be taught in schools as a practical skill, covering budgeting, interest and the dangers of high-cost credit, so that good habits are formed before the first salary arrives. Financial technology can also be harnessed for positive ends: automatic transfers on payday and apps that round up transactions into savings make putting money aside the default rather than an act of willpower. Governments could strengthen motivation by offering bonuses or tax advantages on savings for specific goals, such as a first home, and tighter regulation of instalment schemes would make the cost of borrowing more transparent.

In conclusion, young people struggle to save because of high living costs, insecure work and a culture that encourages consumption. By teaching financial skills early, designing tools that make saving automatic and offering meaningful incentives, society could help them build greater financial security.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Studying at foreign universities

Topic: Universities · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_01

More and more students are choosing to study at universities in other countries. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

272 words

Clear position · relevant main ideas with simple examples but limited development · mechanical linking (The first reason, Secondly, Also) · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, a growing number of students decide to go to universities in foreign countries instead of studying in their home country. In my opinion, this is mainly a positive development, although there are some problems too.

The first reason why I think it is positive is that students can get a better education. Many universities in countries like the UK or Australia have modern facilities and experienced teachers, so students can learn things which is not available in their own country. For example, a student from a developing country who study engineering abroad can use advanced laboratories and learn the newest technology. When they return back home, they can use this knowledge to help the development of their country.

Secondly, living in another country helps young people to become more independent. They have to cook for themselves, manage their money and solve problems without the help of their parents. Also, they meet people from many different cultures, and this make them more open-minded. These skills are very useful when they start working, because many companies want employees who can work in international environment.

However, there are also some disadvantages. Studying abroad is very expensive, and some families have to borrow a lot of money for it. Moreover, some students do not come back after they graduate, so their home country lose talented people. This is a serious problem for poorer countries.

In conclusion, although studying abroad has some drawbacks such as the high cost and the loss of skilled people, I believe it is a positive development because it gives students a better education and helps them to grow as a person.

Band 7

285 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas extended and supported, some generalisation · logical paragraphs with a range of linkers · good collocation (job prospects, widen inequality) · mostly error-free with minor slips.

It has become increasingly common for young people to leave their home country in order to complete a degree abroad. While this trend brings certain risks, particularly for the countries that students leave behind, I believe that it is, on balance, a positive development.

The most obvious benefit is academic. Universities in popular destinations often offer research facilities, specialist courses and teaching methods that are simply not available in many students' home countries. A medical student from a country with few training hospitals, for instance, may gain far more practical experience at an overseas institution. Moreover, an internationally recognised degree can significantly improve a graduate's job prospects, both at home and abroad.

Beyond the classroom, studying overseas develops personal qualities that are difficult to acquire elsewhere. Students must adapt to an unfamiliar culture, communicate in a second language every day and cope without their families nearby. As a result, they tend to return more confident, adaptable and tolerant of different viewpoints. In a globalised economy, these are exactly the qualities that employers are looking for.

Admittedly, the trend has a downside. Many graduates choose to stay in the country where they studied, which means that their home countries lose the talent they invested in during school years. In addition, the high cost of tuition and accommodation means that this opportunity is mostly available for wealthier families, which may widen inequality. Nevertheless, these problems can be reduced through scholarships and incentives that encourage graduates to return.

In conclusion, although studying abroad can contribute to a loss of skilled workers and is not accessible to everyone, its benefits for individual students and, ultimately, for their societies are greater. I therefore regard it as a largely positive development.

Band 8

298 words

Fully developed judgement · well-supported ideas at individual and societal level · drawbacks evaluated rather than listed · skilful cohesion · precise, natural vocabulary · wide range of structures, virtually error-free.

The number of students enrolling at universities outside their home countries has risen steadily in recent decades. Although this movement of young people is not without costs, I would argue that it is a predominantly positive development, both for the students themselves and for the wider world.

For individual students, the advantages are considerable. Studying abroad often provides access to specialised programmes, well-funded laboratories and academics at the forefront of their fields, resources that may be scarce at home. Equally valuable is the experience of living independently in an unfamiliar society. Navigating a new education system, managing a budget and building friendships across cultural and linguistic boundaries cultivate a degree of resilience that few domestic degrees can match.

The benefits also extend beyond the individual. International campuses bring together people who might otherwise never meet, and the professional networks formed there can later underpin cooperation between businesses, research institutions and even governments. When graduates return home, they frequently bring new expertise and fresh perspectives with them, which can stimulate innovation in sectors ranging from healthcare to engineering.

It would be naive, however, to ignore the drawbacks. The so-called brain drain is a genuine concern, as a proportion of graduates settle permanently abroad, depriving their home countries of skills that are badly needed. Furthermore, the considerable expense involved means that overseas study remains largely the preserve of affluent families. Yet these problems stem less from international study itself than from limited opportunities for graduates at home and insufficient financial support, both of which governments can address through targeted scholarships and incentives to return.

In conclusion, while the loss of talent and unequal access are legitimate concerns, the academic, personal and societal gains of studying abroad clearly outweigh them. This is, therefore, a trend to be welcomed rather than feared.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Everyday life moving online

Topic: Technology · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_02

Many people now do most of their everyday tasks, such as banking, shopping and dealing with government services, entirely online. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

271 words

Clear overall position · relevant but fairly general ideas · simple, mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary with some repetition · frequent errors in agreement, articles and plurals that do not impede communication.

These days, many people use the internet to do almost all their daily tasks, for example paying bills, buying food and contacting government offices. I think this is a positive development for most people, but it can cause problems for some groups.

The main advantage of doing things online is that it save a lot of time. In the past, people had to wait in long queue at the bank or at a government office, and sometimes they needed to take a day off work. Now they can transfer money or renew a document in few minutes from their home. This is very convenient, especially for people who is busy with work and family.

Another benefit is that online services are available all the time. Shops and offices close in the evening, but websites and apps are open 24 hours. People who live in villages far from the city can also use the same services as people in the city, so they do not need to travel.

On the other hand, not everyone is comfortable with technology. Many elderly people do not know how to use smartphones, and they may feel left behind when banks close their branches. In addition, there is a risk of online fraud. Some people lose their money because criminals steal their passwords or send fake emails.

In conclusion, I believe that doing everyday tasks online is mostly a positive development because it is fast and convenient for most people. However, the government and companies should still keep some offices open for people who cannot use internet, and they should teach people how to stay safe online.

Band 7

292 words

Clear position maintained · main ideas extended with relevant support · logical organisation and varied cohesion · good range of vocabulary (transparent, running costs) · mostly accurate grammar with an occasional slip.

In many parts of the world, people now manage their finances, do their shopping and even apply for official documents without leaving home. In my view, this shift to online services is largely positive, although it must be managed carefully so that vulnerable groups are not excluded.

The clearest benefit is convenience. Tasks that once required a trip across town and a long wait in a queue can now be completed in minutes on a smartphone, at any time of day. For working parents or people with demanding jobs, this saves hours every month. It also benefits those living in rural areas, who previously had to travel long distances to reach a bank branch or a government office.

Online systems can also make services more efficient and transparent. When forms are submitted digitally, applications are processed faster and there are fewer opportunities for

paperwork to be lost. In addition, digital records allow citizens to track the progress of a request, which reduce the frustration of not knowing what is happening. Governments and banks, meanwhile, can cut their running costs and, in theory, pass these savings on to the public.

Nevertheless, the move online has created real difficulties for some people. Older citizens and those on low incomes may lack the devices or skills needed to use digital services confidently, and as physical branches close, they risk being left without support. The growth of online fraud is another serious concern, since criminals increasingly target people who are unfamiliar with technology.

Overall, I believe the advantages of handling everyday tasks online outweigh the disadvantages, making this a positive development. However, it will only remain so if face-to-face options are kept for those who need them and people are taught how to protect themselves online.

Band 8

320 words

Clear, qualified judgement fully developed · ideas extended with precise examples · confident paragraphing and cohesion · wide, flexible vocabulary (hidden tax, accountable, compounds) · wide range of structures with rare errors.

Over the past two decades, the internet has quietly absorbed many of the routine chores of adult life. Bills are paid through banking apps, groceries arrive at the door and tax returns are filed on government portals. I consider this a broadly positive development, provided that it does not become compulsory for those unable to take part.

The most compelling argument in its favour is the time it returns to people. A task that might once have consumed an entire morning, involving a bus journey, a queue and a counter that closed at four o'clock, can now be completed during a lunch break. This flexibility is particularly valuable for shift workers, carers and residents of remote areas, for whom physical offices were always difficult to reach. In effect, digital services have removed a hidden tax on people's time.

There are systemic gains as well. Digital applications can be processed more quickly and consistently than paper ones, and the automatic record they create makes institutions more accountable. A citizen who can see exactly where a benefit claim has stalled is in a far stronger position than one waiting anxiously for a letter. Moreover, the savings from reduced administration can, at least in principle, be redirected towards improving the services themselves.

The danger lies in treating online access as universal when it is not. Many elderly people, as well as those who cannot afford reliable internet access, find digital systems bewildering, and the closure of branches can leave them dependent on relatives or simply unable to manage their own affairs. The rise of sophisticated online scams compounds this problem, as it is often the least confident users who are targeted.

In conclusion, the migration of everyday tasks online has made life markedly easier for the majority, and I therefore view it positively. Its benefits will only be fairly shared, however, if traditional channels remain available for those who still depend on them.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

AI as personal adviser

Topic: Artificial intelligence · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_positive-negative_03

Increasingly, people are asking artificial intelligence programs for advice on personal matters such as relationships and emotional difficulties. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

284 words

Clear negative position · both sides considered but ideas somewhat general · paragraphing logical though linking is formulaic · adequate vocabulary · several errors in agreement, determiners and word form that do not block meaning.

Recently, more people are using artificial intelligence programs to ask advice about their personal problems, like relationship problems or feeling sad. In my opinion, this is more a negative development than a positive one.

Some people think AI advice is useful. It is available at any time, even in the middle of the night, and it is free or very cheap. Also, some people feel shy to talk about their problems with friends or family, so they prefer to type their questions to a computer because nobody will judge them. For this people, AI can be a first step to understand their feelings.

However, I believe the disadvantages are more serious. Firstly, a computer program does not really understand human emotions. It gives answers based on data, but it does not know the person's full situation, their culture or their family history. Because of this, the advice can be too general or even wrong. For example, if someone has a serious problem in their marriage, a program cannot replace a trained counsellor who listen carefully and ask the right questions.

Secondly, people may become depend on AI and stop talking to real people. Friends and family give not only advice but also love and support, which a machine cannot give. If people share their problems only with a computer, they may feel more lonely in the long term. There is also a privacy problem, because personal information is saved by the companies who make these programs.

In conclusion, although AI can give quick and easy advice, I think this trend is negative because the advice is not always reliable and people can lose the real human connection that they need when they have difficulties.

Band 7

296 words

Clear negative position throughout · counter-argument acknowledged and main ideas well extended · clear progression with varied linkers · some less common vocabulary (plausible, confide) · frequent error-free sentences, occasional slip.

Artificial intelligence chatbots are no longer used only for practical tasks; many people now turn to them for guidance on their relationships and emotional struggles. Although this can offer some short-term comfort, I believe it is, overall, a negative development.

It is easy to understand the appeal. AI programs are available around the clock, cost little or nothing and, crucially, do not judge. A person who feels embarrassed about a problem may find it easier to describe it to a machine than to a friend, and the response can help them organise their thoughts. For people who live in areas with few counsellors, a chatbot may be the only source of guidance available.

However, these advantages are outweighed by several serious concerns. The most important is that AI does not truly understand the people it is advising. It produces plausible answers based on patterns in data, but it cannot read body language, notice what is left unsaid or take full account of a person's history. As a result, its advice may sound convincing while being inappropriate, and in situations involving serious emotional distress this could be harmful.

A further problem is the effect on human relationships. Talking through a difficulty with a friend or relative is not only a way of finding a solution; it also strengthens the bond between them. If people increasingly confide in software instead, they may become more isolated, which is the opposite of what someone in a difficult situation need. There are also questions about how technology companies store and use such sensitive conversations.

In conclusion, while AI can be a convenient starting point for reflecting on personal issues, relying on it for emotional advice is a worrying trend. It should complement, rather than replace, support from people and qualified professionals.

Band 8

322 words

Nuanced, clearly negative judgement · opposing view fairly evaluated · ideas extended with insightful examples · seamless cohesion · sophisticated, precise vocabulary · wide range of complex structures, essentially error-free.

As conversational AI has become more sophisticated, a growing number of people are consulting it about matters that were once discussed only with close friends, family members or therapists. While I accept that such tools can play a modest supporting role, I regard the broader trend as a largely negative one.

The case in favour deserves to be taken seriously. Chatbots are instantly accessible, inexpensive and endlessly patient, and for someone too ashamed or anxious to confide in another person, the anonymity of a screen may lower the barrier to seeking help at all. Articulating a problem in writing can itself bring clarity, and a well-designed program may point users towards professional services they would not otherwise have considered.

Yet the limitations are fundamental rather than incidental. Personal difficulties are rarely what they first appear to be; a dispute with a partner may be rooted in years of unspoken resentment, and low mood may signal a condition requiring clinical attention. A skilled counsellor draws on tone, hesitation and context to uncover these layers, whereas an AI can only respond to the words it is given. Its answers therefore tend towards the generic, and because they are expressed fluently and confidently, users may place more trust in them than they merit.

Perhaps more troubling is what this habit may do to human connection. Seeking advice from a friend is an act of trust that deepens relationships, and receiving support reminds people that they are not alone. If individuals increasingly bring their most intimate concerns to software designed to keep them engaged, they risk becoming more isolated precisely when they most need others. Entrusting commercial platforms with such sensitive information raises additional concerns about privacy.

In conclusion, AI may usefully serve as a first step, but as a substitute for human insight and care it is inadequate. For that reason, the growing reliance on it for personal advice should be viewed with considerable caution.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Banning single-use plastics

Topic: Environment · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_04

Some countries have introduced laws that ban single-use plastic products such as bags, straws and cups. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

268 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas with a personal example but limited depth · basic linking · adequate topic vocabulary · several errors in agreement, verb forms and articles.

In recent years, some governments have made laws to stop people using single-use plastic items like bags, straws and cups. In my opinion, this is a positive development, even though it can be inconvenient for some people at first.

The most important reason is that plastic is very harmful for the environment. Single-use items are used only for few minutes, but they stay in nature for hundreds of years. A lot of this plastic go into rivers and the sea, where fish and birds eat it and die. On many beaches, people can see bottles and bags everywhere, which is also bad for tourism. If these products are banned, the amount of rubbish will reduce a lot.

Another reason is that the ban changes people's habits. When shops stop giving free plastic bags, customers start to bring their own cloth bags. In my country, for example, after the government ban plastic bags, most people quickly got used to carry reusable bags, and now it is normal. So a law can teach people to think more about the environment in their daily life.

However, some people argue that the ban is not fair for small businesses, because paper or metal products is more expensive. Also, some disabled people need plastic straws to drink. These are real problems, but the government can help businesses with the cost and allow special exceptions.

In conclusion, I strongly believe that banning single-use plastic is a positive step, because it protects the environment and helps people to develop better habits. The small problems it cause are much less important than the benefits for nature.

Band 7

277 words

Clear position throughout · well-extended ideas on environmental damage and behaviour change · counter-argument answered · good cohesion · appropriate less common vocabulary · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

A number of countries have recently passed laws prohibiting single-use plastic items such as carrier bags, straws and disposable cups. Although these bans create some short-term difficulties, I firmly believe they are a positive development.

The main argument in favour is the scale of the environmental damage caused by disposable plastic. These products are typically used for a few minutes but can take centuries to break down, and a large proportion of them ends up in rivers and oceans rather than being recycled. Marine animals frequently become trapped in plastic waste or mistake it for food, and tiny plastic particles are now found in the food chain. Banning the most common items therefore tackles the problem at its source rather than relying on clean-up campaigns.

In addition, legislation is often more effective than voluntary change. For years, people have been encouraged to reuse bags and avoid plastic straws, yet many continued to use them

simply out of habit. When a ban is introduced, alternatives quickly become the norm; customers remember to bring their own bags, and cafes switch to paper or reusable options. Such laws also send a clear message that protecting the environment is a shared responsibility.

Critics point out that substitutes can be more expensive and that some people, including certain disabled individuals, genuinely rely on plastic straws. These are valid concerns, but they can be addressed through sensible exemptions and temporary support for small businesses, rather than by abandoning the policy altogether.

In conclusion, while bans on single-use plastic cause some inconvenience, the long-term benefits for wildlife, oceans and human health are far greater. For this reason, I consider them a clearly positive development.

Band 8

304 words

Unequivocal, well-argued judgement · ideas extended with clear causal reasoning · objections evaluated convincingly · skilful paragraphing and cohesion · precise, wide-ranging vocabulary · complex structures used accurately.

Governments in several countries have moved beyond encouraging responsible consumption and have begun to outlaw disposable plastic products altogether. Although such bans are sometimes dismissed as symbolic or inconvenient, I regard them as an unequivocally positive development.

The environmental rationale is difficult to dispute. Items such as straws and carrier bags serve their purpose for minutes yet persist in the environment for generations, and because they are light and cheap, they are among the items most likely to escape waste systems and end up in waterways. Once there, they entangle wildlife, break down into microplastics and ultimately return to humans through the food chain. Restricting their production addresses the problem at its origin, which is far more efficient than attempting to retrieve plastic once it has dispersed across coastlines and seabeds.

Equally significant is the effect such laws have on behaviour. Decades of public awareness campaigns achieved only modest results, largely because individual consumers had little incentive to abandon a convenient habit. A ban, by contrast, removes the choice and in doing so rapidly establishes a new social norm: carrying a reusable bag or cup soon feels unremarkable rather than virtuous. This shift can also stimulate innovation, as manufacturers compete to develop durable or biodegradable alternatives.

Opponents raise two legitimate objections. Replacement materials can be costlier for small retailers, and some people with disabilities depend on flexible plastic straws. Neither point, however, undermines the principle of a ban. Both can be accommodated through carefully designed exemptions and transitional support, and some substitutes carry their own environmental costs, which argues for promoting reuse rather than for retaining plastic.

In conclusion, laws against single-use plastics tackle a serious environmental threat directly and reshape everyday habits in a way that persuasion alone has failed to do. Provided they are implemented with appropriate flexibility, they deserve wholehearted support.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Redeveloping old industrial areas

Topic: Cities · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_05

In many cities, old industrial areas are being turned into expensive apartments, shops and cafes. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

258 words

Clear position · relevant main ideas with limited extension · mechanical sequencing (Firstly, Secondly, On the other hand) · adequate vocabulary · recurring subject-verb agreement errors that do not obscure meaning.

In many cities today, old factories and warehouses are being changed into expensive flats, shops and cafes. I think this is mostly a positive development, although it also has some negative effects on local people.

Firstly, redevelopment makes the city more beautiful and safer. Old industrial areas are often empty and dirty, and sometimes they become dangerous places at night. When these buildings are repaired and turned into apartments and cafes, the area becomes more lively and attractive. People start to walk there, go shopping and meet friends, so the whole neighbourhood improves.

Secondly, these projects are good for the economy. Building new apartments and shops creates many jobs, both during the construction and after that, in the cafes and stores. The city government also receives more money from taxes, which it can spend on public services like schools and transport. In addition, using old buildings is better than building on green land outside the city.

On the other hand, there is a big problem, which is that the new apartments are very expensive. Local people who lived near the old factories often cannot afford the higher rent, so they have to move to another area. This is unfair, because they lived there for many years and they lose their community.

In conclusion, I believe that turning old industrial areas into apartments, shops and cafes is a positive development because it improves the city and the economy. However, the government should make sure that some cheaper homes are also built, so local people can stay in their area.

Band 7

286 words

Clear negative position with benefits acknowledged · ideas extended and linked logically · clear central topic per paragraph · good collocations (priced out, social fabric) · largely accurate with an occasional agreement slip.

Across many cities, abandoned factories, docks and warehouses are being converted into luxury flats, boutiques and coffee shops. While such regeneration brings visible improvements, I believe that in its current form it is more of a negative development than a positive one, mainly because of its effect on existing residents.

Admittedly, there are clear benefits. Derelict industrial sites can be unsightly and even unsafe, and restoring them brings life back to neglected parts of a city. Converting existing buildings is also more sustainable than building on the countryside, and new businesses create jobs and generate tax revenue for local authorities. In some cases, historic industrial architecture is preserved that might otherwise have been demolished.

However, these benefits are not shared equally. As an area becomes fashionable, property prices and rents rise sharply, and long-term residents, who are often working-class families, are gradually priced out. The people who lived through the area's decline are therefore frequently unable to enjoy its revival. The small, affordable shops that served them are replaced by expensive cafes that cater mainly for newcomers and visitors.

Furthermore, this process can weaken the social fabric of a city. Established communities, with their networks of neighbours, schools and local organisations, are broken up when families are forced to move to cheaper districts further from the centre. Over time, cities risk becoming divided into wealthy inner areas and poorer outer suburbs, which increase inequality and commuting times for those with the lowest incomes.

In conclusion, although redeveloping old industrial areas improves the appearance and economy of cities, the displacement of local communities is too high a price to pay. Unless regeneration schemes include a significant share of affordable housing, I regard this trend as largely negative.

Band 8

321 words

Sophisticated, clearly reasoned negative judgement · opposing view given due weight · ideas fully extended · cohesion managed effortlessly · wide, precise vocabulary (polarised, clientele) · wide range of accurate structures.

In cities around the world, the disused factories and warehouses of a former industrial age are being reborn as upmarket apartments, independent boutiques and artisan cafes. This transformation is often celebrated as urban renewal, and in many respects it is. On balance, however, I believe its benefits are real but narrowly distributed, which makes it, as currently practised, a largely negative development.

The case for regeneration is by no means weak. Vacant industrial land tends to attract crime and dereliction, and bringing it back into use can revitalise surrounding streets. Reusing existing structures is also considerably more sustainable than expanding into greenfield sites, and it can preserve architecture that gives a city its distinctive character. Local authorities, meanwhile, benefit from higher tax receipts and new employment.

The difficulty lies in who ultimately enjoys these gains. Once a former industrial district acquires a reputation as fashionable, land values rise and rents follow. Long-standing residents, frequently on modest incomes, find themselves unable to remain in neighbourhoods they have lived in for decades, and the hardware shops and inexpensive cafes they relied upon give way to businesses aimed at a more affluent clientele. What is presented as improvement for an area can thus amount to the replacement of one population by another.

The wider consequences are equally concerning. When displaced families relocate to peripheral suburbs, they lose not only their homes but also the informal support networks that sustain communities, while facing longer and more expensive journeys to work. Repeated across a city, this pattern produces a polarised urban landscape in which the centre becomes the preserve of the wealthy.

In conclusion, converting industrial land into expensive housing and leisure spaces undoubtedly revitalises the physical fabric of cities, but it too often does so at the expense of the people who already live there. Unless such projects are required to include genuinely affordable homes, the trend should be viewed as more harmful than beneficial.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Hire scooters and bikes

Topic: Transport · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_06

Electric scooters and bicycles that can be hired by the hour are becoming common in many cities. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

274 words

Clear negative position · relevant ideas supported with a personal example but some are general · linking present but repetitive · adequate vocabulary · several errors in comparatives, agreement and plurals.

Nowadays, in many cities people can rent electric scooters and bicycles by the hour using a phone app. Although this idea seems modern and useful, I believe it is more a negative development than a positive one.

It is true that these vehicles have some advantages. They are cheap and easy to use for short journeys, for example from the train station to the office. They also do not produce pollution like cars, so they can help to reduce traffic and make the air more cleaner.

However, the biggest problem is safety. Many riders of electric scooters go very fast and they do not wear a helmet. Some of them ride on the pavement, which is very dangerous for pedestrians, especially old people and children. In my city, I often see scooters that nearly hit people who are walking, and there has been many accidents. Also, some users do not know the traffic rules, because they only use the scooter one or two time.

Another problem is that these scooters and bikes are often left everywhere. Because users can leave them in any place, many of them block the pavement or the entrance of buildings. This is annoying for everyone and particularly difficult for people in wheelchair or with a pushchair. In some places scooters are even thrown into rivers, which make more pollution.

In conclusion, although hire scooters and bicycles are convenient and do not pollute the air, I think they are a negative development because they cause accidents and make the streets messy. The government should make strict rules, for example speed limits and special parking areas, otherwise the problems will continue.

Band 7

282 words

Clear positive position throughout · ideas extended with specific support (last mile, congestion) · problems addressed logically · good range of linking · some less common vocabulary · mostly error-free.

Rentable electric scooters and bicycles, unlocked with a smartphone and paid for by the hour, have appeared on the streets of many cities in recent years. Despite some genuine problems, I believe this is a positive development for urban life.

The principal advantage is that these vehicles offer a practical alternative to cars for short trips. Many car journeys in cities cover only a few kilometres, which could easily be made by bike or scooter. Hire schemes make this option available to people who do not own a bicycle or have nowhere to store one. They are especially useful for the so-called last mile, the distance between a train station or bus stop and a person's final destination, and they can therefore encourage more people to use public transport.

Moreover, if these schemes replace even a small proportion of car journeys, the environmental benefits are significant. Fewer cars means less congestion, lower emissions and cleaner air, which improves public health. Cycling also provides exercise, and people who try a hire bike

may decide to cycle more regularly.

Of course, the schemes have caused problems. Scooters are sometimes ridden dangerously on pavements, and vehicles are frequently left lying in the middle of footpaths, creating obstacles for pedestrians, particularly those with poor eyesight or limited mobility. However, these are problems of management rather than reasons to reject the idea. Cities can introduce designated parking zones, speed limits and fines for irresponsible users, as some have already done successfully.

In conclusion, although shared scooters and bicycles require careful regulation, they provide a cheap, flexible and environmentally friendly way of getting around cities. For these reasons, I consider their growing popularity to be a positive trend.

Band 8

293 words

Clear, well-qualified positive judgement · ideas logically sequenced and fully extended · drawbacks weighed rather than listed · natural, precise vocabulary · wide range of structures with full control.

Dockless electric scooters and hire bicycles, located and unlocked through a smartphone, have become a familiar sight in many cities. Their arrival has provoked strong reactions, from enthusiasm about greener transport to irritation at cluttered pavements. Weighing these responses, I consider the trend a positive one, albeit one that demands firm regulation.

The strongest argument in their favour concerns the way people move through cities. A striking number of urban car journeys are short enough to be walked or cycled, yet habit and convenience keep drivers behind the wheel. Hire schemes lower the barriers to change: users need not buy, maintain or store a vehicle, and they can make a one-way trip without worrying about returning it. Crucially, scooters and bikes bridge the gap between public transport stops and people's homes or workplaces, making trains and buses a realistic option for those who previously found them impractical.

The potential environmental and social returns are considerable. Every car journey replaced reduces congestion and emissions, and cleaner streets benefit everyone, not only those who ride. For residents who cannot afford a car, affordable short-term hire also widens access to jobs and services across the city.

The drawbacks, nonetheless, are real and visible. Poorly parked scooters obstruct pavements, posing a particular hazard to blind and elderly pedestrians, and reckless riding has led to injuries. Yet these problems stem from the way schemes were initially introduced, often with minimal oversight, rather than from the vehicles themselves. Cities that have imposed designated parking bays, speed restrictions in pedestrian areas and penalties for operators have largely brought them under control.

In conclusion, shared scooters and bicycles offer a flexible, low-carbon complement to public transport. Provided that authorities regulate them rigorously, their spread should be welcomed as a positive development.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Monitoring employee productivity

Topic: Employment · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_07

Increasingly, companies are using computer software to monitor how productive their employees are. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

286 words

Clear negative position · relevant ideas with simple examples · paragraphing clear but linking mechanical and repetitive (On the other hand used twice) · adequate vocabulary · errors in agreement and word form.

Today, many companies use special software to check how hard their workers are working, for example by counting their keyboard use or taking screenshots of their computer. In my opinion, this is a negative development, although it has a few advantages for employers.

On the one hand, managers say that this software help them to make the company more efficient. They can see which employees are working hard and which are wasting time on social media. This information can be used to give rewards to good workers. Also, when people work from home, the manager cannot see them, so the software is the only way to check that they are doing their job.

On the other hand, I believe the disadvantages are much bigger. The first problem is that employees feel stressful when they know that a computer is watching them all the time. They may be afraid to take a short break or talk with colleagues, even though these things are normal and can help them to work better. As a result, their mental health can become worse.

The second problem is that the software does not measure real productivity. For instance, a designer who spend an hour thinking about a new idea may look lazy to the program, because he does not type anything. On the other hand, a worker who moves the mouse all day may look busy but produce nothing useful. So the company can make wrong decisions about their staff.

In conclusion, I think using software to monitor employees is a negative development because it creates stress and it cannot measure the quality of work properly. Companies should trust their staff more and judge them by the result of their work.

Band 7

294 words

Clear position maintained · counter-argument presented then rebutted with extended reasoning · logical progression and varied cohesion · good vocabulary (staff turnover, morale) · frequent error-free sentences.

With the growth of remote working, a rising number of employers have begun using software that records how long staff spend on particular tasks, which websites they visit and even how often they type. Although this technology may seem to offer greater efficiency, I believe it is essentially a negative development.

Supporters argue that monitoring tools give managers useful information. When teams work from home, it can be difficult to know whether tasks are being completed, and data on working patterns may help identify employees who are struggling or processes that waste time. Some also claim that such software is fair, since it judges everyone by the same objective standard.

However, the main weakness of this approach is that activity is not the same as productivity. Software can count keystrokes and log screen time, but it cannot measure the quality of a report, the value of a creative idea or the time an employee spends helping a colleague. As a

result, workers may learn to appear busy rather than to work well, for example by keeping their mouse moving or avoiding tasks that involve thinking away from the computer.

Perhaps more importantly, constant surveillance damages trust between staff and management. Employees who feel watched every minute are likely to experience higher levels of stress, and many will feel that their employer does not respect them as professionals. This can lower morale and, ironically, lead to lower productivity and higher staff turnover. There is also a risk that personal data collected in this way are misused.

In conclusion, while monitoring software may give employers a sense of control, it measures the wrong things and undermines the trust on which good workplaces depend. For these reasons, I consider its increasing use to be a negative trend.

Band 8

306 words

Clear, nuanced negative judgement · concession handled precisely · ideas developed with insightful reasoning · sophisticated cohesion and paragraphing · wide, precise vocabulary (perform busyness, erodes) · error-free complex structures.

Software that logs keystrokes, captures screenshots and scores employees on their apparent activity has spread rapidly, particularly since remote work became widespread. Employers present it as a neutral tool for improving efficiency, but I would argue that its growing use is, on the whole, a negative development.

It is not difficult to see why managers find such tools attractive. Supervising a dispersed workforce is genuinely challenging, and aggregated data can reveal bottlenecks, uneven workloads or employees who may need additional support. In highly routine roles, such as processing claims or answering calls, some measurement of output is both reasonable and long established.

The central flaw, however, is that these programs mistake visible activity for valuable work. Much of what makes an employee effective, whether analysing a problem, mentoring a junior colleague or simply thinking before acting, leaves little digital trace. A system that rewards constant typing and penalises periods of inactivity therefore encourages staff to perform busyness rather than to achieve results, and may even discourage the reflective work on which innovation depends. In this sense, monitoring can distort the very productivity it claims to measure.

Equally damaging is its effect on the relationship between employer and employee. Continuous surveillance communicates distrust, and people who feel perpetually observed tend to become anxious, less willing to take initiative and more inclined to leave. Talented staff, who have the greatest choice of employers, are often the first to go. Furthermore, the detailed personal data such systems accumulate create obvious risks if they are stored carelessly or used for purposes employees never agreed to.

In conclusion, although monitoring software can offer useful insights in certain narrowly defined roles, its widespread use rests on a flawed understanding of what productive work looks like and erodes workplace trust. Organisations would be better served by judging employees on the outcomes they deliver.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Power of technology giants

Topic: Business · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_positive-negative_08

A small number of very large technology companies now control much of the world's online activity. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

270 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas supported with personal examples but limited analysis · simple, mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · errors in agreement, plurals and quantifiers that do not impede meaning.

Today, only a few huge technology companies control most of what people do on the internet, such as searching for information, shopping and using social media. Some people worry about this, but in my opinion it is mostly a positive development for ordinary users.

The main reason is that these big companies can offer very good services, and many of them are free. For example, anyone can use a search engine, send emails or watch videos without paying any money. Because these companies are so rich, they can invest a lot in new technology and make their products fast and easy to use. A small company would not have enough money to do this.

Another advantage is that it is easier for people to communicate when everyone use the same platforms. My family live in different countries, but we can talk every day using one messaging app. Also, small businesses can sell their products all over the world through a big online marketplace, which was impossible in the past.

However, there are some disadvantages. When a few company have so much power, they can collect a huge amount of information about their users and use it for advertising. Some people feel that their privacy is not protected. In addition, it is difficult for new companies to compete with them, so there are less choices for customers.

In conclusion, although there are some problems with privacy and competition, I believe that this situation is generally positive, because big technology companies give people free, useful services and connect people around the world. However, governments should make laws to protect users' personal data.

Band 7

294 words

Clear negative position · benefits conceded then main ideas extended with examples · logical progression · good range of topic vocabulary (concentration of power, target advertising) · mostly accurate, one agreement slip.

A handful of enormous technology firms now dominate internet search, social networking, online shopping and cloud computing. Although these companies provide popular and often free services, I believe that such a concentration of power is a negative development.

It is true that their size has brought some benefits. Large firms can afford to invest heavily in research, and this has produced fast, reliable services that billions of people use every day. Because so many people use the same platforms, communication across borders has also become much easier.

However, the main problem is the lack of competition. When one company controls most of a market, it can buy up or copy smaller rivals, which makes it very hard for new businesses to

succeed. Without competition, there is less pressure to improve products or to treat customers and suppliers fairly. For example, independent sellers who depend on a single online marketplace may have to accept whatever fees and rules the platform decides to impose.

A second concern is the amount of personal data these companies hold. By tracking what users search for, buy and watch, they build detailed profiles that are used to target advertising and to keep people online for longer. Most users have little idea how this information is used, and there is always the risk that it is leaked or misused. Moreover, because these platforms decide what news and opinions people see, they have considerable influence over public debate, which is worrying when so few companies are involved.

In conclusion, while the dominance of a few technology giants has given people convenient services, it reduces competition, threatens privacy and concentrates too much influence in too few hands. Overall, therefore, I regard it as a negative development that governments need to regulate more strongly.

Band 8

299 words

Well-developed negative judgement · economic and political arguments fully extended and precisely supported · effective paragraphing and cohesion · wide, sophisticated vocabulary · wide range of structures with no noticeable errors.

Much of what people do online, from searching for information to shopping and keeping in touch with friends, now passes through the systems of a very small number of technology corporations. While this concentration has delivered undeniable conveniences, I believe its long-term consequences make it a predominantly negative development.

The benefits should be acknowledged. The scale of these firms allows them to offer sophisticated services free of charge, funded by advertising, and to invest in infrastructure and research that smaller companies could never afford. Their platforms have also created shared spaces in which people across the globe can communicate with ease.

The first cause for concern, however, is economic. Dominant platforms act simultaneously as marketplaces and competitors within those marketplaces, giving them both the ability and the incentive to favour their own products. Promising start-ups are frequently acquired before they can pose a threat, and the businesses that depend on these platforms for customers have little choice but to accept the terms imposed on them. Over time, reduced competition tends to mean slower innovation and fewer alternatives for consumers.

The second concern relates to personal and political freedom. These companies accumulate unprecedented quantities of data about individuals' habits, relationships and beliefs, and their business models depend on exploiting that information. At the same time, the algorithms that determine which content users encounter shape public opinion in ways that are neither transparent nor accountable to voters. When such influence is held by a handful of private organisations, a single policy change or failure can affect billions of people at once.

In conclusion, the dominance of a few technology giants has made the internet more convenient, but at the cost of competition, privacy and democratic accountability. It is, on balance, a negative development, and one that calls for more robust regulation.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Doctor appointments by video

Topic: Health · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_09

In many countries, patients can now consult a doctor by video call instead of visiting a clinic. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

276 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas with some development · paragraphing logical but linking mechanical · adequate vocabulary · errors including comma splice, agreement, comparative and plural that do not block meaning.

Nowadays, in many countries people can talk to a doctor through a video call on their phone or computer, and they do not need to go to the clinic. I think this is a positive development, but it cannot replace normal visits completely.

The first advantage is that video consultations save time and money. Patients do not need to travel to the clinic or wait for a long time in the waiting room. This is very helpful for people who live in the countryside, where the nearest hospital can be far away. Also, working people do not have to take a whole day off for a short appointment, they can speak with the doctor during their lunch break.

Another advantage is that it reduce the spread of diseases. When sick people sit together in a waiting room, they can easily pass infections to each other. If patients with a cold or a flu stay at home and speak to the doctor online, other patients, specially old people and babies, are more safe.

However, video calls also have some limitation. A doctor cannot examine the patient's body properly through a screen, for example he cannot listen to the heart or check the blood pressure. So there is a risk that some serious illness is missed. In addition, some elderly people do not know how to use video call technology.

In conclusion, I believe that seeing a doctor by video call is a positive development because it is convenient and it can protect people from infections. However, it should be used only for simple problems, and patients should still visit the clinic when they need a physical examination.

Band 7

286 words

Clear position throughout · main ideas well extended with relevant examples · logical organisation and good use of cohesive devices · good collocations (improve access, free up) · mostly error-free with a minor agreement slip.

In a growing number of countries, patients can now speak to a doctor over a video link rather than attending a clinic in person. In my opinion, this is a positive development, as long as it is used alongside traditional appointments rather than instead of them.

The greatest benefit is improved access to healthcare. For people living in remote areas, a visit to a clinic can involve hours of travel, and for elderly or disabled patients even a short journey may be exhausting. Video consultations allow these groups to receive advice quickly and from the comfort of their own home. They are also convenient for working people and parents, who no longer need to take time off work or arrange childcare for a routine appointment.

Remote consultations can also make health systems more efficient. Many appointments, such as renewing a prescription or discussing test results, do not require a physical examination, and handling them by video frees up clinic space for patients who really need to be seen in person. Furthermore, keeping people with infections out of crowded waiting rooms reduce the risk of illnesses spreading to other vulnerable patients.

Nevertheless, there are clear limitations. A doctor on a screen cannot carry out a full physical examination, and subtle signs of serious illness might be missed. In addition, not every patient has a reliable internet connection or the confidence to use the technology, so an over-reliance on video calls could disadvantage the very people who most need care.

In conclusion, video consultations make healthcare more accessible and efficient, and I therefore see them as a positive development. However, they should complement face-to-face appointments, and patients must always have the option of seeing a doctor in person.

Band 8

306 words

Clear, qualified positive judgement · well-developed ideas with precise reasoning · limitations integrated into the argument · skilful cohesion · wide, accurate vocabulary · wide range of complex structures, error-free.

Consulting a doctor by video call, once a rarity, has become an established part of healthcare in many countries. I view this as a positive development, since it widens access to medical advice and relieves pressure on overstretched clinics, although it works best as a complement to, rather than a substitute for, face-to-face care.

The most important advantage is accessibility. For patients in rural areas, a routine appointment may involve a long journey and considerable expense, while for those with limited mobility or caring responsibilities, simply reaching a surgery can be a significant obstacle. A video consultation removes these barriers, and as a result people may be more willing to seek advice at an early stage rather than delaying until a problem becomes serious.

Remote appointments also allow health services to use their resources more intelligently. A substantial share of consultations, such as reviewing medication or discussing results, require conversation rather than physical contact. Handling these remotely shortens waiting times for patients who do need to be examined and reduces the number of potentially infectious people gathered in waiting rooms.

The limitations, however, should not be underestimated. Certain diagnoses depend on touch, sound and close observation, and a clinician relying on a camera may overlook important signs. There is also a danger that the convenience of video calls leads health providers to cut in-person services, disadvantaging older patients and households without dependable internet access. These risks do not negate the value of remote consultation, but they do mean that its use must be guided by clinical judgement rather than cost-saving alone.

In conclusion, video consultations represent a welcome advance: they bring medical advice within reach of people who previously struggled to obtain it and make better use of limited clinical time. Provided that in-person care remains readily available when needed, this development deserves to be embraced.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Becoming parents later

Topic: Family · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_10

In many countries, people are choosing to have children later in life than in the past. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

268 words

Clear positive position · relevant but somewhat predictable ideas · basic linking with some repetition · adequate vocabulary · errors in agreement, tense and articles that do not impede understanding.

In many countries today, people wait until they are older before they have children. For example, many couples now have their first baby in their thirties instead of their twenties. In my opinion, this is generally a positive development.

The main reason is that older parents are usually more ready for the responsibility. When people are in their thirties, they have normally finished their education and have a stable job, so they have more money to take care of a child. They can pay for good food, clothes and education, and they do not need to depend on their own parents. In contrast, young couples often have financial problems and this can cause stress in the family.

Another reason is that older parents are more mature. They have more experience of life, and they already did many things they wanted to do, like travelling or building a career. Because of this, they are more patient and they can give more time and attention to their children. They also know better what kind of values they want to teach them.

However, having children later has some disadvantages. It can be more difficult for women to become pregnant when they are older, and parents may have less energy to play with young children. In addition, children may have less time with their grandparents, because the grandparents are also very old.

In conclusion, even though there are some problems, I believe having children later in life is a positive development. Parents who are older are usually more stable in money and more mature, and this is good for the children's future.

Band 7

294 words

Clear negative position with concession · ideas extended at personal and social level · logical paragraphing with varied linkers · some less common vocabulary (conceive, demographic) · mostly accurate with an occasional agreement slip.

Across much of the world, the average age at which people become parents has been rising steadily. While there are understandable reasons for this, I believe that the trend is, on the whole, a negative development, both for families and for society.

It is true that delaying parenthood has some advantages. People who have children in their thirties or forties are often more financially secure and emotionally mature than younger parents. They may also have had time to complete their education and establish a career, which can reduce stress within the family.

However, there are significant biological disadvantages. It is widely recognised that fertility declines with age, so couples who wait may find it difficult to conceive and may need expensive medical treatment, which does not always succeed. As a result, some people who wanted children end up having fewer than they hoped, or none at all. Moreover, older parents may

have less energy for the physical demands of raising young children.

The trend also has consequences across generations. When each generation has children later, grandparents are older when their grandchildren are born and may be less able to help with childcare or to enjoy an active role in their lives. At the same time, parents may find themselves caring for young children and elderly relatives simultaneously, which put considerable pressure on them. At a national level, later parenthood tends to contribute to lower birth rates, which creates an ageing population and places a heavier burden on the working-age population.

In conclusion, although older parents often enjoy greater stability, the difficulties with fertility, the strain on families and the long-term demographic effects make this trend largely negative. Governments could reduce it by offering better support to younger parents, such as affordable housing and childcare.

Band 8

292 words

Clear positive judgement fully sustained · ideas extended with insight (gender, demographics) · drawbacks evaluated persuasively · sophisticated cohesion · precise, wide-ranging vocabulary · error-free, varied complex structures.

In many countries, the age at which people have their first child has risen considerably over the last few decades, as longer education, demanding careers and high housing costs encourage couples to postpone parenthood. Although this shift carries genuine risks, I believe it is, on balance, a positive development.

The principal benefit is that children are more likely to be born into stable circumstances. Parents who have completed their studies and established themselves professionally are generally better placed to provide secure housing, adequate income and a settled home life. Just as importantly, they tend to become parents through deliberate choice rather than circumstance, which often means they approach the role with greater commitment and emotional maturity.

Later parenthood has also changed opportunities for women in particular. When childbearing no longer coincides with the years in which careers are established, women are far better able to gain qualifications and seniority before taking time away from work. This not only benefits individual families financially but also allows economies to make fuller use of the skills of half their population.

That said, the drawbacks are not trivial. Fertility declines with age, and some couples who delay discover that conceiving is difficult or impossible, often after considerable emotional and financial strain. At a societal level, later parenthood tends to lower birth rates, compounding the challenges of an ageing population. Yet these concerns are arguably better addressed by making earlier parenthood more feasible, through affordable childcare and housing, than by regarding the choice to wait as a problem in itself.

In conclusion, while delaying parenthood can bring biological and demographic costs, the greater stability it affords children and the wider opportunities it creates for parents, especially mothers, outweigh them. I therefore regard this trend as largely positive.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Widening gap between rich and poor

Topic: Society · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_positive-negative_11

In many countries, the gap between the richest and the poorest members of society is growing. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

267 words

Clear negative position · relevant main ideas and a counter-argument, though development is general · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary with repetition (rich, poor) · several agreement and quantifier errors.

In many countries, the difference between rich people and poor people is becoming bigger and bigger. In my opinion, this is a clearly negative development, because it causes many problems for poor people and also for the whole society.

Firstly, when the gap is big, poor people have less opportunities in their life. Rich families can pay for private schools, extra classes and good universities for their children, but poor families cannot afford this. As a result, children from poor family often get lower-paid jobs when they grow up, and they stay poor. This is not fair, because talented children should have the same chance to succeed.

Secondly, a big gap between rich and poor can cause social problems. When people see that some people have very expensive cars and houses but they cannot even pay their rent, they feel angry and unhappy. This can lead to more crime and less trust in the government. In some cities, rich and poor people live in completely different areas and they never meet each other, so the society become divided.

Some people say that inequality is not a problem because it motivate people to work harder and become rich. It is true that people need some rewards for hard work, but when the gap is too big, poor people feel that working hard is useless because they can never catch up.

In conclusion, I strongly believe that the growing gap between the richest and poorest people is a negative development. Governments should try to reduce it, for example by giving free education and making rich people pay more tax.

Band 7

296 words

Clear, consistent negative position · ideas extended and supported, counter-argument rebutted · well-organised paragraphs with a range of linkers · good vocabulary (social mobility, lobbying) · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

In many nations, the wealth and income of the richest citizens have grown far faster than those of the poorest, causing the gap between them to widen. I believe this is a highly negative development, as it limits opportunity and threatens social stability.

The first problem is that growing inequality reduces social mobility. Wealthy families can invest heavily in their children's education, health and connections, while low-income families often struggle to meet basic needs. As a result, a child's future increasingly depends on the family they are born into rather than on their talent or effort. This is not only unfair to individuals but also wasteful for society, since the abilities of many capable young people are never fully developed.

Secondly, a large gap between rich and poor can damage the cohesion of a society. When people feel that the economic system benefits only a small elite, they tend to lose trust in institutions and politicians. This frustration can fuel social unrest and support for extreme political movements. In addition, the wealthy are able to exert disproportionate influence over political decisions, for example through lobbying, which may lead to policies that further protect their interests.

Some argue that inequality is a natural result of a free economy and that it encourages people to work hard and take risks. There is some truth in this, as a certain degree of difference in income rewards effort and skill. However, when the gap becomes extreme, it no longer acts as a motivation, because the poorest see no realistic way of improving their situation.

In conclusion, although some inequality is inevitable, a continually growing gap between the richest and the poorest is harmful. It restricts opportunities, weakens trust and concentrates power, and governments should therefore take steps to reduce it.

Band 8

306 words

Forceful, fully developed negative judgement · counter-argument evaluated with precision · logical, well-signposted progression · wide, sophisticated vocabulary (self-perpetuating, squanders) · complex structures used flexibly and accurately.

In a large number of countries, the share of national wealth held by the most affluent has grown while the incomes of those at the bottom have stagnated. Some economists regard this as a tolerable by-product of growth, but I consider the widening gap to be an unmistakably negative development.

The most fundamental objection concerns opportunity. When wealth is heavily concentrated, advantage becomes self-perpetuating: affluent families can secure better schooling, healthcare and professional networks for their children, while those on low incomes struggle to meet everyday costs. Over successive generations, life chances come to depend increasingly on birth rather than merit, and a society squanders the potential of countless able people who never have the means to develop it.

A second objection is political. Extreme economic disparities tend to translate into disparities of influence, since those with vast resources can fund campaigns, shape public debate and lobby for favourable treatment. The result is a system that responds more readily to the concerns of the few than to those of the many. Unsurprisingly, citizens who perceive the system as rigged become disillusioned with mainstream institutions, and this erosion of trust can open the door to polarisation and instability.

Defenders of inequality argue that the prospect of great rewards drives enterprise and innovation. This argument has some force when applied to moderate differences in income, which do reflect variations in skill and effort. It becomes far less convincing, however, when the gap grows so wide that those at the bottom have no realistic prospect of advancement, for at that point inequality ceases to motivate and instead breeds resignation.

In conclusion, while a degree of inequality is an inevitable feature of any market economy, its continued growth undermines equal opportunity, distorts democratic politics and weakens social cohesion. It is therefore a development that governments should actively work to reverse.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Sharing private lives online

Topic: Social media · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_12

Many people now share details of their private lives publicly on social media. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

293 words

Clear negative position · relevant ideas with simple examples but limited depth · list-like linking (first, second, Finally) · adequate vocabulary · errors with uncountable nouns, agreement and articles.

These days, a lot of people post many details about their private life on social media, for example photos of their family, where they are on holiday and what they eat every day. In my opinion, this is a negative development, because it has more risks than benefits.

Of course, there are some good points. People can keep in touch with friends and relatives who live far away, and they can share happy moments like a wedding or the birth of a baby. Some people also say that sharing their problems online help them to get support from others.

However, the first big problem is privacy and safety. When people post their address, their school or the place where they are at the moment, criminals can use this informations. For example, if a family post photos from the beach, a thief can know that their house is empty. Also, pictures of children can be seen by strangers, which is dangerous.

The second problem is that sharing everything online can make people unhappy. Many users only post the best parts of their life, so other people compare themselves and feel that their own life is boring or not successful. Some people also become addicted to getting likes and comments, and they spend more time on their phone than with the real people around them. Another risk is that the things people post can stay on internet forever. A young person may share something embarrassing today, and many years later an employer can find it and decide not to give them a job.

In conclusion, although social media helps people to stay connected, I believe sharing private life publicly is negative because it is risky for safety and it can damage people's happiness and future.

Band 7

272 words

Clear positive position throughout · ideas extended with relevant examples · risks acknowledged and answered · logical progression and varied linkers · good vocabulary (stigma, taboo, self-esteem) · largely error-free.

It has become normal for people to post photographs of their homes, children, holidays and even personal struggles on social media for anyone to see. Although this trend certainly carries risks, I believe that overall it is a positive development.

The most obvious benefit is that it helps people maintain relationships. Families are now often spread across different cities or countries, and regular updates allow relatives to feel involved in each other's lives in a way that occasional phone calls cannot. A grandparent abroad, for instance, can watch a grandchild grow up through shared photos and videos.

More significantly, openness about private life can create support and reduce stigma. When people share their experiences of illness, unemployment or the challenges of parenting, others in similar situations realise they are not alone. Online communities built around such

experiences offer practical advice and emotional encouragement, and public conversations about topics that were once considered taboo, such as mental health, have helped change attitudes in society.

That said, there are genuine dangers. Personal information can be misused by criminals, and posts made carelessly may harm a person's reputation or career years later. There is also a concern that constantly comparing oneself with the carefully edited lives of others can damage self-esteem. However, these problems largely depend on how people use social media, and they can be reduced if users learn to adjust their privacy settings and think carefully before posting.

In conclusion, while sharing personal details publicly requires caution, the ability to stay connected with loved ones and to find support from people with similar experiences makes this a mainly positive development in my view.

Band 8

298 words

Clear negative judgement with fair concession · ideas extended with insightful, specific consequences · paragraphing and cohesion managed skilfully · wide, precise vocabulary (curated, external validation) · varied, error-free structures.

Social media has blurred the boundary between public and private life. Details that people once shared only with close friends, such as family celebrations, health scares and relationship breakdowns, are now routinely broadcast to hundreds or even thousands of followers. While this openness has some genuine merits, I believe that, taken as a whole, it is a negative development.

It would be unfair to dismiss the practice entirely. Sharing personal news allows people to sustain relationships across great distances, and candid accounts of difficult experiences can foster solidarity and help to dismantle stigma around issues that were long hidden. For some, a supportive online audience provides comfort that is not available in their immediate surroundings.

The difficulty is that most users greatly underestimate the permanence and reach of what they post. Content shared casually can be copied, archived and rediscovered long after it has lost its original context, sometimes resurfacing when its author applies for a job. Information that seems harmless in isolation, such as a child's school uniform or a holiday departure date, can, when pieced together, expose people to fraud, stalking or burglary. Children are particularly vulnerable, since parents frequently publish details of their lives before they are old enough to consent.

There is also a subtler psychological cost. When private experiences are presented to an audience, they tend to be curated for approval, and life becomes something to be performed rather than simply lived. Constant exposure to others' highlights encourages unfavourable comparison, while the pursuit of likes can make self-worth dependent on external validation.

In conclusion, although sharing personal lives online can strengthen connections and reduce isolation, the long-term risks to privacy, safety and wellbeing are, in my view, greater. It is therefore a trend that calls for far more caution than it currently receives.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Teaching university courses in English

Topic: Culture / Education · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_13

In many non-English-speaking countries, universities are increasingly teaching their courses in English. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

268 words

Clear positive position · relevant main ideas with brief examples · paragraphing clear though linking mechanical · adequate vocabulary · errors in agreement and articles that do not block meaning.

In many countries where English is not the first language, more and more universities teach their courses in English. I believe this is a positive development, although it can be difficult for some students.

The first advantage is that English is the international language of science and business. Most important research papers, books and websites are written in English, so students who study in English can read them easily. Also, when they graduate, they can work for international companies or find a job in other countries, because their English level is high. This gives them a big advantage in the job market.

Another advantage is that universities can attract students and teachers from other countries. For example, a university in Asia which teaches in English can accept students from Europe, Africa and South America. This makes the university more international, and local students can learn about different cultures and make friends from around the world. The university also earns more money from international students.

However, there are some problems. Some students have a low level of English, so they cannot understand the lectures well, and their marks may be worse. In addition, if all courses are in English, the local language may become less important, especially in science subjects, and in the future there may be no modern textbooks in the local language at all.

In conclusion, I think teaching university courses in English is mostly a positive development because it helps students to find better jobs and makes universities more international. But universities should give extra English classes to students who need it, so nobody is left behind.

Band 7

277 words

Clear position maintained · main ideas extended with relevant support · drawbacks acknowledged with solutions · clear paragraph topics and varied cohesion · good academic vocabulary · mostly accurate with a minor slip.

Universities in many non-English-speaking countries are increasingly offering degree programmes taught entirely in English. Although this policy raises concerns about the quality of learning and the status of national languages, I consider it a positive development overall.

The main argument in its favour is that it prepares graduates for an international labour market. English is the dominant language of academic research, technology and global business, so students who have studied their subject in English are able to read the latest publications, attend international conferences and work confidently with colleagues from other countries. For a young engineer or economist, this can open up career opportunities that would otherwise be unavailable.

Teaching in English also allows universities to become more international. Courses in the local language are only accessible to local students, whereas English-medium programmes can attract applicants and academic staff from around the world. This diversity enriches the learning environment, as students are exposed to a wider range of perspectives, and it also brings valuable income from tuition fees.

Nevertheless, the trend is not without disadvantages. Students whose English is weak may understand only part of their lectures, and some lecturers may struggle to explain complex ideas in a second language, which could lower the standard of teaching. There is also a risk that the national language gradually loses its role in academic life, particularly in scientific fields. These problems, however, can be reduced by providing language support and by continuing to offer some courses in the local language.

In conclusion, while English-medium teaching presents certain challenges, it gives students valuable skills and helps universities compete globally. For these reasons, I regard it as a largely positive development.

Band 8

301 words

Clear, well-argued negative judgement · opposing rationale fairly presented · ideas developed with insight into learning and language policy · skilful cohesion · precise academic vocabulary · error-free, varied structures.

In a growing number of countries where English is not the native language, universities are replacing instruction in the national language with English, particularly at postgraduate level and in scientific and business disciplines. Although the motives behind this shift are understandable, I believe that, as it is currently being pursued, it is more negative than positive.

The rationale is clear enough. English has become the principal language of international scholarship and commerce, and graduates who can operate in it enjoy a significant advantage. English-medium programmes also enable universities to recruit international students and staff, raising their global profile and generating income from fees.

The first problem, however, is educational. Learning a demanding subject is challenging enough in one's first language; doing so through a language in which one is less than fluent inevitably consumes cognitive effort that would otherwise go into understanding the material. Students may memorise terminology without grasping underlying concepts, while lecturers who are not fully confident in English may simplify their explanations or avoid spontaneous discussion. The result can be a degree that sounds international but conveys less knowledge.

A second concern is the long-term impact on national languages. When advanced study and research are conducted exclusively in English, the local language ceases to develop the vocabulary needed for specialised fields. Over time, it risks being confined to everyday use, and knowledge becomes less accessible to citizens who do not speak English well. This also tends to favour students from wealthier backgrounds, who are more likely to have received strong English tuition at school.

In conclusion, while proficiency in English is undeniably valuable, making it the sole medium of university teaching can undermine both learning and linguistic heritage. Strengthening English as a subject, while teaching most courses in the national language, would achieve the benefits without these costs.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Volunteering on holiday abroad

Topic: Tourism · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_14

More and more people are choosing to spend their holidays doing voluntary work on projects in other countries. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

264 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas with a simple example · mechanical linking (Firstly, Secondly, However) · adequate vocabulary · errors in articles, quantifiers and agreement that do not impede meaning.

Nowadays, many people decide to use their holidays for doing voluntary work in other countries, for example building schools, teaching children or protecting animals. In my opinion, this is a positive development for both the volunteers and the local communities.

Firstly, voluntary work can help poor communities. In many developing countries, there are not enough teachers, doctors or money for projects like building a clean water system. When volunteers come, they can give their time and skills for free. For instance, a group of volunteers can build a small school in a village in only few weeks, and many children can study there for years.

Secondly, volunteers themselves get a lot of benefits. They can learn about a new culture, a different way of life and maybe some words of the local language. This is much more interesting than lying on a beach in a hotel. Also, they learn to be grateful for what they have at home, and they can develop new skills such as teamwork and problem solving, which is useful for their future career.

However, some people say that volunteering holidays are not always helpful. Some volunteers have no experience, so the work they do is not very good quality. In addition, some companies charge volunteers a lot of money but only small part of it goes to the project.

In conclusion, I believe that doing voluntary work on holiday is mainly a positive development, because it helps communities in need and give volunteers an unforgettable experience. However, people should choose a good organisation and a project that match their skills.

Band 7

291 words

Clear positive position throughout · main ideas extended with specific examples · criticisms addressed logically · effective paragraphing and linking · good range of vocabulary · frequent error-free sentences.

Rather than spending their holidays relaxing on a beach, a growing number of people are choosing to volunteer on projects abroad, such as building homes, teaching English or supporting wildlife conservation. Despite some criticisms of this kind of travel, I believe it is a positive trend.

For communities that receive volunteers, the most direct benefit is practical help. Many projects in developing regions depend on outside labour and funding to succeed, and volunteers often contribute both. A conservation programme, for example, may rely on visitors to monitor endangered species, while the fees they pay help to cover the salaries of local staff. In this way, volunteering can support work that would not otherwise be possible.

The experience is also valuable for the volunteers themselves. Living and working alongside local people gives them a far deeper understanding of another culture than ordinary tourism

provides. Many return home with a greater awareness of global issues such as poverty and environmental damage, and some go on to support charities or choose careers in development. The skills they gain, including adaptability and teamwork, are also highly valued by employers.

It is true that the industry has been criticised. Some projects accept volunteers with no relevant skills, for instance allowing untrained visitors to teach in schools for only a week or two, which can do more harm than good. There are also commercial agencies that charge high fees while giving little to the communities. However, these problems show the need for careful choice of project rather than a reason to reject volunteering altogether.

In conclusion, when volunteers choose responsible organisations and suitable projects, their work benefits both local communities and themselves. For this reason, I consider the rise of volunteer holidays to be a positive development.

Band 8

309 words

Clear, critical judgement developed with nuance · specific, well-chosen examples · concession integrated naturally · sophisticated cohesion and paragraphing · wide, precise vocabulary · varied structures used with full accuracy.

Volunteer tourism, in which travellers spend their holidays working on community or conservation projects overseas, has grown into a substantial industry. The idea is admirable in principle, yet I would argue that, in the form it most commonly takes, it is a more negative development than its popularity suggests.

Its appeal is easy to understand. Volunteers hope to make a tangible difference, and some projects, particularly those involving skilled professionals such as doctors or engineers, undoubtedly do. Participants also gain an insight into unfamiliar cultures and global inequalities that conventional tourism rarely provides, which may shape their attitudes and choices for years afterwards.

The problem is that most short-term volunteers lack the skills the work requires. A teenager who spends two weeks teaching in a village school, with no training and no knowledge of the local language, is unlikely to contribute much to children's learning, and a steady stream of such visitors can disrupt continuity in the classroom. Similarly, construction projects carried out by inexperienced tourists may be of poor quality and may take paid work away from local builders who could have done the job better and more cheaply.

There are also ethical concerns. Because volunteering has become a profitable product, some agencies design projects around the wishes of paying customers rather than the needs of communities. In the worst cases, children in orphanages form attachments to a succession of visitors who then disappear, which can be emotionally harmful. Such arrangements risk treating poorer communities as a backdrop for the personal growth of wealthier travellers.

In conclusion, although volunteer holidays can broaden travellers' horizons and some skilled contributions are genuinely valuable, many schemes deliver little lasting benefit and occasionally cause harm. For this reason, I regard the trend as largely negative, and would suggest that donating to established local organisations is often a more effective way to help.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Remote workers leaving cities

Topic: Population · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_15

Because they can now work remotely, many people are moving away from large cities to live in smaller towns and the countryside. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

277 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas for individuals and communities with limited development · simple linking · adequate vocabulary · several agreement errors and a quantifier error that do not affect clarity.

Because of the internet, many people can now work from home, and some of them decide to leave big cities and move to small towns or the countryside. I think this is a positive development for the people and also for the country.

The main benefit is for the people who move. Life in a big city is very expensive and stressful. Rent is high, the traffic is terrible and there is a lot of noise and pollution. In a small town, people can rent or buy a bigger house with a garden for less money, and they can enjoy fresh air and nature. This make their life healthier and more relaxing, especially for families with children.

Another benefit is for the small towns. In many countries, young people have left the countryside to find jobs in the city, so villages become empty and shops and schools close. When remote workers move there, they spend their money in local shops and cafes, and the town become more alive again. Also, big cities become less crowded, which help to reduce traffic and pollution.

However, this change can cause some problems. When many people from the city move to a village, the house prices goes up, and local young people cannot afford to buy a home. Also, the internet in the countryside is sometimes slow, and there are less hospitals and other services.

In conclusion, I believe that people moving from cities to the countryside because of remote work is a positive development. It gives people a better quality of life and brings new life to small towns. However, the government should improve internet and services in rural area.

Band 7

298 words

Clear position throughout · benefits for individuals and communities well extended · problems acknowledged and answered · clear central topics and good cohesion · good collocations (spending power, population pressure) · largely error-free.

The rise of remote working has allowed many employees to leave expensive cities and settle in smaller towns and rural areas. In my view, this movement is a positive development, both for the individuals concerned and for the places they move to.

For the people who relocate, the improvement in quality of life can be considerable. City living often involves high housing costs, long commutes and limited green space. By moving to a smaller community, remote workers can usually afford more spacious homes, spend the time they once lost travelling with their families, and enjoy a calmer environment. Many report that this balance between work and personal life makes them healthier and more productive.

The trend can also help to revive rural areas. For decades, young people have moved away from the countryside in search of employment, leaving behind ageing populations and declining

services. New residents who keep their city salaries bring spending power to local businesses, and their children help to keep village schools open. At the same time, a reduction in population pressure can ease congestion and housing shortages in overcrowded cities.

Admittedly, this migration creates some tensions. In popular areas, the arrival of wealthier newcomers has pushed up property prices, making it harder for local people to stay in the communities where they grew up. Rural infrastructure, such as broadband and public transport, may also struggle to cope with a growing population. However, these are problems that careful planning, such as building affordable homes for local residents and investing in digital connections, can address.

In conclusion, although the movement of remote workers to smaller towns needs to be managed carefully, it offers a better quality of life for many people and new energy for struggling rural communities. Overall, I see it as a positive trend.

Band 8

319 words

Clear, qualified positive judgement · ideas fully extended at individual and national level · drawback weighed persuasively · seamless cohesion · wide, natural vocabulary (rebalance, circulates) · error-free, wide range of structures.

Freed from the obligation to commute daily to an office, a significant number of professionals have left large cities for market towns, coastal villages and the countryside. Although this migration has created real difficulties in some places, I believe that its overall effect is positive.

The benefits for those who move are the most immediate. Residents of major cities frequently pay a large share of their income for cramped accommodation and spend hours each week travelling to work. Relocating allows them to exchange these costs for more space, cleaner air and closer contact with nature, while continuing to earn a city salary. For families in particular, this can mean more time together and a less pressured daily routine.

More significantly, the trend has the potential to reverse a long-standing imbalance between urban and rural areas. For generations, economic opportunity has been concentrated in a few large cities, drawing young people away from smaller communities and leaving them with shrinking populations and disappearing services. Remote workers bring income that circulates through local shops, cafes and tradespeople, and their presence can justify investment in schools, transport and broadband. Meanwhile, cities themselves may benefit from slightly reduced pressure on housing and transport.

The principal drawback is the effect on housing in desirable rural areas. When buyers with urban salaries compete for a limited supply of homes, prices can rise beyond the reach of local families, and young people may be forced to leave the very places that newcomers are moving into. This is a serious concern, but it reflects a failure of housing policy rather than a flaw in the trend itself, and it can be mitigated by building more homes and prioritising local buyers.

In conclusion, provided that its impact on local housing is managed responsibly, the movement of remote workers away from large cities improves individual wellbeing and helps to rebalance regional economies. I therefore consider it a positive development.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Shopping online instead of in-store

Topic: Consumerism · Difficulty: Moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_16

Many people now buy most of the things they need online rather than in shops. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

267 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas on convenience and price with some support · linking adequate but formulaic · adequate vocabulary · several agreement and article errors that do not reduce clarity.

Today, many people prefer to buy almost everything online, such as clothes, electronic devices and even food, instead of going to the shops. In my opinion, this is a positive development, although it has some bad effects too.

The biggest advantage of online shopping is convenience. People can order things at any time of the day from their sofa, and the products are delivered to their door, sometimes on the next day. This is very useful for busy people, parents with small children and people who cannot walk easily. They do not need to drive to the city centre, look for a parking place and carry heavy bags.

Another advantage is that online shopping is often cheaper. Online stores do not need to pay rent for a big shop, so they can sell products for lower price. Customers can also compare the prices on different websites in a few minutes and choose the cheapest one. In addition, they can read reviews from other buyers, which help them to avoid buying bad products.

However, online shopping also causes some problems. Many small shops in town centres has closed because they cannot compete with big online companies, and some shop workers lost their jobs. Also, all the packaging and delivery vans create more rubbish and pollution. Sometimes the product looks different from the picture, and returning it take a lot of time.

In conclusion, I believe that buying things online is mainly a positive development, because it saves people time and money. However, people should also sometimes buy from local shops, so that town centres do not become empty.

Band 7

293 words

Clear negative position after conceding benefits · ideas extended on community, environment and labour · logical progression · good vocabulary (high streets, insecure contracts) · mostly error-free with a minor agreement slip.

Online shopping has grown so rapidly that many people now purchase the majority of their goods, from groceries to furniture, over the internet. Although this has made shopping more convenient, I believe that overall it is a negative development.

There is no doubt that buying online has clear advantages for consumers. It saves time, allows people to compare prices easily and gives access to a far wider range of products than any local shop could offer. For people with limited mobility or those living far from shopping centres, home delivery can be particularly valuable.

However, the decline of physical shops has serious consequences for local communities. As more spending moves online, independent retailers and even large chains are forced to close, leaving empty units in high streets and town centres. These places used to be not only somewhere to buy things but also social spaces where people met and interacted. When they

decline, towns lose their character and jobs disappear, often in areas that already have limited employment opportunities.

In addition, the environmental cost of online shopping is often underestimated. Individual deliveries mean that large numbers of vans travel to people's homes every day, and each order usually comes with plastic and cardboard packaging. The ease of returning products also encourages people to order several items and send most of them back, which creates even more transport and waste. Furthermore, many warehouse and delivery workers face intense pressure and insecure contracts, which raise questions about the true cost of cheap and fast delivery.

In conclusion, while online shopping offers undeniable convenience for individuals, its effects on town centres, the environment and working conditions are harmful. For these reasons, I consider the shift towards buying most goods online to be a largely negative trend.

Band 8

318 words

Clear positive judgement fully supported · original ideas (lower barriers to business) well extended · drawbacks weighed and qualified · skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (hollowed out, accrue) · error-free complex structures.

For a large proportion of consumers, the weekly trip to the shops has been replaced by a few minutes on a smartphone, with purchases arriving at the door within a day or two. This shift has undoubtedly come at a cost to traditional retail, but I believe that, on balance, it is a positive development.

The most obvious gains accrue to consumers. Online retail offers a range of choice that no single shop could match, together with the ability to compare prices and read other customers' experiences before buying. The resulting transparency places downward pressure on prices, which is of real value to households on tight budgets. Home delivery, moreover, has been transformative for people who find conventional shopping difficult, including elderly and disabled people and those in rural areas without nearby stores.

The internet has also lowered the barriers to starting a business. Whereas opening a shop requires premises, stock and a location with sufficient passing trade, a craftsperson or small producer can now reach customers across the country, or even the world, through a website or online marketplace. In this sense, online shopping has broadened, rather than merely concentrated, commercial opportunity.

The losses, however, are real. High streets in many towns have been hollowed out as shops close, taking with them jobs and a sense of place, and the proliferation of delivery vans and packaging has a considerable environmental impact. Yet town centres were already under pressure before online retail became dominant, and those that have reinvented themselves around leisure, services and community events show that decline is not inevitable.

Environmental harm, likewise, can be reduced through consolidated deliveries and recyclable packaging.

In conclusion, although the move to online shopping has contributed to the decline of traditional high streets, it has given consumers greater choice, lower prices and easier access, and has opened markets to small producers. Overall, therefore, I regard it as a positive change.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Private funding for public facilities

Topic: Public services · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_17

In some countries, public facilities such as museums, libraries and parks increasingly depend on money from private companies. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

267 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas with simple examples but limited analysis · basic, repetitive linking · adequate vocabulary with some informal choices (win-win) · agreement errors that do not impede meaning.

In some countries, public places like museums, libraries and parks now get a lot of their money from private companies. I think this is a positive development, because without this money many of these places could not survive.

The main reason is that governments often do not have enough money. They have to spend their budget on important things like hospitals, schools and the police, so culture and parks are not a priority. When a company give money, a museum can stay open, buy new exhibitions and keep its entrance free. A library can buy more books and computers, and a park can have new playgrounds and better cleaning.

Another reason is that both sides get benefits. The companies get good advertising, because people see their name and logo in the museum or the park, and they think the company is responsible and care about society. At the same time, the public can enjoy better facilities without paying more tax. So it is a win-win situation.

However, there are some risks. A company may want to control what a museum shows, or it may use the museum to hide bad things it has done, for example an oil company that pollute the environment. Also, if the company decides to stop giving money, the facility can have serious financial problems.

In conclusion, I believe it is a positive development that public facilities get money from private companies, because it helps them to provide better services for people. However, the government should make rules so that companies cannot control the content, and it should still give some money itself.

Band 7

290 words

Clear negative position throughout · concession then two well-extended arguments · clear central topic per paragraph · good vocabulary (eye-catching, economic downturn) · frequent error-free sentences with one agreement slip.

In many countries, museums, libraries and public parks are relying more and more on sponsorship and donations from private businesses to cover their costs. Although this extra funding brings short-term benefits, I believe that growing dependence on it is a negative development.

It is easy to see why such partnerships are attractive. Public budgets are under pressure, and cultural institutions and green spaces are often among the first areas to face cuts. Corporate money can pay for new exhibitions, longer opening hours or improved facilities, and companies gain a positive public image in return.

However, the first problem is that sponsorship can affect what these institutions do. A museum that depends on a particular company may be reluctant to host an exhibition that criticises that company's industry. Similarly, sponsors naturally prefer popular, eye-catching projects that attract publicity, so less glamorous work, such as preserving archives or running services in poorer neighbourhoods, may be neglected. Over time, decisions that should be made in the public interest become shaped by commercial priorities.

A second concern is instability. Private funding depends on a company's profits and marketing strategy, both of which can change quickly. If a sponsor withdraws during an economic downturn, a library or park that has come to rely on its money may be forced to reduce services suddenly. Moreover, heavy reliance on corporate support can give governments an excuse to reduce their own responsibility for funding facilities that all citizens is entitled to use.

In conclusion, while private contributions can be a useful addition to public funding, facilities that depend on them risk losing their independence and financial security. For these reasons, I regard this trend as mainly negative, and I believe governments should remain the main source of funding.

Band 8

315 words

Clear, carefully qualified negative judgement · sophisticated arguments on independence and fragility fully developed · seamless cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (implicates, fragility) · wide range of accurate complex structures.

Faced with tight public budgets, many museums, libraries and parks have turned to corporate sponsors to fund everything from new galleries to playground equipment. Private support can be a welcome supplement, but when these institutions come to depend on it, I believe the development becomes a largely negative one.

The attraction of corporate money is understandable. Governments must balance cultural spending against the more pressing demands of healthcare, education and security, and in lean years it is often facilities such as libraries that suffer most. Sponsorship can keep doors open and admission free, and companies are often happy to fund projects that associate their brand with public benefit.

The difficulty is that funding is rarely neutral. Institutions that depend on a particular sponsor face a quiet but persistent pressure to avoid offending it, whether by declining an exhibition critical of its industry or by giving its logo prominence it has not earned. In some cases, sponsorship has been used by companies with poor environmental or ethical records to acquire respectability, a practice that implicates the institution in their public relations. Even without any direct interference, sponsors' preference for high-profile, marketable projects can divert resources from essential but unglamorous work, such as conservation or outreach to disadvantaged communities.

Dependence also creates fragility. Corporate budgets fluctuate with profits and marketing fashions, and a facility that has built its operations around a single donor can be left in crisis when that support is withdrawn. Perhaps most significantly, the availability of private money allows governments to retreat from funding institutions that exist precisely because they serve everyone, not just those who are commercially valuable.

In conclusion, private contributions have a legitimate role as an addition to public funding, but reliance on them compromises the independence and stability of institutions that belong to the public. The growing dependence described is therefore a trend that should be resisted rather than encouraged.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Reporting crimes through apps

Topic: Crime · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_18

In some countries, members of the public can now use mobile phone apps to report crimes and send video evidence directly to the police. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

280 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas with some support but limited depth · mechanical linking (The first, The second, On the other hand) · adequate vocabulary · tense and agreement errors that do not block meaning.

In some countries, people can now use an app on their mobile phone to report a crime and send videos to the police. In my opinion, this is a positive development, although it must be used carefully.

The first advantage is that reporting a crime become much easier and faster. In the past, people had to call the police or go to the police station, and many people did not want to do this because it take a lot of time. With an app, a person who sees a car accident or a theft in the street can send a report in only one minute. As a result, more crimes are reported and police can react more quickly.

The second advantage is that video evidence is very useful. Often, it is difficult for the police to know exactly what happened, because witnesses remember different things. A video clearly shows the person who commit the crime, his face and the time and place. This can help the police to catch criminals and to prove in court that they are guilty.

On the other hand, there are some problems. Some people may send false reports about neighbours they do not like, or they may film innocent people and put them in trouble. Also, if people try to film a dangerous situation, they can put themselves in danger. Moreover, the police may receive too many small reports and not have time for serious crimes.

In conclusion, I think crime reporting apps are a positive development because they make reporting easier and give the police good evidence. However, the police should check all reports carefully and tell people not to take risks for filming.

Band 7

288 words

Clear position maintained · main ideas extended with specific examples · risks acknowledged and answered · well-organised with varied cohesion · good vocabulary (intimidating, malicious) · mostly error-free, one agreement slip.

Several countries have introduced mobile phone apps that allow citizens to report crimes and upload photographs or video evidence directly to the police. I believe this is a positive development, as it makes reporting easier and can improve the effectiveness of policing.

The main benefit is that it removes many of the barriers that discourage people from reporting crimes. Calling the police or visiting a station can be time-consuming and intimidating, so many minor offences, such as vandalism or dangerous driving, are simply never reported. An app allows a witness to submit a report within minutes, and even anonymously in some cases. This gives the police a more accurate picture of where and when crimes happen, which can help them decide where to send patrols.

Video evidence can also strengthen investigations. Eyewitness memories are often incomplete, particularly after a stressful event, whereas a recording captures details such as appearances, vehicle registration numbers and the order of events. This kind of evidence can help identify suspects more quickly and may also protect innocent people who have been wrongly accused.

Nevertheless, there are some risks to consider. Some users might submit false or malicious reports, and there are concerns about privacy when members of the public film others without permission. There is also a danger that people put themselves at risk by stopping to record a violent incident instead of moving to safety. However, these problems can be managed if the police verify all reports carefully and the app clearly advise users never to endanger themselves.

In conclusion, although crime-reporting apps must be carefully managed, they encourage more people to report offences and provide valuable evidence. For these reasons, I consider them a positive development in the fight against crime.

Band 8

300 words

Clear, qualified positive judgement · ideas developed with precise reasoning and examples · risks evaluated with realistic safeguards · skilful cohesion · wide, precise vocabulary (exonerate, fly-tipping) · error-free, varied structures.

Police forces in a number of countries now allow members of the public to report offences through smartphone apps, attaching photographs or video footage as evidence. While such tools raise legitimate concerns about privacy and misuse, I consider them, on the whole, a positive development.

Their chief merit is that they make reporting crime far more accessible. Many offences go unreported not because witnesses are indifferent but because the process seems disproportionately burdensome: waiting on the phone, visiting a station or giving a lengthy statement for an incident that may appear minor. By reducing reporting to a few taps, apps capture offences that would otherwise disappear from official records, such as antisocial behaviour, fly-tipping or reckless driving. Better data, in turn, allows police to identify patterns and deploy their limited resources more intelligently.

Footage recorded at the scene can also be valuable evidence. Human memory is notoriously unreliable, especially under stress, while a timestamped video preserves details that witnesses may later forget or misremember. Such material can accelerate investigations and, just as importantly, can exonerate people who have been wrongly suspected.

The risks, however, deserve careful attention. An easy reporting channel may be exploited to harass neighbours or settle personal disputes, and the circulation of footage of identifiable individuals raises obvious privacy concerns. There is also a danger that the desire to record encourages bystanders to film incidents instead of seeking safety or offering help. These problems are serious but manageable: reports can be screened by trained staff, footage can be restricted to police use, and users can be clearly instructed to prioritise their own safety.

In conclusion, crime-reporting apps enable the public to contribute more effectively to their own security and supply the police with better intelligence. Provided that robust safeguards accompany them, they represent a welcome step forward.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes:

Starting school at younger ages

Topic: Children · Difficulty: Upper-moderate · id wb2_positive-negative_19

In many countries, children are starting formal education at an increasingly young age. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

269 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas though some are general · paragraphing present but not always logical (brief separate concession) · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · errors in agreement and articles.

In many countries today, children begin formal education at a younger age than before, sometimes when they are only three or four years old. I believe this is mostly a positive development for children and also for their parents.

Firstly, starting school early helps children to learn basic skills. At a young age, children's brains develop very quickly, so they can learn letters, numbers and even a foreign language more easily than older children. If they start school early, they will be more prepared when they go to primary school, and they can do better in their studies later.

Secondly, school gives young children the chance to make friends and learn how to behave with other people. At home, a child may only play with their parents or one brother or sister. At school, they must share toys, wait their turn and follow the rules of teacher. These social skills are very important for their future life. Also, early education is helpful for parents. Today, in many families both mother and father work full-time, so they need a safe place for their children during the day. When children go to school, parents can work without worry, and the family have more income.

However, some people think that young children need more time to play and they may feel stress if they study too much. This is true, so schools for small children should focus on games and activities, not on exams.

In conclusion, I think that children starting formal education earlier is a positive development, because it helps their learning and social skills, and it also support working parents.

Band 7

302 words

Clear negative position throughout · opposing view summarised then main ideas well extended · logical organisation · good vocabulary (head start, developmentally ready) · largely error-free with a minor slip.

In many parts of the world, children are now expected to begin formal schooling, with structured lessons in reading, writing and mathematics, at an increasingly early age. Although this is usually intended to give children a head start, I believe it is largely a negative development.

Supporters of early education argue that young children learn quickly and that starting sooner will lead to higher achievement later. It also meets the needs of working parents, who require reliable childcare, and can help children from disadvantaged backgrounds who may receive little educational support at home.

However, many young children are simply not ready for formal learning. At the age of three or four, most children learn best through play, exploration and conversation rather than by sitting at desks completing worksheets. When they are pushed to read and write before they are

developmentally ready, some become frustrated and may begin to see learning as something difficult and unpleasant. This negative attitude can last for years and affect their motivation throughout school.

In addition, an early focus on academic skills can leave less time for developing other important abilities. Through unstructured play, children learn to solve problems, cooperate with others, manage their emotions and use their imagination. These qualities are essential for success in later life, yet they cannot be easily measured in tests, so they are often given lower priority in formal classrooms. Furthermore, children who spend long days in a structured environment from such a young age may experience stress and tiredness, which affect their wellbeing.

In conclusion, while early education can provide childcare and support for some families, introducing formal lessons too early may harm children's attitude to learning and limit their broader development. I therefore regard this trend as mainly negative, and I believe the early years should focus on play-based learning.

Band 8

307 words

Clear negative judgement built on a precise distinction · ideas fully extended and logically sequenced · concession handled deftly · wide, accurate vocabulary (opportunity cost, self-regulation) · complex structures with full control.

Across many countries, the age at which children first enter a classroom and begin structured academic instruction has steadily fallen. This is generally justified as an investment in children's future achievement, but I would argue that, in most cases, it is a negative development.

The rationale for early schooling is not without merit. High-quality early education can narrow the gap between children from affluent and disadvantaged homes, since the latter may have fewer books and less adult conversation at home. For families in which both parents work, early school entry also provides dependable, affordable care.

Yet there is a crucial distinction between early education and early formal education. What benefits young children most is a rich environment of play, talk and exploration, in which language, curiosity and social skills develop naturally. Formal instruction, by contrast, demands sustained attention, fine motor control and the ability to sit still, capacities that many four-year-olds have not yet acquired. Children pushed into reading and arithmetic before they are ready may struggle, and early experiences of failure can shape a lasting belief that they are not good at learning.

There is also a question of opportunity cost. Every hour spent on phonics drills or worksheets is an hour not spent building with blocks, negotiating games with peers or inventing stories, activities through which children develop the creativity, resilience and self-regulation that underpin later success. Several countries with consistently strong educational outcomes do not begin formal schooling until around the age of six or seven, which suggests that an early start is by no means a prerequisite for high achievement.

In conclusion, while providing young children with stimulating care is highly desirable, subjecting them to formal academic instruction at an ever earlier age risks undermining both their wellbeing and their long-term enthusiasm for learning. This trend is therefore, on balance, a regrettable one.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes ☐ Notes:

Experimenting with basic income

Topic: Money and consumer behaviour · Difficulty: Difficult · id wb2_positive-negative_20

Some governments are experimenting with giving every adult a regular basic income, whether or not they work. Is this a positive or negative development?

Band 6

260 words

Clear positive position · relevant ideas and counter-arguments but limited development · mechanical linking · adequate vocabulary · recurring subject-verb agreement errors and a comparative error that do not obscure meaning.

Some governments are now testing a system where every adult get a regular amount of money, even if they do not have a job. In my opinion, this is a positive development, although there are some problems with the idea.

The most important advantage is that a basic income can reduce poverty. Many people today have jobs that pay very little or are not stable, so they worry about paying for rent and food. If everyone receive a fixed amount every month, nobody will be extremely poor. This can also reduce stress and make people more healthy and happy.

Another advantage is that basic income give people more freedom. For example, a person who wants to study a new skill or start a small business can do it without being afraid of losing all their money. Also, people who take care of their children or old parents at home can receive some money for their important work, which is usually unpaid.

On the other hand, many people think that basic income is too expensive for the government, and it may need to raise taxes. Some people also believe that if people get free money, they will become lazy and stop working. However, I think most people want to work because they want a better life, not only to survive.

In conclusion, I believe that experimenting with basic income is a positive development, because it can reduce poverty and give people more choices in their life. Of course, governments must test it carefully first to see if they can afford it.

Band 7

302 words

Clear negative position throughout · opposing arguments summarised then own ideas well extended · logical progression · good vocabulary (targeted support, labour shortages) · mostly error-free with an occasional agreement slip.

In several countries, governments have begun trials in which every adult receives a fixed sum of money at regular intervals, regardless of whether they are employed. Although the aim of reducing poverty is admirable, I believe that this is essentially a negative development.

Supporters argue that a basic income would provide security in an economy where many jobs are low-paid, temporary or at risk from automation. It would also be simpler to administer than complex welfare systems, and it would recognise unpaid work such as caring for children or elderly relatives.

However, the most serious problem is cost. Giving a meaningful amount of money to every adult, including those who are already wealthy, would require an enormous budget. To fund it, governments would probably have to raise taxes significantly or cut spending on other public services, such as healthcare and education, which the poorest people depend on most. In this

sense, a universal payment may be a less efficient way of helping those in need than targeted support.

Another concern is the possible effect on work. While most people would continue working, some might reduce their hours or leave jobs that are unpleasant but necessary, such as cleaning or care work. If this happened on a large scale, it could cause labour shortages and slow economic growth, which in turn would make the scheme even harder to afford. Moreover, there is a risk that the payments push up prices, particularly rents, so that people is no better off in real terms.

In conclusion, although a basic income aims to give everyone financial security, its high cost and potential impact on employment and prices make it an unwise policy. I therefore regard governments' experiments with it as a negative development, and believe that resources would be better spent on improving existing welfare systems.

Band 8

312 words

Clear, precisely framed positive judgement · distinguishes the policy from experimenting with it · ideas fully extended and evaluated · cohesion managed skilfully · wide, precise vocabulary (destitution, empirical) · error-free, sophisticated structures.

A number of governments have launched trials in which adults receive a regular, unconditional payment, irrespective of whether they are in work. Whether a universal basic income would succeed as a permanent national policy remains highly uncertain, but I believe that the decision to test it is a clearly positive development.

The case for exploring the idea is compelling. Many welfare systems are complex, stigmatising and riddled with gaps, leaving people who are entitled to support unable to obtain it. Meanwhile, insecure employment and the prospect of automation have left many workers exposed to sudden losses of income. An unconditional payment could provide a stable foundation, allowing people to retrain, care for relatives or take the risk of starting a business without fear of destitution.

Equally, the objections to basic income are serious and deserve to be tested rather than assumed. Critics warn that it would be ruinously expensive, that it might discourage people from working and that landlords and retailers could simply absorb the extra money through higher prices. These are empirical questions, and debates about them have long been conducted largely on the basis of ideology. Carefully designed experiments can reveal how recipients actually behave, how much the policy would really cost and which groups benefit most.

It should be acknowledged that trials have limitations. Because they are small and temporary, participants may behave differently than they would under a permanent scheme, and a pilot in one region cannot fully reflect the economic effects of a national programme. Nevertheless, imperfect evidence is preferable to none, and gradual experimentation is far less risky than either adopting such a radical policy wholesale or rejecting it without investigation.

In conclusion, whatever the eventual verdict on basic income itself, governments that test it are approaching a difficult question in a responsible, evidence-based way. For that reason, I regard these experiments as a positive development.

☐ Approved ☐ Needs changes Notes: